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VCE English Exam Preparation Guide

Units 3/4 English · 2027 examination · South Oakleigh College

Part

Picnic at Hanging Rock

Practice Analytical Text Response Topics

Section A topics on *Picnic at Hanging Rock* tend to take one of three shapes. Learn to recognise them in reading time, because each asks you to do something slightly different.

Task type	What it asks	Typical wording
Construction	How Weir builds an idea through the film: framing, sound, costume, setting, structure.	How does Weir explore / depict / portray / highlight / challenge...?
Relationship	How two ideas connect: cause and effect, contrast, comparison or connection.	...causes, shapes, leads to, limits; more than, as much as; despite, both...and
Idea / message	What the film suggests, reveals or demonstrates about an idea.	The film suggests that...; There are no...; ...is rarely...; ...is not necessarily...

The four big ideas that sit underneath almost every topic are **nature as a fundamental force**, **the human need for rationality and control**, **time**, and **class and civilisation**. Topics will not always name these ideas directly, so practise translating unexpected wording back into them.

1. How does Weir portray nature as mysterious in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

2. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, appearances are carefully maintained, but rarely reflect reality. Discuss.

3. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, answers are unattainable. Discuss.

4. How does Weir portray the Australian landscape as mysterious in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

5. How does Weir explore the tension between human civilisation and the natural world in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

6. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the natural world is ultimately unknowable. Discuss.

7. How does Weir explore the human desire to understand the world in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

8. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the need to explain events is driven more by a desire for control than a desire for truth. Do you agree?

9. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that reason cannot solve every problem. Discuss.

10. How does Weir portray the limitations of authority in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

11. The greatest threat to social order in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* comes not from nature but from within society itself. Discuss.

12. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that social rules exist only to create the illusion of order. Discuss.

13. How does Weir explore different perceptions of time in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

14. How does Weir contrast the timelessness of nature and the fleeting nature of human existence in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

15. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that human existence is insignificant in the vastness of time. Discuss.

16. How does Weir depict the natural world as a source of both fascination and fear?

17. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that nature reveals the limitations of human civilisation. Discuss.

18. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, social conventions restrict individual freedom. Discuss.

19. How does Weir explore the limits to human understanding in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

20. Weir suggests that civilisation is far more fragile than it appears. Discuss.

21. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the passing of time deepens rather than resolves the mystery of the girls' disappearance. Discuss.

22. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the desire for certainty creates more problems than it solves. Discuss.

23. How does Weir explore the relationship between freedom and vulnerability in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

24. 'The greatest threat to civilisation comes from within.' To what extent is this true in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

25. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, people are imprisoned by their need to understand the world. Discuss.

26. How does *Picnic at Hanging Rock* explore the tension between the security of the familiar and the attraction of the unknown?

27. How does *Picnic at Hanging Rock* explore the importance of social status and appearances?

28. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that society can be disrupted but nature is timeless. Do you agree?

29. How does Weir explore the relationship between knowledge and control in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

30. How do events in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* expose true natures?

31. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, crossing boundaries can be both liberating and dangerous. Discuss.

32. 'Nothing changed – ever.' *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that nature is both timeless and disruptive. To what extent do you agree?

33. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the desire for control leads to disorder. Discuss.

34. 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream.' In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, nothing is quite what it seems. Discuss.

35. 'There's some questions got answers and some haven't.' *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that we must learn to live with uncertainty. Do you agree?

36. 'People just don't disappear, my dear. Not without good reason.' The search for reasons in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* reveals more about the searchers than about the lost. Discuss.

37. 'How foolish can human creatures be.' *Picnic at Hanging Rock* is a critique of human arrogance. Discuss.

38. 'We shall only be gone a little while.' The characters of *Picnic at Hanging Rock* underestimate the forces beyond their control. Do you agree?

39. How does Weir use Hanging Rock to challenge the authority of Appleyard College?

40. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, attempts to measure the natural world lead only to greater uncertainty. Discuss.

41. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that it is difficult to escape the expectations of society. Discuss.

42. How does Weir portray the restrictions placed on young women in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

43. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, social status matters more than human suffering. Do you agree?

44. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* reveals that civilisation is powerless against time. Discuss.

45. How does Weir highlight the contrast between European culture and the Australian landscape in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

46. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, those who are drawn to nature find freedom as much as danger. Discuss.

47. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that order is not necessarily the same as safety. Discuss.

48. How does Weir use sound and music to suggest forces beyond human understanding in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

49. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the pressure to keep up appearances causes more suffering than the disappearance itself. Discuss.

50. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* celebrates the beauty of the natural world as much as it fears it. Do you agree?

51. 'Waiting a million years, just for us.' In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, nature is indifferent to human concerns. Discuss.

52. How does Weir depict Mrs Appleyard's need for control, and its consequences, in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

53. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggests that the past can never be fully known. Discuss.

54. 'We shall only be gone a little while.' *Picnic at Hanging Rock* shows that human plans are fragile in the face of time. Discuss.

55. How does Weir use costume to explore class and conformity in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

56. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, rationality limits people as much as it protects them. Discuss.

57. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, encounters with nature expose vulnerabilities. Discuss.

58. How does the girls' disappearance change the world of *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

59. To what extent does *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggest that the desire to understand the world is ultimately futile?

60. How does the film challenge the belief that every mystery can be solved?

61. The film suggests that human systems of order collapse when confronted by nature. To what extent do you agree?

62. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, certainty is an illusion. Discuss.

63. How does Weir reveal the weaknesses beneath civilisation in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?

64. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the order and rules of civilisation are rendered meaningless by the natural world. Discuss.

65. Human systems of order are insignificant when confronted by the natural world. Discuss.

66. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* highlights how nature is timeless and mysterious. Discuss.

67. Weir demonstrates that attempts to preserve order are ultimately pointless. Discuss.

68. *Picnic at Hanging Rock* portrays human order as temporary rather than enduring. Discuss.

69. Peter Weir's film explores a world filled with mysteries beyond human understanding. Discuss.

Background and Context

Overview

Peter Weir's *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1975) opens with a title card dating its events to St Valentine's Day, 1900: a party of schoolgirls from Appleyard College picnics at Hanging Rock, near Mount Macedon in Victoria, and several members of the party disappear without trace. The film never explains what happened. Instead, it studies how a rigid, ordered colonial society reacts when something happens that its rules, clocks and explanations cannot contain. Knowing where the story comes from, when it is set and how it was made will help you write about Weir's choices rather than just the plot.

Joan Lindsay's Novel

The film is adapted from Joan Lindsay's 1967 novel of the same name. Lindsay deliberately blurred fact and fiction, presenting the disappearance as if it might have happened and declining to say whether it did. That ambiguity became part of the story's legend: many readers and viewers came to believe the events were real. A final chapter that Lindsay cut from the novel, offering a strange, quasi-supernatural resolution, was published after her death; it plays no part in the film.

Analysis

You are studying the film, not the novel. Weir keeps Lindsay's refusal to resolve the mystery and makes it the centre of the viewing experience: the audience, like the characters, is left wanting an answer that never arrives. When you write about 'unresolved mysteries', remember that this is a deliberate construction, not a gap.

Peter Weir and the Australian New Wave

Picnic at Hanging Rock was one of the defining films of the Australian New Wave, a revival of local filmmaking in the 1970s supported by new government film funding. Directed by Peter Weir from a screenplay by Cliff Green, it was a major critical and commercial success and helped bring Australian cinema to international audiences. Appleyard College was filmed at Martindale Hall in South Australia, while the picnic and search scenes were shot at Hanging Rock itself.

Analysis

The New Wave was partly about Australians telling stories about their own landscape and history. Weir's film looks back at colonial society with a mixture of beauty and unease: the European culture of the college looks lovely but out of place against the ancient Australian bush. This tension between imported civilisation and the land is at the heart of most essay topics.

Victoria in 1900

In 1900 Victoria was still a British colony; Federation would come on 1 January 1901. Wealthy colonial society modelled itself on Britain: its schools taught deportment, French, poetry and the accomplishments expected of young ladies, and its social life was governed by strict rules

about class, dress and behaviour. Girls were laced into corsets, gloved and hatted outdoors, and expected to be decorative, obedient and chaste.

Class divisions were sharp. The Fitzhuberts are landed gentry; Albert, their groom, is a working man who grew up in an orphanage; Sara, his sister, is a ward whose fees go unpaid. Mrs Appleyard's college depends on wealthy parents' money and on its reputation for respectability.

Analysis

The rules of this society explain much of what we see: the gloves Mrs Appleyard allows the girls to remove only 'once the drag has passed through Woodend', the horror at Miss McCraw being seen without her skirt, the police assumption that the explanation must be a man. Weir shows how fragile these conventions are once they meet something beyond them.

Hanging Rock

Hanging Rock is a volcanic formation in the Macedon Ranges, north-west of Melbourne, and lies on the traditional lands of the Dja Dja Wurrung, Taungurung and Wurundjeri Woi-wurrung peoples. Geologically it is relatively young, a point Miss McCraw makes in the film, but in human terms it is ancient. Its jagged pinnacles, narrow passages and balanced boulders give it the maze-like quality Weir's camera exploits.

Analysis

The colonial characters treat the Rock as a picnic spot and a curiosity to be measured. The film suggests that it existed long before them and will outlast them. The settlers' lack of any real relationship with the land, including the Indigenous history they overlook, is part of what makes it seem so alien and threatening to them.

The Film Script

A transcript of the film's dialogue is available online: *Picnic at Hanging Rock* film transcript (script-o-rama). Use it to check the exact wording of quotes, which can differ from the published screenplay. The transcript leaves out numbers (times and dates), so check those against the film.

The Look and Sound of the Film

Cinematographer Russell Boyd gave the film its dreamy, soft-focus look, with diffused light, slow motion and lingering shots of the landscape. The soundtrack mixes Gheorghe Zamfir's haunting pan flute, original music by Bruce Smeaton, European classical pieces such as the slow movement of Beethoven's Fifth Piano Concerto, and an unsettling low rumble associated with the Rock.

Analysis

These choices create the film's central tension between beauty and menace. The images are lovely, almost like paintings, but the sound and pacing keep the viewer uneasy. See the Film Techniques section for how to use them in essays.

The Novel and the Film

Your set text is Peter Weir's 1975 film, not Joan Lindsay's 1967 novel. The film follows the novel closely, but the novel contains events and explanations that never appear on screen. Anything that exists only in the novel cannot be used as evidence in your essay, and using it tells the assessor you are not writing about the film.

What Happens Differently in the Novel

- **Sara's death.** In the novel, Sara is found days later beneath the school's tower, apparently a suicide. In the film, the head gardener finds her body in the greenhouse; how she died is never shown.
- **Mrs Appleyard's death.** In the novel, she jumps from a peak on the Rock. In the film, a closing voice-over reports that her body was found at the base of the Rock and that 'it is believed she fell while attempting to climb the rock'.
- **Miss Lumley.** In the novel, she leaves with her brother Reg, and both die in a hotel fire. In the film, she simply resigns.
- **Mademoiselle.** In the novel, she announces she is getting married and leaves the college. In the film, she is still there at the end, dining with Mrs Appleyard.
- **Miss McCraw.** In the novel, a frill of calico thought to be from her dress is found in 1903. The film gives no such clue.

The Missing Final Chapter

Lindsay cut the novel's final chapter before publication. It was published after her death, in 1987, as *The Secret of Hanging Rock*. In it, the girls and a woman who seems to be Miss McCraw throw off their corsets and pass through a 'hole in space' in the Rock, while Irma is shut out when the hanging boulder tilts. This chapter has nothing to do with the film. Weir deliberately leaves the disappearance unexplained, and that refusal to explain is one of the most important things to analyse. Never use the missing chapter as an 'answer'.

How to Stay on the Film

- Name the director, not the author: 'Weir suggests', not 'Lindsay suggests'.
- Use film evidence: shots, framing, sound, music, costume, setting and editing, as well as dialogue.
- If you have read the novel, check every detail you plan to use against the film. If you cannot point to the moment on screen, leave it out.
- Use the novel only as context, and only in passing: for example, that Lindsay blurred fact and fiction, and that Weir keeps the mystery unresolved.

Values in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*

Social Values

Order, Rules and Respectability

Appleyard College values discipline, punctuality and propriety above all. Mrs Appleyard's instructions before the picnic about gloves, 'tomboy foolishness', snakes and returning 'at about 8' show a world that tries to anticipate and control every risk. The film questions whether these rules create real order or only the appearance of it: when the girls vanish, the rules offer no answer, and the institution begins to collapse.

Class and Social Hierarchy

Wealth and status decide who belongs. Sara, an orphan whose fees are 'impossibly overdue', is excluded from the picnic and treated harshly; Mrs Appleyard insists the college is not a 'charitable institution'. Michael and Albert's friendship across the class divide stands out as a rare challenge to these values.

Femininity and Restraint

The girls are dressed in white, corseted and gloved, praised for beauty and refinement. The film links this ideal of femininity to repression: the girls who climb the Rock shed their shoes, stockings and gloves, and the community's reaction to the disappearance focuses obsessively on bodies and sexual danger.

Cultural Values

Rationality and Science

The characters trust measurement, investigation and explanation. Miss McCraw studies geometry and geology; Sergeant Bumpher interviews witnesses and organises searches; the doctor examines Irma. The film presents a world that does not yield to these methods, suggesting the limits of a purely rational worldview.

European Culture in the Australian Landscape

The college is a piece of England transplanted to the bush: Botticelli prints, Valentine's poetry, cultivated flowers, high tea and classical music. Weir sets this imported culture against an ancient landscape it does not understand, revealing the colonists' sense of being outsiders in the land they occupy.

Romanticism and the Sublime

Some characters, especially Miranda and Michael, are drawn to nature as something beautiful, spiritual and liberating. This Romantic longing for connection with nature coexists with fear: the Rock is both enchanting and terrifying.

Key Ideas and Vocabulary

The film can be strange and confusing, so it helps to know the main ideas before you watch. The most fundamental idea is that the natural world is powerful, overwhelming and

mysterious, while the human world tries to measure, quantify and make rules to create a sense of control. Weir's film explores an event that challenges every illusion of control his characters have. The vocabulary below will help you write about each key idea with precision.

Nature as a Fundamental Force

From the opening image of the Rock, the audience sees nature as monumental and powerful. But it is not only the Rock: Weir provides many vignettes of trees, birds, lizards and insects that present the varied, multifaceted natural world beyond human control. Some characters, like Edith, are afraid of and repelled by the untamed bush; others, like Miranda, are drawn to it, literally walking away from the constraints of the human world. Every other idea in the film relates to nature, so any essay on *Picnic at Hanging Rock* needs to analyse nature in some way.

- **Nature:** natural environment, landscape, wilderness, Australian bush, surrounding landscape, untamed world, world of nature, natural realm, surrounding wilderness.
- **Nature as a mysterious force:** elemental forces of nature, impenetrability of the wilderness, untameable power of nature, overwhelming nature of the wilderness, primordial landscape, inscrutable forces of nature, unknowable dimensions of the wilderness, enigmatic world of the Australian landscape, ancient and indifferent landscape.

The Human Need for Rationality and Control

Because life and nature are so overwhelming, people quantify, measure and control the world around them so that they feel powerful and clever. Throughout the film, characters try to explain the mystery of the disappearance, while others recognise the limits of human knowledge. Marion and Miss McCraw measure, calculate and put numbers on the world. As the party approaches the Rock, there is a short discussion about how old it is, as though knowing its age will help them understand it.

- **Order:** structure, stability, certainty, predictability, clarity, understanding, balance, control, rationality, coherence.
- **Chaos:** disorder, uncertainty, unpredictability, confusion, mystery, wilderness, irrationality.
- **Desire for knowledge:** need to understand, the importance of learning, feeling of expertise, prioritisation of education, promotion of intellect, the search for reason, accumulation of information, desire to comprehend, need to make sense.
- **Measurement:** quantification, imposition of order, reduction of data, transforming the unknowable, a means of establishing order, faith in mathematical understanding.

Class and Civilisation

As part of the effort to measure and control the world, humans have created 'civilisation', the opposite of the natural world. Appleyard College is its obvious symbol: a monumental colonial building surrounded by a manicured lawn in the middle of the Australian bush. Even nature is controlled there: plants grow in a greenhouse and exotic flowers are arranged in vases. Costume carries the same idea: girls are strapped into corsets every morning, policemen wear brightly polished buttons, Mrs Appleyard's hair is a carefully coiffed beehive. The characters are arranged into serving classes and ruling classes. Everyone has rules to follow, and the rules make them feel they have tamed the world. As Weir reveals, they have not.

- **The ordered world of Appleyard College:** carefully regulated environment, controlled world of the school, a world governed by rules and expectations, institutional world of Appleyard College, the structured life of the schoolgirls, artificial order of the school environment, the confined world of Appleyard College, the institutional structures that govern the girls, the school as a symbol of civilisation.
- **The social structure of Edwardian society:** the rigid social structures of the time, conventions of polite society, social codes of the 1900s, the social mores of the time, constraints of the civilised world, accepted behaviours and conventions, the hierarchical nature of Edwardian society, the conventions of British colonial culture, the values of colonial society.

Time

Time is a tool of measurement, so it belongs with rationality and control, but it is important enough to deserve its own place. The characters are obsessed with time: the girls disappear on a specified date, there are clocks and watches everywhere, and the characters are disturbed when they stop. In contrast stands the natural world, which operates on a scale that is almost incomprehensible: the Rock is millions of years old. Weir also plays with the audience's sense of time by slowing some of the action down and presenting it in a dreamlike, timeless way.

- **Human-scale time:** temporal order on the world, systems of clocks, schedules and routines, linear notions of time, time as quantifiable, time as a boundary that separates and defines, linear progression of human life, human attempts to organise the passage of time, the measured rhythm of civilisation.
- **Time in the natural world:** collapse of established routines, cyclical and fluid nature of time, a timescale that transcends human experience, transcending human life, shifting and deceptive in the natural world, geological time, the eternal cycles of nature, the ageless landscape.

Thematic Quote Bank

Nature as a Fundamental Force

> *Miranda* (voice-over): ‘What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*: ‘The vicinity is renowned for its venomous snakes and poisonous ants of various species.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*: ‘The Rock is extremely dangerous, and you are therefore forbidden any tomboy foolishness in the matter of exploration.’

> *Irma*, as the Rock comes into view: ‘Waiting a million years, just for us.’

> *Edith*: ‘Why can’t we just sit on this log and look at the ugly old rock from here?’

> *Edith*: ‘It’s nasty here.’

> *Edith* (remembering the Rock): ‘It was a cloud… it was red.’

> *Michael*, of the Rock: ‘It comes back at night in dreams.’

> *Sara*, in Albert’s dream: ‘I’ve come a long way to see ya, and now I must go.’

> *Sara*, after the disappearance: Miranda had many ‘secrets’; ‘she knew she wouldn’t come back.’

The Human Need for Rationality and Control

> *Mr Hussey*: ‘No one knows. No one saw her leave. We were asleep.’

> *Sergeant Bumpher* (to Edith): ‘Was there a man?’

> *Mrs Bumpher*, reporting local gossip: ‘It couldn’t be local… No one around here would do a thing like that.’

> *Mrs Bumpher*, to her husband: ‘People just don’t disappear, my dear. Not without good reason.’

> *A townsman* outside the police station: ‘We’ve got a bloody right to know.’

> *The doctor*, examining Irma: her unmarked feet are ‘very strange’.

> *The doctor*, on Irma’s survival: ‘Remarkable.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*, of Miss McCraw: how could her ‘masculine intellect’ be ‘spirited away… like a silly schoolgirl’?

> *The head gardener*: ‘There’s some questions got answers and some haven’t.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*, on Irma being the only girl found: ‘This makes it worse.’

> *Michael*, to Albert: ‘I wake up every night in a cold sweat. Just wondering if they’re still alive.’

> *Michael*, insisting on searching the Rock himself: the girls ‘may be out there dying of thirst.’

> *Miss Lumley*, rebuked by Mrs Appleyard: Irma’s discovery is ‘wonderful news.’

Time

> *Miranda*, of her watch: ‘Don’t wear it anymore. Can’t stand the ticking above my heart.’

> *Irma*, of Miranda’s watch: she would wear it ‘always… even in the bath.’

> *Mr Hussey*: ‘Blowed if me watch hasn’t stopped. Dead on twelve.’

> *Miss McCraw*: ‘Stopped at twelve. Never stopped before. Must be something magnetic.’

> *Mr Hussey*: ‘Well after two, I’d say. We’d better be careful. I promised Mrs Appleyard I’d have you lot back at the college by eight.’

> *Marion*: ‘I should like to make a few measurements of the rock if we have time.’

> *Irma*: ‘We’ll be back long before tea.’

> *Miranda*: ‘Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place.’

> *Edith*: ‘When are we going home?’

> *Miranda*, to Mademoiselle: ‘We shall only be gone a little while.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*, remembering Bournemouth: ‘Nothing changed – ever.’

Class and Civilisation

> *Mrs Appleyard*: ‘You may remove your gloves once the drag has passed through Woodend.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*: ‘Mr Hussey! I shall expect you back, Miss McCraw and Mademoiselle, at about 8.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*: ‘There are several sets of tuition fees impossibly overdue… Sara Waybourne, for instance.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*: Appleyard College is not a ‘charitable institution’.

> *Marion*, looking down from the Rock: ‘Whatever can those people be doing down there? Like a lot of ants. Surprising the number of human beings are without purpose. Although it is probable they’re performing some function unknown to themselves.’

> *Miss McCraw*, as the party settles beneath the Rock: ‘How foolish can human creatures be.’

> *Albert*: if ‘the bloody cop and the bloody… tracker and the bloody dog can’t find ‘em, well, no one bloody can.’

> *Albert*, to Michael: ‘I say the crude things. You just think ‘em.’

> *Edith*, of the Fitzhuberts: they ‘might be the only living creatures in the whole world.’

> *Mrs Appleyard*, to Sara: ‘You will be returned to the orphanage.’

> *Sara*, repeating Mrs Appleyard’s words to herself: ‘This is not a charitable institution.’

> *Miss Lumley*, to Sara: Sara is ‘not to go on the picnic.’

Beauty, Innocence and Appearance

> *Mademoiselle de Poitiers*: ‘Now I know… Miranda is a Botticelli angel.’

> *Mademoiselle*, embracing Irma on her return: she is ‘prettier than ever’.

> *Mrs Appleyard*, to the students: they can ‘thank the Lord for this merciful deliverance of our dear classmate Irma’.

> *Miss Lumley*, of strapping Sara to the gymnasium wall: it is ‘for her own good’, to cure her ‘terrible stooping’.

Character Quote Bank

Miranda



Miranda leads the girls up the Rock and does not return. Beautiful, serene and drawn to the natural world, she is idealised by almost everyone around her.

> ‘What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.’ – *the film’s opening voice-over*.

> ‘Don’t wear it anymore. Can’t stand the ticking above my heart.’ – *rejecting her jewelled watch at the picnic.*

> ‘Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place.’ – *on top of the Rock, just before she disappears*.

> ‘Someday, Sara, you shall have to come home with me to the station… meet my sweet, funny family for yourself.’ – *to Sara on the morning of the picnic.*

> ‘You must learn to love someone else, apart from me.’ – *to Sara, as if anticipating her own absence*.

> ‘We shall only be gone a little while.’ – *reassuring Mademoiselle as the girls set off to explore*.

Marion



Marion is intellectual and detached, taking measurements on the Rock with a protractor. She does not return.

> ‘I should like to make a few measurements of the rock if we have time.’ – *asking permission to explore.*

> ‘I do wish you’d stop talking for once.’ – *to Edith during the climb.*

> ‘Whatever can those people be doing down there? Like a lot of ants. Surprising the number of human beings are without purpose.’ – *looking down on the picnickers from the Rock.*

Irma



Irma is the heiress of the group and the only climbing girl who comes back, with no memory of what happened.

> She would wear Miranda’s watch ‘always… even in the bath.’ – *at the picnic.*

> ‘Waiting a million years, just for us.’ – *awed by the Rock on the journey.*

> ‘We’ll be back long before tea.’ – *before the climb.*

> ‘If only we could stay out all night and watch the moon rise.’ – *on the Rock.*

> ‘Poor Edith. We’ll go back soon.’ – *to Edith before the girls disappear.*

Edith



Edith is plump, complaining and frightened. She keeps her hat, gloves, shoes and stockings on, and runs screaming from the Rock.

> ‘Why can’t we just sit on this log and look at the ugly old rock from here?’ – *during the climb.*

> ‘It’s nasty here.’ – *as the others are drawn further in.*

> ‘When are we going home?’ – *repeatedly, during the climb.*

> ‘It was a cloud… it was red.’ – *remembering, when she returns to the Rock with Sergeant Bumpher.*

> Miss McCraw ‘was funny’ – *explaining that she was climbing without her skirt.*

> The Fitzhuberts ‘might be the only living creatures in the whole world.’ – *after the picnic meal.*

Mrs Appleyard



The headmistress embodies authority, convention and institutional control. As events slip beyond her control, she unravels.

> ‘You may remove your gloves once the drag has passed through Woodend.’ – *instructions before the picnic.*

> ‘The Rock is extremely dangerous, and you are therefore forbidden any tomboy foolishness in the matter of exploration.’ – *warning the girls.*

> ‘Mr Hussey! I shall expect you back, Miss McCraw and Mademoiselle, at about 8.’ – *as the drag departs.*

> ‘This makes it worse.’ – *chiding Miss Lumley for calling Irma’s discovery ‘wonderful news’.*

> ‘There are several sets of tuition fees impossibly overdue… Sara Waybourne, for instance.’ – *as the college faces financial pressure.*

> ‘We shall have to make other arrangements.’ – *to Sara, about her unpaid fees.*

> ‘You will be returned to the orphanage.’ – *in her final meeting with Sara.*

> Bournemouth was ‘a delightful place’ where ‘nothing changed – ever.’ – *reminiscing with Mademoiselle at dinner.*

> She had come to ‘depend so much on Greta McCraw’ and her ‘masculine intellect’: ‘How could she allow herself to be spirited away?’ – *at the same dinner.*

Sara Waybourne



An orphan and ward of the college, Sara is forbidden from the picnic and devoted to Miranda. She is later found dead.

> Miranda had many ‘secrets’: ‘she knew she wouldn’t come back.’ – *after the disappearance.*

> At the orphanage she had her head shaved for telling the matron she wanted to be a ‘circus rider’. – *confiding in Minnie.*

> ‘This is not a charitable institution.’ – *repeating Mrs Appleyard’s words to herself, beneath a painting of a woman holding two babies.*

> ‘I’ve come a long way to see ya, and now I must go.’ – *to Albert, in his dream on the night of her death.*

Miss McCraw



The mathematics mistress, admired by Mrs Appleyard for her ‘masculine intellect’. She climbs the Rock alone and does not return.

> ‘Stopped at twelve. Never stopped before. Must be something magnetic.’ – *when the watches are found stopped.*

> The Rock is ‘quite young, geologically speaking.’ – *explaining its volcanic origin at the picnic.*

> ‘How foolish can human creatures be.’ – *reflecting that the picnickers have come for pleasure to a place of ‘venomous snakes and poisonous ants’.*

Mademoiselle de Poitiers



The French mistress is warm, romantic and admired by the students, but increasingly anxious for answers.

> ‘Now I know… Miranda is a Botticelli angel.’ – *watching Miranda.*

> Irma is ‘prettier than ever.’ – *embracing Irma, before questioning her about what she told the police.*

Miss Lumley



The junior mistress is timid and fearful of Mrs Appleyard. She eventually resigns.

> Irma’s discovery is ‘wonderful news.’ – *rebuked by Mrs Appleyard.*

> Sara is ‘not to go on the picnic.’ – *reminding Sara, though she is not going either.*

> Strapping Sara to the wall is ‘for her own good’, to cure her ‘terrible stooping’. – *in the gymnasium.*

Michael Fitzhubert



A young English aristocrat visiting his uncle and aunt. He watches the girls cross the stream and becomes obsessed with finding them.

> ‘I wake up every night in a cold sweat. Just wondering if they’re still alive.’ – *to Albert.*

> The girls ‘may be out there dying of thirst.’ – *insisting on searching the Rock himself.*

> ‘It comes back at night in dreams.’ – *telling Albert he can’t stop thinking about the Rock.*

Albert Crundall



The Fitzhuberts’ groom: earthy, practical and loyal. He finds Irma and, without knowing it, is Sara’s brother.

> If ‘the bloody cop and the bloody… tracker and the bloody dog can’t find ‘em, well, no one bloody can.’ – *trying to talk Michael out of searching.*

> He dreams of his ‘kid sister’ on the night of Sara’s death. – *telling Michael about the dream.*

> ‘I say the crude things. You just think ‘em.’ – *to Michael, at the stream.*

The Investigators and the Town

> Mr Hussey: ‘No one knows. No one saw her leave. We were asleep.’ – *reporting to Mrs Appleyard and Sergeant Bumpher.*

> Sergeant Bumpher: ‘Was there a man?’ – *questioning Edith.*

> Sergeant Bumpher: ‘As the girls were jumping the creek, what were you thinking of?’ – *interviewing Michael, who answers by pointing to a swan vase.*

> Mrs Bumpher: ‘It couldn’t be local… No one around here would do a thing like that.’ – *repeating the town’s gossip.*

> Mrs Bumpher: ‘People just don’t disappear, my dear. Not without good reason.’ – *to her husband, who has no answers.*

> A townsman: ‘We’ve got a bloody right to know.’ – *outside Bumpher’s house after Irma is found.*

> The doctor: Irma’s unmarked feet are ‘very strange’. – *listing her injuries.*

> The doctor: ‘Remarkable.’ – *on Irma surviving a week on the Rock.*

> Mr Hussey: ‘Well after two, I’d say. We’d better be careful.’ – *after his watch stops at the picnic.*

> The head gardener: ‘There’s some questions got answers and some haven’t.’ – *one of the film’s few direct statements of its idea.*

Character Relationships

Mrs Appleyard and Sara Waybourne

The film's most painful relationship is one of power. Mrs Appleyard is upright, ornately dressed and usually framed above other characters or behind her desk; Sara is small, plain, stooped and often seated or diminished in the frame. Sara loves poetry and feeling; Mrs Appleyard values rules and fees. As the college comes under pressure, Mrs Appleyard turns her frustration on Sara, the one person with no family or money to protect her.

Key Quotes

- *Mrs Appleyard:* 'There are several sets of tuition fees impossibly overdue… Sara Waybourne, for instance.'
- *Mrs Appleyard:* 'We shall have to make other arrangements.'
- *Mrs Appleyard:* Appleyard College is not a 'charitable institution'.

Key Ideas

- Class and social hierarchy
- Authority and cruelty
- Reason versus emotion
- Victim or agent of her own fate?

Sara Waybourne: Victim of Fate or Author of Her Own Demise?

One of the most significant minor characters, Sara is Miranda's devoted admirer. We first see her watching Miranda wash her face and presenting her with a Valentine's card. Her outsider status is established early: she is prevented from going to the picnic and must stay behind to learn poetry, but she thinks her own poetry is better than the classic and refuses to learn it. Mrs Appleyard nags her about her posture throughout, a good symbol of how Sara doesn't, or won't, fit in. Late in the film we learn that her guardian has not been paying her fees. Her story is 'doomed', as Irma predicts.

Sara is contradictory. She stands up to Mrs Appleyard, and it is easy to cheer for her. But in Edwardian times orphans were near the bottom of the class ladder, and a girl like Sara could easily have ended up closer to Minnie the maid's position, like her brother Albert. She also has a comfortable life for an orphan, lounging about a privileged boarding school writing poetry. Yet she is bullied by Mrs Appleyard, and Miss Lumley ties her to a wall to 'improve' her posture.

One side of Sara's story	On the other hand
Miranda: 'Someday, Sara, you shall have to come home with me to the station… meet my sweet, funny family for yourself.'	Sara says Miranda had many 'secrets… she knew she wouldn't come back'.
Miranda: 'You must learn to love someone else, apart from me.'	Sara shakes her head at this advice, but she has a brother she apparently doesn't keep in touch with.

One side of Sara's story	On the other hand
Miss Lumley reminds Sara that she is 'not to go on the picnic'.	But Miss Lumley is sympathetic, because she is not allowed to go on the picnic either.
Mrs Appleyard: 'There are several sets of tuition fees impossibly overdue... Sara Waybourne, for instance.'	Mrs Appleyard: 'This is not a charitable institution.'
Sara shakes her head when Mrs Appleyard says, 'We shall have to make other arrangements.'	Sara grew up in an orphanage with her brother Albert, so she must have some understanding of her position in society.
Sara tells Minnie that she had her head shaved in the orphanage for telling the matron she wanted to be a 'circus rider'.	Sara bit the matron's arm until it bled.
Miss Lumley ties Sara to the gymnasium wall to 'cure her terrible stooping'.	Mademoiselle has the courage to stand up to Mrs Appleyard, but Miss Lumley is too afraid (until she finally resigns).
Just before Sara dies, Weir focuses on her photograph of Miranda, suggesting that Sara is all alone.	Albert dreams of his 'kid sister' on the night of her death.
The head gardener finds Sara's body in the greenhouse.	Mrs Appleyard claims that Sara's guardian took her away.

Question to answer: Is Sara a victim of fate, or does she bring about her own demise?

Control and the Natural World: a Spectrum

Sara's surname is symbolic: 'Waybourne' sounds like 'wayward', or contrary. Sara does not fit the rigid hierarchy of Appleyard College and is the complete antithesis of Mrs Appleyard. Try placing the characters (Sara, Mrs Appleyard, Miranda, Miss McCraw, Michael, Albert, Mademoiselle, Miss Lumley, Irma) on a spectrum from **control** (logic and hierarchy) to **untamed forces** (nature and mystery), and label each with a phrase:

- **Towards control:** systematic regulation, a desire for logic and reason, the established conventions of social order, the pursuit of understanding and certainty, the acceptance of social conventions, submission to established systems, the security of rationality and an ordered world, a belief in the authority of social institutions, an attempt to create meaning through systems, the triumph of structure over the natural world, a fear of the unknown.
- **Towards untamed forces:** the wildness of nature, untamed forces, elemental forces, the enigma of life, challenges to established order, the unpredictability of the natural world, primal forces, the fragility of human attempts to impose order, the uncertainty of nature, the raw energy of the natural world, the mystery of nature.

Miranda and Sara

Sara adores Miranda, who is kind to her and seems to offer belonging. Miranda's gentle advice that Sara 'must learn to love someone else' reads, in hindsight, like a farewell. With Miranda gone, Sara is completely alone; just before Sara's death, Weir focuses on her photograph of Miranda.

Key Quotes

- *Miranda:* 'Someday, Sara, you shall have to come home with me to the station... meet my sweet, funny family for yourself.'
- *Miranda:* 'You must learn to love someone else, apart from me.'

- *Sara:* Miranda had many 'secrets… she knew she wouldn't come back.'

Key Ideas

- Love and isolation
- Foreshadowing
- The cost of the disappearance for those left behind

Michael and Albert

Michael is a privileged young Englishman; Albert is the Fitzhuberts' groom, raised in an orphanage. At the picnic Albert makes crude remarks about the girls while Michael watches them in silence. The search draws them together: Albert rescues Michael from the Rock, and their conversations grow into a genuine friendship that ignores the social hierarchy around them. In their final scene Albert tells Michael about his dream of his 'kid sister', a connection to Sara that neither fully understands.

Key Quotes

- *Albert:* If 'the bloody cop and the bloody… tracker and the bloody dog can't find 'em, well, no one bloody can.'
- *Michael:* The girls 'may be out there dying of thirst.'
- *Michael:* 'I wake up every night in a cold sweat. Just wondering if they're still alive.'

Key Ideas

- Friendship across class
- Acceptance (Albert) versus the search for understanding (Michael)
- Instinct and intuition

An Evolving Relationship

Through Michael and Albert's friendship, Weir suggests that the natural world transcends the rigid class divisions of society. Their shared experiences in nature transform both men, while also leaving them disoriented and stripped of certainty. Theirs is the only relationship that genuinely evolves through the film: as they become immersed in the mystery, their friendship mirrors nature's ability to transcend the social divisions that once separated them.

Beginning	Middle	End
Although Albert belongs to a different class, he is friendly and open towards Michael at the picnic, offering to share a drink. Michael returns the friendliness. Albert comments candidly on the girls' appearance as they cross the stream. When Michael calls him 'crude', Albert replies, 'I say the crude things. You just think 'em.'	Albert believes the girls must be dead, but agrees to help Michael search. He accepts that Michael wants to stay on the Rock overnight and lies to Michael's uncle for him. Albert finds Michael the next day, recognises the importance of the torn fabric in his hand, then searches the Rock and finds Irma.	In Michael's final scene he shares his dreams with Albert: he can't help thinking about the Rock; 'It comes back at night in dreams.' Albert responds with his own 'funny dream', in which he sees his sister Sara, accompanied by the powerful smell of pansies.

Sentence starters: *Rather than reinforcing social hierarchy, Michael and Albert's relationship…; Unlike the rigid social world they inhabit…; Against the backdrop of a*

transcendent natural world…; In contrast to the strict social hierarchies of Edwardian society…; Eschewing the social mores of the time… + becomes more…, resists…, goes beyond…, evolves from… to…, surpasses…, overcomes…, redefines…

Comparative statements to agree, disagree or partly agree with:

- Throughout the film, Albert is more open to new experiences than Michael.
- Albert's connection to nature is instinctive, whereas Michael's must be learned.
- Michael learns more from Albert than Albert learns from Michael.
- Michael's search for the girls is ultimately a search for himself, while Albert remains secure in his identity.
- Albert embodies acceptance, while Michael embodies the search for understanding.

Dreams

At the end of the film both men have dreams. Michael's is about the Rock; Albert's is about his sister Sara, which seems random, because for most of the film we did not know they were related. Now, just after Sara has died, Albert dreams about her. Possible readings: for Weir, dreams are symbolic of the mysterious powers of nature; because dreams are disconnected from the rational mind, they symbolise a natural world beyond our control; people and nature are connected in ways that transcend logical thought, and dreams symbolise these connections.

Albert and Sara

Albert and Sara are brother and sister, separated in the orphanage. The film never brings them together: Albert does not know his sister is at the college a few miles away, and Sara does not keep in touch with him. On the night of Sara's death, Albert dreams that she visits him to say goodbye.

Key Ideas

- Class and lost opportunity
- Mystery and the supernatural
- Dramatic irony

Mrs Appleyard and Miss McCraw

Mrs Appleyard relies on Miss McCraw as the embodiment of reason and order. That the most rational person in the film is 'spirited away' shakes Mrs Appleyard's belief that the world can be controlled.

Key Quotes

- *Mrs Appleyard:* She had come to 'depend so much on Greta McCraw' and her 'masculine intellect'.
- *Mrs Appleyard:* 'How could she allow herself to be spirited away?'

Key Ideas

- The limits of reason

- Dependence and control

Mademoiselle and Miss Lumley

The two junior teachers are visual opposites: Mademoiselle wears lace, pearls and softly waving hair, while Miss Lumley wears plaid, spectacles and muddy colours. Mademoiselle goes to the picnic; Miss Lumley, like Sara, is left behind. Mademoiselle has the courage to stand up to Mrs Appleyard and stays to the end; Miss Lumley is too afraid until she finally resigns.

Key Quotes

- *Miss Lumley:* Irma's discovery is 'wonderful news'.
- *Mademoiselle:* Irma is 'prettier than ever'.

Key Ideas

- Appearance versus reality
- Fear of authority
- Curiosity and the need for answers

Appearances Are Deceiving

In many ways the two women are presented as opposites, and it is easy to typecast them: Mademoiselle is glamorous, French and sympathetic to the girls; Miss Lumley defers to Mrs Appleyard, is unfashionable, wears spectacles and is a little afraid of the girls. But Weir makes both more complicated than they appear.

Costume: Mademoiselle wears lace blouses, frills and bows, pearls, gently waving hair, lace gloves and flowers and ribbons on her hats; Miss Lumley wears plaid, simple printed blouses, spectacles, muddy colours and mousy hair. Vocabulary: *elegant, graceful, chic, romantic, charming, tastefully adorned, embellished, innocent* (Mademoiselle); *dowdy, prim, sensible, muted, utilitarian, respectable* (Miss Lumley). Phrases for analysis: *emotionally perceptive, harmonious with nature, in touch with innocence and girlhood, connected with the natural world, graceful and nurturing, dreamlike and ethereal*; *well organised and disciplined, strict and conservative, accepting of her role in the social hierarchy, emotionally restrained, respectful of societal conventions, rule-bound and dutiful*.

	Miss Lumley	Mademoiselle
Beginning	Is aligned with Sara, because neither is allowed to go to the picnic.	Goes to the picnic. Compares Miranda to a work of art.
Middle	Tells Mrs Appleyard that it is 'wonderful news' that Irma is found; is clearly frightened when chastised; believes the other girls will be found.	Presses Edith to remember what happened, at her bedside and on the Rock; gives the police one of Miranda's garments for the sniffer dogs; is disappointed when only Irma is found; hugs Irma, tells her she is 'prettier than ever', but questions her about what she told the police.
End	Is frightened by the girls' wild behaviour towards Irma and cowers behind the piano; protests that she tied Sara up 'for her own good'; quits.	Brings Irma back to the school and leaves her with the class; shouts at Edith and slaps her; stays at Appleyard College to the end, listening to Mrs Appleyard at the dinner table.

What motivates them? Statements to weigh up: Miss Lumley is motivated by a desire to obey her headmistress and do a good job; Mademoiselle wants to be liked and admired by the students; while Mademoiselle appears to want the best for the students, she is ultimately driven by her own interests; Miss Lumley is driven by fear of Mrs Appleyard's authority, although she can understand that some of her behaviour is wrong; Miss Lumley would like to appear rational and dutiful but is actually driven by emotions and fear.

Topic sentence to develop: *Throughout the film, Weir demonstrates that people often act according to their own emotional needs, even when they appear to be acting rationally or professionally.*

Irma and the Other Girls

When Irma returns, the girls who once envied and admired her surround her in the gymnasium demanding 'Tell us, Irma!'. Her vivid red dress sets her apart from their white uniforms. The scene turns into a frightening display of mob behaviour, showing how quickly civilised behaviour collapses when people are desperate for answers.

Key Ideas

- Mass hysteria and mob mentality
- The desire for certainty
- The collapse of civility

Scene Summaries and Analyses

The sequences below follow the order of the film. Use them to locate evidence quickly; the Analysis notes suggest how each sequence connects to the big ideas.

Sequence 1 : The Opening

Summary : Hanging Rock emerges from mist while Miranda's voice-over says 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.' A title card gives precise factual details about the disappearance. Appleyard College is then shown framed against a foreground of wild summer grass.

Analysis : The order is significant. We see the Rock first, then the facts, then the college. From the outset Weir establishes the three forces of the film: nature as a fundamental force, the human need for factual order, and civilisation. The facts tell us what happened but not why, so the film begins with the mystery already unsolved.

Sequence 2 : St Valentine's Morning

Summary : The girls dress, lace each other's corsets, and exchange Valentine cards and poems. Miranda and Sara share a tender moment. Flowers are everywhere. Mrs Appleyard addresses the girls about gloves, snakes, 'tomboy foolishness' and returning 'at about 8'. Sara is told she is not to go on the picnic.

Analysis : Weir portrays the students as elegant, refined and innocent, but also sheltered, uniform and restrained. The cultivated flowers represent a version of nature that has been domesticated and controlled. Mrs Appleyard's warnings reveal an institutional fear of disorder, danger and lost time.

Sequence 3 : The Picnic

Summary : The drag, driven by Mr Hussey, carries the girls, Miss McCraw and Mademoiselle to the Rock. Miranda opens a gate to let the party through. The picnic is laid out with cake, china and white dresses. Nearby, Colonel and Mrs Fitzhubert picnic with their nephew Michael and their groom Albert. Mr Hussey's and Miss McCraw's watches are found stopped at twelve. Much of the party grows drowsy and falls asleep.

Analysis : The picnic and the characters' clothing appear incongruous against the ancient landscape; civilised behaviour seems intrusive or strangely detached from the wilderness. The gate is the first threshold between the familiar world and the unknown. The stopped watches signal that the Rock operates outside measured, human time.

Sequence 4 : The Climb

Summary : Miranda, Marion, Irma and Edith get permission to take measurements at the base of the Rock. Michael watches them cross the stream; Albert makes crude remarks. The girls climb higher, the rocks becoming increasingly maze-like. Near the top they fall asleep, then wake. Miranda, Marion and Irma, now without shoes and stockings, walk between two great rocks. Edith screams and runs back down. Miss McCraw is seen climbing alone.

Analysis : Successive thresholds (the gate, the stream, the narrowing passages) create the sense that the Rock is drawing the girls towards it. Miranda's line that 'everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place' suggests acceptance of a different kind of time, while Edith's 'when are we going home?' clings to ordinary chronology. Shedding clothes signals liberation from social convention.

Sequence 5 : The Return of the Drag

Summary : The drag arrives back at the college late at night. Mrs Appleyard, who has been waiting, hears from Mr Hussey that 'no one knows... We were asleep.'

Analysis : The schedule Mrs Appleyard imposed has collapsed. Mr Hussey's admission that everyone was asleep suggests that the rational, conscious mind was absent at the very moment of the event, an early sign that reason will not provide an answer.

Sequence 6 : The Investigation

Summary : Sergeant Bumpher leads the inquiry. Edith is examined by the doctor and asked 'Was there a man?' Mrs Bumpher reports that the town believes 'it couldn't be local.' Michael first says he saw three girls, then four. Asked what he was thinking of as the girls crossed the creek, he points to a swan vase. Edith returns to the Rock and remembers a red cloud and Miss McCraw climbing in her drawers; Bumpher fixates on the missing skirt. Search parties, a tracker and dogs comb the Rock.

Analysis : Each line of inquiry looks for an explanation that fits society's assumptions: a male attacker, an outsider, a sexual crime. Memory proves unreliable. Bumpher's dismissal of the red cloud shows that the authorities seek only the kind of explanation that fits their worldview. The film suggests rational thinking can be more concerned with preserving a sense of control than with discovering the truth.

Sequence 7 : Michael's Search

Summary : Against Albert's advice, Michael rides to the Rock and searches alone, staying overnight. He becomes disoriented, struggles to climb and falls asleep. Albert finds him dazed and injured, clutching a scrap of lace. Following Michael's trail, Albert discovers Irma alive.

Analysis : Michael succeeds where the official searches failed, perhaps because he is guided by emotion and intuition rather than logic. Yet the Rock also overwhelms him, rewarding curiosity while frustrating the desire for certainty.

Sequence 8 : Irma Recovers

Summary : Irma recuperates at the Fitzhuberts' home, shrouded beneath white gauzy fabric. The doctor tells Bumpher her condition is 'very strange.' She cannot remember what happened. The townspeople gather, demanding 'we've got a bloody right to know.' At the college, Miss Lumley calls the news 'wonderful'; Mrs Appleyard says it 'makes it worse.'

Analysis : Irma's return should solve the mystery but instead deepens it. Her lost memory denies rational explanation even to someone who was there. Mrs Appleyard's reaction reveals her real priority: one survivor with no story is worse for the college than a clear answer of any kind.

Sequence 9 : ‘Tell Us, Irma!’

Summary : Before leaving for Europe, Irma visits the college in a vivid red dress. In the gymnasium, where Sara has been strapped to the wall to cure her stooping, the girls surround Irma demanding answers. The scene becomes hysterical; Miss Lumley cowers behind the piano and Mademoiselle intervenes, slapping Edith.

Analysis : Irma’s red links her to the red cloud and suggests she has been transformed. The scene exposes the breakdown of social conventions: fear of the unknown and desperation for answers turn the ‘refined’ young ladies into a mob. Sara’s literal restraint is a stark image of the college’s oppressive control.

Sequence 10 : The College Unravels

Summary : Parents withdraw their daughters. Miss Lumley resigns. Mrs Appleyard drinks alone and tells Sara she must return to the orphanage. Sara is later found dead in the greenhouse by the head gardener. That night Albert dreams of his ‘kid sister’. Mrs Appleyard tells Mademoiselle that Sara’s guardian collected her.

Analysis : The greatest damage comes not from the Rock but from within the institution. Mrs Appleyard’s need for control turns into cruelty, and the most vulnerable person pays for it. Her lie about Sara shows her preserving appearances to the end.

Sequence 11 : The Ending

Summary : At dinner, Mrs Appleyard, dressed more softly than ever before, reminisces about Bournemouth, where ‘nothing changed – ever,’ and wonders how Miss McCraw could ‘allow herself to be spirited away.’ A final voice-over reports that the searches continued without result and that Mrs Appleyard died ‘while attempting to climb the rock.’ The film closes on slow-motion images of the picnic, with Miranda turning to wave.

Analysis : Mrs Appleyard, the film’s champion of order, is finally drawn to the Rock herself. Her dishevelled hair and black mourning clothes contrast with her immaculate appearance at the start. The closing return to the picnic, filmed to resemble old footage, leaves the audience suspended in the moment before the disappearance, and suggests that nature is timeless while society can be disrupted and destroyed.

Sequence and Theme Grid

Use this grid when you plan a Section A essay. Find the idea in the topic, read down the column, and choose the sequences where it is central for your main evidence. The sequence numbers match the Scene Summaries and Analyses page, and the evidence under the grid shows where to look.

Key: •• = central to the sequence; • = present and usable; blank = not a strong choice for that idea.

Sequence	Nature	Reason	Time	Class	Appearance	Restraint
1. The Opening	••	•	•	•	•	
2. St Valentine's Morning	•	••	•	••	••	••
3. The Picnic	••	•	••	••	•	•
4. The Climb	••	•	••	•	•	••
5. The Return of the Drag		••	•			
6. The Investigation	•	••		•		••
7. Michael's Search	••	•		•		•
8. Irma Recovers	•	••		•	••	•
9. 'Tell Us, Irma!'		•		••	••	••
10. The College Unravels	•	•		••	•	•
11. The Ending	••	•	••	•	•	•

Column headings: *Nature* = nature as a fundamental force; *Reason* = the human need for rationality and control; *Time* = time, measured and timeless; *Class* = class and civilisation; *Appearance* = beauty, innocence and appearance; *Restraint* = femininity, restraint and release. The first five match the Thematic Quote Bank; the sixth draws on the Values page.

Nature as a Fundamental Force

Central: 1, 3, 4, 7, 11.

- 1: the Rock emerges from the mist before we see the college, and Miranda's voice-over says 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.'
- 3: Irma, as the Rock comes into view: 'Waiting a million years, just for us.'
- 4: the narrowing passages draw the girls upward; Edith: 'Why can't we just sit on this log and look at the ugly old rock from here?'
- 7: the Rock overwhelms Michael, who is found dazed and injured, clutching a scrap of lace.
- 11: Mrs Appleyard, the champion of order, is found at the base of the Rock; the voice-over says 'she fell while attempting to climb the rock'.

- **Present:** the cultivated flowers of Sequence 2; Edith's memory of a red cloud in 6; Michael's 'It comes back at night in dreams'; Albert's dream of Sara in 10.

The Human Need for Rationality and Control

Central: 2, 5, 6, 8.

- 2: Mrs Appleyard's warnings about gloves, snakes and 'tomboy foolishness'.
- 5: Mr Hussey: 'No one knows. No one saw her leave. We were asleep.'
- 6: Sergeant Bumpher asks Edith, 'Was there a man?'; Mrs Bumpher insists, 'People just don't disappear, my dear. Not without good reason.'
- 8: the doctor finds Irma's condition 'very strange', and the townspeople shout, 'We've got a bloody right to know.'
- **Present:** Miss McCraw's 'Must be something magnetic' (3); Marion's measurements (4); Michael's intuition against Albert's advice (7); the girls' demand for answers (9); Mrs Appleyard's grip on the college (10); her question about Miss McCraw being 'spirited away' (11).

Time

Central: 3, 4, 11.

- 3: Mr Hussey: 'Blowed if me watch hasn't stopped.' Miss McCraw: 'Never stopped before. Must be something magnetic.' Miranda rejects her watch: 'Can't stand the ticking above my heart.'
- 4: Miranda: 'Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place'; Edith: 'When are we going home?'
- 11: Mrs Appleyard remembers Bournemouth, where 'Nothing changed. Ever.'; the slow-motion closing images hold the picnic in time.
- **Present:** the title card's exact date (1); Mrs Appleyard's expectation that the party will be back 'for a light supper' (2); the drag's late return (5).

Class and Civilisation

Central: 2, 3, 9, 10.

- 2: gloves, corsets and rules; Sara is told she cannot go on the picnic.
- 3: cake, china and white dresses laid out beneath the ancient Rock; Miss McCraw: 'How foolish can human creatures be.'
- 9: the 'refined' young ladies become a hysterical mob around Irma.
- 10: parents withdraw their daughters, and Mrs Appleyard tells Sara she will be returned to the orphanage.
- **Present:** the college framed by wild grass (1); Marion's 'Like a lot of ants' from the Rock (4); the town's 'It couldn't be local' (6); Michael and Albert's friendship across class (7); Mrs Appleyard's concern for the college's name (8); Bournemouth (11).

Beauty, Innocence and Appearance

Central: 2, 8, 9.

- 2: the girls in white, exchanging Valentines; flowers everywhere.
- 8: Irma, shrouded in white gauze; when Mademoiselle visits, she finds her ‘so pale but prettier than ever’.
- 9: Irma returns in a vivid red dress, set against the girls in white.
- **Present:** ‘what we see and what we seem’ (1); white dresses at the picnic (3); Mademoiselle’s ‘Botticelli angel’; Mrs Appleyard’s lie about Sara’s guardian (10); the final wave from Miranda (11).

Femininity, Restraint and Release

Central: 2, 4, 6, 9.

- 2: the girls lace one another’s corsets.
- 4: Miranda, Marion and Irma go on without shoes and stockings.
- 6: the investigation fixates on a man and on Miss McCraw’s missing skirt.
- 9: Sara strapped to the gymnasium wall, ‘for her own good’.
- **Present:** gloves removed after Woodend (3); the scrap of lace (7); the doctor’s examination of Irma (8); Miss Lumley’s departure (10); Mrs Appleyard dressed more softly than ever before (11).

Strong Combinations

- **Nature against civilisation:** 1, 3, 4, 11.
- **The failure of reason:** 5, 6, 8, 9.
- **Time, measured and timeless:** 3, 4, 11.
- **Institutional cruelty:** 2, 9, 10.

Close Analysis of Key Elements

Because there is little dialogue or character development in this film, you need to spend most of your time analysing setting, costume, objects, sound and structure. The notes below work through the key elements of the film in order, with evidence, possible interpretations and sentence starters for turning them into analysis.

The Opening and Closing Scenes

The film opens with a prologue card: *On Saturday 14th February 1900 a party of schoolgirls from Appleyard College picnicked at Hanging Rock near Mt. Macedon in the state of Victoria. During the afternoon several members of the party disappeared without trace…* This statement sets up the central mystery, but it also suggests a historical event, even though the story is invented. The credits then play over the Rock emerging as if from the mists of time, establishing it as a monument to the endurance of nature, all in under a minute and a half. The film ends with a deep voice explaining what happens to Mrs Appleyard and her college, and noting that the missing girls were never found. The final images are quasi-historical footage of the picnic, in disjointed camera work that further suggests the historical 'truth' of the film.

Throughout the film, Weir contrasts human lives with the natural world: humans need to understand, measure and create rules for their lives, but nature is impervious to all of them. The scenes that bookend the film make this contrast clear.

- **The prologue outlining a specific date** implies that humans need to measure and quantify experiences so that they can understand them.
- **Placing the events in a real, geographical space** creates the sense of a real, human tragedy that is recognisable and understandable.
- **The Rock gradually emerging from the mist** hints at the permanence of the natural world, as opposed to the ephemerality of human lives.
- **Clouds passing slowly over the immutable Rock** suggest that nature is timeless and immeasurable against human lives.
- **The final voice-over detailing the fates of the characters** creates the impression of events that can be quantified and understood.
- **The disjointed, quasi-historical style of the final footage** lends the film a reassuring sense of reality in an otherwise mysterious and confusing narrative.
- **The lingering final images of the girls** reinforce the idea that nature is mysterious and unknowable.

Contrasting the Opening and Closing

The two sequences are similar, but not identical. Some statements describe both; others suit one more than the other. Ideas to sort and compare:

- although people like to think of themselves as separate from nature, they are an integral part of the environment;
- the beauty of nature is reflected in the youthful grace of the girls;

- statements of fact are like natural features: fixed, measurable and knowable;
- human events sit within the natural landscape;
- nature possesses a power that exceeds human control;
- humanity is fragile when contrasted with the strength of nature;
- nature exists outside human understanding;
- nature exposes the limitations of human knowledge;
- knowledge is as stable and reliable as a rock.

Sentence building: *The film's framing scenes / In the opening and concluding moments / Both the opening and the closing of the film / The scenes that bookend Weir's film / By framing his film with scenes that… + share / mirror / reflect / echo + the sense that / a concern with / the idea that / the perception of / a view that / an understanding of… + however / yet / despite this / on the other hand / in contrast…*

Picnicking

It seems the only reason anyone goes to Hanging Rock is to picnic. Michael is there with his aunt and uncle (and Albert, although as a servant he has to eat on his own), and the girls of Appleyard College have their own picnic. Both groups eat in a highly ritualised fashion. Michael and his family gather around a tiny table, sipping tea from cups and saucers and staring into space. The girls offer up a toast to 'St. Valentine' as Miranda ritualistically cuts the cake. All of this says a great deal about the conventions and customs of the time.

Weir deliberately juxtaposes the elements of human civilisation against the ancient bushland. As you watch, look for human objects that seem out of place in the wilderness: the tablecloth, china cups and saucers, the cake, white dresses, parasols, gloves and hats, the drag and its harnessed horses, Mr Hussey's watch.

Word bank for incongruity: *are presented as incongruous against / contrast sharply with / appear discordant with / appear at odds with / provide an intrusive presence in / seem strangely detached from + the ancient landscape / this untamed wilderness / the elemental forces of nature / this rugged terrain / this expansive bushland / a world remote from civilisation.*

Sentence starters: *As the characters eat…; In the picnicking scenes…; When the characters picnic…; In comparison to the upper-class characters, who eat…, Albert…*

After the Meal

After they have finished eating, Edith looks at Michael's family and remarks that they 'might be the only living creatures in the whole world'. Weir then focuses on a group of ants who seem to be having their own picnic of the St Valentine's cake. By zooming in on the ants, Weir reminds us that the human picnic is only one small event in a teeming natural world that carries on regardless of it, and that civilisation's rituals are no defence against nature reclaiming what humans leave behind.

Having eaten, the humans show how 'civilised' they are through actions only humans perform:

- Mr Hussey wants to know the time.

- Irma talks about wearing diamonds in the bath.
- Marion asks if she can take measurements of the Rock.
- Miss McCraw reads.
- Mademoiselle compares a human girl to a piece of art.

These actions can be read in several ways: human beings are driven by a desire to make sense of their surroundings; people seek order in an otherwise chaotic world; individuals strive to categorise and define the world around them; the pursuit of knowledge reflects a deep-seated need for control; people feel compelled to shape the unfamiliar into a meaningful pattern.

Topic sentence to develop: *Weir's film examines the human impulse to impose a civilised order that is at odds with the natural world.*

Linking phrases: *Throughout the picnicking scene...; Weir depicts...; In doing so, Weir demonstrates...; This suggests that...; This implies that...; This is reinforced by...; Furthermore...; Similarly...; In addition...; Weir further emphasises this through...*

Thresholds

A threshold is a border between two places; a doorway, for example, is a threshold between the inside of a house and the outside world. Thresholds matter in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* because there are two distinct worlds in the film: the civilised, confined and restricted world of Appleyard College, and the wild, transcendent natural world of Hanging Rock. To pass from one world to the other, the girls cross physical thresholds that symbolise their transition from one way of thinking and behaving to another.

- **Threshold:** boundary, transition, barrier between, liminal space, passage from... to..., crossing over from... to..., the demarcation between, entry into a world of..., leaving behind.
- **Civilised world:** sanctioned space, the known, the familiar, order, control, institutional world, safety, routine, obedience.
- **Natural world:** the unknown, wilderness, discovery, freedom, instinct, the primal self, otherness, ungoverned nature, untamed nature.

The Gate

When the girls arrive at the base of the Rock there is a physical gate they must pass through. The symbol is simple, but Weir adds extra layers of meaning to the action of opening a gate between two worlds:

- Immediately before the gate scene, Michael and Albert, men from different classes, share a drink.
- Miranda, Irma and Marion, the three girls who go missing, sit at the head of the drag. Miranda leaps from the drag to open the gate.
- Miranda removes her hat, leaving it in the drag, to open the gate.
- Just before Miranda opens the gate, there is a close-up of a decrepit notice board, its bulletins unreadable from age and weathering.

- Immediately after the gate is opened, Miranda sees a group of birds flying through the sky, and the harnessed horses rear and cry out.

Sentence starters: *When the schoolgirls first arrive at the base of the Rock, Miranda opens a gate, symbolising…; Weir reinforces the significance of this symbol by…, which highlights…; Moreover…*

The Stream

When Miranda, Marion, Irma and Edith set out to climb the Rock (which they were warned not to do), they must cross a stream. Albert, watching, makes a crude, sexualised remark about the girls' appearance. Miranda throws a flower into the stream as she crosses, almost like an offering. Weir then provides a close-up of the stream, revealing its murky, organic naturalness. Possible interpretations:

- Miranda's flower offering suggests the girls are not simply crossing water: they are entering a kind of ritual, perhaps even making a pact with the natural world.
- Albert's voyeuristic commentary frames the crossing as a moment of exposure, as if crossing the stream strips away the girls' protection and makes them vulnerable.
- The murkiness of the stream suggests obscured vision, foreshadowing the incomprehensible nature of what is about to occur.
- The doubling of thresholds creates a sense of inevitability, as though the Rock is drawing the girls towards it through successive layers of boundary.

The Rocks

The final threshold is the rocks themselves. At the top, the girls find not a single rock but an immense series of rocks that have formed into tunnels and passageways. Miranda, Marion and Irma disappear through one such passageway at the end of the scene. Words to describe how Weir presents the rocks: *maze-like, labyrinthine, mysterious, disorienting, enthralling, drawing in, deep, cavernous, immersive, consuming, primordial, magnetic, twisting, spiralling, hypnotic, powerful*; the rocks form a *pathway* or *entrance way*.

Sentence frame: *When the girls get to the top, Weir depicts the rocks as… and…, symbolising how they offer a threshold to a world that is…*

Time Stops

After the picnic, the girls lounge about and one recites Shakespeare's sonnet 'Shall I compare thee to a summer's day', a poem full of references to time: seasons, months, days. At about this point Mr Hussey notices that his watch has stopped. Even though he says they need to be careful of the time, the four girls head up the Rock for the purpose of measuring it. On the Rock they gossip about Sara, and Irma compares her to a 'doomed' baby deer. Then they move in slow motion, taking off their shoes and stockings.

Each character's words reveal an attitude towards time:

- **Miranda:** 'Don't wear it anymore. Can't stand the ticking above my heart.' – she feels constrained by human constructs of time and seeks to escape them.

- **Miss McCraw:** 'Stopped at twelve. Never stopped before. Must be something magnetic.' – she is dependent on time as a scientific construct and searches for a rational cause.
- **Mr Hussey:** 'Well after two, I'd say. We'd better be careful. I promised Mrs Appleyard I'd have you lot back at the college by eight.' – he is compliant towards the conventions and expectations of schedules.
- **Marion:** 'I should like to make a few measurements of the rock if we have time.' – she feels a sense of authority about the measurement and regulation of time.
- **Irma:** 'We'll be back long before tea.' – she is confident, perhaps naively, in the relentless, predictable passage of time.
- **Miranda:** 'Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place.' – she is fatalistic about, even acquiescent to, a larger order that blurs temporal boundaries.
- **Edith:** 'When are we going home?' – she is reliant upon institutional order and patterns.

Attitude vocabulary: *fatalistic about, constrained by, reflective about, acquiescent to, feel a sense of authority about, dependent on, searching for, compliant towards, have a sense of agency + the relentless passage of time, adherence to human constructs of time, the ephemerality of time, time as a scientific construct, the measurement and regulation of time, a blurring of temporal boundaries, humanity's relationship with time, the conventions and expectations of schedules, a reliance upon institutional order and patterns*.

Miranda's attitude differs from the others: where most characters measure, obey or depend on time, she rejects her watch and accepts that events happen at their 'right time', as though she belongs to nature's timescale rather than the college's.

Film Techniques and Time

Weir also plays with time through cinematic devices. Action frequently happens in slow motion, suggesting time is not always linear. Compare two short scenes:

- **Miranda crosses the stream (00:23:20–00:23:43):** a young character, outdoors in nature, in slow motion, with ancient-sounding pan pipes in the background.
- **Mrs Appleyard waits (00:34:49–00:35:08):** an old character, indoors, in silence except for the ticking of a clock.

Statements to weigh up:

- Weir explores the tension between Edwardian society's obsession with schedules and the timelessness of the natural world.
- Weir suggests that humanity's need to measure time reflects a broader desire to impose order on an inherently mysterious universe.
- By disrupting conventions of time, Weir reveals the limitations of human understanding and rational thought.
- Weir's film illustrates that time may be fluid or multidimensional, rather than strictly linear.
- While some people live by the constraints of time, Weir demonstrates that others escape these limitations and transcend normal experience.

Trying to Make Sense of What Happened

The drag returns to Appleyard College without Miranda, Irma, Marion and Miss McCraw. The burning question on Mrs Appleyard's lips is not what has happened but 'Why are they so late?', which she asks of herself and of Mademoiselle as she steps down from the drag. This highlights a key focus of the authorities in the aftermath: attempting to make rational sense of an irrational situation.

What someone says or does	What it shows about 'rational' thinking
Mr Hussey, the first to give an account, tells Mrs Appleyard and then Sergeant Bumpher: 'No one knows. No one saw her leave. We were asleep.'	Being unconscious or asleep prevents the rational mind from witnessing, so reason is absent at the very moment of the event.
Sergeant Bumpher asks Edith 'Was there a man?' and the doctor checks her for evidence of assault.	For the authorities, the most rational explanation of girls disappearing is a male attacker: they look for an answer that fits their assumptions.
Mrs Bumpher reports the town's view: 'It couldn't be local... No one around here would do a thing like that.'	According to the community's rational thinking, a threat cannot come from within but must come from outside, because the community needs to believe in its own respectability.
Michael tells Sergeant Bumpher he saw three girls climbing the Rock, then recalls that it was four.	Human memory is not rational or reliable, yet it is all the investigation has to work with.
Edith, back at the Rock, remembers 'It was a cloud... it was red' and that Miss McCraw was climbing without her skirt, in her drawers. Bumpher ignores the cloud and fixates on the missing skirt.	Bumpher seeks a rational explanation that fits with his existing worldview, dismissing anything inexplicable.

Sentence starters:

- People try to make rational sense of the disappearances in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* by...
- Through various reactions to the disappearances, Weir suggests that people possess a deep psychological need to...
- Bumpher's failure to engage with Edith's revelation about the 'red cloud' portrays how rational society is unable to...
- The film reveals that rational thinking is often less concerned with discovering the truth than preserving a sense of...
- Ultimately, Weir portrays the disappearances as an event that resists rational explanation, exposing the limitations of...

Costume, Hair and Undress

Because this is a period drama, costume and styling are deeply symbolic. Mrs Appleyard has a towering pompadour, whereas Miranda's hair is long, blonde and naturalistic. The policemen's uniforms have brass buttons, while the workers wear shirt sleeves and waistcoats (not wearing a jacket was almost shockingly casual in Edwardian times). Michael wears a top hat even at a picnic.

Hair

When the picnic party arrives back at the college, Mademoiselle's hair is different from when she left. Mrs Appleyard descends the stairs with her hair very firmly in place, although later in the film this changes.

- **Miranda:** naturalistic, natural, untamed, romantic, innocent – connecting her to nature and freedom.
- **Mademoiselle:** carefully arranged before the picnic; dishevelled, tangled and in a state of disarray after it – the day at the Rock has loosened the order she brought with her.
- **Mrs Appleyard:** formal, rigid, upright, severe, restrained, carefully arranged – embodying institutional control, until it unravels in her final scenes.

What Each Group Wears

Watch the scenes from 00:38:14 to 00:45:56 and notice how costume signals class and the conventions that govern each character: gloves, hats and accessories as formal; jewels and watches as signs of wealth; flowers as a connection with nature or the romantic; uniforms as a job or profession; high necks or buttoned-up shirts as formal. Look closely at Mrs Appleyard, Mr Hussey, the policemen, the searchers (the Indigenous tracker wears a red coat), the doctor, Michael and Mademoiselle.

A State of Undress

Before the girls disappear into the Rock, they take off their shoes and stockings, and Edith reports that Miss McCraw 'was funny' because she was not wearing her skirt. Phrases you could use to interpret this: *free from social constraints, drawn to wilderness, divesting themselves of convention, leaving social order behind, guided by instinct, embracing freedom, celebrating the natural world, returning to a state of nature, immersed in the landscape, connected to a natural order, becoming one with nature, engaging in pagan ritual.*

Michael's Quest

The film is really three intersecting stories: the missing girls, Mrs Appleyard's victimisation of Sara, and Michael Fitzhubert's personal journey. In this part of the film, Weir suggests that answers to the mystery cannot be found through rational inquiry alone, but through a willingness to be open to the mystery and power of nature. The big question is: **why is Michael the only one who finds a missing girl?**

A Different Mindset

- Michael followed the girls partly up the Rock on the day they disappeared.
- When Sergeant Bumpher asks 'As the girls were jumping the creek, what were you thinking of?', Michael does not answer in words but points to a swan vase containing a native flower (one of the few times a native cut flower is shown).
- After Michael points to the swan vase, the scene segues to an image of Miranda and then of a real swan.
- Michael says, 'I wake up every night in a cold sweat. Just wondering if they're still alive.'

- Albert believes that if 'the bloody cop and the bloody… tracker and the bloody dog can't find 'em, well, no one bloody can.' But Michael believes 'they may be out there dying of thirst.'

This evidence supports several readings: Michael is guided by emotion rather than logic; he feels a spiritual or mystical connection to Miranda; he is less constrained by conventional society; he has developed a personal connection to the landscape; his youthful imagination lets him see possibilities others cannot; he is undertaking his own journey of self-discovery.

An Individual Search

While most characters have given up on finding the girls, Michael cannot let the mystery go.

- On the first day he searches with Albert and they find nothing. He leaves a trail of note paper to show where he has searched – a rational method.
- He decides to spend the night on the Rock, sending Albert home to tell his uncle he is staying the night in Woodend. There is an orange-red, mystical sunset.
- The next day he searches alone.
- At the top of the Rock he falls asleep, and we hear the voices of the girls describing the Rock from earlier in the film.

Words for analysis: *undergoes a…, open to…, driven by emotions of…, moves beyond, reflects the nature of…, drawn to…, personal, crosses a threshold by…, enters a different…, guided by, attuned, receptive to*.

Sentence frame: *Weir suggests that Michael succeeds in finding one of the girls where others fail because…*

Irma Returns

After Albert rescues Michael, he rushes back to the Rock to find the source of the white lace fragment Michael handed him, and finds Irma. At first he is wary, thinking she must be dead, but after nudging her he realises she is alive. Everyone should be delighted, but the discovery unsettles them, because it raises more questions. Where are the others? How did the searchers miss Irma? Why was she not dead after a week on the Rock? As the doctor says: 'Remarkable.'

Writing About Mystery

Evidence from quotes and cinematography:

- When Albert finds Irma there is an eerie sound of wind rushing through the Rock.
- As the news spreads, the townspeople gather to find answers or renew the search.
- Outside Bumpher's house, a man shouts, 'We've got a bloody right to know.'
- Mrs Appleyard tells her students they can 'thank the Lord for this merciful deliverance of our dear classmate Irma'.
- Mrs Appleyard chides Miss Lumley, saying that 'this makes it worse'.
- Irma recuperates shrouded beneath white, gauzy fabric.
- As the doctor lists Irma's injuries, he tells Bumpher that her unmarked feet are 'very strange'.

- The head gardener says that 'there's some questions got answers and some haven't'.

Analytic phrases: *evokes a sense of, suggests, highlights how, demonstrates, imbues the scene with, reveals, elicits the feeling of, signals, implies, examines, accentuates, brings into focus.*

Mystery phrases: *resistant to definitive explanations, steeped in ambiguity, demand rationality in everyday life, are subject to forces beyond understanding, human understanding has limits, believe that everything can be explained with effort and application, suggestive of forces beyond logic, imbued with a dreamlike uncertainty, veiled from rational explanation, shrouded in mystery, must accept the limits of human comprehension.*

Practice topic: *Peter Weir's film explores a world filled with mysteries beyond human understanding. Discuss.* Possible topic sentences:

- Weir suggests that humanity's desire to impose order on the world is ultimately challenged by forces beyond its understanding.
- Weir's film demonstrates that rational explanations are often inadequate when confronted with the mysteries of the natural world.
- *Picnic at Hanging Rock* explores the tension between humanity's need for answers and the existence of mysteries that remain unresolved.
- By surrounding key events with ambiguity, Weir emphasises that complete understanding is often unattainable.
- *Picnic at Hanging Rock* demonstrates the discomfort that people experience when faced with the inexplicable.

Linking language: *The film further explores this idea when...; Weir's exploration of... is exemplified by...; The significance of this... is evident in...; Weir reinforces this through...; This idea is visually represented by...; This becomes particularly evident when...; moreover, again, furthermore, likewise, what is more, more profoundly; while, however, yet, even though, although, whereas.*

Mrs Appleyard's Story

Mrs Appleyard is one of the film's most important characters. She has created the school's ethos and rules, so she represents a form of institutional authority that seeks to organise and control the lives of women. Her status and reputation depend on how the girls present themselves to the world. When the girls disappear under mysterious circumstances, and evidence emerges that their corsets and clothing had been removed, her standing as a figure of authority, respectability and decorum is irreparably damaged. She is ultimately a tragic figure: like many tragic characters she cannot bend or adapt, clinging desperately to social status, order and control. This rigidity leads to her downfall. She dies, apparently, 'while attempting to climb the rock', the natural force that challenged her belief in human order and exposed the limits of her authority.

Mrs Appleyard's Nature

- Her formal, ornate and old-fashioned hairstyle.

- The watch she wears pinned to her chest.
- Most of her interactions with others involve reminding them of the rules.
- Her unsympathetic interactions with Sara Waybourne.
- Her dark clothing and black dresses.
- In the second half of the film, she wears a brooch with a photograph of her husband.
- Her belief that finding 'only one' girl 'makes it worse'.
- Her insistence that Appleyard College is not a 'charitable institution'.
- She is typically shown at her desk, standing higher than other characters, or in an over-the-shoulder shot.
- The dinner where she remembers the good old days at Bournemouth, when 'nothing changed – ever'.

Vocabulary: *authoritarian, controlling, representative of institutional authority, strict, fragile, fearful of disorder, inflexible, rigid, elitist, lonely, conventional, rule-bound, cold, distant.*

Sentence frames: *Weir depicts Mrs Appleyard's... nature through...; Weir creates a portrait of Mrs Appleyard as... and... by...*

Mrs Appleyard's Setting

Weir conveys Mrs Appleyard not only through what she wears and how she behaves, but through the spaces she occupies, chiefly her study and sometimes her bedroom.

- **The clock that constantly and audibly ticks in her study** conveys her obsession with order, schedules and discipline.
- **The large portrait of Queen Victoria, surrounded by the English flag, above her desk** represents her need to display her reverence for authority and status.
- **The pictures of her husband and ancestors on her study walls** symbolise her attachment to history and convention.
- **The picture of a tiger on her study wall** illustrates both the power of her authority and hidden emotional depths.

Mrs Appleyard's End

Because Mrs Appleyard represents institutional authority, the events at the Rock, which challenge human order and certainty, have a profound effect on her.

- On the night before her death, she dines with Mademoiselle de Poitiers, wearing softer, less severe clothing: the only time we see her dressed this way.
- At dinner, she reminisces about annual holidays in Bournemouth with her late husband, describing it as 'a delightful place'.
- She admits she had come to 'depend so much on Greta McCraw' and her 'masculine intellect', wondering, 'How could she allow herself to be spirited away?'

- The final image of her shows her in black mourning clothes and a funeral veil, staring directly into the camera, as we are told she died 'while attempting to climb the rock'.

Question to answer: What are the consequences of Mrs Appleyard's controlling mindset?

Unresolved Mysteries

You could write an essay about unresolved mysteries that goes: *There's a rock. It does strange things. End of story.* It would not get a good mark. Instead, consider the evidence for each mystery and weigh up possible interpretations.

1. Why Does Irma Return but the Others Stay Missing?

Evidence:

- When Miranda says at the picnic that she no longer wears her pretty jewelled watch, Irma says that if it were hers, she would wear it 'always… even in the bath.'
- Before the girls disappear, Irma says to the prone Edith, 'Poor Edith. We'll go back soon.'
- Irma cannot recall what happened to her on the Rock.
- **M**iranda, **M**arion and Miss **M**cCraw are all linked in their names; Irma is different.
- When Irma revisits Appleyard College, she wears a vivid red dress. The cloud Edith saw at the Rock was red.

Possible interpretations: Irma belongs more to the world of civilisation than to the mysterious world of nature; Irma belongs to both worlds; one girl returning heightens the mystery and uncertainty of what happened to the others, a reminder that some mysteries can never be solved; nature allows no rational explanation of its mysteries, even to those who experienced them; Irma has been transformed by her experiences on the Rock, offering a glimpse of what might have happened to the other girls.

2. Why Does the Rock Affect People Differently?

Evidence:

- On the day of the picnic, many characters at the Rock (including Michael's uncle and aunt) are overcome by sleepiness.
- While Miranda, Marion and Irma are drawn to the Rock, Edith finds it 'nasty'.
- Michael and Albert remain unaffected by the sleepiness that overtakes others on the day of the picnic.
- When Edith returns to the Rock with Sergeant Bumpher and Mademoiselle, she seems unaffected by its mysterious power.
- When Bumpher and the first search party climb the Rock, they stop halfway, overcome by heat and exhaustion.
- When Michael searches the Rock alone, he becomes disoriented, struggles to climb and eventually falls asleep.

- After Irma returns, the final search shows the party gathered at the base of the Rock in a relaxed, almost picnic-like atmosphere.

Possible interpretations: the more people attempt to investigate and control the mysteries of the Rock, the more it resists them; the Rock's power is shaped by each person's willingness, or inability, to embrace the unknown; those who approach the Rock with openness are more receptive to its power; the Rock invites people to abandon the constraints of civilisation and enter a timeless world; the Rock reveals people's true nature rather than affecting everyone the same way; it rewards curiosity but frustrates the desire for certainty; its power cannot be predicted or explained by human logic.

3. What Happened to Sara?

Weir creates a trail of deliberately conflicting clues about Sara's fate.

- Before Mrs Appleyard sees Sara for the last time, Sara sits on her bed beneath a painting of a woman holding two babies, repeating to herself, 'This is not a charitable institution.'
- Mrs Appleyard tells Mademoiselle that Sara's guardian has come to collect her, though this appears not to have happened. In their final meeting she instead tells Sara, 'You will be returned to the orphanage.'
- Immediately after this, we see luggage being packed into a carriage, although it later becomes clear this is happening at Michael's house.
- After her final meeting with Mrs Appleyard, Sara smiles to herself with an expression of quiet resolution.
- On the night of Sara's death, Albert dreams of his sister, who tells him, 'I've come a long way to see ya, and now I must go.'

Possible interpretations: Mrs Appleyard drives Sara to end her own life; Mrs Appleyard murders Sara; Sara's fate mirrors the disappearances, suggesting the Rock's influence extends beyond the landscape; the search for certainty about Sara's death is as futile as the search for the missing girls; Sara's fate shows that human actions in 'civilisation' are just as mysterious as nature; Sara escapes institutional control only through death.

4. What Happened to Mrs Appleyard?

Evidence:

- In her final scene, Mrs Appleyard wears mourning clothes, as though grieving the loss of her school, her reputation or even herself.
- In her final scene, she wears an expression of quiet resolve, echoing Sara's demeanour before her death.
- She admits she had come to 'depend' on Miss McCraw and cannot understand how her masculine intellect could be 'spirited away… like a silly schoolgirl.'

Possible interpretations: Mrs Appleyard confronts the mysterious power of the Rock and is overwhelmed by it; she is seeking answers at the Rock; she is unhappy with her status and identity and seeks transformation on the Rock; by climbing the Rock herself, she abandons the ordered world she spent her life defending.

Activity: Arrange the four mysteries on a spectrum from *mysterious, unsettling and disturbing* to *makes sense, can be accepted*. Which do you find least and most explicable, and why?

Time: Finite and Infinite

Humans measure time in years, months, weeks, days, all the way down to microseconds, as though it gives them control. Most characters measure out their lives, but there are notable exceptions: Miranda has an almost mystical belief that everything happens at 'exactly the right time'. One of Weir's central points is that the natural world has boundless, apparently infinite time, while humans have only a brief, finite time to live.

- **Time as finite and measurable:** 'What time is it?'; the grandfather clock in Mrs Appleyard's study; the regular beat of classical music; 'can't stand the ticking above my heart' (Miranda, of her watch); the date and year at the opening of the film; Minnie and Tom rushing to get dressed because time has got away from them; 'Blowed if me watch hasn't stopped'; 'When are we going home?'; 'I'd wear it always' (Irma, of Miranda's watch); 'We'd better be careful. I promised Mrs Appleyard…'.
- **Time as infinite and endless:** 'Everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place'; slow-motion filming of Miranda; the thrumming of the Rock; 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream'; the haunting pan flutes; the footage of the picnic at the end of the film, simulating the limited frames of historic film; the Rock is 'quite young, geologically speaking'; 'Waiting a million years, just for us'; the girls losing track of time and dancing on top of the Rock; the opening shot of Hanging Rock emerging from mist.

Organising Evidence for Essays

For each key idea, gather evidence from three areas before you plan. Tick off what you can use, then note quotes, actions or scenes for each.

- **Characters:** Miranda, Marion, Irma, Edith, Sara, Mrs Appleyard, Mademoiselle, Miss McCraw, Michael, Albert, Bumpher.
- **Symbols:** the Rock, thresholds, animals, the swan, flowers, costume, hairstyles, mirrors, watches, clock sounds, contrasting settings.
- **Film techniques:** slow motion, the prologue card, the closing voice-over, pan-pipe music, classical music, thrumming sounds, shrieking sounds, science-fiction-like sounds.

Guiding questions for each idea:

- **Nature as a fundamental force:** how do these elements show that nature is powerful, mysterious, frightening, fascinating or beyond human control?
- **Rationality and control:** how do they show that humans yearn for order and certainty, as opposed to the irrationality and disorder of nature?
- **Class and civilisation:** how do they show aspects of institutions, authorities, social divisions, rules and conventions?
- **Time:** how do they show aspects of time, systems, routines, measurement and cycles?

A Paragraph Frame

Topic: *In Picnic at Hanging Rock, the natural world is unknowable. Discuss.*

- **Topic sentence:** From the beginning of *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Peter Weir presents the natural world as a mysterious force that can never be fully understood.
- **Initial examples:** In the scene where…, Weir suggests that nature…; Through the use of…, Weir emphasises…; This suggests that the natural world…
- **Link:** Weir further underlines the mystery of the untamed world through…
- **Further examples:** When…, we see that…; By…, Weir illustrates that…
- **Synthesising sentence:** Ultimately, Weir represents the natural realm through these scenes as… and…

A second topic sentence to try: *The majority of human interactions in the wilderness surrounding Hanging Rock illustrate a deep discomfort and unease.*

Unpacking Topics into Sub-Ideas

To what extent does *Picnic at Hanging Rock* suggest that the desire to understand the world is ultimately futile? Brainstorm alternatives for 'understand the world' and 'futile', then choose a sub-idea:

- The film suggests that humanity's search for certainty is ultimately defeated by the enduring mysteries of the natural world.
- Weir portrays the failure of the police investigation as a symbol of the limits of human explanation.
- By refusing to explain the disappearance, Weir challenges the audience's assumption that every mystery has a solution.
- Although the truth remains elusive, the characters' attempts to understand the disappearance expose important truths about themselves and their society.
- While *Picnic at Hanging Rock* denies both its characters and audience definitive answers, it suggests that the search for meaning remains an essential part of the human experience.

The film suggests that human systems of order collapse when confronted by nature. To what extent do you agree?

- Throughout *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Weir presents the natural world as a force that exposes the fragility of human attempts to impose order.
- The disappearance at Hanging Rock reveals how quickly the certainty and structure of society begin to unravel.
- The film portrays institutions of society as ineffective when faced with forces they cannot explain.
- The failure of authority figures throughout the film demonstrates that positions of power offer little protection against nature's influence.

- As the mystery deepens, the carefully maintained appearance of control gradually gives way to confusion, fear and disorder.

In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, appearances are carefully maintained, but rarely reflect reality. Discuss. This topic has two parts: appearances are carefully maintained; appearances do not reflect reality. Brainstorm vocabulary and examples for each, then write a paragraph whose first half shows how Weir presents people and settings with carefully maintained appearances, and whose second half shows how these do not reflect reality.

The greatest threat to order in *Picnic at Hanging Rock* comes not from nature but within society itself. Discuss. Brainstorm 'threats from nature' against 'greater threats from within society', then write a paragraph responding to each part.

An essay process for time topics: circle key words in the topic; brainstorm alternative vocabulary; refer back to your notes and tables to brainstorm examples; sort examples into three or four groups as the basis for body paragraphs; plan the topic sentence for each group; write the essay. Try it on: *Human systems of order are insignificant when confronted by the natural world*; *Picnic at Hanging Rock highlights how nature is timeless and mysterious*; *In Picnic at Hanging Rock, the order and rules of civilisation are rendered meaningless by the natural world*.

Film Techniques

List of Techniques

Film Techniques in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*

Technique	Definition / Effect	Example in the film
Extreme long shot	Shows a subject from a great distance, often dwarfed by its surroundings.	The girls appear tiny against the towering pinnacles of the Rock, emphasising human insignificance.
Low-angle shot	Camera looks up at a subject, making it seem powerful or threatening.	The Rock is frequently shot from below, so it towers over and dominates the characters.
High-angle shot	Camera looks down on a subject, making it seem small or vulnerable.	Marion looks down on the picnickers 'like a lot of ants'; Mrs Appleyard is often positioned above others.
Framing	How elements are arranged within the frame to direct attention or suggest relationships.	Characters are enveloped by foliage or enclosed by rock walls, appearing subsumed by nature.
Slow motion	Footage played slower than real time, creating a dreamlike or significant effect.	Miranda at the stream and the final picnic images, suggesting a moment outside ordinary time.
Soft focus and diffused light	Blurred edges and hazy light that soften the image.	The morning at Appleyard and the picnic glow like paintings, idealising the girls and the bush.
Dissolve	One image fades gradually into another, linking them.	Michael's swan vase gives way to Miranda and then to a real swan, linking the three.
Voice-over	Narration heard over the images.	Miranda's opening 'dream within a dream'; the closing report of Mrs Appleyard's death.
Diegetic sound	Sound that exists within the world of the film.	The ticking of clocks, the thrum of the Rock, cicadas and birdsong.
Non-diegetic sound	Sound added for the audience, such as the score.	Zamfir's pan flute and Bruce Smeaton's music over the landscape.
Soundscape	The combination of music, effects and ambient sound that builds atmosphere.	A low rumble and shrieking, insistent noise during the climb create unease.
Costume	Clothing used to communicate character, class and ideas.	White muslin, gloves and hats at the college; Irma's red dress on her return; Mrs Appleyard's black mourning clothes.
Mise-en-scène	Everything placed in the frame: setting, props, costume, lighting, actors' positions.	Mrs Appleyard's study with its grandfather clock and portrait, signalling order and authority.
Symbolic colour	Colour used to carry meaning.	White suggests innocence and conformity; red links Miss McCraw's dress, the red cloud and Irma's return.
Cross-cutting	Cutting between two scenes happening at the same time.	Moving between the college and the Rock, or between Sara and Albert on the night of her death.
Close-up	Tightly frames a face or object to reveal emotion or detail.	Stopped watches, Miranda's face, Sara's photograph of Miranda.

Technique	Definition / Effect	Example in the film
Point-of-view shot	Shows what a character sees.	Michael watching the girls cross the stream; the girls looking up at the Rock.
Archival effect	Footage styled to look like old film.	The final picnic images simulate the limited frames of historic film, as if the past is a lost record.

Framing the Rock

How Weir frames the Rock is one of the most reusable pieces of evidence in the film. The camera presents the Rock as something that acts on the characters. Useful vocabulary:

- **What the Rock does (verbs):** towers over, dwarfs, encloses, conceals, swallows, lures, beckons, traps, dominates, overwhelms.
- **What the Rock is (nouns):** labyrinth, barrier, gateway, prison, predator, refuge, mystery, force, portal, wilderness.
- **What the Rock is like (adjectives):** towering, ancient, mysterious, claustrophobic, menacing, alluring, hypnotic, overwhelming, otherworldly, unknowable.
- **How characters are framed within nature:** vulnerable, subsumed, enveloped, immersed, diminished, overshadowed.

> *'Through low-angle shots that make the Rock tower over the climbing girls, Weir portrays nature as an ancient, dominating force that dwarfs human ambition.'*

Sound and Music

The soundtrack is one of Weir's main tools for creating mystery. Notice how each element connects to an idea:

- **Classical music** (such as Beethoven) – the human construct of measurable time and European order imposed on beauty.
- **Pan pipes** – the timelessness and haunting allure of nature; liberation from social convention.
- **The string quartet and parlour music** – the constraints of etiquette and the preservation of social hierarchy.
- **The thrumming of the Rock** – the inexplicable power of the natural world and its ancient rhythms.
- **Shrieking, insistent noise** – human horror and discomfort in the face of the unknowable.
- **Ticking clocks** – humanity's desire to measure, schedule and control.
- **Science-fiction-like beeping** – nature governed by incomprehensible forces; the transcendence of conventional time.

> *'Through the soundtrack, Weir demonstrates that humanity's obsession with measuring time is ultimately pointless when compared with the timelessness of nature.'*

Some of the music has a time signature (like most music you hear), some has a drifting, ethereal time signature (the pan pipes), and some has no time signature at all (the thrumming of the Rock). Music also creates mood. Other connections to consider: people's desire to create structures and societal conventions; the quest for individual identity outside social mores; temporal order imposed on beauty; liberation from social convention; frustration with unanswered questions.

Other topic sentences for a paragraph that refers only to sound:

- The soundtrack of Weir's film underscores how humanity's desire to impose order contrasts with the mysteries of the natural environment.
- Through the soundscape of his film, Weir presents how humans have a limited and incomplete understanding of enigmatic natural forces.
- Through the music of the film, Weir suggests that nature offers liberation from the restrictive expectations of Edwardian society.
- The music and soundscape of *Picnic at Hanging Rock* evoke the timeless rhythms of nature and the artificiality of human structures and conventions.

Costume

Costume tells us about class, conformity and transformation.

- **The schoolgirls:** white dresses, gloves and hats suggest elegance, innocence and respectability, but also fragility and restraint. Those who climb remove hats, gloves, shoes and stockings; Edith keeps hers on.
- **Mrs Appleyard:** dark, severe dresses, an ornate, old-fashioned hairstyle and a watch pinned to her chest. Later she wears a brooch with her late husband's photograph, and at the end her carefully arranged hair becomes dishevelled.
- **Miss McCraw:** a dark red dress and a veil to keep flies off her face.
- **Mademoiselle:** lace blouses, frills, pearls, lace gloves and softly waving hair – elegant and romantic.
- **Miss Lumley:** plaid, simple printed blouses, spectacles and muddy colours – sensible, muted, utilitarian.
- **Irma's return:** a vivid red dress among the white uniforms, linking her to the red cloud and marking her transformation.
- **Uniforms:** the police, the doctor and the searchers (including the Indigenous tracker in a red coat) are identified by their roles, showing how society organises people by function and class.

Symbols

Symbol	Meaning and significance
Hanging Rock	– Symbolises the power of nature and humanity's attraction to and fear of it – Ancient and unknowable, it exists beyond human understanding, control and time – Represents not only the external natural world but people's inner nature: their instincts, feelings and desires
Watches and Clocks	– Represent the human need to measure, organise and control time – Miranda rejects her watch; Irma would wear it 'always'; Hussey's and McCraw's watches stop at twelve – Mrs Appleyard's pinned watch and the grandfather clock in her study embody institutional order
Flowers	– Cultivated flowers represent nature domesticated, arranged and controlled by civilisation – Reinforce a European ideal of feminine beauty imposed on the Australian landscape – Contrast with the wild grasses and growth at the Rock; Miranda's flower offering at the stream suggests a pact with nature – Many girls carry red roses on the way to the St Valentine's picnic; Irma wears a robe with floral emblems when Mademoiselle visits her; her red hat on her return looks like a red rose – Albert's dream of his sister comes with the 'strong' smell of pansies; in Mrs Appleyard's final scene, a white rose sits on her desk
Thresholds: the Gate, the Stream, the Rocks	– Each marks a crossing from the familiar, sanctioned world into the unknown – The murky stream suggests obscured vision and foreshadows the incomprehensible – The doubling of thresholds creates a sense of inevitability, as if the Rock is drawing the girls in
The Swan	– Associated with Miranda through Michael's swan vase and the dissolve to a real swan – Like the 'Botticelli angel', suggests grace, purity and something otherworldly – Represents Michael's romantic, intuitive connection to Miranda and the natural world – A white swan glides on the water twice and appears beside Michael's bed once; only Michael sees it, and in its final appearance it flies away off-screen
Animals	– The world of the Rock features ants, cicadas, lizards and snakes: strange, ancient and beyond control – The world of civilisation features horses, dogs and turkeys: tame, obedient and dependent – Marion's comparison of people to 'a lot of ants' reverses the hierarchy, making humans seem insignificant
The Colour Red	– Miss McCraw's dark red dress, the red cloud Edith remembers, and Irma's red dress on her return – Suggests danger, passion and transformation in contrast to the white of innocence and conformity
Clothing: Corsets, Gloves and Stockings	– Symbolise the restraint society places on young women – Removing them on the Rock signals liberation; Irma's missing clothing becomes an obsession for the investigators
The Botticelli Angel	– Mademoiselle's comparison idealises Miranda as a work of art: beautiful, pure, and not quite of this world – Shows how the characters see Miranda through European cultural ideals rather than as she is
Mirrors	– Miranda is first seen combing her hair at a table, her reflection shown in multiple mirrors – When Mademoiselle first speaks to Irma after her return, Irma is initially shown as a blurred reflection in a mirror – Near the end, Mrs Appleyard combs her hair while looking mournfully into a mirror

Symbol	Meaning and significance
	– Suggest the quest for identity: reflecting, examining and confronting the self; more than one identity; hidden feelings
Dreams	– Michael dreams of the Rock; Albert dreams of his sister on the night of her death – Disconnected from the rational mind, dreams suggest connections between people and nature that transcend logic
Mrs Appleyard's Study	– Its clock, desk and portrait of her husband represent authority, order and the past – As events spiral, it becomes a place of drinking and isolation, symbolising the collapse of her control

Linking a Symbol to a Key Idea

A model, using vocabulary from the notes on mirrors:

> *Throughout Picnic at Hanging Rock, Weir emphasises the quest for identity through the symbolism of mirrors. By repeatedly showing characters* ***examining*** *themselves in mirrors, Weir suggests that identity is something that must be* ***confronted*** *rather than simply accepted. At the very beginning of the film, Miranda is first shown sitting at a table combing her hair, her reflection appearing in multiple mirrors to suggest that her* ***sense of self*** *cannot be reduced to or* ***confined*** *by a single definition.*

Try the same with animals (*strange, safe, familiar, obedient, ancient, threatening, beyond control, untameable, tame, dependent*), flowers (*transformation, romance, loss, beauty, youth, innocence, fragility, the domestic world, ephemerality, the passing of time, refinement, transience, grief, death, connection to emotions, civilisation, respectability, the ordered natural world, traditional femininity*) and the swan (*idealisation, transformation, purity, of the natural world, dreamlike quality, transcendence, serenity, conventional beauty, unattainable, beyond the human world, out of reach, freedom*).

Written Exemplars

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Ideas & interpretation | Structure & evidence | Language & technique

Written Exemplars

Sample 1: Model *Picnic at Hanging Rock* Essay

Topic: **How does Weir depict the natural world as a source of both fascination and fear?**

Introduction

In *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1975), Peter Weir constructs the Australian bush as a place that draws people in at the very moment it threatens to consume them. Through his framing of the ancient Rock, his treatment of time and the haunting soundscape of the film, Weir presents a landscape that is at once enchanting and menacing to the members of colonial society who visit it. Ultimately, the film suggests that nature's allure and its danger come from the same source: it lies beyond the reach of human understanding and control.

Body Paragraph 1

From the opening sequence, Weir establishes the Rock as an alluring yet ominous presence that overshadows the civilised world. The film begins not with Appleyard College but with the Rock emerging slowly from mist, accompanied by Miranda's voice-over: 'what we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.' By placing the Rock first, before the factual title card and the image of the college, Weir signals that nature is the primary force in the film, older and more powerful than the society that tries to explain it. As the girls climb, low-angle shots make the pinnacles tower over them, while narrow passages enclose them in a labyrinth of stone. The girls are enthralled, gazing upwards as if hypnotised, yet the same framing diminishes them, rendering them vulnerable within a landscape that seems to be swallowing them. Through this framing, Weir positions viewers to share the girls' fascination while sensing the threat they cannot see. This is how the film makes nature's allure and its danger inseparable.

Body Paragraph 2

Weir further portrays nature as captivating and frightening by showing that it operates outside the measured, human time on which civilisation depends. Mrs Appleyard's instruction to return 'at about 8' and Irma's confidence that they will be back 'long before tea' reflect a society organised by schedules. At the Rock, however, these certainties dissolve: Mr Hussey's and Miss McCraw's watches stop at twelve, and Miss McCraw can only speculate that there 'must be something magnetic.' For Miranda, this escape from clock time is liberating. She cannot 'stand the ticking above [her] heart' and, at the summit, declares that 'everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place.' For Edith, by contrast, the loss of ordinary time is terrifying, as her repeated plea, 'when are we going home?', reveals. Weir thus shows that the timelessness of nature is fascinating to those willing to surrender to it and frightening to those who cling to human order.

Body Paragraph 3

The soundscape of the film reinforces this duality, making the bush seem both enchanting and unsettling. Gheorghe Zamfir's pan flute drifts over images of the girls crossing the stream, imbuing the landscape with an ethereal, romantic beauty and associating it with freedom from the restrictions of the college. Yet beneath this music Weir layers a low, insistent rumble that seems to emanate from the Rock itself, and as Edith flees, her screams merge with a shrieking, discordant noise. These sounds destabilise the idyllic images and evoke a sense of forces beyond human comprehension. Even after Irma is found, an eerie rush of wind through the rocks suggests that nature's mystery remains intact. Through this contrast between seductive melody and menacing sound, Weir ensures that the audience never fully trusts the beauty of the bush.

Conclusion

Weir's *Picnic at Hanging Rock* depicts the natural world as a source of fascination precisely because it is a source of fear. Through framing that dwarfs the characters, a treatment of time that defies human measurement and a soundscape that blends beauty with menace, Weir presents a landscape that invites surrender while threatening destruction. In refusing to explain the disappearance, the film leaves its audience in the same position as its characters: drawn to a mystery that cannot be solved.

Sample 2: Paragraph Rewrite

Topic: **In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the passing of time deepens rather than resolves the mystery of the girls' disappearance. Discuss.**

Original paragraph (does not fully respond to the topic)

Irma's return provides hope that the mystery of the other girls' disappearance might eventually be solved. When Irma is found, the townspeople gather together to find answers and renew the search. One man even shouts, 'we've got a bloody right to know,' showing that people are still determined to discover what happened. However, Irma cannot remember what happened to her on the Rock. The doctor also describes Irma's condition as 'very strange,' while Mrs Appleyard says that her return 'makes it worse.' These examples show that Irma's return does not solve the mystery and that the characters still have lots of unanswered questions.

What is wrong with it?

- The topic sentence argues the opposite of the topic (hope of resolution) and never mentions time.
- It shows that questions remain unanswered, but not how Irma's return creates *new* questions.
- It does not explain why Mrs Appleyard says Irma's return 'makes it worse'.
- It ends by summarising events rather than making a larger point about Weir's message.

Rewritten paragraph

Rather than bringing the investigation closer to the truth, Irma's return a week after the picnic only multiplies the questions surrounding the disappearance. As news spreads, the townspeople gather outside Bumpher's house, and one man's insistence that 'we've got a

bloody right to know' reveals a community that assumes time and effort will inevitably produce answers. Yet Irma cannot remember what happened on the Rock, and the doctor's verdict that her condition is 'very strange' turns the one surviving witness into a fresh mystery. Mrs Appleyard's response, that the discovery 'makes it worse', is telling: a single survivor with no story removes the possibility of a simple ending, leaving the fate of the others more uncertain than before. Weir underscores this as Irma recuperates shrouded beneath white gauze, an image that veils her as completely as the mist veils the Rock. Through Irma's return, Weir suggests that the passage of time does not erode a mystery but entrenches it, exposing the limits of a society that believes everything can be explained.

Sample 3: Essay Plan

Topic: **How does Weir explore the relationship between knowledge and control in *Picnic at Hanging Rock*?**

This topic has two ideas, and both must be addressed. You might show how characters are motivated more by one than the other, how the desire for one leads to the other, or how the two come into conflict.

Contention

Weir suggests that characters seek knowledge in order to gain control, but that the Rock exposes the limits of both, forcing them to confront a world that cannot be understood or mastered.

BP1: People initially seek knowledge as a way of gaining control over the world.

- Miss McCraw studies the Rock through geometry and geology – she tries to understand nature through measurement and logic.
- Marion wants to 'make a few measurements of the rock' – knowledge as a way of claiming the landscape.
- Mrs Appleyard's warnings about snakes, ants and 'tomboy foolishness' – knowing the dangers in advance is meant to keep the girls safe and controlled.
- Sergeant Bumpher questions witnesses ('Was there a man?') – seeks a rational explanation that will restore order.

BP2: Weir shows that attempts to gain knowledge often reveal the limits of human control.

- Michael changes his memory from three girls to four – memory and perception are unreliable.
- Bumpher dismisses Edith's red cloud and fixates on Miss McCraw's missing skirt – the authorities accept only knowledge that fits their worldview.
- The watches stop at twelve: 'Must be something magnetic' – the instruments of control fail.
- The doctor finds Irma's condition 'very strange' – investigation deepens rather than solves the mystery.

BP3: Ultimately, people must accept that complete knowledge and control are impossible – and those who cannot accept this are destroyed.

- Mrs Appleyard says finding only one girl ‘makes it worse’ – uncertainty threatens her need for order.
- Her control turns to cruelty towards Sara, and her college collapses.
- The head gardener: ‘There’s some questions got answers and some haven’t’ – acceptance of uncertainty.
- Mrs Appleyard dies ‘while attempting to climb the rock’ – the champion of control is consumed by what she could not understand.

Section A Sample Essays: *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (Low, Medium and High)

Topic: **Weir suggests that the order imposed by Appleyard College cannot contain the natural world. To what extent do you agree?**
Sample Essay I (Low)

Introduction

In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Peter Weir shows a school trying to control nature and failing. I agree with the statement because the college’s rules, its clocks and its sounds all break down when the girls go to the Rock. Weir uses setting, time and sound to show this.
Body Paragraph 1

Weir shows that the college’s rules mean little against the power of nature. Mrs Appleyard has many rules for the picnic. She tells the girls to return ‘at about 8’ and warns them about snakes. This shows the college wants to control the girls. However, when they get to the Rock the rules do not work anymore because the Rock is very big. Weir shows the Rock in big shots so it looks powerful.
Body Paragraph 2 The rules meant to protect the girls are the first thing the Rock overrides.

Time is another way the college tries to control things. Mr Hussey’s and Miss McCraw’s watches stop at twelve, and Miss McCraw says it ‘must be something magnetic’. This shows the Rock is stronger than the clocks. Irma says they will be back ‘long before tea’, but they never come back, so the college’s plans fail.
Body Paragraph 3 So the order the college relies on fails at the very point it is meant to hold.

Weir’s soundtrack makes nature seem both beautiful and dangerous. The music is calm at first, then there is a scary noise. This shows nature is beautiful but also dangerous. When Edith runs, she screams, which makes the audience feel scared.
Conclusion The threat of the Rock is therefore something the audience hears as well as sees.

Weir shows the college trying to control nature and failing. The rules, the time and the sound all show this. Therefore I agree with the statement.
Sample Essay II (Medium)

Introduction

In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Peter Weir presents Appleyard College as a place built on order: its timetables, its rules about gloves and punctuality, its certainty about when the girls will return. I agree that the film shows this order failing against nature, though the failure is not a simple victory for the Rock. Weir uses time, framing and sound to show an ordered world losing its hold on the people inside it.
Body Paragraph 1

The college lives by the clock, and the picnic is planned around it . Mrs Appleyard tells the girls to return 'at about 8', and Irma is confident they will be back 'long before tea'. At the Rock, though, the clocks stop. Mr Hussey's and Miss McCraw's watches stop at twelve, and Miss McCraw can only suggest that it 'must be something magnetic'. The mechanical measures of the college become meaningless in a place that seems to run on a different time.
Body Paragraph 2 The college's order therefore depends on a time that the Rock does not share.

Weir also reduces the girls' authority through framing. As they climb, low-angle shots make the pinnacles tower over them, and narrow passages enclose them. The girls are shown gazing upwards, enthralled, yet the same shots make them look small. The college's rules about gloves and snakes are trivial beside a landscape that seems to be swallowing them.
Body Paragraph 3 Framing, then, turns the college's authority into something the landscape can overwhelm.

The soundtrack completes the picture. Gheorghe Zamfir's pan flute makes the bush seem romantic, but beneath it Weir layers a low rumble that seems to come from the Rock. When Edith flees, her screams merge with a shrieking noise. Beauty and threat are never separated, so the audience cannot fully trust the bush.
Conclusion The soundtrack therefore carries the film's argument that order cannot contain nature.

Weir presents Appleyard College as an order that cannot survive contact with the Rock. Its clocks stop, its rules shrink and its voices are drowned out by the sound of the bush. The film does not give nature a simple victory, however. The girls are not conquered so much as taken , and that is what makes the order's failure so unsettling.
Sample Essay III (High)

Introduction

The opening of *Picnic at Hanging Rock* sets up its argument before the college appears at all. Weir begins with the Rock emerging from mist and Miranda's voice-over: 'What we see and what we seem are but a dream, a dream within a dream.' I agree with the statement, but the film's argument is harder than a story of defeat. The order of Appleyard College is not overpowered by the Rock. It is revealed as a fiction the moment it meets the bush . Weir builds this through the opening, the stopped clocks and the soundtrack.
Body Paragraph 1

The opening makes that fiction visible. Before the title card gives its factual details, the Rock is shown first, and Miranda's voice-over frames everything that follows as a dream. Weir inverts the usual hierarchy : nature is presented as the older, more real authority, and the college is an afterthought. When the girls later climb the Rock, they walk into the same dream and accept it without question.

Body Paragraph 2 The opening therefore settles the film's answer before the disappearance begins.

Time shows most clearly how the college's order gives way to the Rock. The clocks provide the clearest evidence. Appleyard College runs on instructions to return 'at about 8', and Irma is sure they will be back 'long before tea'. At the Rock, Mr Hussey's and Miss McCraw's watches stop at twelve, and Miss McCraw can only suggest that it 'must be something magnetic'. Miranda goes further, rejecting her own watch because its ticking is unbearable, and at the summit she declares that 'everything begins and ends at exactly the right time and place'. Weir shows the college's measured time as a convention the Rock simply does not recognise.
Body Paragraph 3 The college's clocks are the first thing the Rock makes meaningless.

Sound finishes what time begins. Gheorghe Zamfir's pan flute drifts over the crossing of the stream, making the bush seem freely romantic, but Weir layers a low rumble beneath it and lets Edith's screams merge with a shrieking discord. The audience is never allowed to rest in the beauty. Even after Irma is found, the rush of wind through the rocks keeps the question open. The college wants an explanation, and the film offers only sensation .
Conclusion That refusal to explain is what makes the college's failure complete.

Weir's film argues that order is a story people tell themselves, and the Rock refuses to co-operate with it. The opening dream, the stopped watches and the shrieking soundtrack each undermine the college's authority in a different register. Because the film never explains the disappearance, the failure of Appleyard College is not a single moment. It is the condition the whole film describes.

Part

The Lottery and Other Stories

Practice Analytical Text Response Topics

Topics on *The Lottery and Other Stories* take the same three shapes as any Section A topic: **construction** (how does Jackson portray…?), **relationship** (how two ideas connect) and **idea / message** (what the stories suggest). Because this is a collection, the strongest essays draw on several stories, and often place examples from two different stories in the same paragraph. Treat 'The Lottery' as your anchor story: it shows almost every key idea and technique in the collection.

The four key ideas underneath most topics are **social judgement and exclusion**, **insecurity and dissatisfaction**, **unexpected events that expose our struggles**, and **the violence and cruelty beneath a civilised society**.

1. How does Jackson portray social judgement and exclusion?

2. Challenges to social expectations are treated as threats in Jackson's stories. Discuss.

3. Jackson's stories suggest that ordinary social settings can conceal disturbing cruelty. Discuss.

4. How does Jackson depict the pressure to belong in her short stories?

5. The desire for social acceptance shapes the behaviour of many of Jackson's characters. Do you agree?

6. Jackson's stories are tales of exclusion and isolation. Discuss.

7. How does Jackson portray the quiet despair hidden within ordinary lives?

8. In Jackson's stories, dissatisfaction is often a catalyst for imagining alternative realities. Discuss.

9. Jackson's stories suggest that the search for fulfilment rarely leads to happiness. Discuss.

10. How does Jackson use disruption to expose weaknesses?

11. Unexpected encounters force confrontation with uncomfortable truths. How is this idea explored in Jackson's stories?

12. In Jackson's stories, strangers often reveal what others would prefer to ignore. Discuss.

13. How does Jackson use everyday settings to make violence and cruelty more disturbing?

14. The most disturbing violence in Jackson's stories comes from ordinary people. Do you agree?

15. Jackson's stories explore discontent with identity. Discuss.

16. How does Jackson portray the conflict between individuals and society?

17. How does Jackson explore the relationship between community and conformity?

18. How do Jackson's short stories subvert traditional expectations of gender?

19. Jackson's stories suggest that respectable appearances can conceal disturbing behaviour. Discuss.

20. How does Jackson expose the cruelty beneath ordinary life?

21. In Jackson's stories, social expectations encourage intolerance and hostility. Discuss.

22. How does Jackson expose the darker aspects of human behaviour beneath ordinary life?

23. Jackson's stories reveal that the appearance of a civilised society can disguise deeply entrenched prejudice and a lack of compassion. Discuss.

24. How does Jackson reveal the reality beneath the surface of society?

25. In Jackson's stories, outward appearances disguise disturbing truths. Discuss.

26. In Jackson's stories, what appears safe and familiar is often unpredictable. Discuss.

27. Beneath the surface of ordinary life lies a world of fear and insecurity in Jackson's stories. Discuss.

28. To what extent do unexpected events create vulnerability and insecurity in Jackson's stories?

29. How does Jackson depict the pressure to conform to social expectations?

30. In Jackson's stories, appearances are frequently mistaken for reality. Discuss.

31. How does Jackson portray the gap between the lives people lead and the lives they imagine?

32. How does Jackson challenge the distinction between insiders and outsiders?

33. Jackson suggests that maintaining social order is more important to communities than protecting individuals. Discuss.

34. Jackson's stories suggest that the world is more frightening when everything appears normal. Discuss.

35. How does Jackson turn ordinary encounters into moments of crisis?

36. 'The morning of June 27th was clear and sunny.' In Jackson's stories, the most ordinary days hold the greatest danger. Discuss.

37. 'There's always been a lottery.' Jackson's stories show how tradition is used to excuse cruelty. Do you agree?

38. 'She was not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment.' Jackson's characters are trapped by their own expectations. Discuss.

39. How does Jackson use strangers to unsettle her characters' sense of security?

40. In Jackson's stories, the fear of being judged is more damaging than judgement itself. Discuss.

41. Jackson's stories suggest that it is difficult to belong without sacrificing who you are. Discuss.

42. How does Jackson portray the gap between how characters see themselves and how others see them?

43. In Jackson's stories, imagining a different life only deepens dissatisfaction with the present. Discuss.

44. Jackson's stories suggest that people create much of their own unhappiness. Do you agree?

45. How does Jackson use endings to leave her characters, and her readers, unsettled?

46. In Jackson's stories, children learn cruelty from the adults around them. Discuss.

47. Jackson's stories suggest that tradition is not necessarily a source of comfort. Discuss.

48. How does Jackson portray communities that protect themselves by excluding others?

49. In Jackson's stories, politeness disguises prejudice as much as it prevents conflict. Discuss.

50. Jackson's stories reveal that ordinary people are capable of extraordinary cruelty. Discuss.

51. 'Mrs. Walpole closed her eyes… harsh hands pulling her down.' In Jackson's stories, the individual is powerless against the community. Discuss.

52. 'Pretty soon they… they'll tell someone else to speak to me.' Jackson's stories show how quickly an insider can become an outsider. Do you agree?

53. How does Jackson use the recurring figure of James Harris to disrupt ordinary lives?

54. In Jackson's stories, characters rarely escape the roles society assigns them. Discuss.

55. Jackson's stories suggest that the desire for order can lead to cruelty. Discuss.

56. How does Jackson use domestic settings to explore dissatisfaction and conflict?

57. In Jackson's short stories, judgement is often based on fear rather than understanding. Do you agree?

58. In Jackson's short stories, belonging often depends on rejecting someone else. Discuss.

59. How does Jackson expose the dangers of prejudice and social suspicion?

60. In Jackson's stories, appearances are more important than empathy. Do you agree?

61. Jackson's stories warn of the dangers of blind conformity. Discuss.

62. In Jackson's stories, communities enforce obedience in both subtle and brutal ways. Discuss.

63. To what extent do Jackson's stories suggest that conformity comes at the cost of compassion?

64. Loneliness in Jackson's stories is both self-created and socially imposed. Discuss.

65. To what extent is anxiety inescapable in Jackson's stories?

66. Isolation shapes perception. How is this idea explored in Jackson's stories?

67. In Jackson's fiction, emotional insecurity often distorts understanding of reality. Discuss.

68. Jackson's stories suggest that ordinary life can be transformed in an instant. Discuss.

69. Routine and familiarity create a false sense of security in Jackson's fiction. Do you agree?

70. Jackson's stories depict moments when everyday life becomes unsettlingly unfamiliar. Discuss.

71. To what extent do sudden changes expose hidden fears in Jackson's short stories?

72. How does Jackson challenge assumptions?

73. In Jackson's fiction, disruption is often necessary for hidden truths to emerge. Discuss.

74. Politeness in Jackson's short stories often masks something far more sinister. To what extent do you agree?

75. In Jackson's stories, violence emerges most shockingly from everyday life. Discuss.

76. Jackson's stories reveal darkness beneath respectable appearances. Discuss.

77. In Jackson's stories, moments of calm and familiarity make acts of cruelty more confronting. Discuss.

78. Civilised behaviour in Jackson's short stories is little more than a performance. Do you agree?

79. Shirley Jackson's short stories reveal lack of satisfaction. Discuss.

80. Shirley Jackson's short stories consistently subvert societal expectations. Discuss.

81. How does racism affect the characters in Shirley Jackson's short stories?

82. In the world of Shirley Jackson, identity is constructed in response to the demands of society. Discuss.

83. How does Jackson use doors and windows to reveal the dissatisfaction of her characters?

84. In her stories, how does Jackson use the physical setting to convey the experiences of characters?

85. How does Jackson portray the inner frustration of ordinary lives?

86. Dissatisfaction in Jackson's stories is both self-created and socially imposed. Discuss.

87. Jackson's stories depict moments when the safety of everyday life becomes threatening. Discuss.

88. In Jackson's stories, ordinary life is both predictable and fragile. Discuss.

Introduction and Context

Overview

The Lottery and Other Stories (1949) is Shirley Jackson's only collection of short stories published in her lifetime. Its twenty-five stories are mostly set in ordinary places: New York apartments, offices, buses and trains, small towns and suburban streets. Jackson finds something unsettling in each of them. Her characters are lonely, dissatisfied or anxious to fit in, and her communities are polite on the surface but capable of exclusion, prejudice and violence. The collection ends with its most famous story, 'The Lottery', in which a friendly village gathers on a sunny morning to stone one of its own.

America After the Second World War

The stories were written in the 1940s, in the years during and immediately after the Second World War. Post-war America prized stability, prosperity and conformity: suburbs expanded, the ideal family was a breadwinning husband and a homemaking wife, and pressure to fit in was intense. At the same time, the war had revealed how ordinary people could take part in organised cruelty, and the late 1940s saw growing suspicion of anyone considered different or disloyal.

Analysis

Jackson's stories expose the anxieties beneath this ideal of order. Her communities enforce sameness, punish difference and turn on outsiders. When you write about conformity, social judgement or 'the violence beneath a civilised society', you are writing about fears that were very much alive when Jackson wrote.

Gender Roles

Middle-class women in the 1940s were expected to marry, keep house and raise children; single women in the city, like the protagonists of 'The Daemon Lover' and 'The Villager', lived with the anxiety of ageing outside these expectations. Men were expected to be confident, practical and dominant.

Analysis

Many of Jackson's characters struggle with these roles. Some, like David in 'Like Mother Used to Make' or the restless women of 'The Tooth' and 'Elizabeth', do not fit them; others, like Tessie Hutchinson with her dishes in the sink, play them dutifully until it is too late. Jackson shows both the pressure to conform and the price of conforming.

Race and Prejudice

America in the 1940s was deeply segregated, and racism was often expressed through polite, respectable behaviour rather than open hostility. Two stories, 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' and 'Flower Garden', examine this directly.

Analysis

Jackson is interested in the gap between how people see themselves and how they behave. Mrs Wilson thinks she is generous; the people of the town think they are protecting their community. Both stories show prejudice maintained by people who believe themselves to be good.

The Reception of 'The Lottery'

'The Lottery' was first published in *The New Yorker* in June 1948. It provoked one of the largest reader responses in the magazine's history: hundreds of letters, many angry, confused or disturbed, and some asking where such lotteries were held. Readers were shocked that a story could show ordinary, likeable people carrying out a murder as calmly as a town meeting.

Analysis

The reaction proves Jackson's point. Readers recognised the village as their own, which is exactly what made the story so disturbing. Its power comes from its ordinariness.

Shirley Jackson and the Short Story

Shirley Jackson (1916–1965)

Shirley Jackson was born in San Francisco and spent most of her adult life in North Bennington, Vermont, where her husband, the critic Stanley Edgar Hyman, taught at Bennington College. She raised four children while writing novels, short stories and humorous accounts of family life. As an outsider in a small New England town, she experienced the kind of suspicion and gossip her stories depict. She is best known today for 'The Lottery' and for her novels *The Haunting of Hill House* (1959) and *We Have Always Lived in the Castle* (1962), and is regarded as a major writer of psychological suspense and the uncanny.

Why the Short Story?

A short story has little room for explanation. Jackson uses this to her advantage. She often:

- opens with a description of the protagonist's ordinary routine or a pleasant setting;
- introduces an unexpected event, stranger or disruption;
- lets tension build through small, everyday details and dialogue;
- ends abruptly, often with the protagonist excluded, defeated or trapped, and without explaining what it all means.

The reader is left to fill the silence, and that is where much of the unease comes from.

Reading the Collection as a Whole

Although each story stands alone, the collection is designed to be read together. A figure named James Harris (or Jim, or Jamie) appears in many stories in different guises: a missing fiancé, a writer, a dinner guest, a neighbour, a stranger in a blue suit. The book is divided into parts introduced by epigraphs from Joseph Glanvill's seventeenth-century treatise on witchcraft, and ends with an epilogue: verses from the old ballad 'James Harris, The Daemon Lover', in which a mysterious lover carries a woman away to her doom.

Analysis

These links suggest that the strangeness in each story is part of a larger pattern. James Harris works almost like a demon or tempter who drifts through ordinary lives, exposing the dissatisfaction and fear already present beneath the surface. In essays, connecting stories through these recurring figures and motifs shows the examiners that you understand the collection, not just individual stories.

Structure and Themes in *The Lottery and Other Stories*

How the Stories Can Be Grouped

This guide concentrates on twelve stories that together cover the collection's key ideas. A useful way to study them is in groups:

- **Discontent and identity:** 'The Daemon Lover', 'Like Mother Used to Make', 'The Villager'
- **Cruelty taught and normalised:** 'The Witch', 'The Renegade', 'Charles'
- **Insiders and outsiders:** 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', 'Flower Garden'
- **Challenging or yielding to expectations:** 'Elizabeth', 'The Tooth', 'Of Course'
- **The anchor story:** 'The Lottery'

Unexpected Events Expose Our Struggles

Jackson uses unexpected events and strangers to expose characters' hidden fears, insecurities and dissatisfaction with their lives. A fiancé fails to arrive; a stranger knocks on the door; a man on a train tells a child a violent story. The disruption does not create the problem so much as reveal what was already there.

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

Jackson shows how people feel uncertain about their identities and dissatisfied with their lives, often imagining that another life might make them happier. The protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' is 'not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment'; Miss Clarence in 'The Villager' once wanted to be a dancer; Clara Spencer in 'The Tooth' drifts away from her own identity altogether.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Jackson explores how social expectations pressure people to conform and leave those who do not fit in feeling judged, anxious and excluded. Mrs MacLane is frozen out of the town in 'Flower Garden'; Mrs Walpole fears her neighbours in 'The Renegade'; Tessie Hutchinson is cast out in the most final way possible.

The Violence and Cruelty Beneath a Civilised Society

Jackson reveals how violence, cruelty and hostility can exist beneath the polite and orderly surface of everyday life. Physical violence features in only a few stories, so think of this idea more broadly: cruelty, insensitivity, aggressive intolerance and a lack of compassion. Strangers mock, neighbours gossip, children learn to relish violence, and a whole village picks up stones.

Endings

Jackson's stories often end grimly, and these endings are some of the most useful evidence you have. Compare:

- ‘The Daemon Lover’: ‘No matter how often or how firmly she knocked, no one ever came to the door.’
- ‘Like Mother Used to Make’: David thinks miserably of his own warm home and hears faintly down the hall the sound of laughter.
- ‘The Villager’: ‘Her shoulders ached.’
- ‘The Witch’: ‘Prob’ly he was a witch.’
- ‘The Renegade’: Mrs Walpole closes her eyes, ‘suddenly feeling the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat.’
- ‘Flower Garden’: Mrs Winning ‘swung around without speaking and started, with great dignity, back up the hill toward the old Winning house.’
- ‘The Lottery’: ‘It isn’t fair, it isn’t right,’ Mrs. Hutchinson screamed, and then they were upon her.

Some endings shut characters out (exclusion); some leave them trapped in disappointment (defeat and resignation); some show cruelty becoming normal. Very few offer justice or resolution.

Language and Style

An Understated, Ordinary Voice

Jackson writes in a plain, calm, almost conversational style. She describes terrible things in the same tone as a morning's errands. In 'The Lottery', the stoning is introduced through the same matter-of-fact narration as the gathering of the villagers and their chat about tractors and taxes. This flatness is deliberate: by refusing to signal horror, Jackson makes the reader feel the horror of how normal cruelty has become.

Everyday Detail

Jackson builds her worlds from small, concrete details: coffee, dishes in the sink, the neat chairs in David's apartment, a lollipop, a bus ticket. These details make the settings feel real and familiar, which is what makes the disruptions so unsettling. They also carry meaning: the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' repeatedly finds 'nothing to eat', and her lack of appetite suggests the emptiness of her life.

Dialogue and Polite Speech

Characters in Jackson's stories are often unfailingly polite while saying cruel or prejudiced things. Mrs Wilson's generosity in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' is full of assumptions; the neighbours in 'The Renegade' cheerfully suggest ways to kill a dog; Mrs Harris in 'Of Course' imposes her views through seemingly friendly conversation. Listen for the gap between the tone of what is said and what it means.

Irony

Irony runs through the collection: a lottery whose 'prize' is death; a sunny summer day for a murder; a title, 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', that mocks performative politeness; a mother in 'Charles' who never suspects the badly behaved boy is her own son.

Unnamed and Symbolic Names

Some characters have no name at all: the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover', 'the little boy' in 'The Witch'. This makes them seem anonymous and interchangeable, as if their stories could belong to anyone. Other names are pointed: Laurie suggests a crown of laurels, a symbol of glory; Walpole has been read as meaning 'foreigner'; Clara means 'clear' or 'bright'; Mrs Winning belongs to the family that always wins.

Setting and Weather

Jackson often sets disturbing events against pleasant weather. The village of 'The Lottery' gathers on a 'clear and sunny' morning 'with the fresh warmth of a full-summer day'. Ask whether the weather in a story reinforces ordinary life, contrasts with it, mirrors the characters' feelings, or creates an ironic contrast with them.

Open Endings

Jackson rarely explains. We never learn what happened to Jamie Harris, who the man on the train really was, or where Clara Spencer is going. The reader is left uneasy, and must decide for themselves what the story reveals.

Story Summaries and Analyses

The collection contains twenty-five stories. The VCAA 2027 text list sets twelve of them for study, and they are the twelve below: learn them well enough to use them flexibly across many topics. Jackson originally subtitled the collection *The Adventures of James Harris*, and a man of that name (or a man in a blue suit) drifts through many of these stories. Watch for him: he usually arrives just as a character's grip on her ordinary life starts to loosen.

'The Daemon Lover'

Summary : On the morning she is to marry Jamie Harris, an unnamed woman of thirty-four prepares anxiously. She writes to her sister Anne, agonises over whether to wear a blue silk dress Jamie has already seen or a print dress she fears looks too young, tidies her apartment and stocks food for their new life. Jamie does not arrive. By late morning she leaves him a note and goes looking for him. At the building where he said he lived, the superintendent and his wife have never heard of him, and the couple who lent their apartment to a man in a blue suit know almost nothing about him. The delicatessen man brushes her off, the newsdealer and a customer turn her questions into a joke, and the florist, while trying to sell her flowers, 'remembers' a man buying chrysanthemums. An old shoeshine man and a twelve-year-old boy finally say they saw a man with flowers go into a run-down house. On the top floor she knocks at a door and seems to hear voices and laughter, but no one answers. The other door opens on an empty attic where a rat watches her with an 'evil face', and she flees, tearing her dress. For weeks afterwards she returns to knock, morning and evening, but 'no one ever came to the door.'

Analysis : The protagonist is defined by deep-seated dissatisfaction: she is 'not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment' and hopes marriage will transform her life. In the 1940s, a woman unmarried at thirty-four faced real social pressure, which explains her urgency. The recurring lack of food ('There was nothing to eat in the apartment') suggests a life that is empty and hollow. Jackson slowly undermines the reader's trust in her: she cannot clearly picture Jamie's face, nobody official will confirm he exists, and the only people who claim to have seen him (a vague old man and a cheeky boy) are as unreliable as she is. The reader is pushed to re-read everything she has said. The title comes from an old Scottish ballad, 'The Daemon Lover', also known as 'James Harris', in which a lover lures a woman away with promises of a new life and then destroys her. 'Daemon' can mean demon, but also a guiding or inspiring spirit; Jamie is both, offering hope and then vanishing cruelly. The casual cruelty of strangers ('the boy grinned insolently at her') shows how easily individual suffering is dismissed. The real conflict is internal, between hope and reality, and the door that never opens is one of Jackson's starkest images of exclusion.

Links to other stories : Jamie's blue suit returns in 'The Tooth' and 'The Witch'; the lonely single woman pinning her hopes on a Harris reappears in 'Elizabeth' and 'The Villager'.

'Like Mother Used to Make'

Summary : David Turner shops carefully for dinner and returns to his small, neat apartment, which he has painted and furnished himself with great pride. He lets himself into the untidy apartment of his neighbour Marcia (she has no key to his, and he likes it that way) to leave her a reminder about dinner. Marcia arrives late, loud and hungry, and admires his home. David

serves a cherry pie, only his third attempt, and worries it is too sour. When Mr Harris, a large man from Marcia's office, calls by, Marcia lets him assume the apartment is hers, calls David 'Davie', and claims the pie as her own. David, unable to assert himself, washes every dish, is gently edged out by Marcia's hostess manner, thanks her for dinner, and accepts her key. He ends in Marcia's cluttered apartment, hearing laughter from his own home across the hall, and miserably begins to clean.

Analysis : Jackson contrasts David's control ('small quick movements', 'the neat small table and four careful chairs') with Marcia's disorder ('Marcia arrived with a shout and fresh air and disorder'). David's home is an extension of his identity, so losing it is a psychological as well as a physical displacement. His pleasure in domestic activities challenges traditional ideas of masculinity, and his passivity makes him complicit: he never tells Mr Harris the truth. Dramatic irony drives the second half, since the reader knows what Mr Harris does not. Cleaning Marcia's apartment is David's weary attempt to rebuild a sense of order and self. The title is ironic: the comforts of home 'like mother used to make' are made by a man and claimed by a woman who did not make them.

Links to other stories : The swapped identity in a borrowed apartment mirrors 'The Villager'; the home as a symbol of the self also drives 'The Renegade' and 'Flower Garden'.

'The Villager'

Summary : Miss Hilda Clarence, about thirty-five, came to Greenwich Village from a small town twelve years ago hoping to become a dancer, but now works as a stenographer. She carries a novel she read only 'up to page fifty and only carried now for effect'. Answering an advertisement, she visits an apartment to look at furniture for sale. The owner, Nancy Roberts, has left her a note to come in and look around. Miss Clarence finds the apartment dirty and the furniture not to her taste, but she lingers over a book of modern-dance photographs and tries one of the poses. Artie Roberts phones and tells her they are selling because he has the chance to go to Paris. When another prospective buyer, Harris, arrives, he assumes she is the owner, and she slips into the role, telling him she is a dancer and that 'Artie's going to Paris'. After he leaves, she writes a note for Mrs Roberts and returns to her own life.

Analysis : Harris's unexpected arrival is the catalyst that exposes Miss Clarence's disappointment with her life. She tells herself she has 'a good job' and lives 'better than she would have in her home town', but her props (the half-read novel, the occasional dance recital) show how much she cares about appearing sophisticated. The Robertses seem to live the artistic life Miss Clarence came to the city for (Arthur is an artist with a chance to go to Paris), so she simply borrows it. The dance pose symbolises her abandoned ambition, and the strain it causes shows how hollow the attempt is. The story has no climax and no change: the pretence brings only brief relief. The final line, 'Her shoulders ached', suggests the weight of carrying unfulfilled dreams.

Links to other stories : Compare David's lost apartment in 'Like Mother Used to Make' and Elizabeth's thwarted ambitions in 'Elizabeth'.

'The Witch'

Summary : A four-year-old boy, Johnny, travels on a nearly empty train with his mother and baby sister, looking out the window and announcing what he sees. Bored, he tells his mother he saw 'a big old ugly old bad old witch' and told her to go away. An elderly, friendly stranger

sits beside him. Johnny gives silly answers to the usual questions (he is 'Twenty-six', his name is 'Mr. Jesus', his baby sister is 'twelve-and-a-half'), and his mother corrects him. The man asks whether he loves his sister, then calmly tells a gruesome story about killing his own little sister, cutting her into pieces and putting her head in a cage with a bear. The mother is horrified and orders the man away, but the boy is delighted. As he leaves, the man and the boy share a laugh. The mother insists he was only teasing, gives Johnny a lollipop, and the boy decides 'Prob'ly he was a witch.'

Analysis : The story shows how children learn what behaviour is normal. The baby 'strapped securely to the seat' and the boy rewarded with a lollipop suggest a world of control and reward, yet the boy greets violence with breathless excitement ('Did you cut her all in pieces?'). Children in Jackson's fiction are often less bound by social convention than adults: the mother reacts with horror because that is what respectable adults must do, while the boy simply enjoys the story. The old man appears just after the boy imagines a witch, as if the fantasy has summoned him, and he is the only adult who takes the boy's imagination seriously. Evil arrives in a pleasant, everyday setting behind a harmless exterior, which makes it more disturbing. The boy's final explanation turns real violence into a fairy tale.

Links to other stories : The stranger who unsettles an ordinary journey recalls Jim in 'The Tooth'; children who absorb cruelty appear in 'The Renegade' and 'The Lottery'.

'The Renegade'

Summary : Mrs Walpole, new to a small country town, is rushing her twins, Jack and Judy, off to school when a neighbour phones to say that the family dog, Lady, has been killing Mr Harris's chickens and must be dealt with. Shaken, she goes to see Mrs Nash, who has already heard. On her way through town, neighbours offer increasingly cruel advice: Mr White suggests tying a dead chicken around the dog's neck, and the grocer and his customer suggest worse, in a tone of amusement. Lady comes home 'quietly, harmlessly', with flecks of blood on her legs. When the twins return, they gleefully describe a spiked collar that would cut the dog's head off if she chased a chicken, while patting Lady affectionately. Mrs Walpole goes outside for air but feels as though she is the one being punished.

Analysis : The title is deliberately ambiguous. A renegade is someone who rejects conventional behaviour; the dog is one, but so in a sense is Mrs Walpole, an outsider who cannot bring herself to have Lady killed. The neighbours' casual enthusiasm normalises violence: Lady kills by instinct, but the townspeople plan cruelty calmly and with pleasure. Even Mrs Walpole's own first impulse is to beat the dog, so no one is entirely innocent. She is alienated within her own family too: her husband barely notices her, and her children's delight shows how readily cruelty is passed on. Jackson drew on her own struggle to fit into a small Vermont town. The ending, 'the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat', transfers the punishment from the dog to the woman, revealing her fear of the community's judgement.

Links to other stories : The hostile small town returns in 'Flower Garden' and, at its most extreme, 'The Lottery'.

'Charles'

Summary : Told in the first person by Laurie's mother, the story follows Laurie's first weeks at kindergarten. He immediately becomes ruder at home, calling his father 'y'old dust mop', and comes home each day with stories about a boy called Charles who misbehaves dreadfully:

hitting the teacher, saying bad words, being kept after school. His parents are fascinated and amused, and ‘Charles’ becomes a family byword for any mischief. At the parent-teacher meeting, Laurie’s mother looks for Charles’s mother, then corners the teacher, who describes Laurie’s difficult adjustment in terms that match Charles exactly. The mother still misses the point, until the teacher says there is no Charles in the class.

Analysis : Laurie invents an alter ego to confess his own bad behaviour without being punished, while keeping his parents’ affection and attention. The clues are all there (his new rudeness, his stomping, his pause before naming Charles), and the reader usually guesses the truth before the narrator does, which creates dramatic irony. A second irony is that the mother is eager to meet Charles’s mother, not realising it is herself. Her unquestioning acceptance shows how parents see what they want to see. The comic tone hides a sharper point about how adults misread, and help create, children’s behaviour.

Links to other stories : The gap between appearance and reality also drives ‘Of Course’ and ‘The Lottery’; invented identities appear in ‘The Villager’.

‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’

Summary : Mrs Wilson is baking gingerbread when her son Johnny brings home his friend Boyd, a Black boy, who is carrying wood for their game. She scolds Johnny for letting Boyd carry the load and invites Boyd to lunch. Over scrambled eggs and tomatoes, she assumes Boyd’s family is poor, his father a labourer, and his mother overworked. Each assumption is corrected: his father is ‘a foreman’, his mother does not need to work, and his sister plans to become a teacher. Mrs Wilson then offers Boyd some of Johnny’s old clothes. Boyd politely says his family does not need them. Offended, she withdraws the gingerbread and says she is not angry, only disappointed. The boys, puzzled, go back outside to play, Johnny remarking that his mother is ‘screwy sometimes’.

Analysis : The title comes from *Alphonse and Gaston*, a comic strip about two absurdly polite Frenchmen who keep deferring to each other; the boys use the phrase to play at manners, and it frames their easy, equal friendship. Jackson uses it ironically to expose the gap between outward politeness and genuine respect. Mrs Wilson believes she is being kind, but her ‘kindness’ is built on racist stereotypes, and her withdrawal of the gingerbread exposes the ill-manners beneath her charity. The quiet, domestic setting shows that everyday prejudice can do harm without any open violence. The boys have not yet absorbed adult bias, which suggests prejudice is learned rather than natural.

Links to other stories : ‘Flower Garden’ shows the same racism hardening into a whole town’s exclusion; the innocence of children contrasts with ‘The Witch’ and ‘The Lottery’, where children absorb cruelty readily.

‘Flower Garden’

Summary : Young Mrs Winning has married into the town’s oldest family and lives in the old Winning house under her mother-in-law’s control; after eleven years the two women have begun to look alike, and she is ‘officially a Winning’. She once dreamed of restoring a small cottage nearby. When Mrs MacLane, a widow from the city, moves into that cottage with her son Davey, Mrs Winning befriends her, and their sons play together. Mrs MacLane transforms the cottage and garden into exactly what Mrs Winning had imagined. When Mrs MacLane makes Davey apologise to Billy Jones, a boy of mixed race whom Howard Winning has

insulted, and then hires Billy's father, Mr Jones, to work her garden, the town turns against her. Mrs Winning's mother-in-law, Mrs Harris and other neighbours pressure her to speak to Mrs MacLane, and Davey is left out of a birthday party. Mrs Winning withdraws and laughs at her friend in public. As the town's coldness grows, the garden begins to fail. After a storm brings a neighbour's tree down across it, Mrs MacLane wonders aloud whether she should give up and go back to the city, and Mrs Winning, watching, will not greet her.

Analysis : The townspeople act as gatekeepers, advising Mrs Winning to speak to Mrs MacLane 'about that colored man'. Mrs Winning's own fear shows how the pressure works: 'pretty soon they'll stop coming to me first, they'll tell someone else to speak to me.' When Mrs MacLane asks whether it is 'because of Mr. Jones working here', Mrs Winning denies it, then privately thinks, 'The nerve of her, trying to blame the colored folks.' Racism here is not one person's attitude, as in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', but a whole community's, and it drives a family out. Mrs Winning is a disturbing protagonist: her own life is constrained and loveless, and her envy of Mrs MacLane's freedom, warmth and garden turns into cruelty. The cottage symbolises the life she gave up; her own dutiful nasturtiums contrast with Mrs MacLane's flourishing garden, which wilts as the town's hostility grows. Children reveal the town's values: Howard's racist name-calling towards Billy Jones shows how early prejudice is learned. The ending shows conformity and tradition winning over friendship.

Links to other stories : The pressure of tradition and the community against an outsider anticipate 'The Lottery'; envy of another woman's life echoes 'The Villager'.

'Elizabeth'

Summary : Elizabeth Style wakes from a dream of a warm, beautiful place to a grey, rainy New York morning. She has worked for nearly eleven years at a struggling literary agency with Robert Shax, who is both her business partner and her lover, though the relationship has lost its warmth. At the drugstore, Tommy, a young clerk, admits he has sent his play to another agency. At the office she finds that Robert has hired a pretty young assistant, Daphne Hill, without telling her. Over lunch she bitterly reminds Robert of Jim Harris, the writer whose signed photograph hangs on his wall and who left the agency after a quarrel. She turns down her visiting uncle, phones Jim Harris and talks him into coming to her apartment for a drink that evening, then dismisses Daphne, pretending it was Robert's wish. At home she buys drinks and crackers and waits, imagining a new apartment and a new life.

Analysis : Elizabeth's story is one of insecurity and quiet despair beneath a professional surface. Her small cruelties (to Tommy, to Daphne, to Robert) are signs of a deep unhappiness she will not face. Daphne, young, attractive and untroubled, is a foil who reminds Elizabeth of everything she has lost, and Elizabeth's sneer about whether Robert means to 'beautify the office' gives away her fear. Her name may allude to Elizabeth Style, a woman accused of witchcraft in seventeenth-century England. Harris is real, but his role in her future exists only in her imagination; Elizabeth is both a victim of the indifferent city and the antagonist of her own life, clinging to fantasy instead of changing anything. Like the protagonists of 'The Daemon Lover' and 'The Villager', she pins her hopes on a man who may never deliver.

Links to other stories : Compare the women swallowed by the city in 'The Tooth' and 'The Daemon Lover'.

'The Tooth'

Summary : Clara Spencer's husband sees her onto an overnight bus to New York, where she will see a dentist about a painful tooth. Dazed by codeine, whisky and lack of sleep, she meets a man who says his name is Jim. He sits with her, lets her rest her head on his shoulder, and speaks dreamily of a faraway place where 'The sand is so white it looks like snow'. In the city he reappears, holds out a handful of pearls as he passes. The dentist sends her to a surgeon to have the tooth pulled, and under the anaesthetic her tooth feels like 'the only part of her to have any identity'. Afterwards, in a washroom full of women, she cannot pick out her own reflection, thinks 'you'd think my own face would know me', and has to find her name on her belongings. She drops her barrette and a pin bearing the letter C into an ashstand. At the end she runs barefoot through what she imagines is hot sand, hand in hand with Jim, while passers-by stare.

Analysis : Jim represents Clara's desire to escape her ordinary, grey life. His poetic visions ('the waves ringing on the shore like bells', 'the grass is so green and so soft') evoke a mythical place far from bus stations and dentists' rooms. He appears when she is drowsiest and vanishes while she is with the medical staff, so the reader can never be sure he is real; he may be a symptom of her breakdown rather than its cause. Her name, engraved on a barrette and a pin, is a symbol of identity, and abandoning it marks the loss of her self. Clara's name means 'clear' or 'bright', ironic for a woman whose identity has faded. The whole collapse happens within a day, which makes it more dramatic. Unusually, the ending suggests escape from social expectations rather than defeat, though whether it is liberation or madness is left open.

Links to other stories : Jim's blue suit and promises echo Jamie in 'The Daemon Lover'; the dream of a warm place echoes the opening and ending of 'Elizabeth'.

'Of Course'

Summary : Mrs Tylor, eager for a neighbour with a child her daughter Carol's age, watches a new family move in next door and decides from their furniture and clothes that they are 'nice people, obviously'. She invites Mrs Harris and her son James in to rest from the move. In the garden, Mrs Tylor's suggestions keep failing: James does not go to movies, Mr Harris does not allow radio or newspapers, and he has gone to his mother's to avoid the stress of moving. Mrs Harris explains that her husband believes movies are 'intellectually retarding', and even bridge is out. Mrs Tylor keeps answering 'Of course'. As soon as the Harrises go home, Carol asks to go to the movies, and Mrs Tylor says, 'I'll go with you, dear.'

Analysis : The story turns on the pressure of neighbourliness. Mrs Tylor's first judgements are based on appearances; Mrs Harris then projects her husband's rigid views through friendly conversation ('it means such a lot to have really thoughtful neighbors'). Mr Harris never appears, yet he controls his family completely. The title is ironic: Mrs Tylor's repeated 'Of course' is politeness, not agreement, and her quiet trip to the movies at the end is her only act of resistance. Social conformity and the appearance of politeness are maintained, despite the intolerance beneath them.

Links to other stories : Polite surfaces hiding judgement also shape 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' and 'Flower Garden'.

'The Lottery'

Summary : On the morning of June 27th, the villagers of a small farming community of about three hundred people gather in the square for their annual lottery. Children arrive first, and

the boys fill their pockets with stones. Mr Summers runs the drawing from a battered black box, older than anyone can remember, assisted by Mr Graves. Slips of paper long ago replaced the original wood chips. Tessie Hutchinson arrives late, joking that she forgot what day it was. Heads of families draw slips in turn. Mr Adams mentions that a nearby village is talking of giving up the lottery, and Old Man Warner dismisses them as a 'Pack of crazy fools'. Bill Hutchinson draws the marked slip. Tessie protests that Bill was not given enough time to choose and that it 'wasn't fair'. In a second drawing among the five Hutchinsons, Tessie draws the paper with the black spot. The villagers, including her friends and children (little Davy is handed pebbles), stone her as she screams, 'It isn't fair, it isn't right.'

Analysis : 'The Lottery' is the anchor story of the collection: it shows every key idea. The pleasant setting ('clear and sunny') and friendly community ('Take your time, son') make the violence more shocking, and the title itself is ironic, since this lottery's 'winner' dies. The ritual is maintained by authority figures (Mr Summers, Mr Graves, whose name hints at death), defended by Old Man Warner ('There's always been a lottery'), who warns that otherwise 'they'll be wanting to go back to living in caves', and carried out by ordinary people. The old saying 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon' points to the ritual's origin in sacrifice for a good harvest, a purpose no one now examines. Mr Adams mentions villages that have given up the lottery, yet still joins in. Tessie is no rebel: she accepts the lottery until it threatens her. The detail that 'although the villagers had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones' suggests that the violence outlives any meaning the tradition once had. Read as an allegory, the story asks which of our own traditions and scapegoats we accept without question.

Links to other stories : Every story above contributes a piece of 'The Lottery': the hostile town of 'The Renegade', the conformity of 'Flower Garden', the children who learn cruelty in 'The Witch'.

Story Study Guides

Use these guides while you read each story. Each one lists the ideas to underline and the symbols to circle, questions to think about as you read, and close analysis of key moments.

‘The Daemon Lover’

A woman in her mid-thirties is preparing to meet her fiancé and get married. As the story progresses, it becomes clear she has been stood up. Searching for him, she is confronted by the different lives of other people and their indifference to her plight. It is easy to assume the ‘daemon’ of the title refers to the demon-like way her fiancé stands her up, but ‘daemon’ also means a supernatural force that guides a person. Jackson is exploring how the protagonist’s own feelings drive her to the story’s fateful ending.

Annotate:

- **Unexpected events that expose our vulnerabilities** – ripped, torn or ugly things beneath an apparently calm surface.
- **Dissatisfaction with our identities or lives** – the neatness and orderliness of her apartment compared to the Roysters’ home; clothing.
- **Feeling isolated or excluded from wider society** – doors and opportunities being opened or locked.

Questions to consider:

1. Waiting restlessly, she realises she is ‘not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment.’ What does she hope to achieve with her marriage?
2. At the Roysters’, the couple are eating, their apartment is ‘full of music’ and their suitcases are out. How does this compare to her apartment, and what impression does it give of other people’s lives?
3. The story ends with her knocking repeatedly on a door. What might the closed door symbolise?

Food and emptiness. There are recurring descriptions of the protagonist not eating: ‘all this coffee… no real breakfast’; ‘There was nothing to eat in the apartment’; ‘In the drugstore she found that there was nothing she wanted to eat.’ Possible readings: food makes the setting ordinary and realistic; the lack of food suggests her life is empty and hollow; her life has left her hungry and undernourished; she is too absorbed by her obsession with a future husband to eat. The strongest reading is that the lack of food suggests the emptiness of her life.

Dressing for the wedding. She agonises over what to wear:

- ‘she wanted to be soft, feminine’ – she wants to present herself as an idealised bride.
- ‘it was very early in the year for a print dress’ – it is important to her that she observes the social mores of wider society.
- nothing about the blue dress made it special for a wedding day – she is torn between behaving suitably and wanting to celebrate herself as a bride.

- putting on her make-up 'was another delicate balance' between looking her best and deceiving as little as possible – she is balanced between portraying herself honestly and wanting to be thought beautiful.
- the print dress looked made for 'someone who would run freely, dance, swing it with her hips' – she feels like an imposter in her own life.

All these quotes show a woman caught between behaving as she thinks others will find appropriate and following her own heart. For example: *Jackson **explores** the protagonist's **personal desire to present herself** as an idealised bride through her need to be 'soft, feminine'.*

Word bank: *explores, highlights, reveals, demonstrates, represents + the tension between private desire and social expectation; the pressure to conform and private doubts; individual morality is easily suppressed when it clashes with communal norms; the desire to belong outweighs personal ethics; societal dictates can become so deeply embedded they override personal desire; the fragility of self against the behemoth of social order; individual identity and social behaviour.*

'Like Mother Used to Make'

The phrase 'like mother used to make' suggests recipes and traditions passed down through generations of women. It is never used in the story, but it reflects the domestic, orderly way David Turner lives. His sense of order is unsettled when an unexpected stranger disrupts his evening and imposes an outsider's view: the visitor assumes they are all in the home of a woman, eating food prepared by a woman. David goes along with these assumptions, humbly accepting societal expectations.

Annotate:

- **Conformity through judgement and social expectations of gender** – housekeeping (cooking, cleaning, keeping an orderly home), or being messy and slovenly (things broken or ripped).
- **Human isolation or insecurity** – keys, locks, doors; people being ignored.
- **The disruption other people bring** – unexpected events; being unsure how to respond.

Questions to consider:

1. How is David described at the beginning of the story, and what does it suggest about his personality?
2. When David starts cleaning, how does Marcia respond? What does this show about how each of them adheres to social conventions?
3. The story ends with David alone in someone else's apartment. What is Jackson saying about how hard it is to live a different lifestyle?

David and Marcia.

- **David:** 'David Turner… did everything in small, quick movements'; 'The neat small table and four careful chairs'; 'It pleased him to have only one key to his home'; it gave him 'a pleasant

feeling', the only way into his 'warm fine home'; 'He had chosen a sedate, pretty pattern'; 'He had always been partial to yellows and browns.'

- **Marcia:** 'Marcia's home was bare and at random'; it was 'too cluttered'; 'Marcia's bed was unmade'; 'The window had been open all day and papers had blown wildly around the floor'; 'Marcia arrived with a shout and fresh air and disorder'; 'She was a tall handsome girl with a loud voice'; 'Marcia was always hungry.'

Statements to weigh: compared with Marcia, David appears to enjoy traditionally feminine domestic activities; unlike David, Marcia is careless and immature, showing that Jackson disapproves of modern women; in contrast to Marcia's chaotic lifestyle, David demonstrates traditional male structure and routine; in comparison to Marcia, David is careful, controlled and highly organised.

At the end, David is isolated and excluded from his own home while Marcia is assumed to have baked the pie. **Sentence starters:** *At the end of the story, David is exiled by…; Jackson suggests that David's withdrawal is the result of…; In comparison, Marcia…; While Jackson presents David's isolation as a symbol of…, Marcia…*

'The Villager'

Like many of Jackson's characters, Miss Clarence is a woman in her mid-thirties who appears content but is prompted by events to reflect on an alternative life. She identifies strongly with being a 'villager', someone from the famously artistic, bohemian Greenwich Village. But she is now a secretary in 'smart clothes' rather than the dancer she once hoped to be. Inspecting the furnishings of a soon-to-be-vacated apartment, she imagines herself into its occupants' lives, revealing one of Jackson's ongoing concerns: people can feel both satisfied and dissatisfied with their lives at the same time.

Annotate:

- **Insecurity and dissatisfaction about identity, or satisfaction and confidence about self** – opening and closing doors; furniture and household objects; clothing.
- **Social judgement and exclusion** – household duties; men and careers.

Questions to consider:

1. Miss Clarence came to Greenwich Village because 'everyone who wanted to study dancing or sculpture' came there. What does this suggest about how individual she is?
2. Early on she is 'Miss Clarence'; at the end she signs her name 'Hilda Clarence'. What does this tell us about her sense of identity?
3. Jackson's stories often end with an action that sums up how events have made a character feel. What does the ending tell us about Miss Clarence's experience?

Judgements and gender. Miss Clarence is the only woman who appears directly in the story; Artie Roberts and Harris are men. As she walks through the apartment she judges its owners: 'she doesn't even make coffee in the morning'; 'Arthur was the artist, then, and Nancy…'. On the phone, Artie mentions he is going to Paris while his wife returns to her family in Chicago. Readings: society expects women to sacrifice their dreams; men have greater freedom to move through public life and careers; women are expected to quietly accept

disappointment; men are often emotionally disconnected from women's experience; women are expected to prioritise domesticity over careers.

Miss Clarence and Harris.

- **Miss Clarence:** 'she had come to New York… because she wanted to be a dancer'; 'The first thing Miss Clarence did was go to the window… But she could see only dirty roofs'; 'She opened the cupboard'; 'could Nancy, she wondered affectionately, be a dancer?'; 'She had already decided that she could not use any of the furniture.'
- **Harris:** 'I hope to write… Going to get a job and write nights'; 'This place is certainly nicer than mine'; 'He wandered over and opened the bathroom door; when he glanced in Miss Clarence winced'; he 'opened the kitchen door'; 'What I need is a wife'; 'I'm sorry about the furniture… Wish I could have found something.'

Both are hopeful artists without the lives they want; both judge the apartment; but Harris still believes in his future, while Miss Clarence can only borrow someone else's. **Practice topic:** *Shirley Jackson's short stories reveal lack of satisfaction. Discuss.* Starters: *Throughout her short stories, Jackson reveals…; In each of her stories, Jackson's characters demonstrate…; Although many of Jackson's characters expose their…; While both characters…; The parallel activities of…; On the surface both…; Although apparently similar because of…; In comparison to…; The contrast between…; The disparity between…; This is juxtaposed…*

'The Witch'

A young boy takes a train ride with his mother and baby sister. The mother keeps the baby quiet by constantly feeding her toast and largely ignores her son's questions and comments, casually teaching her children compliance. When a strange man sits down and tells the boy a shockingly violent story, the boy is delighted and the mother horrified. When the man suggests chopping off his little sister's head, the boy concludes that the man is a 'witch', someone who lives beyond the conventions of normal society.

Annotate:

- **Violence lies beneath the veneer of civilised behaviour** – excitement about violence.
- **Social pressure and parenting create conformity** – windows to an outside, different world; food and lollipops; the straps that hold the baby in a sitting position.

Questions to consider:

1. Strangers on the train tell the boy he is 'a fine big fellow', and 'These comments annoyed the little boy'. Why might he be irritated?
2. The boy tells his mother he has seen a witch out of the window. She replies, 'Fine.' How does this show adults modelling social norms for children?
3. Asked his age and name, the boy replies 'Twenty-six. Eight hunnerd and forty eighty' and 'Mr. Jesus'. What does this tell us about children's understanding of social conventions?

After the man leaves, the mother insists he 'was just teasing', but the boy decides he was more likely 'a witch'. Readings to weigh: the boy believes adults who don't conform to the rules of society must be mythical; the mother is trying to uphold normative values about how others

should behave; everyone finds ways of rationalising aberrant behaviour; children accept odd behaviour more easily than adults; the mother doesn't want her son to be frightened.

How children are taught to behave: the baby is 'strapped securely to the seat' (restraint); she is 'very quiet and busy with her rattle and her toast' (kept quiet and compliant); 'the little boy had a seat all to himself' (independence, and isolation); he 'ran across the aisle to pet his sister's feet and beg her not to cry… and the little boy received a lollipop' (good behaviour is rewarded).

Practice topic: *Shirley Jackson's short stories consistently subvert societal expectations. Discuss.* Vocabulary: *preserving social order, moulded by cultural expectations, restricted by conventional attitudes, conditioned to bow to societal pressure, behaving according to accepted standards, adhering to social mores; disrupting the expectations of polite society, transgressing conventional boundaries, resisting the expectations of others, defying the conventions of others, pushing against societal mores.*

'The Renegade'

A renegade rebels against the accepted way of doing things, and this story has two. One is Mrs Walpole, who has moved from the city to a small country town where she feels like an outsider, unable to conform to local attitudes and insecure about managing domestic life compared to her more capable neighbours. The other is the dog, Lady, whose killing of chickens becomes the catalyst for Jackson to explore the tension between Mrs Walpole's shaky identity and the apparent confidence of the people around her.

Annotate:

- **Social judgement and pressure** – household duties; time and schedules.
- **Violent attitudes and behaviours** – the dog's violence needing to be controlled through further violence; children's attitudes to violence.
- **Insecurity and dissatisfaction** – comparing yourself to others; Mrs Walpole over-identifying with the dog.

Questions to consider:

1. The story opens with a morning routine that has become disordered and rushed. How does the interruption make the protagonist feel?
2. In what ways does Mrs Walpole try to conform to, or make herself acceptable to, the town?
3. At the end she feels 'the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat.' Whose are the 'harsh hands'?

Mrs Walpole compares herself to the 'country folk' around her and feels an outsider, but that does not necessarily mean she is treated as one. Re-read the advice she receives from each townsperson. Statements to weigh up:

- The townspeople are outwardly kind and welcoming, but firm in their belief that a dog who kills chickens cannot be tolerated.
- Although they speak politely, their comments reveal an underlying judgement about her failure to control the dog.

- While many advocate harsh treatment, some offer gentler advice, revealing conflicting views about authority and control.
- Jackson presents the townspeople as practical and community-minded, valuing order and responsibility above personal feelings.
- The friendly tone of the townspeople contrasts with the harsh reality that they still expect the dog to be punished.
- The townspeople show sympathy towards Mrs Walpole, yet also pressure her to conform to the expectations of country life.
- Beneath the surface politeness of the town lies a strict set of shared values that outsiders are expected to accept.

Analytic verbs: *understands, suggests, implies, reveals, reflects, evokes, symbolises, sympathises, recognises*.

'Charles'

A little boy starts kindergarten and becomes fascinated by a delinquent classmate called Charles. Each day he tells his parents about Charles's misbehaviour: he swears, hits the teacher, punches other children and generally behaves terribly. His mother, who narrates the story, becomes so engrossed in Charles that she can't wait to meet Charles's mother. When she finally gets to school, she discovers there is no Charles at all, only her own son, who 'had a little trouble adjusting'. Through this twist, Jackson explores how insecurity and fear of social judgement can cause people to avoid confronting uncomfortable truths about themselves and their families.

Annotate:

- **Human insecurity and dissatisfaction** – the ways the mother describes the changes in Laurie; anxiety about how others behave.
- **Social judgement** – door slamming; creating mess; refusing to follow instructions or social norms.
- **Violence beneath the veneer of civilisation** – violent actions; interest in violence.

Questions to consider:

1. The narrator describes her son as 'a long-trousered, swaggering character'. What other clues show that 'Charles' is really Laurie?
2. How do both parents encourage the idea that misbehaviour is interesting and worth talking about?
3. At the end, the mother suggests Laurie's 'trouble adjusting' is due to Charles's influence. What does this say about her belief that her son's behaviour comes from outside influences?

Sentence starters: *Many of Jackson's characters fear social judgement and...; Characters in Jackson's short stories frequently internalise the expectations of society and become harsh critics of...; The insecurity of characters like..., who believes...; The societal expectation to... puts pressure on...*

‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’

Mrs Wilson makes a range of assumptions about the family life, finances and values of her son’s African-American friend, Boyd. This culminates in her angry reaction to his lack of gratitude for her ‘charitable’ offer of second-hand clothes, which Boyd and his family do not need because they are not, as she assumes, poor. Beyond exposing Mrs Wilson’s subtle racism, Jackson critiques the way people’s assumptions maintain social divisions and the established order.

Annotate:

- **Communities enforce conformity through social pressure** – food used to control behaviour and interactions.
- **Social judgement and assumptions** – food and clothes representing social status and values.

Questions to consider:

1. Johnny and Boyd play army tanks, ‘running over’ Japanese soldiers who fought against the United States in the Second World War. What does this suggest about how prejudice can be passed on to children?
2. What assumptions does Mrs Wilson make about Boyd’s family, and what do they reveal about her world-view?
3. Mrs Wilson says, ‘Don’t think I’m angry, Boyd. I’m just disappointed in you.’ What word more accurately describes how she feels?

The title. The boys use the phrase when they politely invite each other through a doorway. It comes from a comic strip in which two overly polite Frenchmen constantly defer to each other, satirising performative, superficial politeness that hides self-interest. Readings: the refined phrase challenges Mrs Wilson’s assumption that Boyd comes from an uneducated or disadvantaged background; the title highlights that her stereotypes are inaccurate and based on prejudice; it reflects manners and cultural awareness she does not expect Boyd to have; its exaggerated politeness mocks people like Mrs Wilson who perform kindness while holding racist attitudes; Jackson uses it ironically to expose the gap between outward politeness and genuine respect.

Endings. Jackson’s stories often end with a brief, powerful line that reveals the protagonist’s emotional state, isolation or identity, leaving judgement, discomfort or tension. In ‘The Villager’, ‘Her shoulders ached’ suggests how burdened Miss Clarence has become by her attempt to maintain an artistic persona. In ‘The Daemon Lover’, ‘No matter how often or how firmly she knocked, no one ever came to the door’ reinforces the protagonist’s isolation and suggests her search for connection, certainty and identity will remain unresolved. Try: *In ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, Boyd’s concluding agreement that his mother is ‘screwy’ suggests that parents are…*; *At the very end, Boyd’s use of the catchphrase ‘After you, my dear Alphonse’ reinforces…*

‘Flower Garden’

Mrs MacLane, a recent widow, moves to a country town, renovates a long-unoccupied cottage, grows a rich flower garden and befriends Mrs Winning. Mrs Winning is drawn to her lifestyle,

seeing in the cottage and garden the life she might have had instead of the dreariness of her own home, where she lives mired in routine with her parents-in-law. But Mrs MacLane's decision to hire an African-American man to help in her garden exposes the prejudice of the townspeople. Faced with being associated with Mrs MacLane's transgression, Mrs Winning retreats to the safety of conforming to the town's judgement.

Annotate:

- **Communities enforcing conformity** – schedules and routines; traditions; characters feeling helpless.
- **Insecurity and dissatisfaction** – being alone; looking at and admiring other people's belongings.
- **Unexpected events or strangers disrupting routines and assumptions** – grey tones contrasted with images of colour; surprised reactions.

Questions to consider:

1. The two Mrs Winnings 'had grown to look a good deal alike', and 'uncounted Winning children had played with almost identical toys'. What do these details suggest about Mrs Winning's sense of herself as an individual?
2. Several characters tell Mrs Winning she should talk to Mrs MacLane 'about that colored man'. No one ever says exactly what the problem is. What does this show about the power of unspoken attitudes in the town?
3. Mrs Winning feels differently about walking up the hill to her house at different points. Describe two of these feelings and their causes.

Mrs Winning and Mrs MacLane. House: 'This dreary old place' against Mrs MacLane's renovated cottage. Garden: the Winnings' plain yard against a house surrounded by beautiful flowers. Child: Mrs Winning doesn't show physical affection; Mrs MacLane's son Davey becomes Howard's friend. Husband: Mrs Winning lives under her husband's family; Mrs MacLane is on her own now he is dead. Independence: Mrs MacLane 'had some money in her own name'. Clothing: Mrs Winning puts 'a scarf over her head'; Mrs MacLane wears a rose-coloured sweater, 'a spot of color' in the room.

The townspeople's role. When they advise Mrs Winning to speak to Mrs MacLane, which label fits best? *Critics* (people who judge and disapprove of others), *followers* (who go along with others' opinions), *gatekeepers* (who decide who is accepted or excluded), *cultural guardians* (who protect a community's traditions and values), *insiders* (people accepted within the group).

The name 'Winning'. 'Winning' means victory, yet Mrs Winning experiences the opposite at several points in the story. Vocabulary: *the name reflects her desire to..., the name stands in contrast to..., her name is both..., the symbolism of her name reflects..., the connotations of her name; defeated by the reality of life, trapped by social expectations, confined by social convention, restricted by inherited traditions, unable to escape the pressures of society; the bittersweet victory of conformity, the safety of her position, the privilege of social approval, the quiet power of social acceptance, the rewards of compliance*.

'Elizabeth'

As one of Jackson's clearly named characters, Elizabeth seems to know who she is and what she wants. But other characters call her 'Miss Style', 'Liz' and 'Beth', identities she clearly struggles with. She runs a literary agency with Robbie, an ineffectual man who bumbles through life and work, constantly relying on her for direction. The agency is struggling, weighed down by Robbie's incompetence and his pattern of damaging relationships. By the end Elizabeth has had enough, arranging a meeting with an old client and imagining he may offer her a pathway to a better, more independent life.

Annotate:

- **Conformity through years of habit** – the rituals Elizabeth and Robbie share; meals and drinks.
- **Human isolation, insecurity and dissatisfaction** – being alone; looking through windows; being separated by rooms, partitions or doors; grey tones contrasted with colour.
- **Strangers disrupting any sense of security** – new and different colours, actions and behaviours.
- **A shifting sense of identity** – imagining alternative lifestyles; thinking about the past; names.

Questions to consider:

1. Elizabeth is woken from a dream: 'Just before the alarm went off she was lying in a hot sunny garden', and when she opened her eyes 'it was raining'. How does this contrast show her dreaming of two different lives?
2. Jackson calls her Elizabeth, but others call her 'Liz' or 'Beth'. How do these names show the different roles she plays?
3. At the end she tries to make her apartment more welcoming. What do her actions show about the life she was expected to lead and her current reality?

Gender. The story asks whether Elizabeth meets the expectations of 1940s femininity. Traits often coded as masculine: dismissive of emotional vulnerability, socially dominant, self-assured, uncomfortable with emotional intimacy, confident in public, defined by practicality rather than imagination. Traits often coded as feminine: emotionally perceptive and sensitive, anxious about social acceptance, conditioned to seek approval, responsible for domestic beauty and order, using imagination as escapism, attentive to appearances, dutiful to family. Elizabeth shows traits from both lists: she is a complex character trying to fit a world with restrictive norms around gender.

Practice topic: *How do Jackson's short stories subvert traditional expectations of gender?* Starters: *Set in a world of conventional gender roles…; In Jackson's stories, traditional gender roles are…; Jackson subverts every expectation of…; As they go about their lives, Jackson's female characters feel constrained to…; The male characters in Jackson's stories are bound by… + challenges, resists, disrupts, reframes, redefines, exposes the fragility of, rejects prescribed, unsettles the boundaries between* or *complies with, accepts, submits to, accommodates, adheres to, upholds, embraces the safety of, conforms outwardly, maintains appearances*.

'The Tooth'

One of the stranger stories in the collection, partly because much of the action is a dreamlike sequence. The protagonist travels to New York to see a dentist about her aching tooth, taking a great many painkillers. Her feverish dreams symbolise a different life she could live, and as the boundary between reality and fantasy blurs, Jackson alludes to the appeal of escaping an ordinary, suburban existence.

Annotate:

- **Dissatisfaction, a shifting sense of identity and isolation** – mirrors; physical appearances; torn, ripped or broken things; colourlessness contrasted with bright colours; dreams; uncertainty.
- **Strangers disrupting routines and assumptions** – sudden consciousness and unconsciousness; strangers.

Questions to consider:

1. Many stories open with a description of everyday routine. What does Jackson describe at the start of this story to show what normal life is like for the protagonist?
2. For most of the story she is unnamed, until she finds the name 'Clara' written on one of her belongings. Clara means 'clear' or 'bright'. What is significant about this?
3. Jackson often ends with the protagonist trapped or dissatisfied. Is this how 'The Tooth' ends? Compare it with another story's ending.

Jim, the man in the blue suit. The colour of his suit and his confidence contrast with her uncertainty and the greyness of her sense of self. He describes a place far removed from buses, truck-stop restaurants and dentists' rooms: 'the waves ringing on the shore like bells', 'nothing to do all day but lie under the trees', 'The grass is so green and so soft'. He evokes legends of Samarkand, an almost mythical place on the Silk Road, the ancient route along which traders carried cloth, spices, information and stories. Readings: she imagines Jim because he represents her desire to escape her ordinary, everyday life; Jim is simply a friendly stranger who comforts her; she uses the thought of Jim to transform herself into a different, more glamorous person; speaking lines of poetic beauty, Jim symbolises the possibility of becoming someone else.

Doors, windows and mirrors. As in 'The Daemon Lover', 'Like Mother Used to Make' and 'The Villager', doors and windows offer visions of a different life or opportunities, sometimes closed, that the protagonist could access. Vocabulary: *thresholds into another self, glimpses of a parallel life, …onto unrealised possibilities, …to hidden identities, openings into alternate realities, portals to a different existence, reflections of lives not lived, moments of escape from…, windows into forbidden desires, doorways to self-discovery, glimpses beyond domesticity, openings into emotional truth, thresholds between reality and fantasy, …onto hidden inner worlds, passages into uncertain futures, doorways to reinvention*. Practice question: *How does Jackson use doors and windows to reveal the dissatisfaction of her characters?*

'Of Course'

Mrs Harris moves in next door to Mrs Tylor. Mrs Tylor immediately profiles her and judges that the family must be 'nice people, obviously', another of Jackson's characters wanting a

world that safely conforms to her sense of what is normal and respectable. But Mrs Harris is not the kind of 'nice' person Mrs Tylor hoped for. She lists the forms of media and entertainment her family avoids, and Mrs Tylor becomes increasingly unsettled by their differences. Throughout her growing discomfort she can only answer 'of course', highlighting both her fear of open disagreement and the ease with which she conforms to her own sense of propriety.

Annotate:

- **Communities enforce conformity through expectations and social pressure** – approval of clothes and appearance; assumptions.
- **Unexpected events or strangers disrupting routines and assumptions** – new people; housekeeping routines; other lifestyles.

Questions to consider:

1. Mrs Tylor is 'far too polite' to go outside and stare at her new neighbours, yet she watches in a particular way as she does her chores. What does this tell us about what she thinks is 'polite'?
2. Mrs Tylor stays polite even as it becomes clear their values differ, while her daughter Carol behaves 'sullenly' towards the new neighbour's son. Who is more honest about their feelings?
3. At the end, Mrs Tylor says she will go with her daughter to the movies. Why is this significant in the context of the story?

Neighbourliness and conformity.

- Mrs Tylor 'recognized finally the faint nervous feeling that was tagging her; it was the way she felt when she was irrevocably connected with something dangerously out of control' – characters feel uneasy when neighbours do not behave in predictable or conventional ways.
- 'Carol shut her mouth obstinately and the little boy edged behind his mother' – neighbourly relationships can reveal the tension between personal choice and social expectation.
- Mrs Tylor approves of the woman's 'nice-looking tan suit': 'Nice people, obviously' – it is important for neighbours to fit accepted notions of respectability.
- Mrs Tylor: 'There's something so nice about congenial people right next door' – neighbourliness is meant to involve easy social interactions.
- Mrs Harris: 'it means such a lot to have really thoughtful neighbors' – being a 'good neighbour' can mean behaving in ways others see as conforming to their values.

Vocabulary: *social pressure, expectations, fitting in, acceptance, social norms, desire to belong, fear of judgement, expectations of neighbourly behaviour, pressure to appear polite, discomfort with difference; conventional, neighbourly, agreeable, uncomfortable, judgemental; highlights, reveals, challenges, resists, contrasts, suggests*.

'The Lottery'

A lottery is a form of gambling in which names or tickets are placed in a box and one is drawn at random, usually to win a prize. Because lotteries are so familiar, Jackson presents the ritual as calm, ordinary and completely accepted. The villagers gather, chat and wait as though

taking part in a harmless community tradition, and this unsettling normality gives the story its disturbing atmosphere. Gradually the reader discovers that the 'winner' receives no reward but is violently sacrificed by the community. Through this shocking ending, Jackson shows how societies can destroy individuality and morality through blind conformity to tradition.

Character	First half of the story	End of the story
Tessie Hutchinson	Arrives late, joking and chatting casually with neighbours. Becomes anxious and upset when her family is selected.	Draws the marked paper and protests that it 'isn't fair' as the villagers stone her.
Bill Hutchinson	Quietly participates and draws the marked paper for his family in the first round.	Forces the slip of paper out of Tessie's hand, revealing the black spot.
Mr Summers	Runs the lottery, as he runs the square dances and the teen club; worries about the shabby black box.	Oversees the final selection and keeps the ritual moving efficiently.
Old Man Warner	Defends the tradition and criticises villages that want to stop it.	Urges the villagers on as they close in.
Mrs Delacroix	Chats in a friendly way with Tessie at the start.	Picks up a stone so large she needs both hands and helps kill Tessie.
Mr Adams	Mentions that other villages are talking of giving up the lottery.	Still participates in the stoning, at the front of the crowd.
Davy Hutchinson	Waits with his family during the drawing and takes part in the ritual as a child of the community.	Is given a few pebbles to throw.
Bobby Martin	Collects stones with the other boys before the lottery begins.	The children, who gathered the stones, join in.

Roles in a society: the characters can be labelled *enforcer, traditionalist, scapegoat, bystander, organiser, follower, enabler, accomplice, dissenter, conformist, victim, outcast*.

Tessie as a transgressor. Although Tessie's name is drawn at random, her early actions position her as a transgressor: she comes late because she 'Clean forgot what day it was'. Forgetting the lottery suggests a small, perhaps unconscious, distance from the tradition that sets her slightly apart from the community before chance singles her out.

The anchor story. 'The Lottery' powerfully represents almost every idea in the collection:

- **Isolation, insecurity and dissatisfaction:** Tessie becomes completely isolated once the crowd turns against her; the villagers hide their fear and insecurity beneath cheerful small talk and routine.
- **Social judgement and exclusion:** Tessie is cast out the moment she is chosen; compare Mrs MacLane, ostracised for hiring a Black gardener in 'Flower Garden', and Boyd, judged through racist stereotypes in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse'.
- **Communities enforce conformity through traditions, rituals and social pressure:** the villagers continue the lottery because social pressure and tradition discourage anyone from resisting.
- **Unexpected events disrupting routines and assumptions:** Tessie's selection suddenly transforms an ordinary community gathering into a horrifying event.

- **Violence beneath the veneer of civilised behaviour:** neighbours, friends and family carry out a killing as calmly as a town meeting.
- **A shifting sense of identity:** Tessie shifts from a cheerful member of the community to an isolated victim once she is selected.

Connecting the Stories

When you study a collection, you need to make connections between stories that can seem completely different. The activities below practise linking stories through shared ideas, symbols and character types, which is exactly what high-scoring Section A essays do.

Naming, or Not Naming, Protagonists

Many of Jackson's protagonists have no name. The protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' is never named, although her fiancé and many people she meets are. By contrast, David Turner's name opens 'Like Mother Used to Make'.

Describing the two protagonists. The protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' is *nebulous, unsure, uncertain, undecided, operating in a liminal space, between life stages, doubtful, searching for direction, plagued by self-doubt, torn between possibilities* (of/about herself, who she is, her identity, who she would like to be). David Turner is *definite, particular, sure, individual, well defined, set in his habits, secure, clear about, guided by firm principles, anchored by routine* (about himself, who he is, his identity, his aspirations).

Model paragraph:

> *Many of Jackson's unnamed characters exist in a state of uncertainty about who they are, while characters with names often appear more stable and confident. In 'The Daemon Lover', the unnamed protagonist wanders through the city searching for her missing fiancé. Her lack of a name reflects her weak sense of identity and how much she depends on becoming a 'bride-to-be'. As she moves through apartments, streets and memories, she struggles to define herself outside the expectations of romance and marriage. Jackson develops this uncertainty through the protagonist's fragmented thoughts and growing paranoia, suggesting that her identity is fragile and unstable. By contrast, in 'Like Mother Used to Make', David Turner's full name makes him seem more socially established and certain of his place in the world. However, Jackson still reveals cracks beneath this confidence as David desperately tries to appear sophisticated and domestically capable in front of Marcia and his guests. Although his name gives him a clearer public identity, his anxiety during the dinner party shows how easily constructed identities can fall apart. Through these contrasting characters, Jackson suggests that unnamed characters are often trapped in uncertainty and transition, while named characters possess greater social stability, even if that stability is ultimately fragile.*

Topic sentence options:

- While some of Jackson's characters are unnamed to reflect their shifting sense of themselves, the naming of other characters reflects their individual sense of identity.
- By withholding names from certain protagonists, Jackson emphasises their uncertain sense of self, in contrast to named characters whose identities appear more firmly constructed.
- Many of Jackson's characters have names that reflect their role rather than their sense of individuality, while other characters remain unnamed, representing their inner discontent.

- Jackson often presents unnamed protagonists as psychologically uncertain figures, while named characters appear to possess greater social and personal stability.
- In many of Jackson's stories, anonymity reflects an unstable or transitional identity, whereas named characters are characterised by a stronger sense of certainty and control.

Evidence: 'The Daemon Lover': 'Anxiously she pulled through the dresses in the closet'; she 'hesitated until a door at the end opened'; 'suddenly horribly aware of her over-young print dress'; 'There's more than you think when you look at me.' 'Like Mother Used to Make': 'did everything in small, quick movements'; 'He had always been partial to yellows and browns'; 'It pleased him to have only one key to his home'; 'I like things this way.'

Paragraph frame: *In [story title], the unnamed/named character…; The character's [lack of a name / full name] reflects…; As [character]…, Jackson suggests…; Jackson develops this idea through…; However, in [story title]…; Although [character] appears…, Jackson reveals…; Through these contrasting characters, Jackson suggests…*

Windows and Doors

In Jackson's stories windows are highly symbolic: when characters look out of them, they are often thinking about a different life they could have lived.

- 'The Daemon Lover': 'She went to the window and saw that it was undeniably a fine day. It occurred to her that perhaps she ought not to wear the blue silk dress; it was too plain, almost severe, and she wanted to be soft, feminine.'
- 'Like Mother Used to Make': 'The window had been open all day and papers had blown wildly around the floor. David closed the window, hesitated over the papers, and then moved away quickly.'
- 'The Villager': 'The first thing Miss Clarence did was go to the window… far off to the left, a high building crowned with flower gardens. Someday I'll live there, she thought.'
- 'The Witch': 'The little boy was looking out the window… "I saw a witch," he said.'

In each, a character is having one kind of experience in their own world while seeing, or avoiding, a different kind of experience through the window. Words to describe this: *certainty, escape, possibility, freedom, discipline, logical thinking, separation between worlds, wanting more from life, comfort, belonging, imagination, the divide between, longing, desire for change, seeing beyond ordinary life, emotional escape, new experiences, responsibility, domestic harmony, dreams, fantasy, another life, hope, discontent with ordinary life, different futures, order, control.*

Sentence starters: *Throughout her fiction, Jackson uses windows as symbols of…; In many of her stories, Jackson positions windows as a means of revealing…; Repeatedly, Jackson uses windows to emphasise…; Throughout Jackson's work, windows function as representations of…; In story after story, Jackson uses windows to draw attention to…; Jackson's recurring use of windows highlights…; Across her stories, windows act as portals into…; Jackson repeatedly depicts windows as…; In many of Jackson's stories, windows reveal…*

Doors. Her stories also feature many doors and locks. While windows symbolise *possible* different lives, doors represent *actual* ways to enter other lives or to shut other people out: the

door that never opens in 'The Daemon Lover', David's single key in 'Like Mother Used to Make', the doors Harris opens in 'The Villager'. Word bank: *new experiences, opportunities for change, the ability to enter, access to another life, emotional withdrawal, exclusion from, being shut out, a sense of rejection, feeling of isolation* (ideas); *seek, desire, realise, resist, hope for, yearn, imagine, believe* (what characters do); *desperation for, anxiety, protection, hidden feelings, vulnerability, exclusion, social isolation, optimism, faith in transformation* (feelings).

Social Judgement Across the Stories

One of the powerful forces oppressing Jackson's characters is the social judgement they all feel. Her protagonists spend a lot of energy worrying about what others will think.

- 'The Daemon Lover': 'Why don't I go to the police–you go to the police for a missing person. And then thought, What a fool I'd look like.' She is worried about looking foolish and being pitied.
- 'The Villager': 'He wandered over and opened the bathroom door; when he glanced in Miss Clarence winced.' She is worried that the dirty bathroom will be judged as hers.
- 'The Renegade': 'anyone would tell on a chicken-killing dog; but he doesn't have to be so pleased about it.' Mrs Walpole is worried that her neighbours are enjoying her humiliation.

The protagonists also judge others and themselves: the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' judges her own appearance and apartment; David judges the clerks who don't recognise him; Miss Clarence judges the Robertses' housekeeping; Mrs Walpole judges her own failures against the 'country folk'. In comparison, many minor characters seem almost immune to judgement: the stranger in 'The Witch' doesn't care what the mother thinks; the Robertses leave their messy apartment open for others to see; the grocer and the other men in 'The Renegade' don't consider how the dog's owner feels.

Topic sentence options:

- In Jackson's stories, the protagonists often shape their behaviour based on how they think others will judge them.
- Jackson contrasts anxious protagonists with confident outsiders who ignore social expectations and judgement.
- Many of Jackson's protagonists become trapped by their awareness of how they appear to others.
- Throughout her collection, Jackson suggests that people who are unaffected by social judgement can appear threatening, strange or powerful.

Sentence starters: *In the story..., the protagonist...; Jackson uses the character of... to demonstrate how...; Jackson develops this idea in... through the character of...; This idea is evident in... where... | Their belief that '...' reveals...; ...'s decision to '...' highlights...; When they '...' it demonstrates...; In the scene where '...' Jackson evokes...; Their reaction to '...' demonstrates...; Jackson's description of '...' emphasises...; At the moment where they '...' the reader can see...; The reference to '...' reinforces... | This also reveals...; This further highlights...; This also demonstrates...; Through this, Jackson conveys...; As a result...; Furthermore...; Moreover...; In contrast...; However...*

Racism and Social Judgement

The racism in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' and 'Flower Garden' is part of Jackson's larger concern with how social judgement shapes society. Racism controls not only its victims, like Mr Jones in 'Flower Garden', but also those who act with prejudice. Like any form of social judgement, it makes everyone unhappy.

- **Reasons for social judgement:** desire to maintain social status; fear of being judged by others; pressure to conform to community expectations; anxiety about losing belonging or respectability; need to feel morally or socially superior; acceptance of racist assumptions as 'normal'; desire to appear polite; pressure to behave like others; worry about offending people with social power.
- **Impacts of social judgement:** emotional hurt or humiliation; confusion about how to react; individuals become outsiders within the community; people hide their true thoughts and feelings; resistance to stereotypes; misunderstanding of relationships; reinforcement of the accepted social order; defensiveness and insecurity about being exposed as prejudiced.

Model paragraph: *How does racism affect the characters in Shirley Jackson's short stories?*

- **Topic sentence:** While social judgement of all kinds is present in her stories, Shirley Jackson explicitly depicts racism as one way of maintaining social order in society.
- **Introduce and analyse an example:** The story 'After You, My Dear Alphonse' presents Mrs Wilson's racism towards her son's African-American friend, Boyd, as stemming from her need to position Boyd and his family as poor and working class in order to confirm her own identity as a superior middle-class white person. When Boyd resists Mrs Wilson's racist assumptions, such as her expectation that he 'will eat anything', she is left 'disappointed' because her belief that all people of colour must conform to certain stereotypes has been proven wrong.
- **Link to a further example:** However, while Boyd is able to withstand the controlling force of racism in 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', the same is not true of the victim of social judgement in 'Flower Garden'.
- **Introduce and analyse an example from a second story:** In this story, the white Mrs MacLane unwittingly transgresses the unspoken racist attitudes of the locals and hires an African-American gardener. This results in her ostracism, and Mrs MacLane asks her one-time friend 'what on earth is gone wrong?' Mrs Winning is motivated by her recurrent thought that 'something bad has happened' and that she is losing her own privileged place within the small community by associating with Mrs MacLane. At the end of the story, Mrs MacLane's garden is damaged by a broken branch, symbolising how social judgement and exclusion have broken her dream of a beautiful and fulfilled country life.
- **Synthesising sentence:** Through these two stories, Jackson reveals how racism operates as a powerful controlling force within society, dictating the actions of both perpetrators and victims.

Elizabeth and Clara: Confidence and Uncertainty

In many ways Elizabeth and Clara seem completely different: Elizabeth is determined and decisive, while Clara floats through her story in a kind of delirium. Adjectives to sort into 'Elizabeth', 'Clara' or 'both': *anxious, decisive, authoritative, insecure, uneasy, unstable, conflicted, grounded, confident, timid, principled, unsettled, assured, self-conscious, determined, steadfast*.

Sentence frames: *While at first glance Elizabeth appears… compared with Clara from 'The Tooth', who is more…, underneath they are both…; Even though Elizabeth behaves in a… manner when she…, she is also… because…; Although Clara seems… because she…, she also demonstrates that she can be… when she…*

Analyses of protagonists to match to characters (one analysis may suit more than one character):

- beneath a confident exterior, the character's self-perception remains surprisingly fragile and dependent on social validation;
- appears tentative and directionless in the beginning, but gradually develops a firmer understanding of themselves;
- presents an assured and carefully constructed identity that resists external scrutiny;
- confidence is not innate but carefully performed in order to conceal deep anxieties;
- deeply uncertain, drifting between competing versions of herself without ever fully committing to one;
- oscillates between confidence and self-doubt, never fully inhabiting either state;
- begins the story with absolute conviction, yet ends it isolated, confused and uncertain of her own identity;
- idealised visions of herself reflect a desperate desire for certainty and control;
- projects confidence because she unquestioningly conforms to social expectations;
- attachment to familiar domestic spaces reveals her need for stability and reassurance.

Characters to match: the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover', David ('Like Mother Used to Make'), Miss Clarence ('The Villager'), Mrs Walpole ('The Renegade'), Mrs Wilson ('After You, My Dear Alphonse'), the mother in 'Charles', Mrs Winning ('Flower Garden'), Elizabeth, Mrs Tylor ('Of Course'), Clara ('The Tooth'). Then place every protagonist on a spectrum from *sure of themselves* to *uncertain*, once for the beginning of their story and once for the end.

Practice topic: *In the world of Shirley Jackson, identity is constructed in response to the demands of society. Discuss.*

Organising Evidence for Essays

For each key idea, collect evidence from three or four stories: the characters, their feelings and actions, and the quotes and symbols that show the idea. Re-read the summary of the idea in the Key Vocabulary notes, and use the annotation guides in the Story Study Guides to find stories and symbols that fit.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Topic: *Jackson's stories are tales of exclusion and isolation. Discuss.*

- **Topic sentence:** Many of Jackson's protagonists experience profound isolation because they struggle to fit society's expectations of normality.
- **Initial examples from one story:** In [story], Jackson shows how people are excluded when…; Jackson emphasises this idea by…; This exclusion leads to…
- **Link:** In [story], Jackson presents another kind of social exclusion, when…
- **Further examples from another story:** This story explores… and…; Through [character]'s experience of…, Jackson…
- **Synthesising sentence:** Together, these stories suggest that…

A second topic sentence to try: *Jackson's stories also suggest that people often exclude others in order to protect their own sense of security and belonging.*

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

How does Jackson portray the inner frustration of ordinary lives? Brainstorm words for 'inner frustration' and 'ordinary lives', then choose a sub-idea:

- Many of Jackson's characters feel trapped by ordinary life.
- The stifling effects of family expectations lead to quiet dissatisfaction.
- Social expectations can leave people living with unmet expectations.
- Beneath everyday appearances lies deep emotional disappointment.
- For many characters, ordinary life brings frustration and the sense of unmet potential.
- Unable to change their circumstances, Jackson's characters often long for something more.
- Insecurity and inner grievances quietly shape many of Jackson's protagonists.
- Through everyday routines and settings, Jackson reveals hidden despair.

Dissatisfaction in Jackson's stories is both self-created and socially imposed. Discuss. Sub-ideas:

- Jackson's world is one of dissatisfaction and disillusionment.
- For Jackson's protagonists, unhappiness is rooted in their own insecurities.
- In the world of Jackson's short stories, discontent is fuelled by unrealistic expectations.
- Beyond their own choices, many characters are constrained by the limitations of the community.
- Jackson explores the tension between individual desires and social conformity.
- Unable to trust others, or their own judgement, Jackson's protagonists are trapped in unhappiness.
- Jackson reveals a world populated by those who form unhappy identities reinforced by society.

- Although they imagine themselves judged by others, Jackson's characters are victims of their own self-censorship.

Unexpected Events

Jackson's stories depict moments when the safety of everyday life becomes threatening. Discuss. This topic has two parts: everyday life is routine and safe; changes to routine and convention can reveal dangers. Brainstorm vocabulary and examples for 'safety of everyday life' and 'threatening ideas', then write one paragraph: in the first half, show how Jackson establishes a 'safe world'; in the second, how she 'threatens' it.

In Jackson's stories, ordinary life is both predictable and fragile. Here the focus is less on the unexpected events themselves than on what they reveal about how easily the structures of everyday life can be broken. Brainstorm 'predictable' against 'fragile', then write a paragraph responding to each part.

The Violence Beneath a Civilised Society

An essay process: circle key words in the topic; brainstorm alternative vocabulary; refer back to the stories and your notes to brainstorm examples; sort examples into three or four groups as the basis for body paragraphs; plan the topic sentence for each group; write the essay. Try it on:

- Politeness in Jackson's short stories often masks something far more sinister. To what extent do you agree?
- In Jackson's stories, violence emerges most shockingly from everyday life. Discuss.
- Jackson's stories reveal darkness beneath respectable appearances. Discuss.
- Jackson's stories suggest that ordinary social settings can conceal disturbing cruelty. Discuss.

Quote Banks

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘She was not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘There was nothing to eat in the apartment.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘In the drugstore she found that there was nothing she wanted to eat.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘Anxiously, she pulled through the dresses in the closet.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: She was ‘suddenly horribly aware of her over-young print dress.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘There’s more than you think when you look at me.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘all this coffee… no real breakfast.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: She ‘worried unnecessarily, at the window, over whether it would be a fine day.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: The blue silk dress was ‘too plain, almost severe, and she wanted to be soft, feminine.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: ‘It was very early in the year for a print dress.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: Her make-up ‘was another delicate balance between looking as well as possible, and deceiving as little.’

> *The Daemon Lover*: The skirt looked made ‘for someone who would run freely, dance, swing it with her hips when she walked.’

> *The Villager*: ‘She had come to New York from a small town upstate because she wanted to be a dancer.’

> *The Villager*: ‘She could see only dirty roofs and, far off to the left, a high building crowned with flower gardens.’

> *Flower Garden*: Mrs Winning: ‘This dreary old place.’

> *Flower Garden*: Mrs Winning: 'It seems as though spring would never come. I get so tired of the cold.'

> *Elizabeth*: 'Just before the alarm went off she was lying in a hot sunny garden'; when she woke, 'it was raining.'

> *The Villager*: Miss Clarence tells herself she has 'a good job' and lives 'better than she would have in her home town.'

> *The Villager*: 'Someday I'll live there, she thought.'

> *The Villager*: 'Her shoulders ached.'

> *The Tooth*: Jim describes 'the waves ringing on the shore like bells' and 'nothing to do all day but lie under the trees.'

> *The Tooth*: Jim: 'The grass is so green and so soft.'

> *The Tooth*: 'Her hand in Jim's and her hair down on her shoulders, she ran barefoot through hot sand.'

> *Elizabeth*: 'I wish I'd been a blonde' – *her thought at the mirror*.

> *Elizabeth*: 'the ugly morning noises of people stirring'

> *Elizabeth*: 'something wonderful would happen to change her whole life'

> *The Tooth*: Her tooth 'seemed now the only part of her to have any identity.'

> *The Tooth*: 'you'd think my own face would know me' – *Clara's thoughts at the mirror*.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

> *The Daemon Lover*: 'She looked down and the boy grinned insolently at her.'

> *The Daemon Lover*: 'He said, "I hope you find your young man," and gave it a nasty sound.'

> *The Daemon Lover*: 'No matter how often or how firmly she knocked, no one ever came to the door.'

Like Mother Used to Make: Mr. Harris 'looked suspiciously at David.'

Like Mother Used to Make: The clerk 'looked past David at the next customer'; David thinks 'you'd think they'd know me well enough to be more courteous.'

Flower Garden: The townspeople advise Mrs Winning to talk to Mrs MacLane 'about that colored man.'

Flower Garden: 'Children will call names... There's not much you can do.'

Flower Garden: Mrs Winning thinks: 'pretty soon they'll stop coming to me first, they'll tell someone else to speak to me.'

Flower Garden: Mrs Winning 'swung around without speaking and started, with great dignity, back up the hill toward the old Winning house.'

Of Course: Mrs Harris: 'It means such a lot to have really thoughtful neighbors.'

Of Course: Mrs Tylor: 'There's something so nice about congenial people right next door.'

The Daemon Lover: 'Why don't I go to the police... What a fool I'd look like.'

The Villager: 'He wandered over and opened the bathroom door; when he glanced in Miss Clarence winced.'

The Villager: Miss Clarence judges the absent Mrs Roberts: 'she doesn't even make coffee in the morning.'

The Renegade: 'Anyone would tell on a chicken-killing dog; but he doesn't have to be so pleased about it.'

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Mrs Wilson: 'Boyd will eat anything.'

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Mrs Wilson: 'Don't think I'm angry, Boyd. I'm just disappointed in you.'

Flower Garden: The two Mrs Winnings 'had grown to look a good deal alike'; 'uncounted Winning children had played with almost identical toys.'

Flower Garden: Mrs Winning: 'Something bad has happened, somehow people think

> they know something about me that they won't say.'

> *Flower Garden*: Mrs MacLane: 'What on earth is gone wrong?'

> *Of Course*: Mrs Tylor 'was far too polite to go' out and stare at her new neighbours.

> *Of Course*: 'A nice-looking tan suit… Nice people, obviously.'

> *Of Course*: 'Carol shut her mouth obstinately and the little boy edged behind his mother.'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Mrs Wilson: 'Does he…work?'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: 'Mrs. Wilson restrained an impulse to pat Boyd on the head.'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Mrs Wilson: 'There are many little boys like you, Boyd, who would be very grateful for the clothes someone was kind enough to give them.'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Boyd: 'But I have plenty of clothes, thank you'

> *After You, My Dear Alphonse*: Johnny: 'She's screwy sometimes.' Boyd: 'So's mine.'

> *Charles*: 'None of them looked to me haggard enough.' – *the mother, scanning the other mothers.*

> *Elizabeth*: 'Dried-up old maid' – *a woman on the bus.*

> *Elizabeth*: 'there was no one around to tell Elizabeth Style'

> *The Renegade*: 'The voice sounded satisfied now; Mrs. Walpole had been cornered.'

> *The Renegade*: Mr White: 'Guess you're not going to have any more dog.'

Identity and Gender

> *Like Mother Used to Make*: 'David Turner, who did everything in small quick movements'

> *Like Mother Used to Make*: 'The neat small table and four careful chairs.'

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘It pleased him to have only one key to his home.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘He had chosen a sedate, pretty pattern.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘I like things this way.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘Marcia arrived with a shout and fresh air and disorder.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘She was a tall handsome girl with a loud voice.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘Marcia was always hungry.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘The window had been open all day and papers had blown wildly around the floor.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘He had always been partial to yellows and browns.’

Like Mother Used to Make: ‘Marcia’s home was bare and at random.’

The Villager: Harris: ‘What I need is a wife.’

Charles: Laurie has become ‘a long-trousered, swaggering character.’

Charles: The teacher: ‘We had a little trouble adjusting, the first week or so.’

Flower Garden: Mrs MacLane ‘had some money in her own name.’

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Johnny: ‘Boyd’s father doesn’t have to… He’s a foreman.’

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Johnny: ‘Why should she?… You don’t work.’

Charles: Laurie: ‘Hi, Pop, y’old dust mop.’

Elizabeth: ‘Because they were not married, Robbie was reluctant to take her anywhere where he might be embarrassed by her presence.’

The Tooth: Clara: ‘Leave a note telling him we want eggs.’ – *her last words to her husband.*

The Tooth: Her husband: ‘You had a toothache on our honeymoon’

The Renegade: Lady welcomes the children ‘as though they were the aliens and she the native to the house.’

Unexpected Events and Strangers

The Witch: ‘The little boy was looking out the window’; then he tells his mother, ‘I saw a witch.’

The Witch: ‘Did you cut her all in pieces?’ the little boy asked breathlessly.

The Witch: The stranger: ‘I pinched her and I pinched her until she was dead… I cut off her head and her hands’

The Witch: ‘With his lollipop he went back to his own seat, and settled himself to look out the window again. “Prob’ly he was a witch.” ‘

Of Course: Mrs Tylor ‘recognized finally the faint nervous feeling that was tagging her; it was the way she felt when she was irrevocably connected with something dangerously out of control.’

Charles: ‘Charles? We don’t have any Charles in the kindergarten.’

The Witch: Strangers tell the boy he is ‘a fine big fellow’; ‘These comments annoyed the little boy.’

The Witch: The boy gives his age: ‘Twenty-six. Eight hunnerd and forty eighty’; his name: ‘Mr. Jesus.’

The Witch: The baby is ‘strapped securely to the seat.’

The Witch: The mother: ‘He was just teasing… Just teasing.’

Charles: The mother: ‘I suppose this time it’s Charles’s influence.’

Charles: The father: ‘Bound to be people like Charles in the world. Might as well meet them now as later.’

The Tooth: ‘My name is Jim,’ the strange man said.

> *The Tooth*: Jim ‘held out a handful of pearls.’

The Violence Beneath a Civilised Society

> *The Lottery*: ‘The morning of June 27th was clear and sunny, with the fresh warmth of a full-summer day.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Bobby Martin had already stuffed his pockets full of stones.’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘Clean forgot what day it was.’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘Wouldn’t have me leave m’dishes in the sink, now, would you, Joe?’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘Get up there, Bill.’

> *The Lottery*: Old Man Warner: ‘Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon.’

> *The Lottery*: Old Man Warner: ‘There’s always been a lottery.’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘You didn’t give him time enough to take any paper he wanted. I saw you. It wasn’t fair!’

> *The Lottery*: Bill Hutchinson: ‘Shut up, Tessie.’

> *The Lottery*: Mrs Hutchinson: ‘I think we ought to start over.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Although the villagers had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Mrs. Delacroix selected a stone so large she had to pick it up with both hands.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Come on,’ she said. ‘Hurry up.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘Come on, come on, everyone.’

> *The Lottery*: ‘It isn’t fair, it isn’t right,’ Mrs. Hutchinson screamed, and then they were upon her.

The Renegade: ‘The spikes cut her head off.’

The Renegade: ‘They both began to laugh…’

The Renegade: ‘Mrs. Walpole closed her eyes, suddenly feeling the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat.’

After You, My Dear Alphonse: Johnny: ‘Dead Japanese… We stand them in the ground and run over them with tanks.’

Charles: Laurie: ‘Today Charles hit the teacher.’

Charles: ‘Charles bounced a see-saw on to the head of a little girl and made her bleed’

Elizabeth: ‘I’m afraid Mr. Shax didn’t have courage enough to tell you’ – *Elizabeth, dismissing Daphne.*

The Renegade: ‘the murderous brutality a pretty dog like Lady could keep so well hidden in their home’

The Renegade: The grocer: ‘Scratch his eyes out… He wouldn’t ever be able to see another chicken.’

Character Quote Bank

Every quotation below has been checked word for word against the text of the collection. Quotations are grouped by story and by character, with a note on where each one comes from. Where a character speaks, the words are theirs; where the line is narration or a character's thoughts, the note says so.

'The Daemon Lover'

The protagonist (unnamed, thirty-four)

> 'Anne, by the time you get this I will be married.' – *the letter to her sister, which she tears up.*

> She 'was not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment.' – *narration, at two minutes past ten.*

> She 'tried to think of Jamie and could not see his face clearly, or hear his voice.' – *narration, while waiting.*

> 'Please don't make any mistake… I'm afraid you don't understand.' – *to the superintendent's wife, in a voice 'with thirty-four years of accumulated pride'.*

> 'Why don't I go to the police… What a fool I'd look like.' – *her thoughts, deciding against it.*

Jamie Harris (seen only through others)

> 'He's rather tall, and fair. He wears a blue suit very often. He's a writer.' – *her description of him.*

> 'This is a big day for me, kid' – *the words the boy says Jamie spoke to him.*

The strangers

> 'You got the wrong house, lady' and, more quietly, 'or the wrong guy' – *the superintendent, before he and his wife laugh.*

> 'Now how many men in blue suits go past here every day, lady?' – *the delicatessen man.*

> 'I hope you find your young man' – *the florist, who 'gave it a nasty sound'.*

> 'You gonna divorce him, missus? You got something on him?' – *the boy, running off with*

> *her dollar*.

‘Like Mother Used to Make’

David Turner

> ‘David Turner, who did everything in small quick movements’ – *the opening line*.

> ‘it pleased him to have only one key to his home, and that safely in his own pocket’ – *narration*.

> ‘I like things this way.’ – *to Marcia, over dinner*.

> ‘You ought to keep your home neater.’ – *to Marcia*.

> ‘Guess I better be getting along, Marcia.’ – *instead of telling Mr Harris the truth*.

> ‘Thanks for a simply wonderful dinner, Marcia’ – *leaving his own apartment*.

Marcia

> ‘I didn’t forget, Davie, I’m just late as usual. What’s for dinner?’ – *arriving*.

> ‘Someone should teach me, I guess.’ – *on keeping house*.

> ‘I haven’t made but two, three pies before’ – *claiming David’s pie in front of Mr Harris*.

> ‘I don’t think Davie liked it much… I think it was too sour for him.’ – *said ‘wickedly’*.

> ‘Don’t forget your key.’ – *handing David the key to her apartment*.

Mr Harris

> ‘I just thought I’d stop by.’ – *arriving uninvited*.

> ‘I like a sour pie… A cherry pie’s got to be sour.’ – *as he ‘looked suspiciously at David’*.

‘The Villager’

Miss Hilda Clarence

> Her novel she ‘had read enthusiastically up to page fifty and only carried now for effect’ –

> *narration.*

> In letters home she 'referred to herself as a "Village die-hard."' – *narration.*

> 'Someday I'll live there, she thought' – *looking at a building 'crowned with flower gardens'.*

> 'Not as easy as it used to be, she thought, it catches you in the shoulders.' – *trying the dancer's pose.*

> 'Dancer,' she said. – *answering Harris's question.*

> 'Artie's going to Paris' – *taking on Mrs Roberts's life.*

> 'Her shoulders ached.' – *the final line.*

Harris

> 'Or, rather, I hope to write' – *introducing himself.*

> 'This place is certainly nicer than mine… Mine's a hole in the wall.'

> 'What I need is a wife.'

'The Witch'

Johnny, the little boy

> 'I saw a witch… There was a big old ugly old bad old witch outside.' – *to his mother.*

> 'I'm a man already' – *to the stranger.*

> 'Mr. Jesus' – *when the stranger asks his name.*

> 'Did you cut her all in pieces?' – *asked 'breathlessly'.*

> 'Prob'ly he was a witch.' – *the final line.*

The stranger

> 'Hello yourself, son.' – *his first words.*

> ‘All men smoke cigars… Someday you’ll smoke a cigar, too.’

> ‘I bought her a rocking-horse and a doll and a million lollipops’ – *the start of his story about his sister.*

> ‘Did I frighten you?’ – *to the mother, before he and the boy laugh.*

The mother

> ‘Not much longer now’ – *her answer ‘each time’ the boy asks how far they have to go.*

> ‘Just what do you think you’re doing?… Get out of here.’ – *to the stranger.*

> ‘He was just teasing… Just teasing.’ – *to Johnny.*

> ‘You sit still and be a good boy. You may have another lollipop.’

‘The Renegade’

Mrs Walpole

> ‘That’s perfectly ridiculous’ – *on the phone, told her dog kills chickens.*

> ‘I just can’t believe it of Lady. She’s so gentle.’

> ‘anyone would tell on a chicken-killing dog; but he doesn’t have to be so pleased about it’ – *her thoughts about Mr White.*

> ‘But how did he feel about you?… Did he ever like you again?’ – *to the grocer, about his father’s dog.*

> ‘feeling the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat’ – *the final line.*

The townspeople

> ‘He’s been killing my chickens.’ – *the caller; ‘The voice sounded satisfied now; Mrs. Walpole had been cornered.’*

> ‘You’ll have to do something about the dog.’ – *the caller.*

> ‘Guess you’re not going to have any more dog.’ – *Mr White, grinning*.

> ‘You get a dead chicken and tie it around the dog’s neck’ – *Mr White*.

> ‘Sure… Shoot him.’ – *the man at the grocery, asked if the dog can be cured*.

> ‘Scratch his eyes out… He wouldn’t ever be able to see another chicken.’ – *the grocer*.

Jack and Judy (the twins)

> ‘She’s going to get shot.’ – *Judy*.

> ‘Then we put this real sharp spiky collar around your neck’ – *Jack, before he ‘kissed the top of her head’*.

> ‘The spikes cut her head off’ – *Jack*.

> ‘They both began to laugh’ – *narration, as Lady pants ‘as though she were laughing too’*.

‘Charles’

Laurie

> ‘Isn’t anybody here?’ – *coming home from his first day*.

> ‘I didn’t learn nothing’ – *to his father*.

> ‘Today Charles hit the teacher.’ – *said as he ‘grinned enormously’*.

> ‘Look at my thumb. Gee, you’re dumb.’ – *to his father*.

> ‘Hi, Pop, y’old dust mop.’

Laurie’s mother (the narrator)

> ‘a long-trousered, swaggering character who forgot to stop at the corner and wave good-bye to me’ – *on Laurie’s first morning*.

> ‘this Charles boy sounds like such a bad influence’ – *to her husband*.

> ‘I wanted passionately to meet Charles’s mother’ – *narration*.

> ‘I suppose this time it’s Charles’s influence.’ – *to the teacher*.

Laurie’s father and the teacher

> ‘Bound to be people like Charles in the world. Might as well meet them now as later.’ – *Laurie’s father*.

> ‘We had a little trouble adjusting, the first week or so… but now he’s a fine little helper. With occasional lapses, of course.’ – *the teacher, about Laurie*.

> ‘We don’t have any Charles in the kindergarten.’ – *the teacher*.

‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’

Mrs Wilson

> ‘Boyd will eat anything.’

> ‘Boyd wants to grow up and be a big strong man so he can work hard’

> ‘Does he…work?’ – *about Boyd’s father, after she ‘hesitated’*.

> She ‘restrained an impulse to pat Boyd on the head.’ – *narration*.

> ‘There are many little boys like you, Boyd, who would be very grateful for the clothes someone was kind enough to give them.’ – *taking the gingerbread away*.

> ‘Don’t think I’m angry, Boyd. I’m just disappointed in you, that’s all.’

Boyd

> ‘How do you do, Mrs. Wilson?’

> ‘My father eats anything he wants to’

> ‘But I have plenty of clothes, thank you’ – *refusing the bundle*.

> ‘Is your mother still mad?’ – *asked ‘in a low voice’*.

Johnny

> ‘Dead Japanese… We stand them in the ground and run over them with tanks.’ – *explaining the wood.*

> ‘Boyd’s father doesn’t have to… He’s a foreman.’

> ‘Why should she?… You don’t work.’ – *to his mother, about Boyd’s mother.*

> ‘She’s screwy sometimes.’ (Boyd: ‘So’s mine.’)

‘Flower Garden’

Young Mrs Winning (Helen)

> ‘It seems as though spring would never come… I get so tired of the cold.’ – *the opening.*

> ‘This could have been mine, she was thinking’ – *in the cottage.*

> ‘This dreary old place’ – *of the Winning house.*

> ‘Children will call names… There’s not much you can do.’ – *after Howard’s racist name-calling.*

> ‘You won’t have him working here past today, will you?’ – *about Mr Jones.*

> ‘pretty soon they’ll stop coming to me first, they’ll tell someone else to speak to me’ – *her thoughts.*

> ‘I sound exactly like Mother Winning, and realized, I’m enjoying this’ – *her thoughts, as Mrs MacLane asks for help.*

> ‘The nerve of her, trying to blame the colored folks.’ – *her thoughts.*

> She ‘swung around without speaking and started, with great dignity, back up the hill toward the old Winning house.’ – *the final line.*

Mrs MacLane

> ‘I love gardens.’

> ‘I don’t think I’ve ever been so happy.’

> ‘Go tell that boy you’re sorry’ – *to Davey*.

> ‘What I wanted to ask you is, what on earth is gone wrong?’

> ‘Are you sure it isn’t because of Mr. Jones working here?’

> ‘Do you think I ought to give it up, Mr. Jones? Go back to the city where I’ll never have to see another garden?’

> ‘Leave it for the next people to move!’

The town

> ‘Not that kind of help’ – *the elder Mrs Winning*.

> ‘you ought to talk to her about that colored man working there’ – *the elder Mrs Winning*.

> ‘He’s there every blessed day… And working out there without his shirt on.’ – *the elder Mrs Winning*.

> ‘Where’s that dressed-up friend of yours get to?’ – *Mrs Harris*.

> ‘I just thought you might mind if he didn’t come.’ – *Mrs Burton, about Davey and the birthday party*.

‘Elizabeth’

Elizabeth Style

> ‘Just before the alarm went off she was lying in a hot sunny garden’ – *the opening*.

> ‘the ugly morning noises of people stirring’ – *narration*.

> ‘I wish I’d been a blonde’ – *her thought at the mirror*.

> ‘Is he trying in his own heavy-handed fashion to beautify the office?’ – *her thoughts about Daphne’s hiring*.

> ‘good old Harris, he never has a chance if you talk fast’ – *her thoughts after the phone call*.

> ‘I’m afraid Mr. Shax didn’t have courage enough to tell you’ – *dismissing Daphne.*

> ‘something wonderful would happen to change her whole life’ – *narration, before Harris arrives.*

> ‘while she was planning her new life she forgot Jim Harris, his heavy face, his thin voice’ – *narration.*

Others

> ‘Dried-up old maid’ – *a woman on the bus.*

> ‘there was no one around to tell Elizabeth Style’ – *narration, on her arrival in New York at twenty.*

> ‘Mr. Shax didn’t tell me anything’ – *Daphne Hill.*

> ‘A suit like yours?’ – *Daphne, looking Elizabeth up and down.*

‘The Tooth’

Clara Spencer

> ‘I feel so funny’ – *to her husband at the bus.*

> ‘Milkman… Leave a note telling him we want eggs.’ – *her last words to him.*

> Her tooth ‘seemed now the only part of her to have any identity.’ – *narration.*

> ‘you’d think my own face would know me’ – *her thoughts at the mirror.*

> ‘Clara… Clara?’ – *reading her own name on her barrette.*

> ‘her hand in Jim’s and her hair down on her shoulders, she ran barefoot through hot sand.’ – *the final line.*

Her husband and Jim

> ‘You had a toothache on our honeymoon’ – *her husband, ‘accusingly’.*

> ‘It’s only a toothache.’ – *her husband.*

> ‘My name is Jim’ – *the stranger*.

> ‘Even farther than Samarkand… and the waves ringing on the shore like bells.’ – *Jim*.

> ‘The sand is so white it looks like snow’ – *Jim*.

> ‘The grass is so green and so soft’ – *Jim, on the escalator*.

‘Of Course’

Mrs Tylor

> ‘Nice people, obviously.’ – *her judgement from a tan suit*.

> ‘There’s something so nice about congenial people right next door.’

> ‘Of course… No radio.’

> ‘feeling as though she had been saying nothing else all morning’ – *narration*.

> ‘I’ll go with you, dear.’ – *the final line, agreeing to take Carol to the movies*.

Mrs Harris

> ‘James does not go to movies.’

> ‘Mr. Harris… feels that movies are intellectually retarding.’

> ‘Mr. Harris just feels that the newspapers are a mass degradation of taste.’

> ‘It’s terribly hard for people to understand the desire for a really peaceful life.’

> ‘You’ll be thinking my husband is crazy.’

> ‘Pre-Elizabethan, of course.’ – *the only plays her husband reads*.

‘The Lottery’

Tessie Hutchinson

> ‘Clean forgot what day it was’ – *arriving late*.

> ‘Wouldn’t have me leave m’dishes in the sink, now, would you, Joe?’

> ‘Get up there, Bill.’

> ‘You didn’t give him time enough to take any paper he wanted. I saw you. It wasn’t fair!’

> ‘There’s Don and Eva… Make them take their chance!’ – *trying to add her married daughter’s household.*

> ‘It isn’t fair, it isn’t right’ – *her last words.*

Mr Summers and Mr Graves

> People ‘were sorry for him, because he had no children and his wife was a scold.’ – *narration, on Mr Summers.*

> ‘Little late today, folks.’ – *Mr Summers.*

> ‘Take your time, son.’ – *Mr Summers, to the Watson boy.*

> ‘Daughters draw with their husbands’ families, Tessie’ – *Mr Summers.*

> ‘Let’s finish quickly.’ – *Mr Summers, once Tessie’s paper is shown.*

> ‘Harry, you help little Dave.’ – *Mr Summers; Mr Graves holds the child’s slip.*

Old Man Warner

> ‘Pack of crazy fools’ – *on villages giving up the lottery.*

> ‘Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon.’

> ‘There’s always been a lottery’

> ‘Seventy-seventh year I been in the lottery’

> ‘Come on, come on, everyone.’

The other villagers

> ‘Shut up, Tessie.’ – *Bill Hutchinson, who later ‘forced the slip of paper out of her hand’.*

> ‘Be a good sport, Tessie’ – *Mrs Delacroix.*

> ‘All of us took the same chance.’ – *Mrs Graves.*

> Mrs Delacroix ‘selected a stone so large she had to pick it up with both hands’ – *narration.*

> ‘I can’t run at all. You’ll have to go ahead and I’ll catch up with you.’ – *Mrs Dunbar.*

> ‘Some places have already quit lotteries’ – *Mrs Adams; at the end, ‘Steve Adams was in the front of the crowd’.*

Theme Analysis

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

Jackson's protagonists are frequently discontented. The woman in 'The Daemon Lover' suffers from deep-seated dissatisfaction, anxiety about her appearance and ageing, and insecurity about her desirability; she hopes marriage will let her reinvent herself. Miss Clarence in 'The Villager' disguises her disappointment that she never became a dancer. Elizabeth Style pins her hopes on Jim Harris. Clara Spencer escapes her grey life entirely, at the cost of her identity.

Jackson suggests that these characters' unhappiness is shaped both by society and by themselves. Social expectations about marriage, success and femininity set the standards they fail to meet, but their own fantasies of another life deepen their dissatisfaction. As one useful interpretation puts it, the protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover' intensifies her own unhappiness through her thoughts, choices and actions, while the happiness of others accentuates her dissatisfaction.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Jackson's communities decide who belongs. People who challenge social expectations are judged, excluded or punished: Mrs MacLane for employing Mr Jones, Mrs Walpole for her uncontrolled dog, David for failing to be the right kind of man. Insiders police the boundaries out of fear of becoming outsiders themselves: Mrs Winning abandons her friend because she is anxious about losing belonging and respectability.

Useful vocabulary: *conformity, gatekeepers, ostracise, marginalise, alienated, exclusionary, respectability, social status*.

Unexpected Events Expose Our Struggles

A stranger arrives, a fiancé disappears, a dog kills chickens, a man on a train tells a story. In each case, the disruption exposes problems that already existed beneath the surface: Miss Clarence's disappointment, David's passivity, Mrs Walpole's fear of her neighbours, the mother's inability to control what her son learns. James Harris, who appears in story after story, embodies this idea: he enters characters' lives unexpectedly and reveals the gap between how they see themselves and how others see them.

Useful vocabulary: *catalyst, disruption, destabilise, unravel, expose, vulnerability*.

The Violence and Cruelty Beneath a Civilised Society

Physical violence features in only a few stories ('The Witch', 'The Renegade', 'The Lottery'), so think of this idea as including cruelty, insensitivity, intolerance and lack of compassion. Jackson's violence is often:

- **Arbitrary** – based on chance rather than any fair reason, like the lottery's random selection;
- **Ritualised** – performed according to tradition, like the annual drawing;
- **Normalised** – treated as ordinary even when it is harmful, like the neighbours' advice in 'The Renegade';

- **Entrenched** – so established that it is difficult to change, like the racism of 'Flower Garden'.

Jackson repeatedly shows that the most disturbing cruelty comes from ordinary, respectable people: friendly neighbours, polite mothers, children. Children both reveal the hidden prejudices of adults and occasionally resist them, highlighting the flaws in adult values.

Conformity and Tradition

Many stories show a chain of social pressure: society establishes rules about how people should behave; adults teach children what is normal; fear of punishment pressures people to conform; people come to accept the rules without questioning them; and harmful attitudes are passed from one generation to the next. In 'The Lottery', even little Davy Hutchinson is given pebbles.

Key Vocabulary for the Four Ideas

Jackson's characters are a strange and varied lot, but her stories return again and again to a few central ideas. In the longer stories most of these ideas are present; in the shorter ones it is easier to see just one or two. Reading with these ideas in mind will help you read with purpose.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Like people in the real world, Jackson's characters feel judged by those around them, and they judge others. Many judgements rest on societal expectations about the appropriate way to behave, some tied to the era (women as good housekeepers, men as strong providers). Most of Jackson's protagonists break with what is 'accepted' in some way, and feel uneasy about not fitting in and anxious about their choices. Many feel strongly that they should go along with the unwritten rules of dominant values.

- **Social judgement:** cultural, community, public, accepted, unwritten, expected, dominant, mainstream, collective; expectations, standards, conventions, behaviours, rules, pressures, values, attitudes, roles.
- **Exclusion:** alienation, isolation, marginalisation, ostracism, loneliness, separation, detachment, disconnection, lack of belonging.
- **Anxiety:** tension, uncertainty, dread, unease, insecurity, emotional turbulence, nervousness, agitation, concern.

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

Many protagonists feel insecure about their life choices or identity. Even characters who seem certain daydream about alternative lives or feel unhappy about some aspect of their lives. They often express insecurity by imagining different lifestyles, and they regularly look out of windows or through doorways while doing so. Another sign of self-doubt is choosing clothes and feeling that none of their outfits, belongings or homes are right.

- **Dissatisfaction:** discontent, frustration, restlessness, resentment, longing for more, lack of fulfilment, feeling trapped, disappointment, quiet despair.
- **Insecurity:** uncertainty, self-doubt, self-consciousness, lack of confidence, fear of judgement, feelings of inadequacy, social awkwardness, nervousness, hesitation.

- **Struggling with identity:** disconnection with self, role confusion, internal conflict, feelings of otherness, lack of self-assurance, uncertain of purpose, feelings of personal failure, yearning for validation.

Unexpected Events Expose Our Struggles

In every story there is an unexpected event, or the arrival of a stranger, that exposes the protagonist's inner struggles. Sometimes these events seem positive and make characters feel their lives will change for the better. At other times strange people and events make characters feel more vulnerable and unsure of themselves. Occasionally they help characters see that their own lives are worth keeping. Jackson's larger point is that surprises make us look at our own lives in a new light.

- **Unexpected events:** an unforeseen development, a sudden shift in perspective, a disruption to normality, an unpredictable turn of events, something at odds with convention, an event which is psychologically unsettling, an unprecedented change.
- **Unexpected encounters:** a crossing of paths, a fleeting exchange, an accidental meeting, a destabilising social encounter, a moment of unexpected human connection, a symbolic encounter with otherness, being drawn into a stranger's orbit.

The Violence Beneath a Civilised Society

Beneath the thin veneer of polite society lie violent thoughts and, often, violent actions. Sometimes violence is treated as an ordinary, expected part of life, such as putting down a dog that kills chickens. At other times it is disturbing and frightening, like a stranger telling a child a fantasy about killing his sister. Even stories without physical violence have characters expressing violent emotions or bullying others. Jackson is not condoning violence; she exposes it as a fundamental part of being human.

- **Violent thoughts and actions:** aggressive impulses, destructive behaviour, hostile actions, emotional volatility, eruptions of anger, acts of hostility, simmering resentment, sinister thoughts, impulsive acts of emotional aggression, hostility driven by insecurity, a surprising capacity for brutality.
- **Beneath a civilised veneer:** under the surface of respectability, behind a facade of civility, beneath an appearance of order, concealed by social refinement, hidden beneath cultivated manners, under a mask of normality, concealed by respectability, under the guise of civility, beneath the rituals of polite society, hidden behind outward conformity, obscured by the cultivated image of control.

Story and Theme Grid

Use this grid when you plan a Section A essay. Find the idea in the topic, read down the column, and choose three or four stories: usually one or two where the idea is central, supported by others where it is present. Every rating below is based on what happens in the story itself, and the evidence under the grid shows where to find it.

Key: •• = central to the story; • = present and usable; blank = not a strong choice for that idea.

Story	Insecurity	Judgement	Unexpected	Violence	Conformity	Gender	Children
'The Daemon Lover'	••	•	••	•	•	••	
'Like Mother Used to Make'	•	••	••		•	••	
'The Villager'	••	•	••			•	
'The Witch'			••	••	•		••
'The Renegade'	•	••	••	••	••	•	••
'Charles'		•	•	•			••
'After You, My Dear Alphonse'		••	•	•	••		••
'Flower Garden'	••	••	••	•	••	•	•
'Elizabeth'	••	•	••	•		•	
'The Tooth'	••		••			•	
'Of Course'		••	••		••	•	•
'The Lottery'		••	•	••	••	•	••

Column headings: *Insecurity* = insecurity and dissatisfaction; *Judgement* = social judgement and exclusion; *Unexpected* = unexpected events and strangers expose our struggles; *Violence* = violence and cruelty beneath a civilised society; *Conformity* = conformity and tradition; *Gender* = gender roles, marriage and the domestic sphere; *Children* = children and how they learn adult values.

Insecurity and Dissatisfaction

Central: 'The Daemon Lover', 'The Villager', 'Flower Garden', 'Elizabeth', 'The Tooth'.

- 'The Daemon Lover': she 'was not satisfied with her clothes, her face, her apartment', and pins her hopes on a marriage that never happens.
- 'The Villager': her novel was read 'up to page fifty and only carried now for effect'; the story ends, 'Her shoulders ached.'
- 'Flower Garden': Mrs Winning calls her home 'This dreary old place' and thinks of the cottage, 'This could have been mine'.
- 'Elizabeth': she believes 'something wonderful would happen to change her whole life'.

- ‘The Tooth’: Clara thinks, ‘you’d think my own face would know me’.
- **Present:** David’s need for order in ‘Like Mother Used to Make’; Mrs Walpole’s resentment of her routine in ‘The Renegade’.

Social Judgement and Exclusion

Central: ‘Like Mother Used to Make’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, ‘Flower Garden’, ‘Of Course’, ‘The Lottery’.

- ‘Like Mother Used to Make’: David is edged out of his own home, saying only ‘Guess I better be getting along, Marcia.’
- ‘The Renegade’: Mrs Walpole, a newcomer, thinks of Mr White, ‘anyone would tell on a chicken-killing dog; but he doesn’t have to be so pleased about it’.
- ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’: Mrs Wilson judges Boyd by race: ‘Boyd will eat anything.’
- ‘Flower Garden’: the elder Mrs Winning says ‘you ought to talk to her about that colored man working there’; young Mrs Winning thinks, ‘pretty soon they’ll stop coming to me first, they’ll tell someone else to speak to me.’
- ‘Of Course’: Mrs Tylor judges by appearances (‘Nice people, obviously’), then is judged in turn.
- ‘The Lottery’: when Tessie protests, the crowd replies, ‘Be a good sport, Tessie’ and ‘All of us took the same chance.’
- **Present:** the mocking strangers in ‘The Daemon Lover’; the mother scanning other mothers in ‘Charles’; the woman on the bus in ‘Elizabeth’ (‘Dried-up old maid’).

Unexpected Events and Strangers

Central: ‘The Daemon Lover’, ‘Like Mother Used to Make’, ‘The Villager’, ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘Flower Garden’, ‘Elizabeth’, ‘The Tooth’, ‘Of Course’. Almost every story has one, so choose the stories where the disruption reveals the most.

- A man disappears: Jamie Harris in ‘The Daemon Lover’.
- A man arrives: Mr Harris in ‘Like Mother Used to Make’ (‘I just thought I’d stop by’) and Harris in ‘The Villager’ (‘You’re Mrs. Roberts?’).
- A stranger tells a story: the old man in ‘The Witch’ (‘shall I tell you about my little sister?’).
- A phone call: ‘He’s been killing my chickens’ in ‘The Renegade’.
- A newcomer: Mrs MacLane in ‘Flower Garden’; Daphne Hill in ‘Elizabeth’; the Harrises in ‘Of Course’.
- A guide: ‘My name is Jim,’ in ‘The Tooth’.
- **Present:** Boyd’s visit in ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, where each fact about his family overturns Mrs Wilson’s assumptions; the revelation in ‘Charles’ (‘We don’t have any Charles in the kindergarten’); the second drawing in ‘The Lottery’.

Violence and Cruelty Beneath a Civilised Society

Central: ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘The Lottery’.

- ‘The Witch’: a pleasant elderly man in a blue suit says he ‘pinched her and I pinched her until she was dead’.
- ‘The Renegade’: the twins explain the spiked collar: ‘The spikes cut her head off.’
- ‘The Lottery’: ‘Although the villagers had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones.’
- **Present** (cruelty rather than physical violence): the jeering strangers in ‘The Daemon Lover’; Laurie’s invented violence in ‘Charles’; the boys’ war game in ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’ (‘We stand them in the ground and run over them with tanks’); Howard’s racist name-calling and the town’s freezing-out of Mrs MacLane in ‘Flower Garden’; Elizabeth’s treatment of Daphne.

Conformity and Tradition

Central: ‘The Renegade’, ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, ‘Flower Garden’, ‘Of Course’, ‘The Lottery’.

- ‘The Lottery’: ‘There’s always been a lottery’; ‘no one liked to upset even as much tradition as was represented by the black box.’
- ‘Flower Garden’: after eleven years the two Mrs Winnings ‘had grown to look a good deal alike’; she is ‘officially a Winning’.
- ‘The Renegade’: the grocer insists, ‘Won’t do to have a dog going around killing chickens, Mrs. Walpole.’
- ‘Of Course’: Mrs Tylor keeps saying ‘Of course’, ‘feeling as though she had been saying nothing else all morning’.
- ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’: Mrs Wilson’s charity follows the assumptions of her society, not the facts in front of her.
- **Present:** the pressure to marry in ‘The Daemon Lover’; David’s surrender to politeness in ‘Like Mother Used to Make’; the mother’s lollipop rewards in ‘The Witch’.

Gender Roles, Marriage and the Domestic Sphere

Central: ‘The Daemon Lover’, ‘Like Mother Used to Make’.

- ‘The Daemon Lover’: she begins a letter, ‘Anne, by the time you get this I will be married.’
- ‘Like Mother Used to Make’: David’s pride in his home (‘it pleased him to have only one key to his home’) is taken over by Marcia, who claims the pie: ‘I haven’t made but two, three pies before’.
- **Present:** ‘The Villager’ (Harris: ‘What I need is a wife.’); ‘The Renegade’ (Mrs Walpole’s morning revolves around her husband and children); ‘Flower Garden’ (Mrs Harris: ‘Let that husband of yours do the housework for a change.’); ‘Elizabeth’ (‘Because they were not married, Robbie was reluctant to take her anywhere’); ‘The Tooth’ (Clara’s last instruction to her husband is about the milkman and eggs); ‘Of Course’ (the absent Mr Harris sets every rule); ‘The Lottery’ (‘Wife draws for her husband’).

Children and How They Learn Adult Values

Central: ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘Charles’, ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, ‘The Lottery’.

- ‘The Witch’: Johnny is delighted, not frightened: ‘Did you cut her all in pieces?’
- ‘The Renegade’: the twins describe the collar while Jack kisses the dog’s head.
- ‘Charles’: Laurie invents Charles to report his own behaviour; the teacher: ‘We don’t have any Charles in the kindergarten.’
- ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’: the boys have not absorbed Mrs Wilson’s prejudice. Johnny: ‘She’s screwy sometimes.’ Boyd: ‘So’s mine.’
- ‘The Lottery’: ‘someone gave little Davy Hutchinson a few pebbles.’
- **Present:** Howard’s name-calling in ‘Flower Garden’; Carol’s ‘I want to go to the movies’ in ‘Of Course’.

Strong Combinations

- **Community against an outsider:** ‘The Renegade’, ‘Flower Garden’, ‘The Lottery’ (with ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’ for prejudice in a single home).
- **Women and the life they hoped for:** ‘The Daemon Lover’, ‘The Villager’, ‘Elizabeth’, ‘The Tooth’.
- **The intruder who exposes the self:** ‘Like Mother Used to Make’, ‘The Villager’, ‘The Witch’, ‘Of Course’.
- **Children as mirrors of adults:** ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘Charles’, ‘The Lottery’.

Character Analysis

The Protagonist of ‘The Daemon Lover’

Unnamed and thirty-four, she is anxious, self-critical and desperate to be transformed by marriage. Her search for Jamie exposes her to the indifference and mockery of strangers. She represents the collection’s lonely women, shut out from the happiness they long for.

David Turner and Marcia (‘Like Mother Used to Make’)

David is careful, controlled and highly organised, finding pleasure in domestic order traditionally coded as feminine. Marcia is careless, loud and hungry, comfortable taking what is not hers. Their contrast challenges gender expectations, and David’s inability to assert himself leaves him excluded from his own home.

Miss Clarence (‘The Villager’)

A woman who came to the city with dreams and settled for a job. Her readiness to assume another person’s identity, and to call herself a dancer, reveals her longing to be seen as someone more interesting than she believes she is.

The Little Boy and the Stranger (‘The Witch’)

The boy, named only once (his mother calls him ‘Johnny’), is fascinated rather than frightened by violence. The stranger, friendly and well-dressed, is a figure of casual menace. The mother tries and fails to protect her son from what he has heard.

Mrs Walpole (‘The Renegade’)

An outsider in a country town, anxious to be accepted. As the community’s advice grows more violent, she comes to identify with the dog, and the story ends with her imagining the punishment closing in on her.

Laurie and His Mother (‘Charles’)

Laurie projects his own misbehaviour onto an invented boy; his mother believes every word. Together they show how people misinterpret what is in front of them and see what they want to see.

Mrs Wilson (‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’)

A well-meaning mother whose generosity rests on racial stereotypes. When Boyd challenges her assumptions, her defensiveness exposes how deeply entrenched her prejudice is.

Mrs Winning and Mrs MacLane (‘Flower Garden’)

Mrs Winning longs for independence from her husband’s family but ultimately chooses conformity, abandoning her friend. Mrs MacLane, the outsider, behaves decently and is punished for it.

Elizabeth Style ('Elizabeth')

A woman clinging to a failing career and a cooling relationship, anxious about being replaced. Her hopes in Jim Harris suggest that, like other Jackson protagonists, she imagines escape through someone else.

Clara Spencer ('The Tooth')

A wife and mother whose identity dissolves on her journey to the dentist. Her escape with the man in the blue suit is one of the few endings in the collection that breaks free of social expectations, though it may also be a breakdown.

Mrs Tylor ('Of Course')

Mrs Tylor judges her new neighbours by appearances, then feels pressured to agree with Mrs Harris's rigid views. She shows how politeness can become a form of conformity.

Tessie Hutchinson ('The Lottery')

Is Tessie a transgressor, victim or follower? She arrives late and jokes about the lottery, encourages her husband to 'get up there', and does not question the ritual until her family is chosen. She then protests that it 'wasn't fair' and even tries to include her married daughter to improve her odds. She is chosen by chance, not for any crime, and is killed by friends and family. Most readers see her as a follower who becomes a victim: her protest is against her own selection, not against the lottery itself.

The Enforcers of 'The Lottery'

- **Authority figures:** Mr Summers and Mr Graves organise the lottery and keep it running efficiently.
- **Defender of tradition:** Old Man Warner criticises villages that want to give it up and insists 'There's always been a lottery.'
- **Social conformists:** Mr Adams mentions villages that have stopped the lottery but still takes part in the stoning.
- **Complicit participants:** Mrs Delacroix, Tessie's friend, chooses a stone so large she needs both hands; Bill Hutchinson silences his wife; the children gather stones.

James Harris

Harris appears throughout the collection: as Jamie, the fiancé who vanishes in 'The Daemon Lover'; as the visitor who prompts Miss Clarence's lie in 'The Villager'; as Marcia's colleague in 'Like Mother Used to Make'; as the man in the blue suit in 'The Tooth' (and a blue-suited stranger in 'The Witch'); as the Harris family whose chickens die in 'The Renegade'; as the neighbours in 'Of Course'; and as Elizabeth's dinner date. He enters characters' lives unexpectedly, disrupts their routines and exposes problems that already exist. Some readers see him as a demon or tempter, the 'daemon lover' of the ballad that closes the book.

Literary Device Tracker

Literary Devices in *The Lottery and Other Stories*

Device	Definition / Effect	Example
Situational irony	When what happens is the opposite of what is expected.	A 'lottery' whose winner is stoned to death ('The Lottery').
Dramatic irony	When the reader knows something a character does not.	Readers suspect Laurie is Charles long before his mother does ('Charles').
Foreshadowing	Hints of what is to come.	Bobby Martin stuffing his pockets with stones ('The Lottery').
Pathetic fallacy and ironic setting	Weather or setting that mirrors, or ironically contrasts with, events and feelings.	'The morning of June 27th was clear and sunny' before a murder ('The Lottery').
Symbolism	An object, colour or action that represents an idea.	The black box; doors and windows; the man in the blue suit.
Motif	An image or idea that recurs across the collection.	James Harris; food and hunger; closed doors.
Characterisation through objects	Revealing character through possessions and spaces.	David's 'neat small table and four careful chairs' ('Like Mother Used to Make').
Character contrast	Placing characters side by side to highlight their differences.	David's order against Marcia's disorder; Mrs Winning against Mrs MacLane.
Understatement	Presenting something as less significant than it is.	The calm narration of the stoning ('The Lottery').
Dialogue	Speech that reveals character, attitudes and tension.	'Shut up, Tessie' ('The Lottery'); Mrs Wilson's offers of charity ('After You, My Dear Alphonse').
Anonymity	Leaving characters unnamed so they seem universal or diminished.	The protagonist of 'The Daemon Lover'; 'the little boy' in 'The Witch'.
Symbolic names	Names that carry meaning.	Laurie (laurels), Clara (clear, bright), Mrs Winning.
Twist ending	A final revelation that changes the meaning of the story.	'We don't have any Charles in the kindergarten' ('Charles').
Open ending	An ending that leaves key questions unanswered.	Clara running into the sand with Jim ('The Tooth').
Allusion	A reference to another text or tradition.	The comic strip behind 'After You, My Dear Alphonse'; the ballad of the Daemon Lover.
Imagery	Vivid sensory description.	'The waves ringing on the shore like bells' ('The Tooth').

Symbols and Motifs

- **Windows and Doors**
  - Represent the divide between the life characters have and the life they long for
  - Windows offer glimpses of escape and imagination: Miss Clarence dreaming of the building ‘crowned with flower gardens’, the boy looking out of the train window
  - Closed doors signal exclusion: the door that never opens at the end of ‘The Daemon Lover’
  - An open window can let chaos in, as when Marcia’s papers blow wildly around her floor
- **James Harris**
  - A recurring figure who enters ordinary lives unexpectedly and exposes hidden dissatisfaction
  - Represents the possibility of a different life, and the danger of pinning hope on it
  - Linked to the demon lover of the ballad that closes the collection
- **The Blue Suit**
  - Worn by Jim in ‘The Tooth’ and the stranger in ‘The Witch’
  - Its colour and confidence contrast with the greyness of the protagonists’ lives
- **Food and Hunger**
  - The protagonist of ‘The Daemon Lover’ finds ‘nothing to eat’, suggesting an empty life
  - David’s cooking represents care and order; Marcia, ‘always hungry’, consumes what he makes
- **Homes and Keys**
  - Homes represent identity and security; David’s single key gives him ‘a pleasant feeling’
  - Losing control of a home (David) or being trapped in someone else’s (Mrs Winning) shows loss of self
- **The Black Box and the Stones**
  - The shabby black box stands for a tradition that has lost its meaning but not its power
  - The stones, remembered when everything else is forgotten, show violence outliving reason
- **Weather**
  - Fine weather often creates an ironic contrast with cruelty or disappointment
  - Makes disturbing events seem more ordinary, and therefore more frightening
  - Can reinforce the protagonist’s bleak emotional world, or contrast with disturbing events and dissatisfaction

- ‘The Daemon Lover’: she worried ‘at the window, over whether it would be a fine day’; ‘The Lottery’: ‘clear and sunny, with the fresh warmth of a full-summer day’; ‘Flower Garden’: ‘It seems as though spring would never come… I get so tired of the cold’; ‘Elizabeth’: a dream of ‘a hot sunny garden’, then ‘it was raining’; ‘The Tooth’: ‘she ran barefoot through hot sand’; ‘Like Mother Used to Make’: papers ‘blown wildly around the floor’

- **Children**
  - Reveal the hidden prejudices and cruelty of the adults around them
  - Sometimes resist adult attitudes, exposing their absurdity
  - ‘Flower Garden’: Howard’s immediate racist name-calling towards Billy Jones expresses the racism around him, but his innocent wish to play with Davey exposes how prejudiced his mother is being in shutting out Mrs MacLane
  - ‘The Witch’, ‘The Renegade’, ‘After You, My Dear Alphonse’, ‘Charles’ and ‘The Lottery’ all show children absorbing, testing or exposing adult values
- **Gardens and Flowers**
  - In ‘Flower Garden’, the garden represents Mrs MacLane’s independence and her friendship with Mrs Winning
  - Its growth through the work of Mr Jones becomes the cause of her exclusion
- **Names**
  - Unnamed characters seem anonymous and universal
  - Symbolic names (Laurie, Clara, Winning, Walpole) carry ironic meaning

Written Exemplars

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Ideas & interpretation | Language & technique | Structure & evidence

Written Exemplars

Sample 1: Model *The Lottery and Other Stories* Paragraph

Topic: **The desire for social acceptance shapes the behaviour of many of Jackson's characters. Do you agree?**

This paragraph uses a structure that works well for a collection: topic sentence, story one, link, story two, synthesising sentence.

In many of her stories, Jackson depicts characters whose need for social acceptance is so strong that they repress or lie about aspects of themselves to appear more desirable or successful to others. In 'The Daemon Lover', the unnamed protagonist seeks social acceptance and happiness through marriage. Though the protagonist knows she is 'haggard and lined', she is unable to accept that on the day of her supposed wedding, her 'young' fiancé is missing because he has used and jilted her. When she finally locates him, her unwillingness to admit the truth results in her coming back to his door 'many times', where she is always locked out, representing that this dream is not possible for her. 'The Villager' also features a character who lies to herself and others in an attempt to appear more successful. In this story, Miss Clarence tells herself she has 'a good job' and is living 'better than she would have in her home town'. But this attitude disguises a discontent that she has not pursued the dreams of being a dancer she had when she was younger. She compulsively lies to a stranger that she is a 'dancer', revealing her desire to be seen as someone more accomplished and interesting than she believes herself to be. At the story's end, Jackson describes how the protagonist's 'shoulders ached', symbolically representing the burden of carrying dissatisfaction. Through these examples, Jackson demonstrates that the desire to be accepted and admired by others can cause individuals to construct false identities and deny the bitter reality of their lives.

Sample 2: Model *The Lottery and Other Stories* Essay

Topic: **Jackson's stories suggest that ordinary social settings can conceal disturbing cruelty. Discuss.**

Introduction

Shirley Jackson's *The Lottery and Other Stories* (1949) is set in the most familiar places imaginable: city apartments, trains, small-town streets and village squares. Yet beneath these ordinary surfaces Jackson uncovers cruelty that is all the more disturbing for being so casual. Through stories such as 'The Lottery', 'The Renegade', 'The Witch' and 'Flower Garden', Jackson suggests that cruelty is learned, normalised and enforced by respectable people, and that the polite rituals of community life can disguise, and even sustain, a deep lack of compassion.

Body Paragraph 1

Jackson's most chilling insight is that the familiar rituals of community life can sanction violence, as 'The Lottery' makes devastatingly clear. The story opens on a morning that is 'clear and sunny, with the fresh warmth of a full-summer day', and the villagers gather to chat about 'planting and rain, tractors and taxes'. This deliberately ordinary setting, narrated in a calm, understated voice, lulls the reader into expecting a harmless civic event. The tradition is upheld by authority figures, Mr Summers and Mr Graves, and defended by Old Man Warner, who dismisses villages that have abandoned it as a 'pack of crazy fools' and insists 'there's always been a lottery'. Even Mr Adams, who mentions that other villages are 'talking of giving up the lottery', joins the crowd at the end. That 'although the villagers had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones' suggests a violence that has outlived any meaning the tradition once had. By embedding a murder in the routine of a village fair, Jackson exposes how communities can perform cruelty while believing themselves civilised.

Body Paragraph 2

Jackson further suggests that cruelty is passed on through everyday family life, as children learn from the adults around them what is normal. In 'The Renegade', Mrs Walpole's neighbours respond to her dog's killing of chickens with cheerful, increasingly violent advice, and her own children delight in imagining how a spiked collar would make 'the spikes cut her head off'. Their laughter turns a domestic problem into a scene of shocking cruelty, and the story ends with Mrs Walpole 'suddenly feeling the harsh hands pulling her down, the sharp points closing in on her throat', as if the community's violence had turned on her. Similarly, in 'The Witch', a friendly stranger on a train tells a little boy that he 'cut off her head and her hands', and the boy responds not with fear but with breathless excitement: 'Did you cut her all in pieces?' The pleasant setting of a train journey, complete with a baby 'busy with her rattle and her toast', makes the boy's fascination deeply unsettling. Through these children, Jackson reveals that cruelty is not an aberration but something absorbed and repeated within ordinary homes. The same acceptance of violence appears in 'The Lottery', where 'someone gave little Davy Hutchinson a few pebbles'.

Body Paragraph 3

However, Jackson's cruelty is not always physical: in many stories it takes the quieter form of exclusion, enforced through polite social behaviour. In 'Flower Garden', the town never openly attacks Mrs MacLane; instead, neighbours advise Mrs Winning to speak to her 'about that colored man', and Mrs MacLane recognises that soon 'they'll tell someone else to speak to me'. The cruelty lies in silence and withdrawal, culminating as Mrs Winning turns away 'without speaking' and walks 'with great dignity' back to the old Winning house. The phrase 'great dignity' is bitterly ironic: respectability itself is the instrument of exclusion. In 'After You, My Dear Alphonse', Mrs Wilson's apparently generous offers to Boyd are built on racist assumptions, and her offence when he declines shows how prejudice can hide behind kindness. In these stories, Jackson suggests that the most damaging cruelty is often performed by people who believe they are behaving well.

Conclusion

Across *The Lottery and Other Stories*, Jackson reveals that ordinary social settings are not refuges from cruelty but often its source. Whether in the ritual of the village lottery, the casual advice of neighbours, a story told on a train, or the polite withdrawal of a friend, Jackson exposes a society in which violence and prejudice are normalised beneath a civilised surface.

Her quiet, matter-of-fact style ensures that readers recognise these communities as their own, and that recognition is what makes her stories so disturbing.

Sample 3: Essay Plan

Topic: **Unexpected encounters force confrontation with uncomfortable truths. How is this idea explored in Jackson's stories?**

Contention

Jackson uses unexpected encounters to expose the dissatisfaction, prejudice and cruelty that already lie beneath ordinary lives, though her characters do not always confront these truths; often they retreat from them.

BP1: Jackson uses unexpected encounters to expose individuals' dissatisfaction with their identities and their desire for a different life.

- 'The Villager': Harris's unexpected arrival prompts Miss Clarence to invent a more successful identity as a 'dancer', exposing her disappointment with her own life; 'Her shoulders ached.'
- 'The Tooth': the man in the blue suit offers Clara visions of 'the waves ringing on the shore like bells', exposing her longing to escape her grey life.

BP2: Jackson portrays unexpected encounters as exposing the prejudices and cruelty that exist beneath the polite surface of society.

- 'After You, My Dear Alphonse': Boyd's visit exposes Mrs Wilson's racist assumptions beneath her 'kindness'.
- 'The Witch': the stranger's violent story exposes the boy's fascination with cruelty and the mother's powerlessness to control what he learns.
- 'Of Course': the new neighbours expose the pressure to conform behind neighbourly politeness.

BP3: However, Jackson also suggests that unexpected encounters do not always lead to genuine confrontation; characters often avoid the truth.

- 'Like Mother Used to Make': Mr Harris's arrival exposes David's passivity, but David fails to challenge Marcia's assumption of ownership over his home.
- 'The Daemon Lover': the protagonist refuses to admit she has been jilted and keeps knocking at a door that never opens.
- 'Charles': Laurie's mother learns the truth only at the very end, after weeks of choosing not to see it.

Section A Sample Essays: *The Lottery* (Low, Medium and High)

Topic: **In Jackson's 'The Lottery', the villagers conform because they are afraid of being excluded. To what extent do you agree?**

Sample Essay I (Low)

Introduction

In 'The Lottery', Shirley Jackson shows a village that follows a ritual without question. I agree that the villagers conform because they are afraid of being excluded. Jackson uses tradition, Tessie Hutchinson and the crowd to show this.
Body Paragraph 1

Jackson shows that tradition keeps the villagers in line. The villagers all come to the square on time. Mrs Graves and Mrs Delacroix talk and laugh while they wait. This shows the villagers are friendly , but they still follow the lottery because it is what they have always done. Old Man Warner says 'There's always been a lottery', which shows they will not change.
Body Paragraph 2 So fear of breaking with the ritual is what keeps them coming back.

Jackson shows that people silence anyone who breaks with the group. Tessie is the only one who complains. She says 'It isn't fair, it isn't right'. The other villagers tell her to be a good sport. This shows people are afraid of being different, so they make her quiet.
Body Paragraph 3 So conformity is enforced by pressure as much as by belief.

The final scene shows the crowd acting on its fear. At the end, the villagers pick up stones. Old Man Warner tells everyone to come on. This shows the crowd is scared and wants to join in so they are not left out.
Conclusion This is the result of conforming out of fear of being excluded.

Jackson shows the villagers conform because they are afraid. So I agree with the statement.
Sample Essay II (Medium)

Introduction

In 'The Lottery', Shirley Jackson presents a village whose members gather each June to take part in a ritual none of them questions. I agree that the villagers conform out of fear of being excluded, though the story suggests the fear is learned rather than simply felt. Jackson builds the pressure through the power of tradition, the crowd's manners and the way Tessie is isolated.
Body Paragraph 1

The villagers do not discuss the lottery; they simply attend it. Old Man Warner dismisses the talk of change as 'Pack of crazy fools', and insists 'There's always been a lottery.' His certainty shows that the ritual survives because nobody is willing to be the one who breaks it. The narration confirms this, noting that no one liked to upset 'even as much tradition as was represented by the black box'.
Body Paragraph 2 That is why the ritual survives, even though nobody defends it.

Tessie's protest is what exposes the fear. When she cries 'It isn't fair, it isn't right', her neighbours do not argue the point. Mrs Delacroix calls 'Be a good sport, Tessie', and Mrs Graves reminds her that 'All of us took the same chance.' The phrase is a warning: conformity is presented as fairness, and dissent is treated as poor manners .
Body Paragraph 3 Conformity is therefore presented as the reasonable choice.

The stoning shows what exclusion finally looks like. Once Tessie is singled out, the crowd moves towards her, and Old Man Warner's 'Come on, come on, everyone' pushes the reluctant villagers into the action. The fear of being left out is greater than any sympathy for Tessie , and

the villagers join in rather than stand apart.
Conclusion Fear of exclusion, not sympathy, decides what the crowd does.

Jackson shows that the villagers conform because exclusion is worse than the violence they must commit. The ritual is kept alive by people who would rather be part of the crowd than face being the outsider. The fear is real, so even if it is never spoken, it shapes every choice the villagers make.
Sample Essay III (High)

Introduction

Shirley Jackson opens 'The Lottery' with a morning that is 'clear and sunny', and the pleasantness is the first thing the story asks us to distrust . I agree that the villagers conform because they fear exclusion, but Jackson's argument is more unsettling than that. The villagers are not forced. They have learned to read their own belonging as something they must keep up, and the fear of being separated from the crowd does the rest. Jackson builds this through the normality of the ritual, the inheritance of tradition and the isolation of Tessie.
Body Paragraph 1

The story frames the ritual as ordinary. The children assemble first, 'of course', and the women talk among themselves while they wait. Mrs Hutchinson arrives late, having 'clean forgot what day it was', which suggests the lottery is so routine that it can be forgotten and still be attended. Conformity starts before anybody is asked to conform , because the day has already been made normal.
Body Paragraph 2 Conformity therefore begins in the ordinary, before any fear is needed.

Old Man Warner shows how conformity is passed down. He calls the north village's doubts 'Pack of crazy fools', then offers the proverb 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon'. He is not defending the lottery on grounds of safety; he links it to survival, so anyone who questions it threatens the community's shared sense of its own security. The narration's aside that no one liked to upset 'even as much tradition as was represented by the black box' shows that the tradition has outlasted any reason for it.
Body Paragraph 3 The tradition survives because each generation learns the same fear.

Tessie's protest is what exposes the mechanism. Her 'It isn't fair, it isn't right' is met with 'Be a good sport, Tessie', and then with Mrs Graves's 'All of us took the same chance.' That reply turns fairness into a matter of who is willing to play along . The crowd's first move against her is verbal before it is physical. By the time the stones fly, Tessie has already been reduced to someone who must be silenced so that everyone else can feel safe in their place.
Conclusion Exclusion is the mechanism, and the crowd's fear of it keeps the ritual going.

Jackson's village conforms because each person has been taught that the group's approval is the only safety available. The black box, the proverbs and the good-sport rhetoric all teach that the outsider is the real danger. I agree with the statement, though the story suggests that fear of exclusion is not merely a motive. It is the mechanism that keeps the lottery alive.

Section A Sample Essays: *The Lottery* (Low, Medium and High)

Topic: **Jackson suggests that tradition is more powerful than reason. Do you agree?**

Sample Essay I (Low)

Introduction

In 'The Lottery', Shirley Jackson shows a village that keeps a ritual even though nobody can explain why. I agree that tradition is more powerful than reason in the story. Jackson uses the villagers' sayings, the black box and the response to Tessie Hutchinson to show this.

Body Paragraph 1

Old Man Warner says 'There's always been a lottery'. This shows that tradition is important to the villagers. He also calls the people who want to stop 'Pack of crazy fools'. This shows that tradition wins over reason. Tradition is what keeps the lottery going. So the village keeps the lottery because it has always done so, not because it makes sense.

Body Paragraph 2

The saying 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon' is repeated as if it were a reason. Nobody questions it. This shows the saying is more powerful than thinking. So reason never gets a hearing in the village.

Body Paragraph 3

At the end, the villagers pick up stones, and 'Come on, come on, everyone' is said. This shows tradition is stronger than the people . So the ending proves the same point.

Conclusion

Jackson shows tradition is more powerful than reason. So I agree with the statement.

Sample Essay II (Medium)

Introduction

In 'The Lottery', Shirley Jackson presents a village that continues a ritual no one can justify. I agree that tradition is more powerful than reason, though the story suggests that tradition survives partly through fear. Jackson builds this through the saying the villagers repeat, the black box nobody will replace and the way the crowd answers Tessie Hutchinson's appeal to fairness.

Body Paragraph 1

Jackson shows that the villagers keep the lottery because of what they have always done, not because of any reason they can give. Old Man Warner insists 'There's always been a lottery', and the proverb 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon' is repeated as though it explains everything. The proverb ties the ritual to the harvest, a practical concern, but nobody checks whether the connection is real; the saying is accepted because it is old. Tradition therefore has force even where the reason behind it has disappeared.

Body Paragraph 2

The black box shows how far the village has let tradition outlast its meaning . The narration notes that no one liked to upset 'even as much tradition as was represented by the black box',

and Mr Summers's repeated talk of making a new box never leads to one. The village would rather keep an old box than change a ritual whose reason has been lost. The object carries the practice when the reasons have gone.

Body Paragraph 3

Reason is answered with social pressure, not argument. When Tessie protests 'It isn't fair, it isn't right', Mrs Delacroix replies 'Be a good sport, Tessie', and Mrs Graves adds that 'All of us took the same chance.' Neither reply addresses whether the drawing was fair; both appeal to belonging. So when reason is raised, tradition answers with the pressure of the group, and the ritual continues.

Conclusion

Jackson shows that the lottery survives because tradition has outlived its reasons and reason has no way to win against the group. I agree, though fear of exclusion is part of why tradition wins.

Sample Essay III (High)

Introduction

Shirley Jackson opens 'The Lottery' with a morning that is 'clear and sunny', and with a village that gathers without asking why. I agree that tradition is more powerful than reason, but the story shows that this power is not simply habit. Jackson builds it through the proverbs the villagers repeat, the black box they will not replace and the social pressure that answers Tessie Hutchinson's appeal to fairness.

Body Paragraph 1

The proverbs carry tradition as if it were knowledge. The saying 'Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon' links the ritual to survival, and Old Man Warner warns that without it 'we'd all be eating stewed chickweed and acorns'. The claim is a warning rather than an argument . It sets the ritual against hunger, which is why questioning the lottery sounds reckless. Reason has no part in a proverb that presents the ritual as the thing that keeps people fed, and so tradition gains its power by seeming practical .

Body Paragraph 2

The black box shows that tradition can outlast its own materials. The narration says the villagers 'had forgotten the ritual and lost the original black box, they still remembered to use stones'. The ritual has become detached from its objects, yet its violence remains. Tradition persists in what it demands even when its form has gone, and the stones are the one part of the ritual the village has never let go of.

Body Paragraph 3

Reason has no hearing once the crowd has decided . Tessie's argument is about fairness, 'It isn't fair, it isn't right', and she is answered with 'Be a good sport, Tessie' and 'All of us took the same chance.' The replies concern belonging, not fairness. 'Come on, come on, everyone' turns the crowd towards her, and 'A stone hit her on the side of the head' shows where the argument ends. So tradition wins not by being right but by being shared .

Conclusion

Jackson shows that tradition is more powerful than reason because it does not need to be justified: it survives in proverbs, in objects and in the pressure to belong. I agree, though the story also shows what that power costs.

Part

Analytical Text Response Essays

Introduction

From the very beginning of your schooling career, you have been introduced to several different methods of writing essays. Although all structures have their advantages and disadvantages, it is essential that you have a fool-proof method of writing essays for your end of year examination.

Having a solid method of writing analytical essays and practicing these throughout the year will result in a strong foundation, enabling you to tackle any essay question with confidence. The key to success lies not only in understanding the content but also in being able to present your ideas in a clear, structured, and coherent manner. With a well-practised approach, you will be able to break down complex texts, analyse them effectively, and construct a well-supported argument that demonstrates both depth and clarity of thought.

In the following, we will explore a structured approach to writing an analytical text response. By familiarising yourself with this framework, you will be better equipped to organise your ideas, manage your time efficiently, and ultimately maximise your performance in the exam.

Reading the Question First

Before you write anything, underline the topic's key terms and its instruction word. The instruction word tells you what kind of answer is wanted. "To what extent" asks for a degree of agreement, so your contention has to say how far you agree. "Discuss" asks you to examine more than one side. "How does Weir…" asks for technique and effect. An introduction that answers a different instruction from the one in the question will lose marks even if the writing is good.

What a Strong Introduction Does

A strong introduction does three things in order, and it does them briefly. It names the text, the author and the form. It states your contention, which answers the question directly and takes a position. It then outlines three arguments, in the order your body paragraphs will follow. The reader should be able to predict the essay from the introduction alone.

Here is a short example built on a question about the short story "The Lottery", to show the three moves working together:

> *In Shirley Jackson's short story "The Lottery", the villagers take part in a ritual none of them questions. I agree that they conform out of fear of being excluded, although the story suggests this fear is learned rather than felt. Jackson builds this pressure through tradition, through the language of fairness and through the isolation of Tessie Hutchinson.*

The first sentence is the text, author and form. The second is the contention, and it qualifies the answer with "although" so that the position can be defended. The third sentence is the outline: three arguments, in the order they will appear.

Common Mistakes

- **Opening with a general statement** about life, society or human nature instead of the text. Assessors want to see the text in the first sentence.
- **A contention that avoids the question.** "Jackson writes about a village" is a fact, not an argument.
- **An outline that lists events**, such as "first the lottery starts, then Tessie protests". Name the arguments, not the plot.
- **An introduction that repeats the body.** The introduction should promise the argument; the body paragraphs deliver it.
- **Three arguments that do not connect.** If you cannot write a single sentence that links them, the contention is probably too broad.

Checking Your Introduction

Before you move on, check four things. Does the first sentence name the text, author and form? Does the contention answer the instruction word? Does the outline name three arguments in the same order your body paragraphs will use? Could you defend every sentence of it in the next three paragraphs? If the answer to any of these is no, fix it now, because the body paragraphs cannot repair an introduction that promises the wrong essay.

What is Needed in an Essay

An essay is a structured piece of writing that presents an argument in response to a topic. In Section A, every essay has the same shape: an introduction, three body paragraphs, and a conclusion. Each part has a set job, and the introduction and conclusion follow the same structure.

Introduction

The introduction tells the marker which text you are writing about, what you think about the topic, and how your essay will prove it. Write it in three moves, in this order.

1 **Text, author and form**

Name the text, its author (or director) and its form: novel, film, play, short story collection.

2 **Contention**

Your answer to the topic, in one clear sentence.

3 **Three arguments**

Outline the argument of each body paragraph, in the order they will appear.

Topic: 'The desire for social acceptance shapes the behaviour of many of Jackson's characters.' Do you agree?

> Model introduction
>
> ❶ In her 1949 short story collection *The Lottery and Other Stories*, Shirley Jackson exposes the quiet pressures that sit beneath ordinary American life. ❷ Jackson suggests that the desire for social acceptance shapes much of her characters' behaviour, although it is often the fear of exclusion, rather than a wish to belong, that drives them. ❸ Her characters conform to avoid the judgement of their communities, construct false versions of themselves in order to appear successful, and, at their worst, take part in cruelty so that they are not the ones left outside.

Body Paragraphs

An essay normally has three body paragraphs, one for each argument named in your introduction and in the same order. Build each one with Th.E.S.A.M.L.

Th **Thematic-based topic sentence**

Your topic sentence needs to be based upon a theme in the text, not a character.

✗ *'Tessie Hutchinson is stoned to death by the villagers.'*
✓ *'Jackson suggests that blind loyalty to tradition allows ordinary people to commit extraordinary cruelty.'*

E **Evidence**

Quotes and scenes from the text that support the theme.

S **Symbols**

Symbols that relate to this theme — including historical and social context, and setting.

A **Authorial intention**

What was the author intending?

M **Metalanguage**

Discuss the metalanguage the author uses around this theme.

L **Linking sentence**

Link back to your contention.

Only the **Th** and **L** elements need to appear in this order — the middle elements can be woven through the paragraph.

Conclusion

The conclusion has the same structure as the introduction. Return to the text, author and form, restate your contention, and sum up your three arguments, this time as conclusions you have proven rather than ideas you are about to explore. Use fresh wording and do not add new evidence.

1 **Text, author and form**

Name the text, its author (or director) and its form: novel, film, play, short story collection.

2 **Contention**

Restate your contention, in fresh words.

3 **Three arguments**

Sum up what each body paragraph proved, in the same order.

Model conclusion

❶ Across *The Lottery and Other Stories*, Shirley Jackson presents a world in which belonging is never guaranteed. ❷ The need to be accepted is one of the most powerful forces in her characters' lives, and fear of exclusion, more than a wish to belong, is what drives them. ❸ They conform to escape judgement, invent more impressive versions of themselves, and join

> in cruelty rather than become its target, revealing how fragile, and how dangerous, the desire for acceptance can be.

Moving Up the Mark Bands

Use this as a checklist on your draft. Each band move is a few things you can actually change. The wording of the bands comes from the Section A descriptors on the Exam Assessment Criteria page.

Before you start, check every body paragraph has:

- a topic sentence that states a theme, not a character;
- at least one quotation from the text;
- one technique (narration, setting, sound, a repeated image) and what it does;
- a last sentence that links back to your contention.

From 6 to 7

1. **Use the text in every body paragraph.** Count the quotations in each paragraph. If one has none, find a line that shows the idea you are making.
2. **Name one technique in each paragraph and say what it does.** Replace "Jackson uses a calm voice" with the effect: "the calm voice makes the violence sound ordinary".
3. **Keep the argument going to the end of the paragraph.** If the last sentence only retells the story, rewrite it to say what the story shows.

From 7 to 8

1. **Explain how the technique produces the idea.** Use this order: technique, then effect on the reader, then the idea about the topic.
2. **Link every paragraph back to the contention in its last sentence.** Your essay should read as one argument, not three separate points.
3. **Cut repetition.** Read the essay aloud. If two sentences say the same thing, keep the more precise one.

Worked example, using the Lottery low sample, body paragraph 2.

- **Before (6):** "Tessie is the only one who complains. She says 'It isn't fair, it isn't right'. The other villagers tell her to be a good sport. This shows people are afraid of being different."
- **After (7–8):** "Tessie is the only one who complains, and her 'It isn't fair, it isn't right' is answered not with an argument but with 'Be a good sport, Tessie'. That reply turns a question

of fairness into a question of manners, which is how the village keeps dissent quiet. The pressure is social, not violent, and that is why conformity lasts."

From 8 to 9 or 10

1. **Show one complication.** Find a piece of evidence that works against your view. Answer it in one sentence, then say what your view still is or where it needs limiting.
2. **Use precise verbs for what the text does.** Replace "shows" and "reveals" with the action itself: "silences", "exposes", "normalises". Check each verb against the text.
3. **Check every claim.** Each sentence should point to something a marker can find in the text. If a sentence is a general comment about life, cut it or tie it to the text.

Practice

Take the Picnic low sample and apply the 6-to-7 checklist to one paragraph. Then take the Picnic medium sample and apply the 8-to-9 checklist to the same paragraph. The difference between the two is the band move.

Where this comes from. The band wording is from the Section A descriptors on the Exam Assessment Criteria page. The steps are practical advice based on that wording. The VCAA 2024 and 2025 reports could not be checked when this was written, so nothing here is attributed to them.

Planning

Deconstructing the Prompt

When first planning your essay, you must directly respond to the prompt that is presented to you, and consider the key authorial messages that could help you respond with insight. This involves three important steps:

- Find the key concepts. This will most likely correlate with the key concepts you have studied throughout the unit, you should also make sure to identify synonyms of these concepts too!
- Find any instructional verbs. These are words that instruct you to answer the prompt in a certain manner, in English the main verbs to look out for is discuss, do you agree, to what extent or how.
- Identify any expectations/limitations. These ore words that limit what you con include in your essays and set on expectation on what you should be discussing.

Example prompt: *'In Jackson's stories, characters conform because they are afraid of being excluded.' Do you agree?*

This prompt has three key concepts: *conform*, *afraid* and *excluded*. The instructional phrase is "Do you agree?", which allows you to agree, disagree or argue a conditional position. The word *because* is the expectation to test: the topic claims fear is the *reason* characters conform, so a strong response asks whether fear is the only reason, or whether habit, tradition, ambition or cruelty also play a part. As *The Lottery and Other Stories* is a collection, you are expected to range across several stories, such as 'Flower Garden', 'The Renegade', 'Of Course' and 'The Lottery'. Consider the historical context of small-town and suburban America in the late 1940s, where respectability and belonging mattered and difference was viewed with suspicion.

Contention

Now that you understand what the prompt is asking, we can begin to think about our interpretation of Jackson's message. Let's consider the prompt again:

'In Jackson's stories, characters conform because they are afraid of being excluded.' Do you agree?

We can approach this in multiple ways. Here are three simplistic interpretations (agree, disagree, somewhere in between):

- Jackson suggests that her characters conform because they are afraid of being left out.
- Jackson implies that conformity in her stories comes from habit and tradition rather than fear.
- Jackson shows that some characters conform out of fear, while others resist.

However, these interpretations are quite general and lack specificity. They don't tell the reader exactly what you are arguing. Let's improve them with more precise language and deeper knowledge of the text:

- Jackson suggests that fear of exclusion drives much of her characters' conformity, as Mrs Winning's abandonment of Mrs MacLane in 'Flower Garden' shows, but reveals that this fear is most dangerous when it hardens into a community's cruelty towards outsiders.

- Jackson implies that conformity is often unthinking rather than fearful, as in 'The Lottery', where villagers preserve a ritual whose meaning they have long forgotten, suggesting that habit can be as powerful as fear.
- Jackson presents conformity as a choice made under pressure, contrasting characters who give in, such as Mrs Winning, with those who quietly resist, such as Mrs MacLane, and showing that resistance in her communities always carries a cost.

These improved interpretations use specific language, engage with the complexity of the characters' motivations, and demonstrate a sophisticated understanding of the collection's ideas.

Extending Sentences - Connectives

To create a 'sophisticated' idea you need to avoid single ideas, all of the contentions above are singular and lack connections to other ideas. We can connect them together using three simple connectives (and their advanced synonyms!)

Useful Conjunctions and Their Purposes

Conjunction	Purpose	Synonyms
Because	This conjunction explains why the information you have stated is true, demonstrating greater understanding of the author's purpose.	As, as a result of, considering, being, for, through, seeing as.
But	This conjunction adds contradictory information, allowing for greater debate.	However, nevertheless, yet, despite, even so, nonetheless, except.
So	This conjunction allows for inferencing the cause and effect of the statement, which demonstrates greater thinking and ideas about the text.	Therefore, consequently, accordingly, leading to.

From here, we can take these singular idea contentions and extend them with these connectives in order to make multi-idea contentions that can create sophisticated links between ideas:

Topic Sentences

Now we can create topic sentences that allow to explore complex ideas linked using BECAUSE, BUT & so.

Authorial Message/Intent - NOT PLOT OR CHAPTER!

The sentence should be focused on an authorial message, not just a concept or character make the author active -the most common start is the **author**+ verb:

E.g **Jackson** explores/communicates/illustrates etc.

Authorial Verbs

Analytical Verbs for Text Analysis

Conveys	Explores	Demonstrates	Emphasises
Communicates	Depicts	Illustrates	Challenges
Identifies	Frames	Reveals	Highlights

States	Implies	Suggests	Underlines

Prepositional Phrases

Another way to structure this sentence is to use a *prepositional phrase* at the beginning of the sentence that introduces ideas to vary your sentence structure:

Throughout the collection, Jackson explores..

Textual Analysis Phrases and Sentence Starters

Throughout	By (authorial verb)	In keeping with	With an eye to
Through	From the outset	In the absence of	Under the
By	Beyond the	Within the	To the extent
During	Concerning the	Without	

Specificity and Relevancy

Examiners punish vague or general statements, especially those that lack clear links to the topic or the author's message. For example:

By showing that characters want to fit in, Jackson shows that conformity matters in her stories.

This is not technically incorrect, but it is far too general and superficial. It doesn't demonstrate insightful analysis, nor does it show a clear understanding of Jackson's authorial intent. This kind of vague sentence would not receive full marks.

Here's an improved version:

By charting Mrs Winning's retreat from her friendship with Mrs MacLane in 'Flower Garden', Jackson portrays conformity not as a free choice, but as the price of belonging in a community that polices its boundaries.

This is better. It is clear, specific, well structured, and shows awareness of the idea (conformity and exclusion), character motivation and authorial message. It also links directly to the contention: that fear of exclusion drives the characters' conformity.

The issue you will face is that there is only so much you can discuss in your paragraph from here, as you have only examined one idea: conformity is the price of belonging. To fix this, let's go back to an old friend:

Because, But, So - Make a Complex Sentence!

Too often, students fail to complete long paragraphs because they are stuck repeating themselves or have run out of things to say about the topic they introduced. Therefore, if we have two ideas in our topic sentence, we can 'hinge' these sentences together, which demonstrates complex understanding, writing and structure. All of these are key parts of the rubric you are judged on! Here's an example:

> *By charting Mrs Winning's retreat from her friendship with Mrs MacLane, Jackson conveys how the fear of exclusion pushes characters to abandon their own judgement,*

> *ultimately suggesting that a community which rewards conformity turns its members into the enforcers of its prejudice.*

Now, you have two linked ideas:

- The fear of exclusion pushes characters to abandon their own judgement.
- In doing so, they become the people who enforce the community's prejudice.

This provides a clear structure for an entire paragraph and sets you up to use a hinge sentence later to develop further layers, such as how this pattern reaches its most extreme form in 'The Lottery'.

By planning your paragraph in this way, you'll ensure:

- Specific and sophisticated analysis
- Strong authorial intent
- Complex understanding of the characters' motivations and Jackson's critique of conformity in post-war American communities

Interrogating the Topic

Every Section A topic is new, and every topic is more than a single concept. The exam will never ask “tell me everything the author says about punishment”. It will modify the concept, by asking about its causes, its consequences, its impact, or its relationship with another idea. Reading time is where you take the topic apart before you commit to a contention.

Questions to Ask of Every Topic

- **Absolutes.** Look for words such as *all*, *no one*, *only*, *always*. Is the claim true for everyone in the text? If not, who is the exception, and why (class, gender, race, belief, family)?
- **Modifiers.** Adverbs and adjectives change the question. “Punished” and “justly punished” are different essays. “Moments” and “lasting, ordinary moments” are different essays. Define each modifier before you plan.
- **Connotation.** “Fear that is justified” is not “irrational fear”. “Infatuation with youth” implies shallowness and impermanence that “love of youth” does not.
- **Comparison.** *Most*, *more than*, *as guilty as*, *strongest*: these words require you to weigh one thing against another, not discuss one thing alone.
- **Connections.** “Change is inevitable” implies nothing can stay the same. “Interplay” means two ideas act on each other, not a one-way cause.
- **The verb.** *Celebrates*, *condemns*, *warns*, *mocks* each tell you the author’s attitude. Do not flatten them into “presents”.

Two Kinds of Quotation Topic

Quotation topics do not all work the same way, so read them closely.

- **The quote as a key moment.** The quote is attached to a question (“How is the idea of truth explored?”). The panel has chosen a passage that matters to the question. Decide where it fits in your sequence of ideas and discuss it there.
- **The quote as the proposition.** The quote is the claim you are asked to assess (“To what extent does the author demonstrate this to be true?”). Here the quote *is* the topic. Treating it as one piece of evidence would mean missing the question entirely.

Ordering Is Not Connecting

“Firstly”, “secondly”, “initially”, “subsequently” put paragraphs in order. They do not explain how one idea relates to the next. A connection says *why* paragraph two follows paragraph one: it builds on it, qualifies it, complicates it, or shows its consequence. Before you write, check two things in your plan: that every topic sentence answers the topic, and that you can state the link between each pair of paragraphs in one phrase.

Concepts Worth Rehearsing

Recent Section A topics have centred on concepts such as hardship, home, control, social convention, threat, knowledge, punishment, truth, choice and privilege. The panel can and does introduce new ones. A useful revision routine: take each concept, ask what your text says

about it, then ask what it says about the concept's causes, its consequences, and its relationship to a second concept. You build knowledge and practise the skill at the same time.

The Dynamics of a Text

The study design asks you to analyse the *dynamics* of a text. These are lenses for knowing your text so well that any topic can be answered. They do not sit in separate boxes: a character's motivation usually connects to a tension, a setting or a point of view. Make one page of notes for each lens, with evidence.

1. Character Motivations

Ask why each character does what they do. Is the drive emotional (fear, anger, joy), moral (duty, loyalty, compassion), self-image (wanting to seem good or honourable), or cultural, religious and social (beliefs strong enough to compel action)? Note where motivation *changes*: a character driven by money early may be driven by conscience later.

One quotation can support several readings. When Old Man Warner insists, "There's always been a lottery", his loyalty could be read as reverence for tradition, as fear of change (he warns that without it "they'll be wanting to go back to living in caves"), as pride in his own status ("Seventy-seventh year I been in the lottery"), or as superstition about the harvest ("Lottery in June, corn be heavy soon"). Choose the reading the topic needs, and use the words of the quote as your evidence for it.

For *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, try the same exercise with Mrs Appleyard's decision to send Sara back to the orphanage, Michael's search on the Rock, or Irma's return.

2. Tensions in Relationships

Tension is the friction between two characters: betrayal, misunderstanding, conflicting desires, secrecy, trauma, gender expectations, social order. Look at the language a character uses about the other. Line up the key relationships and note what rubs them against each other and whether it is resolved.

3. The Function of Settings

Naming the setting in your introduction earns little. Explaining what a setting *does* earns a great deal. Ask: of all places, why this one? Does it mirror a character's mood, or contrast with it to raise tension? Does it confine characters or free them? Does it give someone authority or take it away? Useful phrasing: "the setting functions as a physical manifestation of", "the confined setting reinforces", "the setting intensifies the conflict between".

For *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, the Rock functions as an ancient, indifferent force that dwarfs the girls, while Appleyard College functions as a fortress of imported order. For *The Lottery and Other Stories*, the sunny village square makes the ritual feel routine, and in 'Flower Garden' the cottage and its garden stand for the life Mrs Winning gave up.

4. The Complexities of the Plot

Map the plot on one large page. Is it linear or non-linear? Are there flashbacks, flash-forwards, frame narratives, dream sequences, circular endings? Then ask why the author chose this sequence. A structural choice (the title card and slow-motion picnic that frame *Picnic at Hanging Rock*; the calm, ordinary build-up of 'The Lottery' before the stoning) is evidence you can use.

5. The Role of Point of View

Whose voice do we hear? Whose perspective are we denied? Is the narrator reliable, and how do we know? Do characters see the same person differently? Does the audience know things characters do not (dramatic irony)? Useful phrasing: “by aligning the audience with”, “the limited perspective heightens”, “from Mrs Walpole’s point of view, however”.

Beyond the Dynamics

The study design also names: ideas, concerns and conflicts (not “themes”: turn a theme into the concerns and conflicts it raises); structures and language features (symbolism, dramatic irony, parallel plots, repetition, stage directions, film techniques), always explained for *how* and *why*; and the historical, social and cultural values of the world of the text, used as evidence in body paragraphs rather than only as a line in the introduction.

Connect the Lenses

Once each lens has its own page, link them. A mind map or colour coding works well: mark the quotes that serve more than one lens (a line that reveals a motivation *and* uses a key language feature), because those are the most flexible pieces of evidence on exam day. Some lenses will matter more for your text than others; that is expected.

Five Ways to Substantiate

No assessor counts types of evidence. But a response that draws on only quotations shows a narrower range than one that also uses characters, structure, plot, setting, language features and context. Quality beats quantity: each piece of evidence must be explained, not just included.

Writing the Introduction

Topics

There are three types of questions you may receive on a SAC or exam. These are the 'Discuss', 'To what extent' and 'Do you agree?' statements. These are all tackled in a slightly varying manner.

- Discuss : This is probably the most common type of prompt that you will encounter. When dealing with such prompts, it is important that you discuss as many aspects of it as possible. One way to improve your discussion here is to include a paragraph that rebuts the prompt, like what you do in your persuasive essays. However, since it is a discuss prompt, you do not need to make the two sides of your argument extremely distinct.

- To what extent: These topics require you to make a decision. Never say 'it is to some extent' in your contention. You really need to assign a portion of something. The best way to do this is to start with subordinating conjunctions like 'whilst" or 'although". To What Extent questions rarely want you to agree or disagree - they want you to explore a shade of grey.

- How: The 'How' topics usually focus on the construction of a text - your evidence should contain metalanguage like 'characterisation' for instance.

Introduction

The introduction is the first piece of your writing that will be examined. For this reason, it should be clear, direct and show your understanding of the topic. The introduction is there to show your examiner how you wish to respond to the set topic.

If your topic contains a quote, ensure that you mention it somewhere in your introduction to show you are addressing the topic.

Structure

An introduction must include the following:

A General Line of introduction

Too often our introductions lack any insight and mainly begin with author+text+background information which has nothing to do with the actual topic. We should attempt to be relevant with our opening statement and discuss why this concept is important.

Textual Analysis Starters, Verbs, and Noun Phrases

Phrases to Introduce	Analytical Verbs	Noun Phrases and Structures
Throughout literature...	Conveys	the challenges of...
Authors are often preoccupied with...	Explores	the pressures and difficulties of...
Much of human thought has focused on...	Emphasises	the dangerous nature of...
In these ... worlds created by authors...	Directs	the devastating impact of...
Most stories are characterised...	Engages	the importance of...

Phrases to Introduce	Analytical Verbs	Noun Phrases and Structures
The importance of... is often highlighted...	Establishes	the consequences of...
	Depicts	the conflict between...
	Grapples	the ... it requires...
	Highlights	the way ... can...
	Illustrates	the ways in which ... can...
	Challenges	the way ... shapes and influences...
	Composes	how ... leads to...
		how ... is able to...
		how ... creates...
		how ... causes...
		how ... challenges us to...
		how ... forces us to...
		how ... compels us...
		how not only ... but also...
		what it means to be...
		what it means for...
		what happens when...
		how a world where...
		how societies in which...
		how times of...
		how situations in which...

Introduce the Text, Author and Contention

Now we introduce the text and author and the audience. Then state how it relates to the topic specifically. These need to be connected fluently, when writing we should be relying on connectives to make sure there is a logical flow in our expression.

Depending on the prompt itself, it might be a wise idea to link either/both of characters and setting to the topic of the essay prompt. We can do this as such:

Linking a Character to a Topic:

Sentence Starters: Character Discovery and Purpose

Introductory Phrase	Verb of Discovery	Linking Phrase
As the main character...	Discover/s	in order to...

Introductory Phrase	Verb of Discovery	Linking Phrase
As the leading character...	Find/s	so that...
As the hero/ine...	Learn/s	by...
As the main focus...	Understand/s	to become...
As the protagonist...	Accepts/s	to work towards...
	Admit/s	since...
	Challenges/s	it is not as important as...
	Confront/s	isn't as necessary as...
	Seeks/s	can never be a substitute for...
	Realise/s	

N.B. the title of a text is always underlined when handwritten (and italicised when typed), i.e. Picnic at Hanging Rock or The Lottery and Other Stories. The title of an individual story goes in single quotation marks, e.g. 'The Lottery'.

Contention

A contention is the author's point of view on the topic. Since you are the author in this scenario, you need to write what your position on the topic. A contention should be short, to the point, and engage with the topic. On this falls the crux of your essay.

Do not be afraid to agree/disagree with a topic. You are allowed to have a conditional contention.

Writing Body Paragraphs

Body Paragraphs

The body paragraphs form majority of your essay. The body paragraphs are the main reasons that the contention your provided is true. Your body paragraphs need to be able to demonstrate your understanding of the text and the fluency of your language. You should ensure that every sentence (and thus every word) brings something towards your argument.

Structure

Below is the structure for a body paragraph using 'Th.E. S.A.M.L.' Method. This method of writing body paragraphs was developed in order to maximise possible marks. Only the 'TH' and 'L' elements of this structure need to be in the order given.

Th

Thematic-based topic sentence

Your topic sentence needs to be based upon a theme in the text, not a character.

✗ *'Tessie Hutchinson is stoned to death by the villagers.'*
✓ *'Jackson suggests that blind loyalty to tradition allows ordinary people to commit extraordinary cruelty.'*

E

Evidence

Quotes and scenes from the text that support the theme.

S

Symbols

Symbols that relate to this theme — including historical and social context, and setting.

A

Authorial intention

What was the author intending?

M

Metalanguage

Discuss the metalanguage the author uses around this theme.

L

Linking sentence

Link back to your contention.

Only the **Th** and **L** elements need to appear in this order — the middle elements can be woven through the paragraph.

Basic Example 'Th.E S.A.M'

> *Jackson suggests that blind loyalty to tradition allows ordinary people to commit extraordinary cruelty. In 'The Lottery', Old Man Warner insists that "There's always*

> *been a lottery", dismissing the villages that have given it up as a "Pack of crazy fools". The battered black box, which the villagers refuse to replace even as it grows "shabbier each year", symbolises a ritual whose meaning has decayed while its authority remains. Writing in the years after the Second World War, Jackson warns that cruelty is most dangerous when it is habitual and shared. Her flat, matter-of-fact narration of the stoning, in which "someone gave little Davy Hutchinson a few pebbles", makes the violence more disturbing by presenting it as ordinary. In this way, Jackson shows that loyalty to tradition can blind a community to its own cruelty.*

Writing About Ideas: Adding Adjectives to Nouns

One of the easiest ways of improving your writing is to add adjectives to nouns, this helps us to create an 'idea phrase'. Here is a list of commonly used nouns in analytic writing, a good way is to use these as springboards to finding even more complex and advanced nouns.

Idea Nouns for Analytical Writing

Column 1	Column 2	Column 3	Column 4	Column 5
Growing up	Survival	Justice	Friendship	Loss
Independence	Conflict	Humanity	Family	Guilt
Coming of age	Courage	Prejudice	Relationship	Redemption
Maturity	Strength	Oppression	Belonging	Hope
Identity	Bravery	Injustice	Loneliness	Grief
Discovery	Persistence	Power	Loyalty	Sorrow
Revelation	Fortitude	Greed	Betrayal	Memory
Concealment	Heroism	Selfishness	Love	Future
Blossom	Resilience	Competence	Hatred	Past
Deteriorate	Cowardice	Potential	Envy	Melancholy

We then can pair these ideas with adjectives of degree - these tell us how big, small, frequent, fast or slow something is, here is a list to help build your writing vocabulary:

small

Adjectives of Degree for Analytical Writing

Category	BIG (Intensifying)	SMALL (Minimising)
SIZE	Deep, Immense, Extensive, Overwhelming	Empty, Insignificant, Little, Tiny
STRENGTH	Extreme, Powerful, Fierce, Determined	Weak, Uncertain, Fragile, Feeble
SPEED	Rapid, Swift, Impulsive, Sudden	Slow, Reluctant, Hesitant, Glacial
CONSISTENCY	Frequent, Constant, Incessant, Unchanging	Unsteady, Unreliable, Erratic, Unstable

Hinge Sentences

In your topic sentence, you can introduce two related ideas. This creates room for a more complex, insightful paragraph. But remember: when you shift focus from the first idea to the second, you must signal this change to the reader clearly. This is where the hinge sentence comes in.

A hinge sentence acts like a bridge: it acknowledges what you've already explored, then transitions to the second idea you introduced in your topic sentence. Here's how that works:

> *By charting Mrs Winning's retreat from her friendship with Mrs MacLane, Jackson conveys how the fear of exclusion pushes characters to abandon their own judgement, ultimately suggesting that a community which rewards conformity turns its members into the enforcers of its prejudice.*

Evidence + Analysis of First Idea

In 'Flower Garden', Mrs Winning's friendship with Mrs MacLane survives only until the town begins to disapprove of Mrs MacLane hiring Mr Jones. When her mother-in-law urges her to "talk to her about that colored man working there", Mrs Winning's private thoughts reveal what really moves her: "pretty soon they'll stop coming to me first, they'll tell someone else to speak to me." Jackson shows that her concern is not for her friend, or even for what is right, but for her own place in the community.

Hinge Sentence (transitioning to Second idea)

However, Jackson does not leave Mrs Winning as a mere victim of social pressure; she shows her becoming its agent.

Analysis of Second Idea

When Mrs MacLane asks whether the town's coldness is "because of Mr. Jones working here", Mrs Winning denies it, then privately thinks, "The nerve of her, trying to blame the colored folks." Having absorbed the town's prejudice, she now voices it as her own. Her final gesture, as she "swung around without speaking and started, with great dignity, back up the hill toward the old Winning house", is deeply ironic: the "dignity" she preserves is the dignity of belonging, bought at the cost of her friend.

By using a hinge sentence, you show your reader that you're not just stacking ideas but developing an argument, deepening your interpretation, and showing the author's nuanced message.

Concluding Dependant Phrases Paired with Analytic Verbs

Concluding Dependant Phrase	Analytic Verb
Even if Jackson recognises...	questions...
Whilst Weir endorses...	illustrates...
Whether or not Jackson implies...	reveals...
In order to explore ... Weir ...	demonstrates...

Writing the Conclusion

Conclusion

If you think of a conclusion as less of summarising everything, and more of combining all of these conflicting ideas and messages into one overall conclusive point. We can do this by using the following structure.

Structure

The structure for a conclusion can follow the same structure as an introduction. However, instead of introducing the text, you are concluding your discussion.

Here is an alternative method:

Topic:

> *'In Jackson's stories, characters conform because they are afraid of being excluded.' Do you agree?*

Conclusion Structure for Analytical Essay Writing

Purpose in Conclusion	Example Sentence
Overview of how the whole text demonstrates the key concepts in the essay topic	Fundamentally, *The Lottery and Other Stories* explores the pressure to belong, and how readily ordinary people give up their own judgement to avoid standing apart.
Summary of the complications of this topic	Throughout the collection, Jackson complicates the idea that fear alone drives conformity, showing that habit, tradition and the pleasure of belonging can be just as powerful, as the villagers of 'The Lottery' reveal.
Focus on the key authorial message in conclusive language	Therefore, Jackson warns that a community which punishes difference turns its members into the enforcers of its prejudice, as Mrs Winning becomes in 'Flower Garden'.

The Initial Concluding Sentence

Here is a list of concluding and verb phrases you can use at the beginning of your conclusion.

Concluding Sentence Starters and Verb Phrases

Concluding Phrase	Verb Phrase
Essentially,	explores
Fundamentally,	is a text about...
At its core,	critiques
At its heart,	is a novel that...
Ultimately,	examines
In the end,	is a science fiction tale
In the final analysis,	exposes
Everything considered,	that...

Sentence Starters

To introduce		
This essay discusses ...	... is explored ...	... is defined ...
The definition of ... will be given	... is briefly outlined ...	... is explored ...
The issue focused on ...	... is demonstrated ...	... is included ...
In this essay ...	... is explained ...	... are identified ...
The key aspect discussed ...	... are presented ...	... is justified ...
Views on ... range from	... is evaluated ...	... is examined ...
The central theme ...	... is described ...	... is analysed ...
Emphasised are ...	... is explained and illustrated with examples ...	

To conclude		
In summary, ...	To review, ...	In conclusion, ...
In brief, ...	To summarise, ...	To sum up, ...
To conclude, ...	Thus, ...	Hence, ...
It has been shown that ...	In short, ...	

To compare and contrast		
Similarly, ...	In the same way ...	Likewise, ...
In comparison ...	Complementary to this ...	Then again, ...
However, ...	This is in contrast to ...	In contrast, ...
And yet ...	Nevertheless, ...	Conversely, ...
On the contrary, ...	On the other hand, ...	Notwithstanding ...
Whereas ...	In contrast to ...	That aside, . . .
While this is the case ...	. . . disputes ...	Despite this, . . .

To add ideas		
Also, ...	Equally important . . .	Subsequently, ...
Futhermore, ...	Moreover, ...	As well as . . .

Next ...	Another essential point ...	Additionally, . . .
More importantly, ...	In the same way ...	Another . . .
Then, ...	In addition, ...	Besides . . .

Next ...	Another essential point ...	Additionally, . . .
Then again, ...	Firstly, ... secondly, ... thirdly, ... finally, ...	To elaborate, . . .

To present uncommon or rare ideas		
Seldom . . .	Few . . .	Not many . . .
A few . . .	. . . is uncommon	. . . is scarce . . .
Rarely . . .	. . . is rare . . .	. . . is unusual . . .

To present common or widespread ideas		
Numerous . . .	Many . . .	More than . . .
Several . . .	Almost all . . .	The majority . . .
Most . . .	Commonly . . .	Significant . . .
. . . is prevalent . . .	. . . is usual . . .	Usually . . .

To present inconclusive ideas		
Perhaps . . .	. . . may be . . .	. . . might be . . .
There is limited evidence for . . .	. . . is debated . . .	. . . is possibly . . .
. . . could . . .	. . . may include . . .	

To give examples		
For example, . . .	. . . as can be seen in . . .	. . . supports . . .
An illustration of . . .	. . . as demonstrated by . . .	. . . is observed . . .
Specifically, . . .	. . . is shown . . .	. . . exemplifies . . .
Such as . . .	As an example . . .	To illustrate, . . .
For instance, ...		

Therefore . . .	As a result . . .	For that reason . . .
Hence, . . .	Otherwise, . . .	Consequently, . . .
The evidence suggests/shows . . .	It can be seen that . . .	With regard to . . .
After examining . . .	These factors contribute to . . .	It is apparent that . . .
Considering ... it can be concluded that ...	Subsequently, . . .	The effect is . . .
The outcome is . . .	The result . . .	The correlation . . .
The relationship . . .	The link . . .	the convergence . . .
The connection . . .	. . . interacts with . . .	Both . . .

. . . affects . . .	Thus it is . . .	. . . causes . . .
. . . influences . . .	. . . predicts . . .	. . . leads to . . .
. . . informs . . .	. . . presupposes	. . . emphasises
. . . demonstrates . . .	. . . impacts on . . .	. . . supports . . .

To present prior or background ideas		
In the past, . . .	Historically, . . .	Traditionally, . . .
Customarily, . . .	Beforehand, . . .	Originally, . . .
Prior to this, . . .	Earlier, . . .	Formerly, . . .
Previously, . . .	Over time, . . .	At the time of . . .
Conventionally, . . .	Foundational to this is . . .	In earlier . . .
Initially, . . .	At first, . . .	Recently . . .
Until now, . . .	The traditional interpretation . . .	

To present others' ideas		
According to . . .	Based on the findings of ... it can be argued . . .	... proposed that ...
As explained by ...	... states that ...	... claims that ...
However, ... stated that ...	... suggested ...	... concluded that ...
Similarly, ... stated that ...	... for example, ...	... agreed that ...
Based on the ideas of ...	... defined ... as ...	... relates ...
As identified by ...	... disputed that ...	... contrasts ...
With regard to ... argued that ...	... concluded that ...	... confirmed that ...
. . . argues ...	... highlights ...	... demonstrates ...
... found that ...	... identifies ...	. . . wrote that ...

... demonstrated ...	... also ...	... reported ...
... pointed out that ...	... maintained that ...	... hypothesised that ...
... expressed the opinion that ...	. . . also mentioned ...	. . . asserts that ...
... identified ...	... goes on to state/suggest/say	... emphasises
... challenges the idea ...	... showed that ...	... explored the idea ...

Proofreading

Take a Break Before Proofreading

After finishing your essay, your mind is still fresh with ideas, but it may be too familiar with the text to catch all mistakes. Step away from the essay for at least 10–15 minutes. This will help you approach it with fresh eyes and a clearer mindset when you return to review it.

Read Aloud

Reading aloud forces you to slow down and focus on each word. It also helps you hear awkward phrasing or sentences that don't flow well. Read your essay aloud, paying attention to how each sentence sounds. If something feels off or too long-winded, make adjustments.

Check for Structure and Coherence

A strong essay is logically structured with clear arguments and smooth transitions. Ensure each paragraph has a clear topic sentence. Verify your argument flows logically from one point to the next. Ensure your introduction sets up your essay well and your conclusion summarises without introducing new ideas.

Look for Clarity and Precision

Vague or unclear language can confuse your reader, even if the argument itself is solid. Check if any sentences can be more specific or concise. Remove unnecessary filler words like 'really,' 'just,' or 'quite.' Replace vague words like 'things' or 'stuff' with more precise terms.

Verify Your Thesis and Topic Sentences

Your thesis statement should be the central focus of your essay, and topic sentences should align with it. Double-check that:

- Your thesis is clear and present in the introduction.
- Each body paragraph clearly supports your thesis with an argument or evidence.
- Topic sentences match the content of their respective paragraphs.

Proofread for Grammar and Syntax

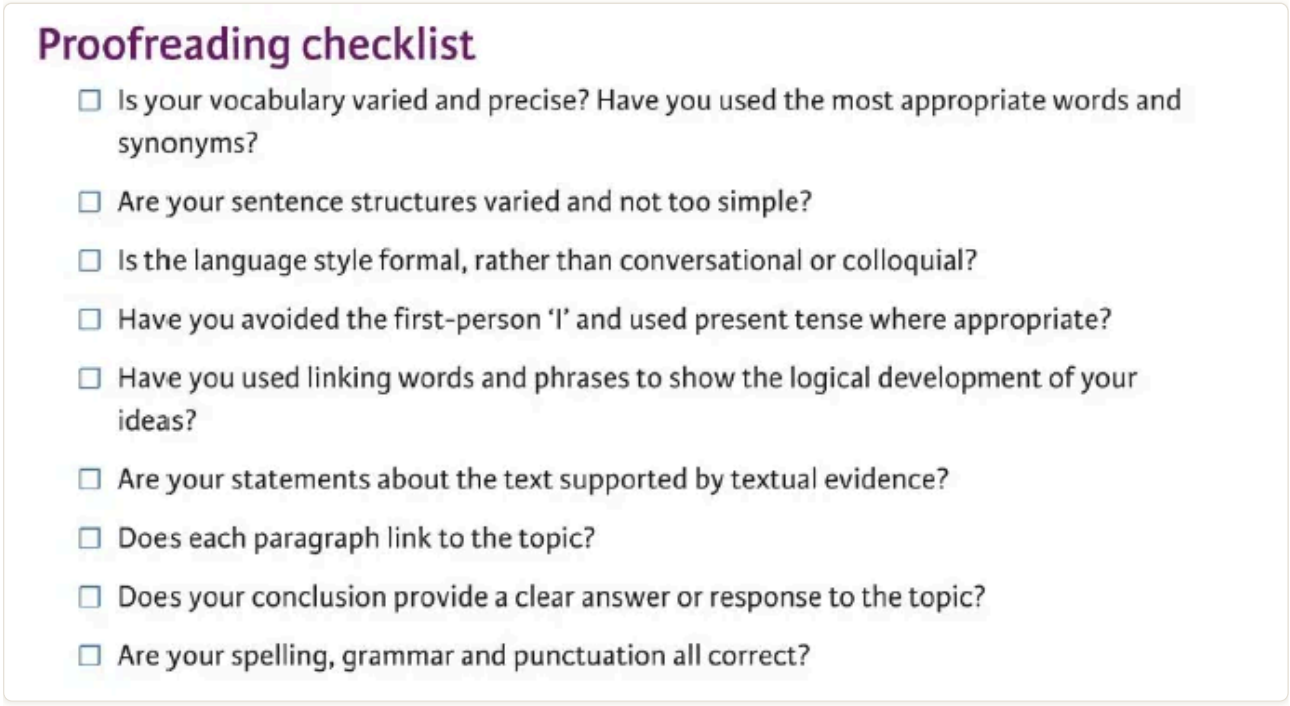
Grammar mistakes, awkward phrasing, or incorrect sentence structure can weaken the professionalism of your essay. Read through your essay for common mistakes (e.g., subject-verb agreement, incorrect punctuation, run-on sentences). Use tools like Grammarly or even Microsoft Word's spelling/grammar checker for a quick second look.

Check for Word Choice and Tone

The right word choice ensures your ideas are clear and impactful. Avoid overly complex words unless they are necessary for the context. Ensure you maintain an academic tone throughout the essay. Replace informal language (e.g., 'kids' or 'stuff') with more formal, specific terms.

Look for Repetition

Repeating the same word or idea can weaken your essay's overall impact. Identify words or phrases that appear too often. Use synonyms or restructure sentences to avoid redundancy. Consider varying sentence structures to keep the reader engaged.



Insight's Proofreading Checklist

Check Punctuation and Spacing

Simple punctuation errors or inconsistent spacing can distract the reader. Verify commas, full stops, and apostrophes are used correctly. Ensure there is proper spacing after full stops and between paragraphs.

Ask Someone Else to Read It

Fresh eyes can often spot mistakes you may have missed. Ask a peer, teacher, or family member to read your essay. Be open to their feedback and use it to improve your writing.

Ensure It Meets the Task Requirements

Your essay should always answer the question and meet the criteria specified in the prompt. Revisit the question to ensure your essay directly addresses it. Check that all key parts of the task are covered and that your argument is relevant.

Part

Creating Texts

Audience

The audience is anyone who reads, views or hears a text. In Section B the task tells you who your audience is, so read that instruction first. Your choice of language, examples, structure and tone all follow from who you think is reading.

Questions to Ask Before You Write

1. What is the piece about, and what does this audience already know about it?
2. What do they care about, and what would make them stop reading?
3. Would they agree with you, disagree, or not care yet?
4. Is there more than one audience, and does one of them matter more?
5. Which existing texts are like this one, and who reads those?

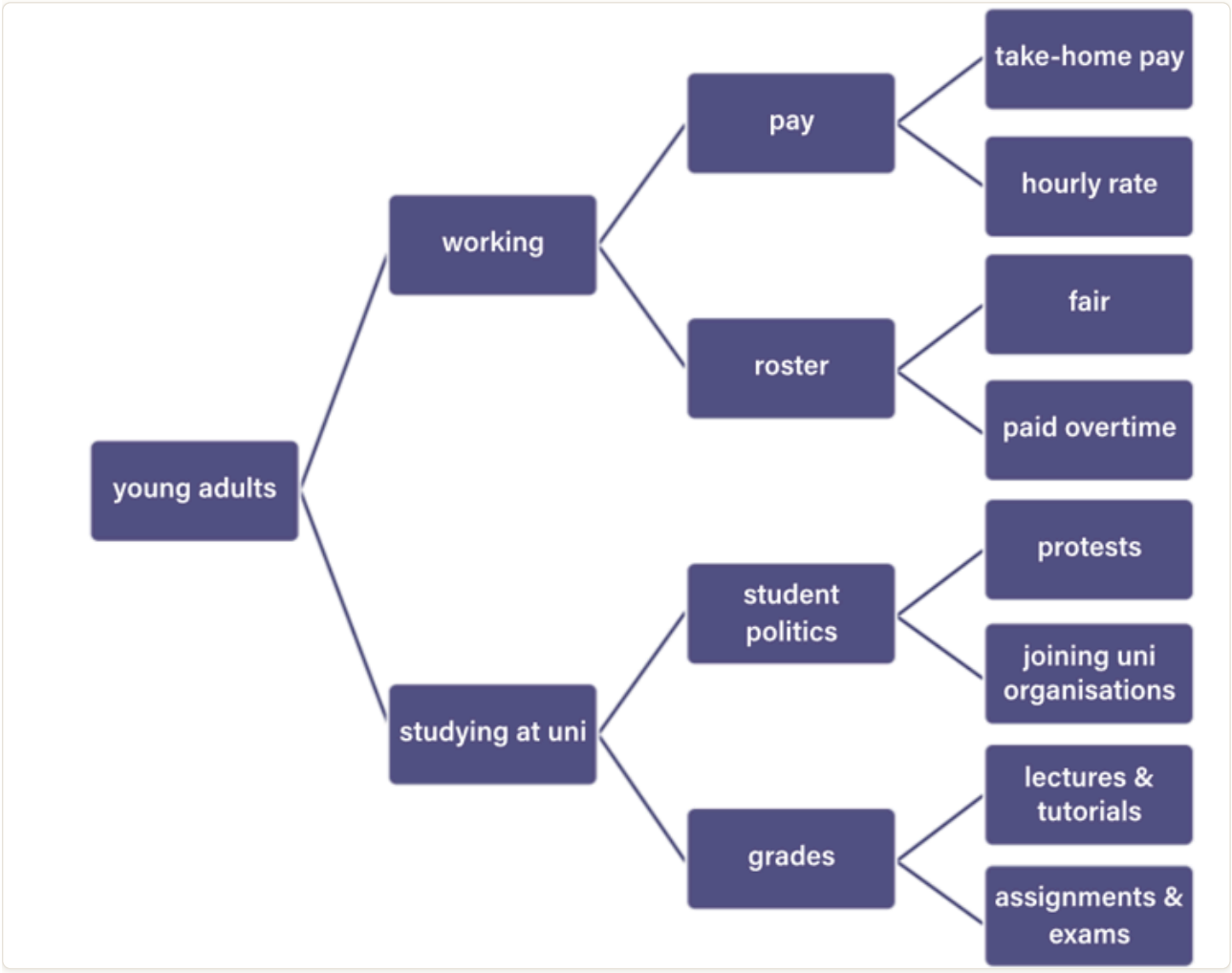
A Worked Example

Suppose the task asks for a piece for a school newspaper about a rule that everyone in your year follows without question. Your audience is classmates, most of whom are not sure the rule is fair. An uncertain reader needs a reason to keep going, so open with something they recognise. Once they trust you, make the argument.

Now suppose the same idea is for a literary magazine. Its readers know short fiction and expect ambiguity. A narrator who explains too much will lose them, so the piece should trust the reader to see what is left unsaid. The subject is the same. The choices are different.

Audience and the Texts

Jackson's 'The Lottery' appeared in *The New Yorker* in 1948, a magazine whose readers were used to stories that did not resolve neatly. Weir made *Picnic at Hanging Rock* for cinema audiences in 1975, who sat in the dark and could not stop the film to ask what had happened. Both texts assume a reader who will work something out for themselves. In the exam, name the audience a text is written for, and show how its choices take that audience into account.



Audience Diagram

Purpose

The study design names four purposes: to **express**, to **explain**, to **reflect** and to **argue**. Strong pieces usually combine more than one, and the purpose should be clear from the writing itself, because in the exam there is no written commentary to explain your intentions. Note that *describing* or *informing* is not one of the purposes. A piece that only describes a protest, a journey, a game or a place has not done the task.

Writing to Express

Expressive writing conveys a feeling, experience or perspective so the reader can share it. It leans on voice, imagery, sensory detail and figurative language. It is the most universal purpose, so on its own it rarely gives a piece direction. Pair it with another.

Writing to Explain

Explaining is often the best place to start planning. You explain the essence of a situation, relationship, problem or difficulty to a reader: a cause and its effect, or a connection between two things. Explanatory writing makes an idea about the Framework clearer to someone who had not considered it.

Writing to Reflect

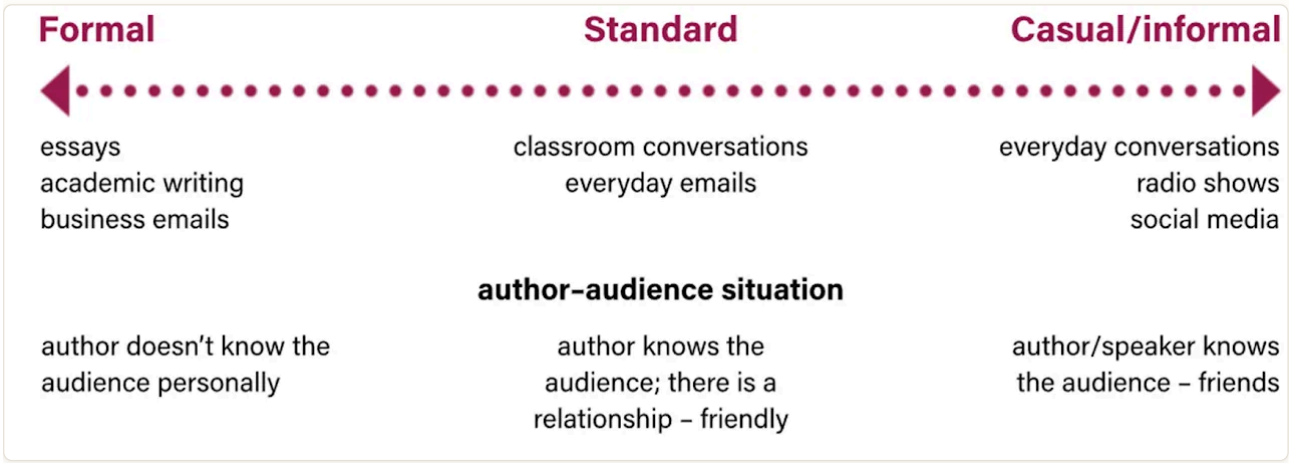
Reflection looks back, whether a minute or a decade, and considers what an experience means now. Hindsight lets the writer analyse how the past shapes the present, which is a powerful way of deepening an idea. Reflective writing tends to move from an experience to an insight.

Writing to Argue

Argument is justification: you sequence reasons to bring a particular audience to a point of view. Audience decides the structure. **If your audience is likely to be uncertain or opposed, hold back your core contention until late in the piece**, after you have built common ground and evidence. If the audience already agrees, you can state it early and focus on mobilising them.

Combining Purposes

Plan purposes as a sequence, not a label. Instead of “to explain”, write “to express an early challenge, then explain how it became a point of growth”. You can sharpen this further by naming your own values as the writer: what do you endorse, criticise or question? Those values become the message the piece builds towards.


Formal
Standard
Casual/informal
essays
academic writing
business emails
classroom conversations
everyday emails
everyday conversations
radio shows
social media
author–audience situation
author doesn't know the audience personally
author knows the audience; there is a relationship – friendly
author/speaker knows the audience – friends

Personal Journeys

From the Study Design

Explorations of 'life' or biographical explorations - telling our stories, telling others' stories, the problem of telling stories, appropriation of stories, who tells the stories and our history, missing stories, marginalised and elevated stories. Students could explore personal milestones, the effects of key events on their lives, or explore these ideas through the eyes of others.

Students who have migrated can explore their stories of movement and disruption. They can explore the expectations of change and the language of a new place and culture.

Text type	Good for ...
Blog post	reflecting on a topic
Opinion piece	arguing a point
Short story	telling a story
Poem	expressing emotions
Script	creating a dialogue and narrative
TED Talk	delivering a persuasive speech
Podcast	discussing a topic in an interview
Review	critiquing or analysing a subject
Personal essay	sharing a personal experience
Feature article	exploring a topic in detail

Insight's Different Forms of Text

Writing

- Writing about personal journeys explores both the physical world and the internal world of oneself and others.
- Reading and crafting texts about journeys provide opportunities to consider new places, perspectives, and self-discovery.
- Personal journeys involve various experiences, including challenges, growth, and self-discovery.
- Writing about personal journeys allows individuals to share unique experiences with others.

REMINDER: You have access to the exam generator and the prompt generator to practice your Section B skills.

Ideas

A personal journey can involve:

- Travel to a physical place.
- Psychological or emotional growth and change.
- A combination of both, where physical travel leads to new insights.
- Interior journeys may take a long time to occur due to significant events.

- The most important aspect of a personal journey is change – the individual or group is fundamentally altered by it.

Framework 3: Writing about personal journeys

- Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys.
- You must use the title provided.
- You must use **at least one** of the following stimuli.

Title: 'Finding My Way'

Stimulus 1

'… but it's no use going back to yesterday, because I was a different person then.'

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

'The caterpillar transforms without thought.
Its journey to a beautiful butterfly, inevitable.
Why must my own metamorphosis
Be shaped by so many choices?'

2024 VCAA English Exam - Section B for Personal Journeys

Reading the Framework Inferentially

Read the Framework statement for what it implies, not only what it says. It centres on life writing and storytelling: who tells stories, whose stories are marginalised or elevated, how storytelling gives or takes power, milestones within a longer story, movement and disruption, the familiar and the unfamiliar, expectations of change, and learning the language of a new place.

Build a synonym bank for the Framework's key ideas so no exam title feels unfamiliar. For example: *journey* (passage, odyssey, path, trajectory, pilgrimage); *change* (transition, evolution, metamorphosis, upheaval, growth); *story* (account, testimony, narrative, history, memoir).

Questions worth exploring:

- Why do people feel a need to tell, or uncover, their own story and heritage?
- How does an onlooker see someone else's journey differently from the person living it?
- Are key moments milestones, or millstones that weigh a person down?
- Is the journeying itself as important as what is achieved or lost?
- How do external events open up pathways no one planned?

Guardrails: Personal but Not Private

- **It is the idea of a personal journey, not your autobiography.** A title such as "Finding My Way" is not an invitation to recount your life. It invites ideas about what finding one's way means.
- **Appropriate for an adult stranger.** Your reader is an assessor you will never meet. Avoid content that is overly traumatic, violent or that you would not share with a person in authority. Assessors also have mandatory reporting obligations.
- **Relatable, not alienating.** The goal is a universal human truth the reader can connect with. Something so unique to you that it fosters no empathy works against you.
- **Write as a person, not a student.** Some of the strongest pieces drop the "Year 12 student" identity and write from a human perspective about feelings any reader recognises.

Take the Reader Somewhere: A to B to C

Your piece must itself be a journey. Plan three points:

- **A** - the starting position or understanding;
- **B** - the complication, tension or turning point;
- **C** - the new position: a realisation the reader reaches with you.

Assessors have criticised "stream of consciousness" pieces that wander without milestones. An A-B-C map prevents that and makes your structure visible.

Binaries for Building a Journey

A journey is easiest to see when it moves between opposites. Choose a pair, then find the context that dramatises it:

- familiar → unfamiliar; conformity → individuality
- ignorance → knowledge; uncertainty → clarity
- chaos → order; tension → resolution; pressure → release
- emotion → reason (or the reverse); past → future
- tradition → progress; powerlessness → power; oppression → resistance

Concept First, Then Context

Start with the concept, then find a situation that embodies it, then map the purposes. Example: concept *familiar to unfamiliar*; context *seeing a place you have known all your life from a new angle* (starting work behind the counter of a shop you have visited for years); purposes *express the nerves of the first shift, then explain how seeing the "back room" changed how you see the familiar*. Starting from the concept means you never lose the idea under the story.

Connected or Cohesive?

Mid-band pieces are *connected*: their parts link in sequence like paper dolls holding hands. Top-band pieces are *cohesive*: like a finished jigsaw, every part interlocks to form one picture. Cohesion comes from a single controlling idea (usually drawn from the title), recurring images or motifs, and an ending that resolves the opening.

Building Voice: A Redrafting Exercise

Voice is the personality and perspective that comes through word choice, syntax, punctuation, imagery and tone. Practise it by redrafting a single sentence about an object.

- **Draft 1 (description):** The shoes had a light brown sole and peach-coloured suede. Mum bought them because other students had them.
- **Draft 2 (context and feeling):** Mum came in the front door, arms laden with shopping. I looked past the paper bags to the one I wanted, but the moment I lifted the lid I knew they were the wrong ones: not the ones my friends wore, not the ones that might have let me belong, just a little. My cheeks prickled with ingratitude.
- **Draft 3 (control):** Now move the parts. What changes if the shoes come last, as suspense? If "laden" replaces "full"? If the sentence about belonging is cut short?

The object has become a symbol of belonging, and the voice now carries the idea. Under timed conditions you cannot redraft every line, which is why this practice belongs in the weeks before.

Engaging with the Title and Stimulus

Use your dictionary in reading time. Not because you do not know the words, but to make sure your definition matches the assessor's, and to find word forms and senses you had not considered. Read the title and every stimulus literally first, then metaphorically (a mountain: height, struggle, vantage, summit; a window: perspective, clarity, separation, opportunity).

Levels of engagement, from mid-band to top-band:

1. The title informs the piece and links it to the Framework.

2. The title and a stimulus are blended to create a new meaning neither had alone.
3. The title and stimulus develop the piece's purposes and its insight into people and society.
4. The title, stimulus, purpose, audience, context and message all interrelate, moving the reader from A to B to C.

Form, Mentor Texts and Practice

- **Commit to a form and know it intimately.** The question is not which form is best, but whether you have practised it, know its conventions, and whether it suits your purpose and audience.
- **Mentor texts are models, not requirements.** They are not assessed and need not be mentioned. Study how they control structure, carry more than one purpose, and make a personal story feel universal.
- **Write regularly.** Aim for short timed pieces (around 30 minutes) at least twice a week, building up to full 60-minute responses to unseen titles.
- **Get feedback from a reader.** What is clear to you as the writer may not be clear to someone else, so ask a teacher, peer or family member.

Practice Titles

Plan (and then write) responses to these unseen-style titles. Define the title, read it literally and metaphorically, choose a binary, then map A-B-C.

- Finding Joy
- Growth
- Looking Back, Looking Forwards
- I Have Something to Say

Prepare two or three developed ideas before the exam, so on the day you can choose the one that best fits the title.

Sample Personal Journeys Piece: 'The Spare Key'

Practice stimuli (written for this site, not from an exam): 'Home is where you leave something behind.'; 'Keys are the only things we carry from one life into the next.'
For eleven years the spare key to our old house hung on a nail beside the back door of the new one. Nobody told me to keep it. It was simply there one morning, a brass thing with a loose tooth, after Mum had unpacked the last box and I was too tired to ask.

We moved in March. I was nine. The new street had a footpath on one side only, and a dog behind the fence that barked at anyone holding an envelope. Mum said we would be settled by winter. Dad did not say much about it. He drove the van up the hill with the windows down, so the dust from the gravel road came in, and he kept one hand on the dashboard as if the house might slide away behind us.

I did not make friends quickly. At school I learned which corners of the oval were mine and which were not. In the evenings I walked the new streets with the key in my pocket and tried to think of the old house as a place I could still reach. It had a lemon tree that dropped fruit onto the tin roof of the shed. It had a hallway that echoed when you whistled. None of that was in the new house, and I kept waiting for it to appear.

It never did, but the key kept working in my head. Every time someone asked where I was from, I gave the old address, and every time I gave it, I felt slightly less like a stranger in the place I lived now.

I went back on a Saturday when I was twenty. The new owners had painted the front door green. I stood on the path with the key in my hand, and I tried it in the lock out of habit. It did not turn. The lock had been changed years before, and the key was a copy of something that no longer existed.

I put it back in my pocket and walked to the end of the street. A boy was kicking a ball against the fence of the house that used to be ours, and a woman in a dressing gown was watching from the porch. Nobody knew me there. I was glad, in a way, because it meant I could leave without explaining.

The key is still in my drawer. It does not fit anything. I look at it sometimes when I am packing for another move, and I think about how much of a home is just a set of directions you keep carrying after the door has changed.
Why this piece works

- It answers both stimuli without naming them. The key is the object that connects the two ideas, and the journey runs from the old house to the new one and back again.
- The voice stays plain. The sentences are short where the feeling is strong, and the details (the lemon tree, the dog, the green door) carry the emotion without explaining it.
- The ending returns to the object. Revisiting the key gives the piece a shape, which the reader can feel without being told what it means.

Section B Under Exam Conditions

In the SAC you had around 80 minutes, a known prompt, teacher consultation and a written commentary. In the exam you have about 60 minutes, an unseen title, unseen stimuli and no commentary. Everything about purpose, audience and context must come through the writing itself.

A Reading-Time Process

1. Turn only to your own Framework. The other three are a distraction.
2. **Cover the visual stimulus.** Start with the title, because the title, not the image, is the core of the task.
3. Unpack the title: what does it imply? Which aspects of your Framework does it open up?
4. Now read all three stimuli, including the visual. Which one adds a spark that extends, deepens or broadens what the title has suggested?
5. Choose the form and approach you have practised that best suits this title.

Rules and Myths

- **The title is fixed.** You cannot change it or add to it. Write it at the top of your response. If your shaded box and your title disagree, assessors follow the title.
- **Choosing a title chooses its Framework.** No mixing titles, Frameworks or stimulus sets.
- **The title should be threaded through the whole piece**, internalised as its controlling idea. You need not repeat the exact words, though you may.
- **The stimulus is used at least once and interpreted freely.** You may read an image in opposite ways (is the tape being put on, or peeled off?) so long as your reading is clear. Use the *idea* the stimulus generates, not its literal contents: a tree in the image does not require a tree in your piece.
- **More stimuli earn no extra marks.** One, two or three is your choice. There is no correlation between number used and score.
- **There is no preferred form.** Anything except poetry, song or verse, and you may embed a line of poetry or a lyric inside prose.
- **Do not write a story about the Framework.** Narrative elements are fine, but the piece must convey ideas, not just an engaging plot.
- **Crossing out a word to improve it is a strength, not an error.**

Stay on the Framework

The most damaging mistake is a fine piece that has drifted off the Framework. Two common versions:

- **Protest as a verb instead of a noun.** The Framework explores protest as a concept: why it arises, why it fails, its consequences, its moral high ground. A piece that simply rants about something you are angry about is not about protest.

- **Touching the Framework once.** A piece about something else, with one scene of children playing in a park, is not about play. The ideas must be Framework ideas from start to finish.

Thin ideas also cost marks. “Protest is good” and “people should play more” are unexamined. Explore causes, consequences and limits.

Recent Exam Titles

Framework	2024	2025
Protest	Resist and Persist	Small Acts, Big Wins
Personal Journeys	Finding My Way	Changing Direction
Play	Time to Play	Life Is a Game
Country	Connections	Origins

Titles are short (one to four words) and the visuals have increasingly been graphics that suggest ideas rather than photographs that invite a story.

Forms That Have Worked

Examples published in recent assessment reports show how far form can flex:

- **An advertorial** for a play-based childcare centre (Play, 2024), aimed at parents of preschoolers, with a distinct marketing voice and the title used explicitly.
- **A recipe for protest** (Protest, 2024), using imperatives, varied sentence length, subheadings, historical awareness and a touch of humour.
- **A sectioned reflection** on “Finding My Way” (Personal Journeys, 2024), with four subheadings (chameleon, metamorphosis, mosaic, reminisce), each marking a stage of development.

These are not templates to copy. They show that form should be chosen to sharpen ideas.

Craft Reminders

- **Fluid and hybrid forms.** Blend styles: an opinion piece with a narrative opening, a speech that quotes a song lyric.
- **Subheadings** organise ideas and signal a deliberate structure, and they can mark shifts in time or place.
- **Paragraphs are your choice.** Vary length and number for effect; one paragraph is one extended idea.
- **Watch heavy dialogue.** Long stretches of colloquial first-person dialogue tend to flatten complex ideas.
- **Consider audience and context** even though you cannot state them: who is reading, when and where, and what do they already believe?
- **Practise unseen.** Every practice piece from now should use a title you have not seen before, timed at 60 minutes, following the reading-time process above.

Practice Stimuli

Stimuli List I

Create a text that incorporates the idea of personal journeys, using the given title. You must include reference to at least one of the following pieces of stimulus in your response. The text should be shaped around a purpose (to express, to explain, to argue, to reflect) and written with an audience in mind.

Writing Task 1

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'Life is a Journey'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *"Life is a journey with problems to solve, lessons to learn, but most of all experiences to enjoy."*

Ritu Ghatourey

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"Don't know what I want*
> *So don't ask me*
> *'Cause I'm still trying, to figure it out*
> *Don't know what's down, this road*
> *I'm just walking*

> *Trying to see through the rain coming down*
> *Even though I'm not the only one, who feels the way I do"*

Taylor Swift

Writing Task 2

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'The Changing Self'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *"The greatest discovery in life is self-discovery. Until you find yourself, you will always be someone else. Become yourself."*

Myles Munroe

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"Choose the path you want and take it (And take it)*
> *If you don't fit the mould, doesn't matter, go on and break it*
> *Yes, it's a square peg life in a round hole town*
> *But it all couldn't be any sweeter*

> *You may be upside-backwards and wrong side-down*
> *But it just couldn't feel more completer."*

Kelly Clarkson

Writing Task 3

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'Stories of Self'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *"I want to share my life story and honour my roots."*

Rocco DiSpirito

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"Wherever I may roam*
> *I will hold fast to my traditions.*
> *My language is my cherished possession*
> *My language is the object of my affection*
> *My precious adornment*

> *My language is my strength,*
> *An ornament of grace”*

Stan Walker

Writing Task 4

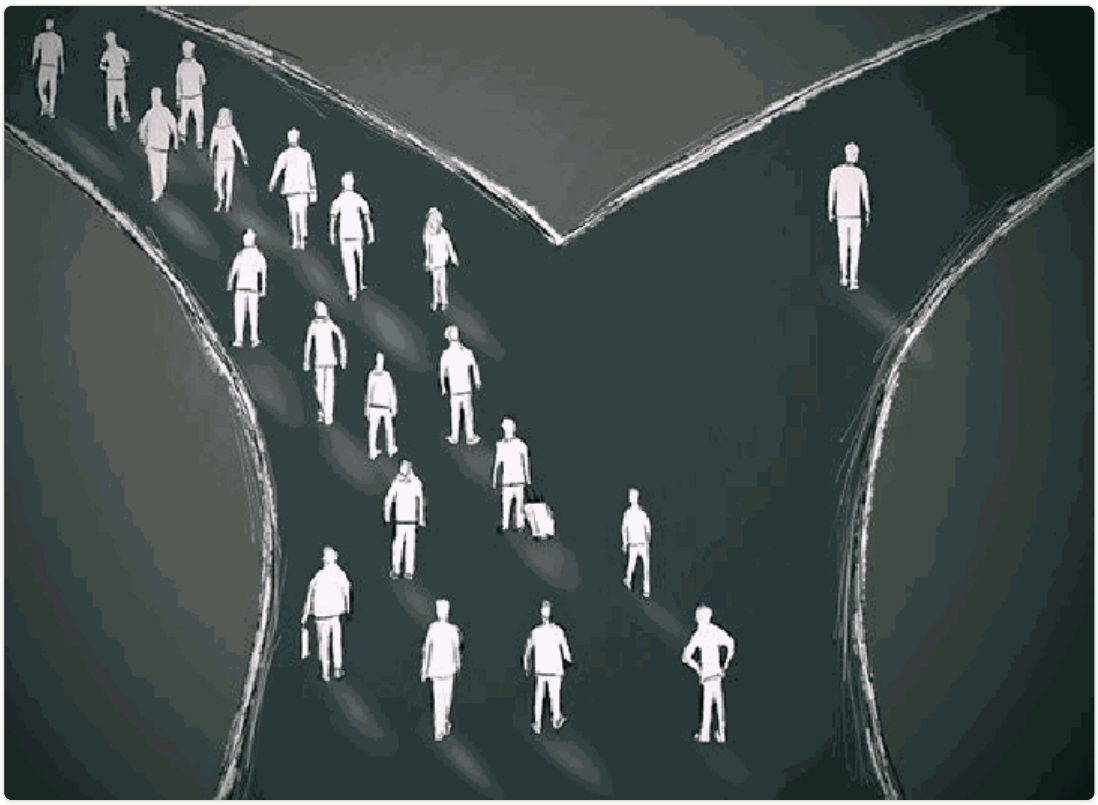
Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **‘Finding Your Own Path’**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *In the rugged expanse of life's rough terrain,*
> *No path laid out, no guiding hand to explain.*
> *Mountains loom tall, a maze to unravel,*
> *Obstacles and messes, chaos to travel.*

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"Do not go where the path may lead. Go instead where there is no path and leave a trail."*

Ralph Waldo Emerson

Writing Task 5

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'Getting Lost'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *All is not lost*
> *when your heart*
> *has been shattered.*
> *All is not lost*
> *when you feel so alone.*
> *All is not lost*
> *when your hope*
> *lies in tatters.*
> *This darkness will pass,*
> *keep watching for dawn.*

John Mark Green

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"If you tried and didn't end up where you wanted to go that's still progress."*

Rupi Kaur, Healing Through Words

Writing Task 6

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'A Journey of Transformation'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *Change is natural. Change is one of the only thing we can be certain of: we change constantly; our moods, feelings, and bodies change – change is a part of life and of our everyday existence. We all change over time.*

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *"Any change, even a change for the better, is always accompanied by discomforts."*

Arnold Bennett

Writing Task 7

Write a text that explores ideas about personal journeys, using the title **'The Journey Together'**.

You may choose to respond to one of the following stimuli.

Stimulus 1

> *It doesn't matter where you're going, it's about who you have beside you.*

Stimulus 2



Stimulus 3

> *Slowly, slowly*
> *we grow together,*
> *skin across the wound*
> *of our separateness.*

david steinberg

Sample Creating Texts Piece (19/20)

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Structure & evidence | Language & technique | Ideas & interpretation | Voice & craft

Sample Creating Texts Piece (19/20)

A high-scoring (19/20) Section B piece written to reflect and express, responding to the title below.

> *Title: 'The Path Less Taken'*

I was at a family dinner over Easter earlier in the year, and one of my aunts asked me a seemingly-innocuous question that made me quite uncomfortable. Usually, I am an upbeat, bubbly person, and most would tell you that I have high confidence. Unfortunately, the opposite is true : every day I question the choices I have made and the impact they have had on my relationships.

When I entered high school, I was faced with a rather uncomfortable choice: I would have to pick a school sport to play during winter, or join a band. The extracurricular lady peered at me over her bifocals , frowning, eyebrows drawn together and raised like little anthills . The only band that had any space was the orchestra, and they needed a piccolo player .

Now, anyone who is acquainted with woodwind instruments would know that the piccolo is a tiny, shrieking version of the flute, and that it should be played only by an experienced flautist with excellent tone. But for a reason unknown both to my parents and myself, I, standing in my oversized blazer with my dress almost at my ankles , boldly offered my services to the school band. The lady in charge of extracurriculars frowned a little harder, and I could almost imagine the tiny ants running in and out of those hills. Then she sat back, sighed, and put my name down, one eyebrow still raised.

Obviously, I was terrible. However, I started practising more and more. I took a certain tormented delight in knowing that while other students were tucking into dinner, or doing a little homework, I was running up and down the same five notes with deliberate focus . As painful as my practice was for all within earshot , the improvement it allowed me in the orchestra gave me surging motivation.

Sometimes in life, you are captured by an idea which is inexplicable to those who haven't felt it. The sense of mastery I felt playing the piccolo made all other subjects at school pale in comparison. What was maths, with all its useless formulae repeated over and over , when music was a space with infinite room for improvement? Where every day's practice contributed to notable growth, however small? Music was not just a hobby for me, but a pursuit which gave me the deepest sense of meaning. Over time, I came to love the piccolo more than anything else.

Unfortunately, as the years went by, my parents, who had initially been in favour of my playing an instrument, slowly started to prioritise other things. I should have been studying more maths, more science, writing more essays. I knew that they expected me to study like my

friends, and to aim for medicine so I could become a doctor. As much as I tried, my enthusiasm for those subjects never matched what I felt for music. I practised more, and my grades fell further. I tried to hide reports from my parents (with little success). Finally, when I entered year 12, I committed a cardinal sin: I listed a music degree as my first university preference.

The decision had a negative impact on my parents. Our relationship turned to more fighting, and then stony, awkward dinners . Parents often have high expectations for their children. Life is short. You only buy books for a new highschool year six times with your child, and they only get the ages of 18-22 to do undergrad with people their own age. For parents, not only does time with children fly by, but in many cases the having of children cut their own professional lives short. I remember my mother constantly reminding me that perhaps she would have been so much further ahead in her workplace if not for the family, as much as she loved us . I think for her in particular, the lives of my siblings and myself were vicarious extensions of her own, through which she could live out different "maybe" paths.

You can understand, then, why I would have been so perturbed by my aunt's question: "And what will you be doing at the end of the year?"

For my part, I could never see why my parents were so upset. My three older siblings all left secondary education and diligently commenced medical school. I, on the other hand, could only see one thing: I had one life to live, and I'd rather do anything than spend it dissecting bodies and examining skin conditions. Once you realise that life is short, you come to terms with the fact that you may as well spend it doing things you enjoy. How sad it would be to die doing something you hated out of a feeling of social obligation.

And yet, this is what so many of us do. Many of us end up trapped in degrees, then internships, then grad roles, then middle-management jobs chosen for us by our high-schooler selves, with extremely little experience to guide the decision . Most people enter this life because it is the socially acceptable thing to do, and also because it is extremely difficult to find direction. Artists, inventors, and scientists have to bet against conventional wisdom to pursue their innate dreams. However, conventional wisdom is usually right (which is why we call it wisdom), and so if you don't have a good reason to ignore it, you probably shouldn't. Perhaps, given how much I know my parents care about me, I do understand their worry after all.

So when my aunt asked me this question, the mood in the room dropped somewhat. I thought carefully about my response. Should I lie, tell her that I'll be doing medicine too? Should I say I was prevented by my poor grades? It was almost true . But then I felt the weight of the truth settle upon me, and it was heavy and liberating all at once . I was different. Who cared? This was my life. "So, then? Will you be following your good older siblings?"

"You know, aunty," I twirled some spaghetti around my fork . "I've decided to walk the path less taken."

Sample Creating Texts Piece: ’Finding My Way’ (10/10)

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Voice & craft | Structure & evidence | Language & technique | Ideas & interpretation

Sample Creating Texts Piece: ‘Finding My Way’ (10/10)

A full-mark Personal Journeys piece responding to the title ‘Finding My Way’.

> *Stimuli used: a pair of feet on asphalt with painted arrows pointing in many directions; ‘The caterpillar transforms without thought. Its journey to a beautiful butterfly, inevitable. Why must my own metamorphosis be shaped by so many choices?’*

I remember the day that I got off the plane so vividly. I remember the sun that day, a cruel god beating down upon me from its court of cloudless blue . It scorched my skin and left no prisoners. It was nothing like the benevolent sun over my homeland of Calcutta, where the gentle rays of morning would shine over the backs of a hundred thousand people, wrapped up in their idiosyncratic lifestyles since twilight .

But there was no one here. There was just me, my father, and the red earth that stretched out before me in every direction, desolate and uninviting. My father, a self-titled opportunist, yearning to abandon the stagnancy that is the defining characteristic of the Indian middle class, saw Laxmi, the Hindu goddess of prosperity, hidden in every crack of the drought-stricken land.

I always thought my father was a little bit of an oddball. His brain was rattled around by the many, many wars it had been exposed to. In the same spirit, his nervous yet paradoxically poised energy set our house alive. It would wake up with the soft, repetitive chants of his Sanskrit prayers in the morning and fall asleep to his many lectures about the ideal governmental system come nightfall. It smelled like incense, asafoetida, and cumin, instead of the burnt smoke of the great Australian outback outside our porch door. It was the only piece of home in a strange new country. I cherished it with all my heart.

He was quick to find his way. In three years’ time, he was listening to The Beatles whilst fortifying himself with double helpings of Milo and Bengali egg fry, perusing an assortment of Hindi newspapers he got internationally delivered to us. The blokes at his sheep shearing job liked to alternate between calling him African and Indigenous Australian, slurs for both inclusive. He paid no heed, jovially punctuating his latest tales of workplace discrimination with, "Their stones and sticks can only rattle my bones! In Calcutta, we used gulel when we really wanted to hurt someone." I didn’t have the heart to quip about his idiomatic misquoting. His spirit was indomitable. Nothing could faze him.

I, on the other hand, could not extricate myself from the diminishing gazes of my peers. Every remark on the failure of my foreign tongue to mold itself to the valleys and troughs of a new language, every question underpinned by perfunctory distaste, every snigger swirled in my head each night, consuming the liminal space between waking and sleeping . The movies I watched, the songs I liked, the food I ate, all underwent a strict metamorphosis like the caterpillar confined within the fecund dark of a chrysalis . Slowly, one choice at a time, aligning more and more with the Australian lifestyle. Slowly, one choice at a time, departing from my roots.

That was, until the diagnosis. "Hepatitis B," the doctor called it, the only bloke in town willing to look at a 'coloured' patient. "From infected needles, or maybe passed down in the womb from his mother." My father, try as he might, could not pronounce the name of the illness eating his liver alive. He jokingly called it a gift from our motherland . Over the next few months, I watched him disintegrate into a shell of himself. He could barely open his eyes most days, and when he could, he would talk. He would rasp his smooth tenor into a small tape recorder into the early hours of the morning, flitting from English to Hindi to Bengali as the disease continued its unending assault into his being.

When they complained to me, he laid his papery, wizened hand, which once, in a bygone era, would emanate vitality so potent it was palpable in his air, upon my shoulder and looked at me in the eye with a desperate so intense I felt it in my very soul. "You must find your way, beta. You must tell my story before my time is up."

When he passed, I lost the only person rooting for me, both on this side of the Indian Ocean and the one where I came from. I was lost without him . I felt stagnant, stuck. Our house suddenly felt as desolate as the golden land on my very first day. Over time, I have found my way. I honour his memory by telling his extraordinary story to anyone that will listen. I continue his tradition by hanging his portrait above my mantel and pestering my eldest daughter to hang a garland of fresh marigolds underneath it every morning , just as my father did with his father's portrait, and how his father would have done with his father before him.

Because of him, I have spent a lifetime working as a social worker, aiding those fragmented because of migration , granting me the insurmountable pleasure of listening to a thousand stories . Many of them are like my father and I's, each marked with their own anecdotes and idiosyncrasies. People, struggling, trying, grappling with making sense of a new world. I see the glint of my father's smile in the face of a stranger coming to Australia to make a better life for themselves and their families. I hear his voice in their adversities. It feels like home .

What made this a 10/10

Every scene threads the stimuli through fresh sensory imagery, recurring motifs, and a quiet, honest voice. That layering is what lifts a Section B piece from competent to top band.

Sample Creating Texts Piece: ’This is Me’ (10/10)

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Voice & craft | Language & technique | Ideas & interpretation | Structure & evidence

Sample Creating Texts Piece: ‘This is Me’ (10/10)

A full-mark Personal Journeys piece responding to the title ‘This is Me’.

> *Stimuli used: ‘Life isn’t about finding yourself. Life is about creating yourself.’; ‘My story is ready. There’s enough to share. As I have made plenty. Come, sit at my table. Listen and learn. And you will see me.’*

"Good evening customers. Your next service to depart from Platform 2 will be the four-fifty-six Flinders Street running express from Newport to Footscray, Footscray to North Melbourne, and then stopping all stations to Flinders Street. Always remember to touch on your Myki at the start of your journey." The train announcer’s voice is a worn chime, filling the stark station like a frayed tapestry in an abandoned household. The station smells like it always does, redolent with the acrid tang of piss, sweat, and smoke. There is something self-righteous about the smell of a train station; none are exempt from its slightly carcinogenic, slightly metallic embrace .

A low mechanical groan swells beneath his feet as the train approaches, its headlights cutting through the dimness of the already-darkening winter sky with a tired reluctance. The doors slide open with a hydraulic sigh. He steps inside. The 4:56 pm train from Newport Station on Wednesday , the 20th of August, the 2025th year of the Common Era is almost deserted.

He looks down at his hands, admiring the soft webbing connecting the valleys between his fingers. His calluses are peeling, revealing the angry red of new skin underneath. It distantly reminds him of the animal documentaries he used to watch as a kid. He recalls his grandfather teaching him about the rattlesnakes as they appeared on their family’s old LCD; how their cyclical shedding of skin added a new segment to their rattles. Each interlocked and keratinised bit of memory ultimately conjoined to create their characteristic rattles, allowing them to alert nearby friends or warn foe when shook. He feels a bit like that rattlesnake now, shedding another layer of him, who he was (is?), as his sole ward against something bigger than him.

He straightens, instinctively brushing his hands against the worn fabric of his jeans, as though he can rid himself of that thin, flaking skin, of the evidence that he is still stuck in the process of becoming something else.

The carriage is quieter than he expects. Subdued, like a room where the conversation has only just ended and the last spoken consonant lingers. A man in a hi-vis vest dozes with his head tilted back, mouth slightly ajar and a tenuous string of drool tracing its way down the

contours of his jaw. Two teenagers sit across from one another, sharing a set of earbuds, their heads bowed together in conspiratorial symmetry . The girl in green does not look up . He takes a seat by the window.

As the train lurches forward, the station recedes into abstraction. The steel beams dissolve into streaks of grey, then into nothing at all. He watches his reflection instead. It hovers faintly against the glass, superimposed upon the passing city: a face that feels both intimately his and faintly unfamiliar . The train gathers speed.

But at the city, the carriage doors part and the world rushes in. The platform is dense with motion. He takes note of the sudden layering of language, the multiplicity of accents folding over another like tenuous silk organza of his mother's sarees. Someone coughs sharply; someone else argues into a phone; a group of schoolboys with reckless affection. The air smells of coffee, of baked bread, and of the faint tang of iron from the rails.

He lingers. He feels it again, that distance . Not exclusion, really, but a kind of peripheral existence. As though he is still watching the city through the glass when in reality, he's out in the cold, the gale lashing unforgivingly like a whip against his face. He looks down at his hands, at the peeling skin, scrutinising the rawness beneath. Shedding, again. Becoming, again.

He steps off the train and follows the crowd instinctively, letting the current of its movement take him toward Queen Victoria Market. It is not the quiet barter of daytime commerce that he expected. Tonight, the market radiates luminous against the winter chill, illuminated by strings of fairy lights and the glow of fire pits. The scents are the first to hit him: the rich spices from the steaming laksa, sweet smoke from grilled takoyaki, and the inviting swirl of mulled wine and spiced Milo in ceramic mugs held tight between gloved hands.

Luxuriating in the sensory overload, he moves deeper into the market. He spots Hungarian chimney cakes next to Malaysian satay, Latin American empanadas beside Turkish gozleme; the diversity of flavour becoming a rare map of the world in itself, condensed into the congested borders of one crowded laneway. At a food stall selling steaming xiaolongbao, an older man smiles at him and nods, the gesture small but genuine. The delicate crows feet of his smile remind him of his grandfather, the passionate twinkle in his eye as he taught the young boy before him, so many moons ago.

Suddenly trapped in the fossilised resin of memory, he remembers his grandfather's parting words to him, "Life isn't just about finding yourself, beta. You must remember to listen to the stories around you." He nods back to the older man, a little bit awkwardly , but finally laden with the understanding that had eluded him prior .

He realises, watching the ebb and flow of the throng, locals and newcomers, laughter and music, old and young, all engaged in the shared act of eating, moving, and breathing as one under the winter light, that belonging is not a singular destination . It is a mosaic of interactions, layered and overlapping, like the rattles on the snake's tail. Distinct segments forming something whole, something enduring .

He leaves the market with nothing in his hands, but a warmth settled somewhere in his throat. A loosening, however slight, of the tight, invisible vice of unfamiliarity.

The next evening, he boards the 4:56 again. The carriage is fuller now, or perhaps he is simply noticing more. A conversation drifts across the aisle, punctuated by laughter. As the train

comes to a grinding halt, someone shifts to make space without being asked . He catches his reflection in the window. It is still there, sullen and superimposed against the speeding city. However, the edges have softened. The distance, though not demolished, has narrowed into something traversable. This is me, he thinks.

"Now arriving at Flinders Street Station..." The train announcer's voice is a worn chime and the station smells like it always does, like piss and sweat and smoke, but this time, he does not flinch . He listens instead, as the city moves with him, no longer a current he moves against , but something he is, slowly, learning how to inhabit.

What made this a 10/10

Every scene threads the stimuli through fresh sensory imagery, recurring motifs, and a quiet, honest voice. That layering is what lifts a Section B piece from competent to top band.

Part

Analysing Argument

Essay Structure

Introduction

What you are trying to achieve

The purpose of an introduction is to 'introduce' both the irrefutable facts about the text you will be analysing, and your interpretation of the text. The best way to do this is to connect the text's plain details with your early analysis of what the contention, tone and intended audience.

Include

- Context and contention
- Details (writer, publication, date and text type)
- Major persuasive devices
- Tone (consistant or shifting)
- Intended audience and how you know this

Revise

A common mistake students make is that they turn their introductions into lists of everything they need to include. Remember to express yourself clearly, professionally and with style. This is the introduction to your analysiss and sets your assesor's expectations for the rest of the piece.

Sentence structure

The first part of your introduction should focus on what issue is being discussed and why it is important. This will help you to create an opening to demonstrate a strong understanding of the article, for example:

> *The current trend of dangerous Tik-Tok challenges has once again sparked debate over whether we should be restricting access to the wildly popular app.*

If we break it down it becomes:

- The current trend - **Phrase of recency**
- of dangerous Tik-tok challenges - **Incident**
- has once again sparked - **Verb phrase**
- debate - **Issue**

Here are some sample sentence builders:

Framing Contemporary Issues in Writing: Phrases of Recency, Cause, and Contention

Phrases of Recency	Verb Phrases	Issues
The latest...	...has once again raised...	issue

Phrases of Recency	Verb Phrases	Issues
The present...	...has sparked...	debate
The recent...	...has led to...	argument
The earlier...	...has motivated...	discussions
The current...	...has caused...	disputes
Once again...	...has generated...	altercation
Recently...	...has engendered...	discourse
Lately...	...has provoked...	consultation
Over the past year...	...has propagated...	dialogue

Key Information Phrase

In this section we should include key information that is usually found in the background information section of the text, including:

- Author's name
- Connection of author to text
- The form of the piece, the date and where it was published
- How this links back to the issue you identified in your first sentence

For example, this sentence can look like:

> *Dr Marko Shellius, CEO of Psychiatric Safe Australia, has written a submission to the parliamentary inquiry into social media, in particular addressing Tik-Tok's burgeoning influence over Australian teens.*

If we break it down, it looks like this:

Authorial Context and Publication Framing for Argument Analysis

Author	Connection of Author to the Issue	Form and Publisher	Link Back to the Issue
Dr Marko Shellius	CEO of Psychiatric Safe Australia	Has written a submission to the parliamentary inquiry on social media	In particular addressing TikTok's burgeoning influence over Australian teens

This order can also be moved around as well:

Form, Author, and Contextual Framing of the Issue

Form and Publisher	Author	Connection of Author to the Issue	Link Back to the Issue
In a written submission to the parliamentary inquiry into social media,	Dr Marko Shellius	CEO of Psychiatric Safe Australia	Addresses TikTok's burgeoning influence over Australian teens

Here are some sentence starters to help build these sentences:

Author Connection, Form of Publication, and Issue Framing Phrases

Connection of Author to Issue	Form and Location	Link to Issue
Chief … of…	has written in/on…	in response to…
Leader of…	has spoken at/in…	addressing…
Instigator…	a blog published…	about…
a writer…	an opinion piece published…	concerning…
an opponent of…	a… newsletter	regarding…
a supporter of…	a speech presented to…	encircling…
a member of…	a debate in front of…	surrounding…
a key…	published a…	acknowledging…
an important…	created a…	responding to…
one of the…		confessing…

Tones

Analysing argument involves understanding how authors use language to persuade their audience. This includes identifying the author's tone, which refers to the overall feeling or attitude conveyed in the text. Recognising shifts in tone is crucial as it often accompanies changes in argument strategies. Authors use tone to appeal to the reader's emotions, establish credibility, and guide the reader's interpretation of the argument.

This is the perfect place for you to show the breadth of your vocabulary. Choose a specific word that relates to the article. Always avoid using the terms 'Positive', 'Negative' and 'Neutral'."

Positive Tone Vocabulary Bank

Amazed	Calm	Appreciative	Affectionate	Amiable
Astonished	Casual	Approving	Benevolent	Amused
Attentive	Collected	Assuring	Compassionate	Cheerful
Curious	Composed	Confident	Concerned	Delighted
Eager	Content	Determined	Considerate	Ecstatic
Interested	Peaceful	Encouraging	Consoling	Elated
Keen	Pleasant	Grateful	Empathetic	Energetic
Polite	Relaxed	Hopeful	Emphatic	Enthusiastic
Startled	Relieved	Inspiring	Friendly	Excited
Stunned	Serene	Optimistic	Loving	Exuberant
Surprised		Pleased	Merciful	Happy
		Promising	Romantic	Humourous
		Proud	Soothing	Jovial

		Respectful	Supportive	Joyful
		Reverent	Sympathetic	Jubilant
		Sanguine	Thoughtful	Playful
		Satisfied		Vibrant
		Thankful		Vivacious

Neutral Tone Vocabulary Bank

Admonitory	Factual	Patriotic
Allusive	Formal	Personal
Authoritative	Frank	Picturesque
Balance	Honest	Questioning
Blunt	Informal	Reflective
Candid	Informative	Reminiscent
Colloquial	Knowledgeable	Resigned
Contemplative	Learned	Scholarly
Controlled	Lyrical	Serious
Conversational	Naïve	Sublime
Discursive	Noble	Virile
Distinct	Nostalgic	
Evocative		
Expectant		

Negative Tone Vocabulary (increasing intensity from left to right)

Negative Tones (increasing intensity from left to right →)			
Negative and passive	**Negative thoughts**	**Negative and uncontrolled**	**Negative and forceful**
Negative and passive	**Negative thoughts**	**Negative and uncontrolled**	**Negative and forceful**
Apathetic	Apologetic	Agitated	Accusing
Bored	Critical	Alarmed	Aggravated
Cold	Doubtful	Anxious	Angry
Dejected	Envious	Apprehensive	Annoyed
Depressed	Foreboding	Defenceless	Belligerent
Despaired	Frustrated	Distressed	Calculating
Disappointed	Gloomy	Disturbed	Condemnatory

Negative Tones (increasing intensity from left to right →)			
Discontented	Guilty	Embarrassed	Condescending
Disinterested	Judgmental	Fearful	Contempt
Dispirited	Pessimistic	Helpless	Disgusted
Gloomy	Regretful	Humiliated	Factious
Hopeless	Remorseful	Mortified	Furious
Hurt	Shameful	Nervous	Harsh
Melancholy	Solemn	Powerless	Hateful
Miserable	Somber	Shocked	Insulting
Regretful	Suspicious	Stressed	Irritated
Sad		Tensed	Manipulative
Upset		Troubled	Outraged
		Uneasy	Quarrelsome
		Vulnerable	Sarcastic
		Worried	Sardonic
			Vexed

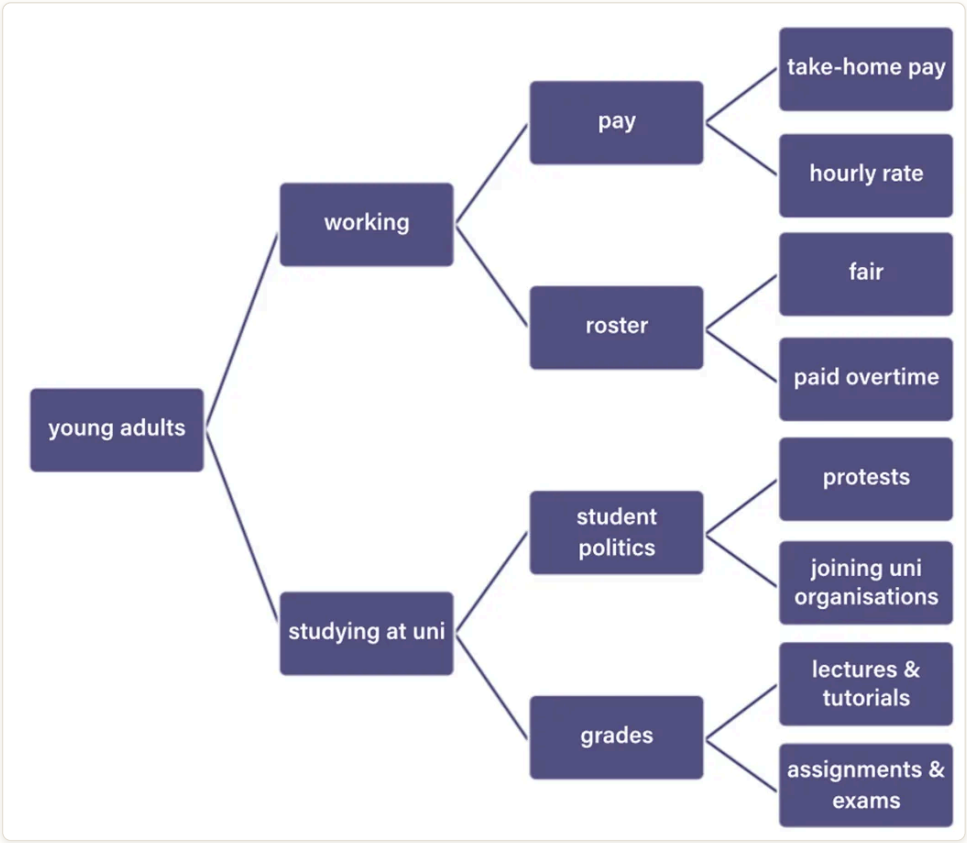
Audience

The audience refers to anyone who is viewing, reading or listening to a text.

When writing an analysing argument essay, it isn't enough to just say your audience is 'everyone' or 'all Australians'. You need to refine your idea of who you are writing for!

Three questions to ask yourself

- What is the author writing about?
- Who would be interested in this topic?
- Is there more than one audience who might be interested in this?



Refining Audience

The key take-away is that you need to be as specific as possible when stating the intended audience.

Body Paragraphs

What you are trying to achieve

Each body paragraph should explore, in sequence, the major arguments that the author uses to support their contention. Remember you are being assessed on your ability to analyse the arguments the author uses and how the language they have chosen supports these.

Step 1: What?

Outline what the author is arguing in your own words. Make a comment on structure; if this is the first or final argument then what is the reason the author introduced this at this time.

Step 2: How?

Begin by identifying the persuasive language features that the author uses to substantiate their argument, include a quote illustrating your point (but no more than 5 words). But this is not enough, then you need to analyse the effectiveness of this approach and discuss how it positions the audience. If there is an image associated with this argument, you should talk about it here - treat it like a persuasive device. Depending on the argument, you may want to talk about how a group of persuasive devices work together.

Note: Try to avoid repetition by constantly stating 'The author uses X which makes the audience feel Y. This can come across tacky and quite robotic. To see examples of how this can

be done in a successful way, look at the three high-scoring essays below.

Step 3: Why?

Finally, you need to infer why the author chose this approach, what is their persuasive intent? How would it appeal to their particular audience? How does it impact the tone of the article? How does this support their contention?

Step 4: Examine (Optional)

Does the tone change for this argument? Does the structure change? How does this position the audience?

Conclusion

What you are trying to achieve

In your conclusion, you are exploring both how the text concludes and wrapping up your analysis at the same time. It is an opportunity to discuss the text as a whole, and emphasises your analytical skills.

Include

- Comment on the structure of the article, including whether there is a consistent or changing tone of writing.
- Focus on the last paragraph of the article, evaluating how it supports the writer's contention.
- Evaluate whether the article developed more trust in the readers and explain why.

Note

Some students find they don't have time for a conclusion. This isn't ideal, but it isn't the end of the world, as most of this information should have been explicit throughout. If you are running short on time, a sentence summarising how each argument leads to the contention is sufficient.

Complex Sentence and Paragraph Building

When analysing persuasive texts, it's not enough to simply spot techniques—you need to explain what is happening, why it's there, and how it affects the audience.

Students often start with short, seperate sentences:

'The writer uses emotive language. This makes the audience feel sympathy'

A stronger version combines ideas into one complex sentence:

'Describing the victims as "cruelly abandoned" evokes a deep sense of sympathy in the audience, prompting them to see the government as neglectful and morally failing in its duty of care.'

Techniques for Stronger Sentences

- Subordinating conjunctions – because, although, while, since, if
- Embedded quotes – weave quotes into the sentence naturally
- Relative clauses – who, which, that

- Appositives – a technique aimed at…

By applying these sentence-building tools, your analysis will become more precise, connected, and persuasive—mirroring the sophistication expected in high-level responses.

To help you identify and discuss these elements in a clear, structured way, we will now look at a step-by-step framework that breaks persuasive writing into its key components.

W.A.S.T.E.: F.A.T.!

This acronym is designed to assist you in crafting complex and sophisticated sentences that strengthen your analytical writing. In higher-scoring essays, writers deliberately weave these elements into their work to add depth, clarity, and precision. While it is not necessary to include every element in every individual sentence, you should aim to integrate all of them across the body of your essay. This means that, by the end of each body paragraph, the reader should be able to identify how you have employed these elements to develop your argument, enhance your expression, and engage the audience effectively. Consistent and purposeful use of these techniques will not only improve sentence complexity but also demonstrate a mature and well-structured writing style.

- **W**ords – Focus on the most persuasive words or phrases of the piece.
- **A**rgument – What is the supporting argument of each section?
- **S**tructure – Where is this located in the piece and why?
- **T**one – How does the author apply tone to be more persuasive in each section?
- **E**ffect upon the audience – How does it position the audience to:
    - **F**eel?
    - **A**ct?
    - **T**hink?

W.A.S.T.E.: F.A.T. Medium Example

The editorial uses emotionally charged words such as "climate catastrophe", "tipping point", and "irreversible damage" to stress the seriousness of the issue. The supporting argument is that urgent government action is necessary to prevent catastrophic environmental collapse. These phrases appear in the introduction so that the reader is immediately confronted with the scale of the problem. The author adopts an alarmist and urgent tone to heighten concern and prompt immediate attention. This positions the audience to feel fear and anxiety about the future, to act by pressuring politicians or signing petitions, and to think that if society does not act now, it will be too late.

W.A.S.T.E.: F.A.T. High Example

The editorial uses emotive phrases such as "climate catastrophe", "tipping point", and "irreversible damage" in its introduction to immediately confront the reader with the scale of the problem. By presenting the argument that urgent government action is needed to prevent environmental collapse, the writer establishes the issue as both pressing and unavoidable. Through an alarmist and urgent tone, the piece positions the audience to feel

fear, act by pressuring politicians or signing petitions, and think that immediate intervention is essential.

Fill-in-the-blanks Analysing Argument Template for an Introduction

Your introduction should discuss the writer's contention and intention, the specific audience, the form, and the publication details, as well as the context of the issue. You might like to make a comment about the tone of the piece in the introduction.

Here is a sample introduction structure:

The issue of ..... (issue) was addressed in a ..... (text type) for ..... (publication) on ..... (date). ..... (Author) contends, in a ..... (tonal word) and at times ..... (tonal word) voice that ..... (contention). The piece is predominantly ..... (words about overall structure or style) in style, and seeks to position its ..... (audience) to accept ..... (intention).

Another sample introduction structure could look like this:

Following ..... (context), debate resurfaced regarding ..... (issue). In a ..... (text type) for ..... (publication) on ..... (date), ... (author) argues in a ..... (tonal word) and ..... (tonal word) fashion that ..... (contention), and seeks to ..... (intention). The piece, targeted at ..... (audience), ...

For example:

In the wake of the recent sentencing of murderer John Smith, Sarah Farah's letter to the editor of The Daily Telegraph (9 June 2014), raises the issue of perceived injustice in the treatment of Australian citizens. In an aggressive tone, she contends that the penalty imposed on this man was too harsh and that such punishment represents a form of anti Australian discrimination. Thus, she hopes to prompt the Australian Government to take action to protect its citizens.

Reading the Background and Mapping the Argument

Section C tests three skills applied to a text you have never seen: inferential reading, analytical thinking and clear expression. The text itself is deliberately easy to comprehend. What is hard is reading it *inferentially*.

What You Already Know About Persuasion

Persuasion happens when a reader trusts the writer, sees the issue from a new angle, believes they share the writer's values, and understands what part they will play in the proposal. So in every text you can expect the writer, at some point, to:

- establish their credibility;
- present the status quo as needing change (or as worth protecting);
- reframe how the reader understands the issue;
- present the proposal as consistent with the reader's values;
- show how it serves both the individual and the common good.

You do not know *how* they will do these things. That is what you discover.

Comprehension Is Not Enough

Comprehension questions (Who wrote it? How long has the event run?) are Year 7 tasks. Inferential questions are yours:

- **Who is persuading whom, of what?**
- **What do these readers believe and value?** Infer it from the publication, the community and the history given.
- **What is the writer's relationship to the issue?** An unaligned "local resident" seems impartial and credible. The chair of an organisation that will close has a stake and must work harder against suspicion.
- **What are the stakes?** Asking readers to "consider" change one day is low stakes. Asking them to vote tonight for something they dislike is high stakes, and the writer's strategy will reflect that.

State these findings briefly in your introduction, so you can draw on them throughout.

Two Recent Contrasts

- **2025:** a resident proposes that a regional town replace a 50-year fireworks tradition with a light show. Tradition is comforting and change is hard, so he spends most of the piece building a case for change, and the stakes are low ("some time in the future").
- **2024:** the chair of a struggling community gym proposes leasing the foyer to a lolly shop. Her readers built the gym for health, so the proposal clashes with their values, and she needs a vote. High stakes, invested speaker.

How Arguments Open

Openings are strategic building blocks. Three common moves (not the only ones):

- outline a situation and frame it as a problem the writer will solve;
- establish the writer's credibility first, so later claims are trusted;
- establish shared values first, so the reader feels on the same side.

A writer who wants a tradition abandoned may open by praising it. That is not a contradiction: shared affection earns the trust needed for what comes after the *but*.

Watch the Hinge Words

But, *however*, *yet*, *until*: what follows a hinge is usually the writer's real point. Mark every hinge as you read. They often reveal the argument's structure, for example a repeated pattern of problem, hinge, then a better alternative.

Explain the Sequence, Do Not Just List It

"Then", "next" and "second" only order the argument. Explain the link instead.

- **Weak:** Next, the writer reframes the status quo as problematic and uses targeted examples to make the audience see the situation differently.
- **Strong:** Having established shared values with his readers, the writer turns those same values against the fireworks, moving systematically through care for the environment, fairness to vulnerable residents, the welfare of pets and economic responsibility. This relentless return to the readers' own values makes change seem not a loss but the only choice consistent with who they are.

Choose the Most Powerful Techniques

Almost every persuasive text appeals to values, characterises its subjects positively or negatively, and compares the favoured option with the alternative. Beyond those, techniques vary each year. You cannot analyse everything, so choose the elements used most powerfully in *this* text, whether common or unusual. A popular technique such as inclusive pronouns may be the least important thing on the page.

Pace Yourself Through the Text

A common error is spending too long on the opening and running out of time before the argument's turn or conclusion. Plan your selections across the whole text before you write.

Analyse the Example, Not the Technique

"The writer uses statistics to support their view. This gives the argument credibility" would fit any text, so it analyses nothing. Analyse *this* example: "Citing figures from the AMA implies thorough research, and the before-and-after comparison, showing participation doubled, presents the intervention as clearly effective." If your analysis of an example takes only a sentence, check that you are explaining the example rather than defining the technique.

What, How, Why

Every analytical point needs three parts: **what** the writer is doing, **how** (the specific words or image), and **why** these readers, with these values, are likely to respond. Summarising what was said is the "what" alone. It is not wrong, but it is incomplete. As you improve, the three parts can merge in a single fluent sentence; the bulk of a strong paragraph is the how and the why.

The Visual

- **Describe versus explain.** "The image shows a small dog hiding under a sheet" is description. Explaining shows how the dog's small size and cowering posture amplify the written claim that pets are innocent and vulnerable.
- **Analyse it where it belongs.** The visual is part of the text. Analyse it alongside the argument it supports, so you show how it is integrated. Tacking it on at the end shows less skill, but is far better than forgetting it.
- **Tick it off.** Put a tick beside the visual in the task book once you have written about it.

Do Not Evaluate

The specifications state you are not required to evaluate whether the argument succeeds. Judgements such as "this is effective" waste time and earn nothing. Explain how the persuasion works and why the intended readers would respond, not how people in general would respond.

Analysing Written Language

Terms and Strategies

Specific Word Choice (word connotation)

Writers choose particular words to provoke an emotional reaction in the reader or emphasise an idea.

For example, if writing about abortion, the author may choose; "I read with disgust that the government is to ... kill, slay, slaughter, murder, butcher, exterminate, destroy, sacrifice, execute ... Emotive language is language that is not logical or rational - it reflects and expresses an emotional or subjective reaction. Such words help create mood. Many words have connotations or associations that the writer uses with deliberate intent to create a desired effect in the reader. Words may have positive or negative connotations. They may evoke intense imagery. You will be expected to discuss some targeted words and their relative connotations in your language analysis piece.

Particular language structure and features

Inclusive language (we, our) may be used to give the audience a sense of being part of a wider community of thought/action.

Modifiers and qualifiers are words used to denote a level of impact. There is a difference between a writer choosing to use ‘some’ instead of ‘all’ or ‘most’ instead of ‘many’. Phrases such as ‘very good’ or ‘basically good’ also suggest different meaning to the reader. Students analysing language need to consider why specific lexical strings have been chosen by the writer as a form of persuasion.

Euphemisms

Euphemisms are words sometimes used to soften a more accurate but seemingly more offensive word or phrase. For example, euphemisms for ‘die’ include; passed away, lose one’s life, kick the bucket, croak. A company may say they are ‘downsizing’ instead offiring workers from the job.

Hypothetical Scenarios

Hypothetical scenarios are used to prompt the reader to imagine possible outcomes, often beginning with phrases like *“Imagine if…”*. These speculative examples draw attention to the consequences of actions or inactions, even if they are not real or likely. Writers use this technique to provoke reflection and emotional investment from the reader.

For example: *“Imagine if the world was ruled by tyrants who dominated our every thought daily…”*

Repetition

Repetition involves deliberately repeating words or phrases for emphasis and to make an idea more memorable.

Anaphora: repetition at the start of successive clauses.

e.g. School is distracting. School is boring. School sucks.

Epistrophe: repetition at the end of clauses.

e.g. Follow the rules. Obey the rules. These are the rules.

Puns

Puns are humorous wordplays based on similar sounds or multiple meanings. They are often used to lighten tone or ridicule opposing views. Some puns also carry double meanings, especially in persuasive or satirical writing.

e.g. "Time flies like an arrow; fruit flies like a banana."

Irony

Irony occurs when the intended meaning of a statement contrasts with its literal meaning. Writers often use irony to highlight absurdities or criticise ideas indirectly.

e.g. "Lovely day," said during a storm.

Sarcasm

Sarcasm is a biting, mocking form of expression usually intended to hurt, ridicule, or convey contempt. It often overlaps with irony but has a more cutting tone.

e.g. "Nice face. Shame about the rest."

Exaggeration / Hyperbole

This technique involves overstating a point for dramatic effect. It can be used to emphasise importance or provoke an emotional response.

e.g. "I'd rather cut off my arm than go back to work under those conditions!"

Humour

Humour engages the reader by entertaining them. It can also make controversial ideas more palatable or draw attention to flaws in opposing arguments.

It is often used as a non-threatening way to critique.

Satire

Satire combines humour and criticism to ridicule individuals, institutions, or ideas. It often exposes hypocrisy or absurdity, making serious points in a humorous way.

e.g. A TV show like Frontline that uses mock-journalism to critique the media.

Oxymoron

An oxymoron combines two contradictory terms to highlight contrast or provoke thought. It is often used to emphasise complexity or irony.

e.g. deafening silence, wise fool, bitter sweet

Assonance

Assonance is the repetition of vowel sounds within words or phrases to create rhythm, mood, or emphasis. Often used poetically or in slogans.

e.g. "cool, calm and collected"

Simile

A simile compares one thing with another using the words *'like'* or *'as'*. It helps readers understand unfamiliar concepts by likening them to familiar ones, often to create vivid imagery.

e.g. My bedroom is like a pigsty. She is as skinny as a rake.

Metaphor

A metaphor is an implied comparison that states one thing is another, thereby transferring qualities from one to the other. Metaphors can make writing more persuasive by enhancing imagery and emotional appeal.

e.g. I stepped into my pigsty, shut the door and climbed into bed. He is a pillar of strength.

Rhetorical Questions

These are questions posed for effect rather than to elicit an answer. They imply that the answer is self-evident, guiding the audience to agree with the writer's point.

e.g. Do you want to see your wife and children out on the streets in rags? Of course you don't!

Scapegoats

A scapegoat is a person or group blamed for something they are not truly responsible for. This technique simplifies complex issues and focuses the reader's anger on a convenient target.

e.g. All our crime and unemployment problems are because of the government.

Assumptions

Assumptions involve treating beliefs or opinions as facts without proof. These are often subtle and can influence readers by appealing to what is generally believed to be true.

e.g. He must be smart because he is on the computer every day.

Presumptions

Presumptions occur when statements are accepted as truths without critical examination. They appeal to common beliefs or cultural norms.

e.g. If it's natural, it's good for you.

Analogy

An analogy compares two things that are alike in some respects to clarify a point or persuade readers that what applies to one must apply to the other.

e.g. If birds can fly because they have wings, then maybe if we develop mechanical wings we can fly too.

e.g. The human brain is like a computer.

Expert Opinion

This technique involves citing someone perceived to have authority or expertise on a topic. It lends credibility to an argument and can be persuasive even if the “expert” is unnamed.

e.g. In the thirty-five years I was Head Surgeon at…

Case Studies and Anecdotes

Case studies and anecdotes are used to personalise or humanise an argument. Anecdotes are usually emotive and personal; case studies more formal and factual. Both aim to build credibility and emotional appeal.

e.g. Pool fencing should be mandatory because my neighbour’s child drowned in an unfenced pool.

Empty Truths

Also known as tautologies, these are statements that repeat the same idea unnecessarily, often sounding meaningful but lacking substance.

e.g. Boys will be boys. Enough is enough. Business is business.

Cause and Effect

This technique suggests that one event directly causes another. It is persuasive because it offers logical explanation, though causality may not always be valid.

e.g. Peter crashed his car. Peter died.

Ends and Means / Means to an End

This approach justifies an action based on the outcome, even if the action itself is questionable.

e.g. A criminal donates to a playground; the donation is good, but the source of funds is illegal.

Consequence of a Fact

This presents a pragmatic response to an existing situation by arguing that something should be done simply because a condition exists.

e.g. Nuclear power exists, so we might as well use it.

Judging an Action by its Consequences

This technique justifies or condemns an action based on its results. It focuses on outcomes rather than intent.

e.g. Stealing from the rich to give to the poor is acceptable because the poor are hungry.

Sweeping Statements / Generalisations

These make broad claims that apply to a group without considering individual differences. Generalisations can sound convincing but often oversimplify.

e.g. All teenagers are irresponsible.

Cliché

Clichés are overused phrases that offer familiar shortcuts to meaning. Though persuasive due to their recognisability, they can also weaken writing if not used purposefully.

e.g. What goes around comes around.

Co-existence

This assumes an automatic relationship between ideas or traits, such as assuming someone is good simply because they attend church.

e.g. She goes to the local church, so she must be a good person.

Guilt by Association

This technique links people, ideas or groups with undesirable individuals or arguments in order to discredit them.

e.g. Premier Kennett has behaved like Hitler since coming to power.

Questioning Motive

This involves undermining an argument by questioning the motives of the speaker, diverting attention away from the argument itself.

e.g. The Health Minister's decision to close the hospital is just an excuse to build a monument to himself.

Figures and Statistics

Numbers and data are used to give the illusion of objectivity and reliability. However, the reader must critically assess source, sample size, relevance, and interpretation.

e.g. 300 people died on our roads last year…

Discredit Another Argument

This technique aims to dismantle opposing viewpoints by exposing flaws or inconsistencies in them. It draws attention away from the original argument and weakens the opposing side's credibility.

Attack

This technique involves criticising or mocking opposing arguments or individuals. It is designed to weaken the opposition's credibility and make their position less persuasive. Writers may use name-calling, ridicule, or other personal attacks to influence the audience's perception.

One form of attack is labelling the opposition in an attempt to belittle them.

Flattery and Praise

This technique involves listing individuals or groups who agree with the writer's position in a positive light. By using terms that convey admiration or respect, the writer bolsters the authority of their own argument.

e.g. "Leading scientists support this research."

Use of Punctuation and Printing Style

Writers use punctuation and formatting deliberately to add emphasis, create subtext, or manipulate tone and flow.

Common strategies include:

- Inverted commas – suggest doubt or irony, even when quoting.
- Exclamation marks – show emotional emphasis or urgency.
- Dashes – indicate pauses, hesitation or parenthetical ideas.
- Long sentences – may signal sophistication or rambling.
- Short sentences – create punch, pace and immediacy.
- Italics, CAPITALISATION, **bold**, *underlining* – all used for emphasis.

Vocabulary Use

The choice of vocabulary significantly affects tone and credibility. Writers use sophisticated or precise word choice to sound more authoritative or to target specific reader emotions.
Students should be aware of:

- Emotive connotations (e.g. *slaughter* vs *kill*)
- Word strength and subtlety (e.g. *sporadic* vs *occasional*)
- Replacing vague or weak terms with more accurate or academic language.

Improving vocabulary can enhance clarity and persuasiveness. For example:

- Replace “straight away” with “immediately”
- Replace “in the next paragraph” with “in the following section”
- Replace “always” with “consistently”

Table of Common Persuasive Techniques

Persuasive Techniques Reference Table

Persuasive Technique	Definition	How It Persuades
Adjective	Describing words usually connected to a noun (naming word). e.g. *The bright red house* (bright and red = adjectives; house = noun)	Adds emphasis.
Alliteration	Repeating and playing upon the same letter. e.g. *A back-breaking job...*	Adds emphasis and reinforces meaning, especially where an idea is repeated. Often used to create a highly emotive image.
Anecdote	A short account or story of an entertaining or interesting incident. e.g. *In my experience...*	Usually makes reader sympathetic and receptive to the point; can set up a character, then position reader to accept or reject that individual character.
Associations	Words that create meanings beyond the literal meaning of the word.	Suggests or influences reader response in certain ways, often subconsciously. Implied meanings need to be

Persuasive Technique	Definition	How It Persuades
	e.g. *attractive, alluring, pleasing, charming*	identified.
Attacks/praise	The writer attacks or praises an opponent or idea. This is really an assertion of the writer's viewpoint. e.g. *denigrating or humiliating the person, discrediting opponents as unreliable, dishonest, suggesting unsatisfactory associations*	Often effective in placing the reader in a position of agreement with the writer/speaker through forceful language and insistent claims, even without evidence.
Bias	One-sidedness in presentation of view/opinion. e.g. *Eminem's tour promoter obviously sees no danger in what Eminem says.*	Can subjectively influence the reader by intentionally only presenting one side of the argument.
Clichés	Worn out, overused expressions. e.g. *Fit as a fiddle, Turn over a new leaf, Pushing the envelope*	Are familiar, often colloquial, so can offer a shortcut to convey meaning.
Colourful words and descriptive language	Words that are heightened, vivid, lively, and full of interest. e.g. *Hot = blistering, sultry, muggy, suffocating...*	Produce a picture and/or induce an emotion. Engage reader by gaining attention and often put a new slant on familiar events and issues.
Contention	The main line of argument in a text. A statement of the main idea being argued or debated. Focuses on WHAT is being argued.	Pinpoints the issue and the writer's point of view. Helps the reader identify the issue and evaluate the techniques used to persuade them to agree.
Emotional Appeals	Play on people's emotions such as fears, insecurities, hopes, desires, and values. Can target: • A sense of justice or injustice • Family values • Tradition or custom • Patriotism • Moral values	Frequently appeal to our values and attitudes, sometimes subtly. Can manipulate reader to take notice of issues by triggering emotional responses.
Emotive Language	The deliberate use of strong emotive words to play on reader's feelings. e.g. *sleazy, slimy, vicious, disgusting, outrageous*	Evokes strong emotional response to coerce or force agreement. Used to stimulate strong emotional reactions and manipulate responses.
Loaded Words (Labelling)	Words that are loaded with associations. e.g. *capitalist, communist, salesman*	Shorthand way of discrediting or praising by suggesting associations. Exploits emotional baggage of such words to sway opinion.
Repetition	Repeated words, phrases, sentence patterns, ideas.	Gives emphasis and prominence to a point or idea; reinforces and makes reader remember the point.
Rhetorical Questions	Questions that have the answer embedded in them; often use irony.	Manipulate the reader to agree because the answer is assumed. Disagreement would mean dismissing a point that commands agreement.
Tone	Refers to the voice of the writer; the writer's attitude to the subject and reader. Tone can be emotive. e.g. *angry, sympathetic, sarcastic*	Reflects writer's attitude, which can influence the reader to agree or reject. Tone can signal a new direction or perspective in the writing.

Table of Verbs for Authorial Intent

Verbs Indicating Authorial Intent

Positive Verbs	Neutral Verbs (“say”, “suggest”)	Subtle Verbs (“imply”, “elicit”)	Negative Verbs
Encourage	Suggest	Insinuate	Condemn
Endorse	Foreground	Reveal	Criticise
Support	Emphasise	Illuminate	Critique
Laud	Highlight	Hint	Attack
Celebrate	Illustrate	Infer	Undermine
Extol	Delineate	Intimate	Contest
Inspire	Showcase	Allude	Refute
Praise	Underscore	Elucidate	Provoke
Applaud	Explore	Evoke	Galvanise
Commend	Express	Engender	Vilify
Venerate	Assert	Invite	Disparage
Glorify	Demonstrate	Induce	Belittle
Elevate	Propose	Explicate	Scorn
Bolster	Announce	Interpret	Censure
Exalt	Declare	Clarify	Castigate
Glamorise	Portray	Exemplify	Reprimand
Reinforce	Depict	Characterise	Harangue
–	Convey	Resolve	Denigrate

Table of Adjectives Describing Tone

Tone Reference Table

Happy Tones	Sad Tones	Angry Tones	Humorous Tones	Neutral Tones
Light-hearted	Disappointed	Accusatory	Satirical	Formal
Hopeful	Shameful	Condescending	Cynical	Matter-of-fact
Elated	Resigned	Aggressive	Taunting	Informative
Enthusiastic	Sympathetic	Disgusted	Facetious	Reflective
Optimistic	Bleak	Incredulous	Amused	Contemplative
Encouraging	Sombre	Demeaning	Animated	Apprehensive

Table of Linking Words and Phrases

Linking Words and Phrases Reference Table

Points of Comparison	Points of Difference	Points of Causality
Also	Conflictingly	Consequently
Likewise	In contrast	As a result
Equally	Contrastingly	Because of this
Synonymously	Contrarily	Thus
Analogously	Unlike	Hence
Akin	Nonetheless	Therefore
Just as	A point of disparity	Ultimately
So too	Conversely	Inevitably
Similarly	Counter to	Accordingly
Furthermore	Contradictorily to	Ergo
Moreover	Opposed to	As a consequence
In the same sense	Inversely	This leads to
–	Alternatively	In turn
–	However	In light of this
–	Although	Given that
–	On the other hand	Since
–	Despite this	This culminates
Yet	–	This foreshadows
Whereas	–	For that reason
Incongruously	–	This is a repercussion of

Persuasive Techniques Reference (printable)

The full reference table — techniques, definitions, examples and intended effects — as a document you can view or print.

Analysing Visual Language

Many students find the analysis of images an accessible and enjoyable part of Year 12 English. It is important, however, to prepare for a variety of visual elements that may appear on your Unit 3 SAC task on analysing argument, as well as on Section C of the end-of-year examination. Below are some elements to keep an eye out for.

Context and Position

In order to fully understand the meaning of the visual elements in a text, you need to understand the context. Be sure to read any background information accompanying the task so that you know what the main issue is. Both the background information and the written material will help give you a sense of the visual's purpose.

Remember that the focus of Area of Study 2 in the Unit 3 SAC and in Section C of the exam is on the analysis of argument. Noticing where and why a visual element is placed in the written piece can help you to tackle the idea of how the argument is structured.

- Is the visual at the start of the article to elicit empathy or shock?
- Is it in the middle to reinforce a particular piece of evidence or reason?
- Is it at the end to consolidate the argument as a whole?
- Is it a frame or border to the written piece that contributes to the overall approach and tone?
- Alternatively, if the visual is a completely separate text from the written piece, does it present the same or a different point of view on the issue?

Ask yourself: where is the visual positioned and why does it matter?

Colour and Design Elements

Although the task material for Section C of the exam will be printed in black and white, your Unit 3 SAC might well contain colour images. If this is the case, you can certainly explore the mood that is created by the use of colour, as well as any relevant connotations of the colour scheme. In a black-and-white image it is possible to discuss degrees of shading and how these affect meaning.

It is important to remember that visual language can pertain to design elements in the text you are analysing. For example, in the task material for Section C of the VCAA sample exam the speaker's first slide has illustrations incorporated into the year '2010'. The embedded images of fish, a flamingo, waves, a tree, and an adult and child holding hands help to promote the speaker's arguments about the beauty of biodiversity and humanity's central involvement in its protection.

Also be alert to the design elements of internet text types such as web pages and blogs. You can, for example, discuss the use of icons, how they position the viewer and the symbolism embedded in them.

Ask yourself: how do design elements, colour and/or shading of the visual contribute to its meaning?



1. The colours are relatively bright considering the seriousness of the issue. This is an example of how a cartoonist can engage an audience through colour and light, making a complex or confronting issue more accessible.
2. The text in the speech bubbles uses irony to comment on how the army tank is affecting the petrol tank.
3. The placement and size of the tank immediately draws the eye to it; the car and the petrol bowser are less prominent. This could be a comment on the scale of the effects the conflict was having on the world at this time.
4. The large, rugged tank is juxtaposed with the small, bright blue car. This contrast may reflect the serious nature of the war and what the soldiers are enduring, in comparison to the everyday lives of people far from the conflict.
5. The tank has driven over the fuel hose, providing a metaphor for the way in which the Ukrainian conflict is creating difficulties for people in Australia.

Insight Example Image Analysis

Cartoons

Cartoons often accompany an opinion piece; they can also be stand-alone texts offering a viewpoint on a current issue – especially one that involves politicians or high-profile figures. To understand a cartoon it can be important to have an understanding of the issues circulating in the media in any given week. As I write, there are two quite different cartoons in The Age and The Australian that contain an image of a whiteboard, among other elements. To make sense of both cartoons, a reader would need to know that earlier in the week security guards in Parliament House used a whiteboard to shield a politician from photographers and journalists.

Without this knowledge it would be difficult, if not impossible, to interpret the cartoons. Try to stay informed about current affairs as you practise analysing media texts, so that you can grasp their full meanings.

Cartoons tend to exaggerate the features of those they represent and use minimal – often quite pithy – text. Be mindful of where this text is: does it appear in a speech bubble or balloon and therefore represent a person's thoughts or speech? Or is the text elsewhere – on a sign, say, or framed as a caption – providing additional context or comment?

The tone of a cartoon is an important feature to note. Political cartoons in particular are often sarcastic and position the reader to be critical of politicians and/or their views and policies.

Ask yourself: how does the cartoon make me feel? Your response will give you a guide to the tone of this visual.

Photographs

Photographs can provide a wealth of material for analysis. Look for a range of elements, including:

- whether the shot is low-angle (looking up at the subject), high-angle (looking down on the subject) or straight-on – for example, a low-angle shot of a child might give the impression that they have been able to overcome adversity and achieve success, whereas a high-angle shot might suggest that a person is vulnerable or remorseful
- whether the subject is in the foreground (making them very prominent) or background (emphasising their context)
- whether elements of the photograph are blurred or in soft focus
- whether a filter (e.g. warm or cool) is used
- where the horizon is placed in a landscape shot (e.g. far away can signal isolation or opportunity)
- what is actually in the frame (mise en scène) and what might have been left out
- whether a text overlay has been used and how that frames your reading of the photograph.

Ask yourself: What would the impact be if I changed an element of the photograph (e.g. camera angle or focus)? Answering this question will give you better insight into what the photograph is intending to achieve.

Charts and Diagrams

Charts and diagrams containing numerical information can be used to present evidence. Although you are not in a position to question the data, you can explore how the information and its visual presentation are used to strengthen and develop an argument. It is good to watch for:

- what the visual elements suggest and how they connect to each other
- whether a background image can be seen beneath a written overlay (e.g. an image of a gun beneath statistics about the number of deaths caused by shooting)

- whether data is attributed to an authority (such as the Australian Bureau of Statistics). Sometimes charts and diagrams can look dry and intimidating.

Ask yourself:how does the information relate to the written text or texts? Does it support or contradict a written text and, if so, how?

Concluding Remarks

For the Exam, it is imperative that you compare the written and visual material supplied. It is also wise to compare the written and visual texts in the examination. Comparing written and visual material in terms of the arguments they present and the ways in which they position the audience will give your analysis more depth and cohesion, and demonstrate a stronger understanding of each.



Section C image from 2024 VCAA English Exam

Practice Articles for Analysis

Four practice tasks in the format of Section C of the English exam. Each one has its own instructions, task and background information, followed by the persuasive text and its visual. Allow about an hour for each: roughly five minutes planning, 50 minutes writing and five minutes proofreading. The people, places, publications and survey figures in these tasks are fictional.

Scenario 1: Backyard hens

Section C – Analysis of argument and language

Instructions

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Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s), written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material below to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background information

The Greenhill Gazette is a free monthly newsletter that is delivered to every home in the small country town of Greenhill. Local clubs and community groups often use the newsletter to share news and information with residents. The following article was written by Margaret Kovac, who has been the secretary of the Greenhill Poultry Club for more than ten years.

Before you bring home the girls: a few honest words about backyard hens



By Margaret Kovac

Over the last few years it seems like every second backyard in Greenhill has a chook pen in it. When I joined the Greenhill Poultry Club eleven years ago, we had nine members and most of us had grey hair. Today we have over sixty, and plenty of them are young families who have never looked after anything bigger than a goldfish. I think that's wonderful. I also think it's time someone said a few things that don't make it into the lovely photos on Instagram.

First, the good news. Hens are funny, friendly little creatures, and they'll happily follow you around the garden in case you've got something for them. A healthy hen will give you four or five eggs a week in her best years, and there is nothing quite like a fresh egg with a deep orange yolk on a Sunday morning. Hens will eat your vegetable scraps (which means less going in the bin), scratch out the weeds and turn the whole lot into some of the best fertiliser you'll ever put on your garden. Kids love them. So do grandparents.

So what's the catch?

A chook is not a kitchen appliance

I've lost count of the number of times someone has rung me in March asking if the club can 'take' their hens. Usually the story is the same. The family bought three young pullets in spring, the kids named them, everyone was very excited – and then winter came, the eggs slowed down and suddenly nobody wanted to go out to the pen at six o'clock in the dark and the rain.

Here's something those videos don't tell you: a hen can live for eight years or more, but most only lay well for the first two or three. After that you have a pet that eats, needs cleaning up after and gives you very little back. If you aren't prepared to look after her for the long haul, please don't get her in the first place. Just like a dog, a hen is a commitment, not a weekend project.

Do your homework

Before you buy anything, ring Greenhill Shire Council or have a look at their website. There are rules about how many birds you can keep (in most residential streets here the limit is six), how far the pen has to be from your neighbour's fence and, yes, roosters are a firm no in town. Nobody wants to be the reason the whole street gets woken up at 4.45 am.

You'll also need to think about:

- a proper fox-proof pen with a roof (foxes are out at dusk and they are a lot cleverer than you'd think)
- somewhere dry and sealed for the feed, because if you leave pellets lying around you'll soon have rats as well as chickens
- who will feed and water them when you go away at Christmas
- what happens when one of them gets sick – and they do.

Not many vets in our area will see poultry, so it pays to find out which ones do before you need them.

What will it really cost?

People often tell me they're getting chooks to save money on eggs. I hate to be the one to break it to you, but that's not how it works – at least not at first. A decent fox-proof coop will set you back anywhere from $400 to well over $1000 (the cheap flat-pack ones from online shops tend to fall apart after a winter or two – ask me how I know). Then there's the feeder, the waterer, straw or wood shavings for bedding, worming and lice treatments, and of course the feed itself. Three hens will get through a 20-kilogram bag of layer pellets about every five or six weeks, and that's around $35 a bag at the produce store on Main Street at the moment.

When one of our members, Danny, sat down and did the sums on his first year, he worked out that each of his eggs had cost him about $1.40. He had a good laugh about it at our March meeting, and to be fair to Danny, he still says it's the best money he's ever spent. But go in knowing the numbers.

Have a word with the neighbours

This one costs nothing at all. Before the pen goes up, pop next door and let them know what you're planning. Most people are happy to have hens nearby, especially if there's the odd half-dozen eggs coming their way over the fence. What they don't like is finding out from the smell on a hot day in January.

Keep it clean

Chickens can carry salmonella even when they look perfectly healthy. That doesn't mean you should panic, but it does mean washing your hands every time you've handled them or their eggs, keeping the pen away from where little ones play and not letting the birds wander through the kitchen (I've seen it happen!). Cuddling is fine. Kissing is not.

The rewards are real

I don't want to put anyone off. Some of my happiest hours are spent sitting on an upturned bucket with a cup of tea, watching my girls have a dust bath in the sun. My granddaughter collects the eggs every Saturday and writes the totals on a chart on our fridge – last year we got to 1104. Keeping hens has taught her more about where her food comes from than any school excursion ever could.

But the families who get the most out of it are the ones who go in with their eyes open. They've done the planning, they've spent a bit more on a good pen than they really wanted to, and they know what they're signing up for.

Come and have a chat

If you're thinking about getting hens, the Greenhill Poultry Club meets on the first Sunday of every month at the Scout Hall on Pine Street from 10 am. Bring your questions, have a look at some of our members' set-ups and maybe even hold a chook or two before you make up your mind. Membership is $20 a year and the scones are free.

Do it once and do it right – your hens will thank you for it.

Scenario 2: Mending, not hauling

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Background information

Buying second-hand clothes from op shops and online marketplaces has become very popular, and many people share videos of their 'hauls' (large amounts of clothing bought in one trip) on social media. Second Stitch is a small clothing repair and alterations studio in the coastal town of Kestrel Bay. Its owner, Jonah Petrakis, posts short videos about mending clothes and has a large online following. The text below is the transcript of one of his videos. The image is the video's thumbnail.



Why your thrift haul might be part of the problem

Second Stitch

Hey everyone, Jonah here from Second Stitch. Before we get into today's video, can I just say thank you – we hit 40,000 followers last week, which is honestly a bit mad for a guy who sews patches onto jeans in a shop the size of a garage. So, thank you.

Okay. Today I want to talk about something that's been bugging me for a while, and I know some of you aren't going to love it.

Hauls.

You know the videos. Someone goes to the op shop, or onto one of the second-hand apps, and comes home with five or six bags of stuff. They hold everything up to the camera one at a time and say, 'I don't know if I'll actually wear this, but it was only five dollars!' And everyone in the comments goes, 'Love this, so sustainable!'

I used to make those videos. I'm not going to pretend I didn't.

But here's what changed my mind. About a year ago a woman came into the shop with a coat. A beautiful old wool coat that had belonged to her dad – probably fifty years old. One of the pockets had ripped away and the lining was gone at the elbows. It took me about three hours to fix, and when she picked it up she cried. Actually cried. And I remember thinking, when was the last time anything in one of my hauls made somebody feel like that?

Look, second-hand is better than new. I'm not arguing with that. Every piece of clothing that gets worn again is one less that ends up in landfill, and one less that has to be made from scratch with all the water and energy and dye that goes into it. But buying second-hand in bulk is still buying in bulk. If the clothes come home, get worn once for the video and then go back in a bag to the charity bin, we haven't really changed anything. We've just made fast fashion a little bit slower.

And the op shops know it. I spoke to a volunteer at one of the big charity shops in town (she asked me not to say which one) and she told me they now have to throw out a huge amount of what gets donated because it's ripped, stained or just too cheaply made to sell. A lot of it was only bought a few months ago. Some of it still has the tags on.

I ran a quick poll on my stories last week and, I'll be honest, the results surprised me. I asked how many of you had bought something second-hand in the last month and never worn it. Just over half of you said yes. Fifty-three per cent! And I'm guessing a few more of you weren't game to admit it.

A lot of you also sent me messages after my last video, and one question kept coming up, so I want to answer it properly. It came from a follower called Tash, who said – and I'm quoting here – 'Easy for you to say, you can sew. I can't afford to pay someone forty bucks to fix a $10 shirt.'

Tash, that's fair. Really, it is. Not everything is worth fixing, and I would never tell anyone to spend money they don't have. But a few things. First, most repairs are a lot cheaper than people think – a button or a small tear is usually under

ten dollars at my shop, and I'm not the cheapest in town. Second, if a $10 shirt isn't worth fixing, maybe it wasn't worth buying either? I know, I know. That one stings a bit. And third, you don't have to pay anyone at all if you learn to do it yourself, which brings me to the actual point of this video.

So what do I actually want you to do? Three things, and they're pretty easy.

One: before you buy anything, new or old, ask yourself if you'd still want it if it cost full price. If the answer is no, leave it on the rack for someone who actually needs it.

Two: learn one repair. Just one. Sewing a button back on takes about four minutes and I've got a video on it – I'll put the link below. Once you've done that, try a simple hem or a patch. Honestly, it gets kind of addictive.

Three: if something's beyond you, take it to someone who can fix it. That doesn't have to be me! There are alteration shops all over the place and most of them are doing it tough because nobody gets things repaired any more. A new zip in a pair of jeans you love costs about the same as a cheap new pair, and the old ones will last you years longer.

Every second Saturday we run a free Repair Café at the Kestrel Bay library. You bring the clothes, we bring the sewing machines, and we'll show you how to do it yourself. Last month we fixed sixty-two things in one afternoon, including a wedding dress and a very sad-looking teddy bear. Our oldest volunteer, Doreen, is eighty-one and has been sewing since she was eight. She will tell you, very kindly, that you're doing it wrong. She'll also be right.

I'm not saying never go shopping again. I still love a good op shop find. I'm just asking you to buy a bit less, keep things a bit longer and fix them when they break. Your wardrobe will thank you, your bank account will thank you, and so will the planet.

Anyway, that's my rant for the week. Show me your best repair in the comments – I want to see them all! See you next time.

Scenario 3: Regional trains

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Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s), written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material below to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background information

Westmere is a regional town about 150 kilometres from Melbourne, and many of its residents travel to the city by train for work, study and medical appointments. In recent years there have been many complaints about delays and cancellations on the line. The Westmere Courier is the local newspaper, and each week it publishes letters from readers. The following letter was written by Priya Raman, a nurse who commutes to a Melbourne hospital. The graph was printed beside the letter and was supplied by the Westmere Rail Users Group, a volunteer group that represents passengers.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

We deserve a train we can count on

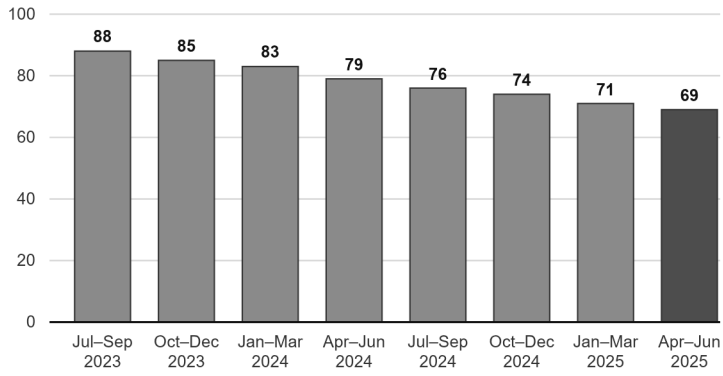
Last Tuesday I sat on the 6.12 am train from Westmere for an hour and forty minutes. The trip is meant to take an hour and five. Somewhere outside Darrow we stopped for ‘signal faults’ and stayed there long enough for the man across the aisle to finish his crossword, eat his lunch at half past seven in the morning and fall asleep. I got to the hospital fifty minutes late for a twelve-hour shift, on a ward that was already two nurses short.

This is not unusual. This is a normal week.

I have caught this train for nine years. When I started, it was something you could set your watch by. You’d get the odd delay in a heatwave, and everyone understood that. Now I leave home with no real idea of when I’ll get to work, or whether my train will turn up at all. My colleagues who travel from Ardley and Hollins say exactly the same thing.

Last month I got talking to a young woman on the platform at Westmere called Ella. She’s in the second year of a nursing degree (I told her she was mad, and she laughed). Because of cancellations, she has missed two of her hospital placement days this year, and the university has told her that if it happens again she may have to repeat the whole unit. So now she gets up at 4.30 to catch an earlier train ‘just in case’, which gets her into the city two hours before she needs to be there, sitting in a café she can’t really afford. She is nineteen. She should not have to plan her whole life around a train that may or may not come.

Westmere line: services arriving on time (%)



Source: Westmere Rail Users Group. 'On time' = within five minutes of the timetable.

The figures back this up. The Westmere Rail Users Group has been keeping track of every service on our line since 2023, and you can see the results on this page. In the middle of 2023, nearly nine out of every ten trains arrived on time. By the middle of this year it was fewer than seven. That means on any given day, roughly one in three of us is late – for work, for school, for medical appointments, for the job interview we spent weeks getting ready for.

And it isn’t only delays. On eleven mornings so far this year my train has been cancelled outright and a coach sent instead – a coach that takes nearly two hours, has no toilet and stops in every town along the way. Try explaining that to the patient whose dressing was meant to be changed at 7.30, or to the night-shift nurse who has been waiting to go home since seven.

Some people will say, well, just drive. I’ve done the sums on that too. A return trip to Melbourne is about 300 kilometres. Between petrol, tolls and parking near the hospital (which is $28 a day if you’re lucky enough to find a spot), driving would cost me close to $90 a day – about $350 for a normal four-shift week. That’s before you even think about wear and tear on the car, or what it’s like to drive home down the highway after a night shift with your eyes closing. My train ticket costs a fraction of that. When it actually runs, the train is the cheapest, safest and most sensible way for people like me to get to work. That is exactly why it matters so much when it doesn’t.

We are told the problem is ‘ageing infrastructure’. I don’t doubt it. Parts of the track past Darrow were laid before my grandparents were born, and the signals are so old that replacement parts have to be specially made. But none of this is news. A state government review pointed out these problems back in 2019, and since then we have had plenty of announcements and very little actual work.

Meanwhile, the city lines have had their new tunnels, their new stations and their shiny new trains. Good on them. I don’t begrudge anyone a better trip to work. But it is hard not to feel that people out here are an afterthought – that because

there are fewer of us, our time somehow matters less.

It does matter. When the train fails, people drive instead, and anyone who has been on the highway at 7 am lately knows how well that's going. Young people who can't rely on getting to uni or TAFE in the city end up moving away, and most of them don't come back. Local businesses lose staff. At my hospital, three nurses from this part of the state have resigned in the past year, and at least two of them told me the train was a big part of the reason. When a ward is already short-staffed, that is not a small thing. And those of us who don't have a choice – who can't afford a second car, or who don't drive – are simply left standing on the platform.

I am not asking for the impossible. I am asking for the track and signal upgrades we were promised six years ago, with a real start date and a real budget. I am asking for honest information on the app, so I'm not standing on a freezing platform watching the departure time change three times. And I am asking our local member, who I notice drives to Melbourne, to come and catch the 6.12 with me one morning and see what it's like.

I'll even save you a seat. If the train turns up.

Priya Raman, Westmere

Scenario 4: Study apps

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Task

Write an analysis of the ways in which argument(s), written and spoken language, and visuals are used in the material below to try to persuade the intended audience to share the point of view presented.

Background information

Many students now use apps to help them study, including flashcard and quiz apps, maths practice programs and AI tutors. Northcliff Secondary College recently held an information evening for parents of students in Years 9 and 10. One of the guest speakers was Dr Helena Varga, a psychologist who works with teenagers and their families. The text below is a transcript of part of her speech. The image is one of the slides she showed during her talk.

Are study apps really helping our kids learn?

Dr Helena Varga

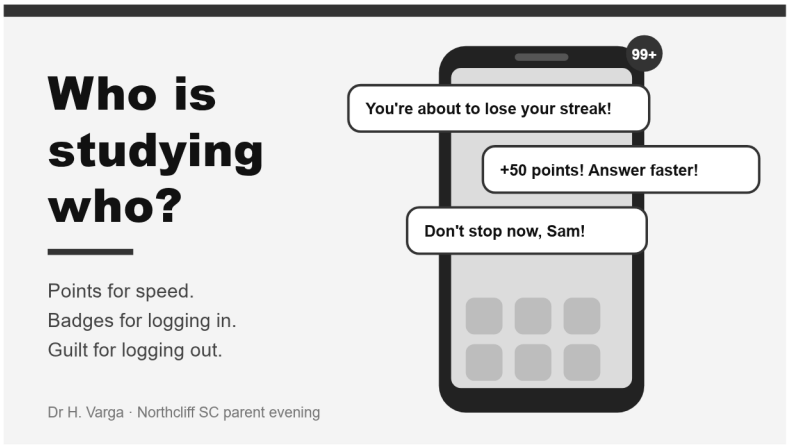
Good evening, everyone, and thank you for having me. I know it's a cold night and the footy's on, so I really appreciate you coming out.

I'd like to start with a quick show of hands. Who here has a child who uses some kind of study app? Flashcards, quiz games, maths practice, one of the new AI tutors? Yes – that's nearly all of you. Now keep your hand up if you've ever sat down and used that app yourself for twenty minutes. Not so many. That's okay. I hadn't either, until a couple of years ago.

I got interested because of a Year 10 boy I was seeing – I'll call him Sam. Sam's mum was worried because his marks had dropped, even though he was 'studying' for three hours every night. And it was true, he was. His study app showed a streak of 211 days. He had badges, he had trophies, he was in the top league of some leaderboard. What he didn't have was much memory of the work. When I asked him to explain a topic he had 'completed' the week before, he couldn't do it.

So I did what any nosy psychologist would do. I downloaded the app.

Within about ten minutes I understood. Every few seconds something flashed, buzzed or congratulated me. I got points for being fast, not for being right. When I tried to close it, a little cartoon character popped up to tell me I was about to 'lose my streak'. I felt guilty! And I'm forty-seven years old.



Here's what we need to understand as parents. A lot of these apps are made by the same kinds of companies, using the same kinds of tricks, as the social media and games we already spend so much energy worrying about. They're designed to keep our kids on them for as long as possible, because that's how they make their money – through subscriptions, through ads, or through the data they collect. Keeping a teenager on a screen and helping a teenager learn are two very different goals. When they clash, I'm afraid you can probably guess which one wins.

Real learning is a bit slow and a bit uncomfortable. It's sitting with a hard problem and not knowing the answer for a while. It's trying to remember something without being handed three multiple-choice options. Researchers sometimes call this 'desirable difficulty', and it's exactly what most of these apps are built to take away, because difficulty makes people put the phone down.

And the AI tutors are a whole new level again. I've watched students type a homework question in, copy the answer out neatly and feel very pleased with themselves. The work is done. Nothing has gone into their heads.

Last year our clinic ran a small trial with two Year 10 classes at a local school. One class used a popular quiz app for their revision; the other used paper flashcards and tested each other in pairs. After six weeks, the app class had actually spent more time studying – about forty minutes more each week. But the paper class scored, on average, eleven per cent higher on the end-of-term test. It was a small trial and I wouldn't build a whole school policy on it. But it fits with what I see in my office every single week.

Now, I know what some of you are thinking, because a dad put his hand up and said it to me at a school very much like this one last term. He said, 'With respect, Doctor, at least they're doing something. If my daughter's not on the study app, she's on TikTok.'

It's a fair point, and I want to take it seriously. If the choice really is between a quiz app and three hours of endless scrolling, then yes, the quiz app probably wins. But I don't think that's the real choice most of the time. The trouble is that the app gives us, the parents, the feeling that the job is being done. We walk past the bedroom, we see the colourful screen and the little trophies, and we relax. These apps are very good at convincing us, as well as our kids, that learning is happening – and that feeling is exactly what these companies are selling. In my experience it can stop us from asking the harder questions, like 'What did you actually learn tonight?' or 'Can you show me?'

I'm not here to tell you to throw the phones in the river. Some apps are genuinely useful, and some kids really do need them. What I'm asking is that we stop assuming that time spent on a 'study' app is time spent learning.

So, a few practical suggestions:

- Turn off the notifications. All of them. The app will still be there when your child decides to open it.
- Ask your child to teach you what they learnt today, without the screen. If they can, great. If they can't, that tells you something.
- Keep at least some study old-fashioned: pen, paper, a textbook and a timer.
- Find out what the app actually collects. Sit down with your child, go into the settings and have a look together – you might both be surprised.
- And – this is the hard one – model it. If we're scrolling all evening, it's a bit rich to expect them not to.

Sam, by the way, deleted the app in the end. It was a rough fortnight. He lost his 211-day streak and he was not happy with me about it. But his next set of results was the best he'd had all year.

Thank you. I'm happy to take a few questions.

Sample Analysing Argument Essays

Select a highlighted passage to see what earns marks in that moment. Use the buttons to show one category at a time.

Structure & evidence | Audience positioning | Language & technique | Ideas & interpretation

Sample Analysing Argument Essays

The three responses below were all written for the same task: Scenario 3 on the Practice Articles for Analysis page, a letter to the editor of the *Westmere Courier* by Priya Raman, a nurse who commutes to Melbourne by train. The first sits in the low range, the second in the middle range and the third in the high range. Each one has an introduction, three body paragraphs built around the letter's main arguments, and a conclusion. Read the task and the letter first, then compare how each response handles argument, language, the visual and the audience.

The Task and Letter

The task, background information and letter are reproduced below.

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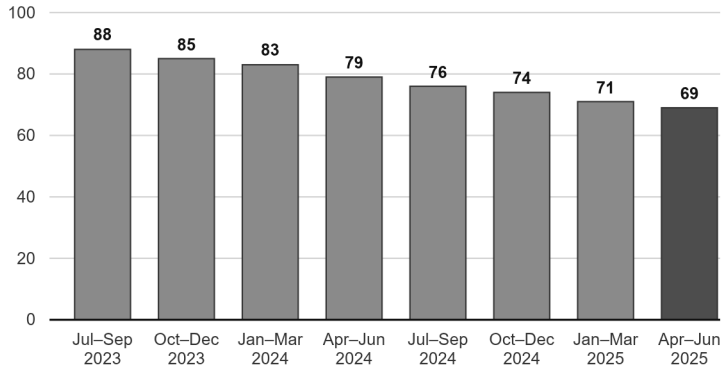
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them don't come back. Local businesses lose staff. At my hospital, three nurses from this part of the state have resigned in the past year, and at least two of them told me the train was a big part of the reason. When a ward is already short-staffed, that is not a small thing. And those of us who don't have a choice – who can't afford a second car, or who don't drive – are simply left standing on the platform.

I am not asking for the impossible. I am asking for the track and signal upgrades we were promised six years ago, with a real start date and a real budget. I am asking for honest information on the app, so I'm not standing on a freezing platform watching the departure time change three times. And I am asking our local member, who I notice drives to Melbourne, to come and catch the 6.12 with me one morning and see what it's like.

I'll even save you a seat. If the train turns up.

Priya Raman, Westmere

Sample Essay I (Low)

In the letter 'We deserve a train we can count on' written by Priya Raman in the Westmere Courier, she talks about how the trains in Westmere are always late and the government needs to fix it. She is a nurse and she uses alot of persuasive techniques to get the reader to agree with her .

Priya's first argument is that the trains are late and it is affecting people. She uses an anecdote at the start about when her train was late last Tuesday. She says that it took 'an hour and forty minutes' when it is meant to take 'an hour and five'. This is an anecdote and it makes the reader feel sorry for her . She also talks about a man who finished his crossword and ate his lunch and then fell asleep which is funny . Then she says she was 'fifty minutes late' for her shift. This makes the reader feel sympathy because nurses are important and the hospital was already short of staff . Priya also talks about a girl called Ella who is a nursing student and is nineteen. Ella has missed placement days because of the train. This is another anecdote and it is sad because she is young and has to get up at 4.30 in the morning. The reader will feel bad for Ella.

Priya's second argument is that the trains are getting worse. She uses statistics to show this. The graph shows that the trains arriving on time went from 88 to 69. This is a big drop and it shows the trains are getting worse. She also says 'roughly one in three of us is late'. Statistics are used to make an argument more believable and the reader will believe her because it has numbers. The graph is grey and the last bar is darker then the others . She also uses a rhetorical question when she says 'Some people will say, well, just drive.' This makes the reader think about it. She then says driving would cost 'close to $90 a day' which is alot of money so the reader will agree that driving is not a good idea .

Priya's third argument is that the government does not care about people in Westmere. She compares the city lines to the country lines. The city has 'new tunnels' and 'shiny new trains' and Westmere doesn't get anything. This is unfair and the reader will think the government doesnt care about people in the country . At the end she uses repetition, 'I am asking' three times. Repetition makes the argument stick in the readers head . She also invites the local member to catch the train with her which is a good way to finish. She says 'I'll even save you a seat. If the train turns up.' This is humour and it makes the reader laugh .

In conclusion, Priya Raman uses anecdotes, statistics, a graph and repetition to persuade the reader that the trains in Westmere need to be fixed. She is very persuasive because she is a nurse and she uses lots of different techniques .

Sample Essay II (Medium)

In her letter to the editor of the Westmere Courier, titled 'We deserve a train we can count on', nurse and long-time commuter Priya Raman contends that the state government has neglected the Westmere train line and must commit to the track and signal upgrades it promised. Writing to an audience of mainly Westmere residents, many of whom would also rely on the train, as well as the local member of parliament , Raman uses a frustrated but at times humorous tone to argue that regional passengers are being treated as less important than those in the city.

Raman first argues that the unreliable train service is having a real impact on the people who use it. She begins with a personal anecdote about her trip to work the previous Tuesday. By describing how she 'sat on the 6.12 am train from Westmere for an hour and forty minutes', she immediately places the reader on the train with her . The humorous image of the man across the aisle who was able to 'finish his crossword, eat his lunch at half past seven in the morning and fall asleep' exaggerates how long the delay lasted, and the audience are likely to find this amusing but also recognise it from their own experiences. As such, the audience, particularly other commuters, are more inclined to see Raman as one of them and trust her point of view. Raman then reveals that she was 'fifty minutes late for a twelve-hour shift, on a ward that was already two nurses short'. This shifts the tone from humorous to serious , as the audience start to understand that the delays do not only affect commuters but also the patients who rely on nurses like her. The short sentence 'This is a normal week' emphasises how regular these problems have become. Raman also includes the anecdote of Ella, a nineteen-year-old nursing student who now catches an earlier train 'just in case'. The audience are positioned to feel sympathy for Ella, as she is young and is already being disadvantaged by something she cannot control.

Raman's second argument is that the service is getting worse and that there is no real alternative to it. She uses the statistics from the Westmere Rail Users Group to show that 'nearly nine out of every ten trains' were once on time but now it is 'fewer than seven', and that 'roughly one in three of us is late'. The use of the inclusive pronoun 'us' groups Raman together with the audience, encouraging them to see the problem as one that affects the whole community. The accompanying bar graph reinforces this, as each bar is lower than the one before it, showing a steady decline over two years. The final bar is shaded darker than the rest , drawing the reader's eye to the lowest figure of 69 per cent. As a result, the audience are more likely to accept that the line is getting worse and is not just having a bad week . Raman then anticipates the argument that people should 'just drive' instead. She uses logic and statistics to rebut this, calculating that driving would cost her 'close to $90 a day', and she appeals to the audience's sense of safety by describing driving home after a night shift 'with your eyes closing'. As such, the audience are more likely to agree that the train is the 'cheapest, safest and most sensible' option, which makes its unreliability seem even more frustrating.

Finally, Raman argues that regional people are being treated unfairly and that the government needs to act. She explains that the problems were identified 'back in 2019' but there has been 'plenty of announcements and very little actual work'. This makes the government seem as though it only cares about looking like it is doing something, causing the audience to lose trust in their promises . Raman then compares the Westmere line to the city lines, which have had 'new tunnels', 'new stations' and 'shiny new trains'. Although she says 'Good on them', the comparison makes the audience feel that regional people are an 'afterthought'. She then lists the wider consequences for the community, such as young people moving away and nurses

resigning from her hospital, which broadens her argument from a personal complaint to a community issue . Raman uses repetition of 'I am asking' to set out exactly what she wants, which makes her demands seem reasonable and clear . She ends by challenging the local member to catch the train with her, and the final line 'If the train turns up' uses humour to leave the audience with a reminder of how unreliable the service is.

Overall, Priya Raman uses personal anecdotes, statistics, a bar graph and a comparison with the city to persuade the audience that the Westmere line has been neglected. She positions the audience to feel sympathy and frustration, and to support her call for the government to finally upgrade the line.

Sample Essay III (High)

In a letter to the editor of the regional Westmere Courier, nurse Priya Raman contends that the Westmere train line has been left to decline while city commuters enjoy new investment, and that the government must deliver the long-promised track and signal upgrades with 'a real start date and a real budget'. Her readership is a community that knows the train intimately, and Raman writes less to inform them than to give their shared frustration a shape and a target . Her tone moves from wry, almost weary humour into measured indignation , and finally into a pointed challenge to the local member, so that by the end of the letter a private inconvenience has become a public question of fairness.

Raman's first argument is that the failing service has real human costs, and she makes this case through story rather than statement. Raman opens not with an argument but with a scene . The 6.12 am train, the 'signal faults' outside Darrow and the man who manages to 'finish his crossword, eat his lunch at half past seven in the morning and fall asleep' are comic in their detail, and this is a deliberate choice. Humour allows Raman to establish herself as reasonable rather than shrill ; she is laughing at the absurdity before she is angry about it. Yet the joke ends abruptly when she arrives 'fifty minutes late for a twelve-hour shift, on a ward that was already two nurses short'. The stakes are suddenly raised from a ruined morning to patient care. Her credibility as a nurse is doing quiet work here . She never has to argue that her lateness matters, because the reader already understands what a short-staffed ward means. The two blunt sentences that follow, 'This is not unusual. This is a normal week', land with the flatness of someone stating a fact that should be shocking but no longer is , and it is this resignation that invites the reader's outrage on her behalf. The anecdote of Ella widens the appeal. Where Raman's own story speaks to fellow workers, Ella, who is 'nineteen', getting up at 4.30 and sitting 'in a café she can't really afford', speaks to parents and to anyone worried about whether young people have a future in the town . The decline of the train is gradually connected to the decline of the town itself .

Having made the problem personal, Raman then makes it measurable , arguing that the decline is real and that neither the alternatives nor the official excuses hold up. Her nine years on the line give her a before-and-after authority ('something you could set your watch by'), but she is careful not to rest on memory alone. The Rail Users Group figures, translated into plain fractions, 'nearly nine out of every ten' and 'fewer than seven', are easier for a general reader to feel than a percentage , and the accompanying graph turns this decline into something almost physical: eight bars stepping steadily down, with the final, darkest bar marking 69 per cent as the low point so far. The grey, unadorned design gives the graph the look of neutral data rather than campaign material , which strengthens its authority, while the inclusive 'us' in 'roughly one in three of us is late' quietly recruits every reader who has stood on that platform

into her argument . Raman then raises the obvious objection, ‘well, just drive’, in a dismissive voice before dismantling it with arithmetic, ‘close to $90 a day’, and with an image that is hard to forget: driving down the highway after a night shift ‘with your eyes closing’. By the time she concludes that the train is ‘the cheapest, safest and most sensible way’ to get to work, she has turned her opponents ’ solution into further evidence for her own case. The same strategy appears in her response to the official explanation of ‘ageing infrastructure’. Rather than disputing it, she concedes it (‘I don’t doubt it’), and then uses the concession against the government: the problems were identified ‘back in 2019’, yet there have been ‘plenty of announcements and very little actual work’. The balanced structure of this phrase exposes the gap between words and action .

Raman’s final argument is that regional people are being treated as an afterthought, and that the government must now act. Her indignation is at its most controlled in the comparison with the city. The list of ‘new tunnels’, ‘new stations’ and ‘shiny new trains’ is followed by ‘Good on them’, a concession that sounds generous but carries an edge of sarcasm . It allows Raman to avoid seeming resentful while still making the reader feel the unfairness, which she then names directly: people out here are ‘an afterthought’, as though ‘our time somehow matters less’. The short rebuttal ‘It does matter’ marks a turning point , after which the letter widens its consequences to the whole community, including nurses resigning from her hospital and people who ‘are simply left standing on the platform’. Her conclusion then shifts from description to demand. The repeated ‘I am asking’ gives her requests the rhythm of a formal petition, and the requests themselves are deliberately modest, which makes refusing them seem unreasonable . Her final move is her most pointed: an invitation to the local member, ‘who I notice drives to Melbourne’, to catch the 6.12 with her. The aside is barbed, quietly suggesting that those who make decisions about the train do not have to live with it . The closing line, ‘If the train turns up’, returns to the dry humour of the opening, but now the joke has a sting , leaving the reader with the very uncertainty the whole letter has been arguing against.

Through a careful movement from comic anecdote to hard evidence, and from concession to challenge, Raman transforms a familiar local grievance into an argument about fairness and respect . Her readers are positioned not only to sympathise with her, but to see their own frustration reflected and justified, and to expect their local member to answer for it.

High-Scoring Vocabulary Bank

Precise analytical verbs and phrases to lift your expression out of the everyday. Swap the word you always reach for with one that says exactly what the author is doing.

Instead of “shows”

demonstrates · illustrates · reveals · highlights · conveys · depicts · exposes · emphasises · evokes · underscores · articulates · renders · constructs · establishes

Instead of “says”

asserts · contends · argues · maintains · proposes · insists · suggests · posits · claims · declares · affirms · implies · intimates

Instead of “does”

manipulates · constructs · orchestrates · positions · cultivates · provokes · reinforces · challenges · subverts · complicates · foregrounds · amplifies

Instead of “likes” / “doesn’t like”

favours · endorses · advocates for · embraces · rejects · condemns · critiques · denounces · disparages · repudiates

Argument analysis: persuasive techniques

appeals to fear · appeals to morality · appeals to justice · appeals to community values · appeals to nostalgia · invokes empathy · mobilises outrage · exploits uncertainty · leverages authority · constructs credibility

Argument analysis: audience positioning

positions the reader to | encourages the audience to | invites the reader to | pressures the audience to | compels the reader to | manipulates the audience into | frames the issue as | recasts the debate as | polarises the audience | aligns the reader with

Sophisticated linking words

Furthermore | Moreover | Consequently | Thus | Accordingly | Nevertheless | Conversely | Significantly | Implicitly | Ultimately

Pair with the Glossary of Techniques for the metalanguage itself.

Sentence Starters for Analytical Writing

A working vocabulary for Section C paragraphs — openers, connectives and reporting verbs, grouped by job. Click any phrase to copy it, then make it your own: the strongest analysis uses these as scaffolding, not wallpaper.

To introduce the issue

> *The recent controversy/problem/incident/debate over (event) has prompted a variety of opinions regarding (issue).*

To introduce evidence of persuasiveness

To affirm this, To attest to this, To confirm this, To endorse this, To further confirm, To further verify, To substantiate this, To support this, To verify this,

Body paragraphs

The author emphasises... The author endorses the argument that ... when ... The article gives prominence to... The author's attitude is exemplified by...

To explain the effects of language

affects illustrates reinforces characterises impacts on reveals demonstrates implies subverts exemplifies portrays underscores

Alternatives to 'presents'

conveys explores implies demonstrates illustrates indicates signals suggests

Alternatives to 'presents positively'

advocates | endorses | promotes | recommends | supports

Alternatives to ‘presents negatively’

challenges | condemns | critiques | exposes | questions

To compare and contrast

Similarly, ... | In the same way ... | Likewise, ... | In opposition to this... | In comparison ... | Complementary to this ...

Then again, ... | However, ... | This is in contrast to ... | In contrast, ... | And yet ... | Nevertheless, ...

Conversely, ... | Instead... | On the contrary, ... | On the other hand, ... | Notwithstanding ... | Whereas ...

In contrast to ... | That aside, ... | While this is the case ... | ... disputes ... | Despite this, ...

To add ideas

Also, ... | Equally important ... | Subsequently, ... | Furthermore, ... | Moreover, ... | As well as ... | Next...

Another essential point... | Additionally, ... | More importantly, ... | In the same way ... | Another ... | Then, ...

In addition, ... | Besides, ... | Then again, ... | Firstly, ... secondly, ... thirdly, ... finally, ... | To elaborate, ...

To present uncommon or rare ideas

Seldom ... | Few ... | Not many ... | A few ... | ... is uncommon ... | ... is scarce ... | Rarely ... | ... is rare ...

... is unusual ...

To present common or widespread ideas

Numerous ... | Many ... | More than ... | Several ... | Almost all ... | The majority ... | Most ... | Commonly ...

Significant ... | Is prevalent ... | Is usual ... | Usually ...

To give examples

For example, ...
... as can be seen in ...
... supports ...
An illustration of ...
... as demonstrated by ...
... is observed ...
Specifically, ...
Is shown ...
Exemplifies ...
Such as ...
As an example ...
To illustrate, ...
For instance, ...

To show relationships or outcome

Therefore ...
As a result ...
For that reason ...
Hence, ...
Otherwise, ...
Consequently, ...
The evidence suggests/shows ...
It can be seen that ...
With regard to ...
After examining ...
These factors contribute to ...
It is apparent that ...
Considering ... it can be concluded ...
Subsequently, ...
The effect is ...
The outcome is ...
The result ...
The correlation ...
The relationship ...
The link ...
The convergence ...
The connection ...
Interacts with ...
Affects ...
Thus it is ...
Causes ...
Influences ...
Predicts ...
Leads to ...
Informs ...
Presupposes ...
Emphasises ...
Demonstrates ...
Impacts on ...
Supports ...

To present prior or background ideas

In the past, ...
Historically, ...
Traditionally, ...
Customarily, ...
Beforehand, ...
Originally, ...
Prior to this, ...
Earlier, ...
Formerly, ...
Previously, ...
Over time, ...
At the time of ...
Conventionally, ...
Foundational to this is ...
In earlier ...
Initially, ...
At first, ...
Recently ...
Until now, ...
The traditional interpretation ...

To present others' ideas

According to ...
Based on the findings of ... it can be argued...
... proposed that ...
As explained by ...
... states that ...
... claims that ...
However, ... stated that ...
... suggested ...
... concluded that ...
Similarly, ... stated that ...
... agreed that ...
Based on the ideas of ...
... defined ... as ...
... relates ...
As identified by ...
... disputed that ...
... contrasts ...
With regard to ... argued that ...
... confirmed that ...
Argues ...
Highlights ...
Demonstrates ...

Found that ...
Identifies ...
Wrote that ...
Demonstrated ...
Reported ...
Pointed out that ...
Maintained that ...
Hypothesised that ...
... expressed the opinion that ...
Also mentioned ...
Asserts that ...
Identified ...
Goes on to state/suggest/say ...
Emphasises ...
Challenges the idea ...
Showed that ...
Explored the idea ...

Pair these with the High-Scoring Vocabulary Bank and the Section C essay structure.

Part

The Exam

Exam Format

The VCE English exam is a three-hour exam, plus 15 minutes of reading time. It has three sections, and you are required to complete all three sections. Each section is worth the same number of marks, so you should spend the same amount of time on each.

Exam Specifications

Overall Conditions

- The examination will be sat at a time and date to be set annually by the Victorian Curriculum and Assessment Authority (VCAA). VCAA examination rules will apply.
- There will be 15 minutes of reading time and 3 hours of writing time.
- The examination will be assessed by a panel appointed by the VCAA.
- The examination will contribute 50 per cent to the study score.

Format

The Task Book will be sixteen pages in length. The front page contains the general cover notes and instructions, including rules about what you can and can't take into the exam.

An English and/or bilingual printed dictionary is permitted.

Mobile Phones and/pr any unauthrosied electronic devices are not permitted.

Specifications from VCAA:

- The examination will be in the form of a Task Book.
- The examination will consist of three sections.
- Section A will consist of an analytical response to a text and will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- Students will be required to write an analytical response to one of the two texts studied from List 1 of the VCE English and English as an Additional Language (EAL) Text List for the year in question. There will be two topics for each of the 20 texts on List 1. Students will be required to write a response to one topic on one text.
- Student responses should demonstrate knowledge and understanding of the text, its structure and the ideas, concerns and values raised by the topic, and support their response with close reference to the text. If the selected text is a collection of poetry or short stories, students may write on several poems or stories, or on at least two in close detail.
- The response will be assessed according to the assessment criteria specified on the following page.
- Section B will consist of creating a text and will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- Students will be required to create one written text. For the purposes of this task, a 'written text' does not include song, poetry or verse. In creating their text, students must use the title provided, relevant idea(s) from at least one unseen stimulus and be connected to one of the Frameworks of Ideas. The text must be developed with a clear purpose(s) – to explain, to express, to argue, to reflect – and should be an effective and cohesive piece of writing.

Students should demonstrate fluency through the selection of vocabulary, text structure(s) and language features, and employ an appropriate voice in their text.

- The place of mentor texts is to provide access to ideas and inform the teaching of writing, but students will not be required to make explicit reference to them in the examination.
- The text will be assessed according to the assessment criteria specified below. Section B will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- Section C will consist of an analysis of argument and language and will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- Students will be required to analyse the use of argument(s) and language to persuade an intended audience to share the point of view expressed in an unseen persuasive text. For the purposes of this task, 'language' refers to written and spoken language, and 'visuals' refers to images and graphics. Students will not be required to evaluate the relative merits or successes of argument(s).
- The response will be assessed according to the assessment criteria specified below.
- Section C will be worth a total of 20 marks.
- The total marks for the examination will be 60.
- Answers to Section A, B and C are to be recorded in the Answer Book.

Exam Mindset, Timing and FAQs

How Your Paper Is Marked

Each section is marked by at least two assessors, each giving a score out of 10, combined into a mark out of 20. If the two scores are too far apart, a third (or further) assessor reads the response. Assessors mark holistically against the expected qualities, and always in relation to the topic or title. They read every word and reward as far as they can. In 2025 the average for each section sat around 5.4 to 5.5 out of 10.

Attitude Is a Predictor

An Australian study of students under test conditions, controlling for ability, found that attitude alone predicted results. “Confident striders” (prepared, and trusting that the test would be fair) did best; students who expected the test to be unfair and stressful tended to fulfil that prophecy. Practical takeaways:

- **Trust the paper to be fair.** Recent papers have been. A question may be phrased unexpectedly, but you are transferring skills you have practised to a new instance.
- **A little nerves is useful.** Adrenaline speeds thinking. Worrying about things you cannot control only takes up brain space.
- **Confidence comes from preparation**, not from hoping.

Habits of Successful Students

- **Train for three hours.** Do some study in three-hour blocks so the exam is not the first time you concentrate that long. Work out what breakfast keeps you going.
- **Practise, get feedback, act on it, practise again.**
- **Eat well, sleep, and exercise** to burn off anxiety when it tips from useful to unhelpful.
- **Have a backup plan.** No single exam decides your future. Missing a first-choice course often means a transfer a year later.

Time Discipline

The three sections are worth equal marks, so give each one hour. The first marks in any response are the easiest to earn. An extra half hour polishing one essay gains far less than the same half hour spent on the next. Use the room clock, and when the hour is up, move on.

Plan, Then Write

Planning is not extra work; it shifts the work. When you write without a plan, you are deciding what to say and how to say it at the same time, and your brain switches between the two and loses time. Plan first (only you need to read it), check it is relevant to the topic, then give your full attention to expression. Fluency is assessed in every section.

Frequently Asked Questions

- **How many quotes should I use in Section A?** There is no number. It depends on how many other kinds of evidence you use (structure, character, setting, language features,

context), and every quote must be explained, not just included.

- **Should I memorise a strong practice response?** No, in any section. You cannot know the topic, title or text, and a memorised piece that does not answer the question cannot score highly.
- **Which section should I do first?** Personal choice. Some students do A, B, C in order; others start with whichever they plan fastest. Try different orders in practice exams.
- **What should I do the night before?** Put the books away and sleep. A year of preparation will not be changed by two more hours.
- **What if I make a mistake?** Cross it out neatly and keep going. If you realise mid-essay you have drifted, fix your topic sentences, but stay within your hour. Checking your plan early is the best prevention.
- **What if I don't get the score I want?** You get the score you get. It is a snapshot of one day, and your skills keep growing after it.

Strategies for Addressing the Requirements

Section A

In Section A you will write an essay that responds to one of the two given topics on a text you have studied. You can choose to write on either your Unit 1 text or your Unit 4 text. In your answer book you will need to identify the text on which you are writing and the topic (i or ii) you are responding to by shading the relevant box.

Spend a few minutes unpacking the topic you feel most comfortable responding to. Look carefully at each term in the topic and make sure you understand its meaning and significance. Use the strategies for identifying topic words, direction words and limiting words outlined on pages 48–50 in English Year 12.

Spend about 5 minutes writing a brief plan that includes your contention, three or four topic sentences and one or two pieces of textual evidence for each topic sentence.

The following strategies will help you to address the Section A requirements and criteria.

- Address the topic in full. Strong responses take account of every word in the topic, including the limiting words, rather than writing about one key term in a general way.
- Use your dictionary. Make sure you understand the meanings of all the words in the topic. Your dictionary will also give you some synonyms for key terms in the topic, and using these will give your writing more variety and precision.
- Consider a range of textual features. Don't limit your reasons and evidence to just what the characters say and do. While authors do use characters to explore ideas, they also use features such as narrative voice, structure, setting and imagery. Film techniques should be referred to when analysing a film, and an analysis of poetry will be enhanced by a consideration of poetic form and techniques. Discussing these features shows a deeper understanding of the text and a more sophisticated response to the topic.
- Integrate quotes and explain their significance. It is useful to include some direct quotes, as this is part of how you show your 'knowledge and understanding of the text' (criterion 2 for Section A). However, make sure you incorporate quotes into your discussion and thoroughly explain how they support the point you are making. If you use a quote and then mention it on its own, or place it at the end of a sentence without further explanation, it will be unclear to your assessor how the quote helps to advance your argument.
- Write precisely and expressively. Develop a wide vocabulary during the year by creating word banks (see the examples on pages 58–63 of English Year 12) and use a variety of words in your practice essays, so by the time you sit the exam you can make effective vocabulary choices in all your responses.

Section B

In Section B you will write a text that responds to a given title and at least one piece of stimulus material. In the answer book, you will need to shade the box of your chosen Framework, and the box (or boxes) corresponding to the stimulus (or stimuli) you have responded to.

The following strategies will help you to address the Section B criteria and weave the stimuli and title into your creative piece.

- Ensure your writing is clearly relevant to your chosen Framework. This involves integrating concepts and perspectives that you've explored during the year. When you are revising in preparation for the exam, refer to your notes and written pieces to stay aligned with the core ideas of the Framework.
- Integrate the title and at least one stimulus into your writing. You must use at least one of the stimuli. The stimulus should not just be referenced superficially; it should be woven into the fabric of your piece. This could mean, for example, using a text stimulus as the basis for a central idea; using a text stimulus as a direct quote at a key point in your text; or drawing inspiration from a visual stimulus to set a scene. Similarly, the title provided for your Framework should provide an idea, a character arc, a central image or another key element of your writing.
- Give your piece cohesion and structure. Your piece should have a clear beginning, middle and end, regardless of whether it's a narrative, an argument or a reflective piece. Each part should seamlessly transition into the next, maintaining a logical flow of ideas.
- Make appropriate use of language, style and voice. The language and style of your writing should suit the purpose and audience. This includes choosing the most appropriate vocabulary, tone and sentence structures. In your Unit 3 drafts and assessment pieces, you will have worked hard to develop your own unique voice. You likely have a preferred form of writing (fiction or nonfiction, story, article etc.) and you should lean into that during the exam.
- Write with fluency and expression. Your writing should read smoothly, with a natural flow of ideas and language. This can be achieved by varying your sentence structures, giving your writing a subtle rhythm and clearly articulating your ideas. Transitions between paragraphs or sections should be logical and easy for the reader to follow.

Section C

In Section C you will analyse a text in which the writer seeks to persuade a particular audience to agree with their point of view on an issue. The text will be primarily written but will also contain one or more visual elements.

This task has been part of the VCE English exam for many years and as part of your preparation you may use past exam papers as sources of practice material. In some cases you will find that the task material consists of more than one written piece, but the exam specifications for 2024–2027 indicate that there will only be a single 'unseen persuasive text' in the English exams during this period.

The following strategies will help you to address the Section C requirements and criteria.

- Understand the contention. What, essentially, is the writer saying? An accurate understanding of the writer's central argument underpins your analysis. Clearly state the writer's contention in your introduction.
- Read the background information carefully. This is where you will find out the intended audience and the context for the text. Your analysis will be strengthened by a consideration of

how the writer's choices of argument and language are shaped by their particular audience and context (see the final bullet point below).

- Examine the sequencing of the argument. Writers will arrange their material and their points of argument in a particular order so as to engage their intended audience and influence their thoughts and feelings. Look at the overall shape of the argument, then drill down into the specific points and language choices. Shifts in tone are important aspects of the structure, too.
- Examine language choices. Writers make deliberate choices of words to add impact to their arguments and to evoke the audience's emotions. Identify words with strong positive or negative connotations and associations and spend some time in your analysis 'unpacking' their likely effects on the audience. You will not have time to analyse every use of language in the text, but discuss a representative sample of language choices.
- Use effective verbs. In your analysis of a persuasive text, verbs enable you to describe what the writer is doing and how they are doing it. Repeating the verbs 'positions' and 'persuades' doesn't show your understanding of how argument and language are being used. Verbs such as 'reinforces', 'emphasises', 'instils', 'elicits' and 'undermines' can be used to show your understanding of how a writer is attempting to persuade. See the verbs in the activity on page 210 of English Year 12 for some other examples.
- Analyse how argument, language and visuals are working together. Don't treat these as separate elements of the text, since an audience's response will be a result of how all these elements are working in combination. Look at how language is used to present an argument, and how an image complements and reinforces particular reasons or pieces of evidence.

Part

Exam Assessment Criteria

Section A Mark Allocation

Section A Exam Rubric

Mark	Expected qualities
9–10	• Demonstrates a close and perceptive reading of the text, considering complexities of its ideas, concerns and values explored through the structure of the text and its language • Demonstrates a clear understanding of the implications of the topic, using an appropriate strategy for dealing with it, and exploring its complexity from the basis of the text • Develops a cogent, controlled and well-substantiated discussion using precise and expressive language
8	• Demonstrates a thoughtful reading of the text, exploring its ideas, concerns and values through a discussion of the structure of the text and its language • Demonstrates an understanding of the implications of the topic, exploring it from the basis of the text • Develops a detailed, substantiated and coherent discussion using language fluently and confidently
7	• Demonstrates detailed knowledge of the text throughout, including some of its ideas, concerns and values by appropriately acknowledging aspects of the structure of the text and its language • Understands the topic, developing a sustained and well-supported response • Develops an organised piece of writing using language accurately and appropriately
6	• Demonstrates a clear knowledge of the text, including some elements of its ideas, concerns and values and some awareness of structure and language • Develops a response to the topic, supported by appropriate evidence from the text • Presents a generally organised piece of writing using language that is mostly accurate and appropriate
5	• Demonstrates an adequate knowledge of the text and makes some reference to its ideas, concerns and values • Presents a response that shows an understanding of the topic referring to evidence from the text • Presents a piece of writing that communicates adequately, displaying some elements of organisation
4	• Demonstrates basic knowledge of the text with limited reference to ideas, concerns and values • Presents a response that shows some understanding of the topic

Mark	Expected qualities
	• Shows adequate expression and language control
3	• Shows a familiarity with the text • Shows a limited awareness of the topic • Shows basic expression and language control
1–2	• Shows limited familiarity with the text • Shows a very limited awareness of the topic • Uses language that is not always clear
0	• Shows no knowledge of the text and/or no attempt to engage with the topic and/or only minimal control of language

Section B Mark Allocation

Section B Exam Rubric

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
9–10	• Demonstrates insightful consideration of the ideas raised by the title and stimulus in connection with a Framework of Ideas • Creates a cohesive text with an explicit purpose(s) and an appropriate voice • Demonstrates sophisticated control of language and text structure(s), that makes rich use of vocabulary and language features
8	• Demonstrates an astute exploration of the ideas raised by the title and stimulus in connection with a Framework of Ideas • Creates a coherent text with an explicit purpose(s) and an appropriate voice • Demonstrates confident control of language and text structure(s), that makes thoughtful use of vocabulary and language features
7	• Demonstrates a detailed connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus related to a Framework of Ideas • Creates a coordinated text with a clear purpose(s) and an appropriate voice • Demonstrates sound control of language and text structure(s), that makes clear use of vocabulary and language features
6	• Develops a clear connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus with reference to a Framework of Ideas • Creates a connected text with a clear purpose(s) and an appropriate voice • Demonstrates clear control of language and text structure(s), makes effective use of vocabulary and language features
5	• Develops an adequate connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus with reference to a Framework of Ideas • Creates an organised text that is linked to a purpose(s) and has an appropriate voice • Demonstrates adequate control of language and text structure(s), that makes some use of vocabulary and language features
4	• Shows a basic connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus • Shows some connection to a purpose(s) and some awareness of voice • Shows basic control of language and text structure(s), that makes simple use of vocabulary and language features
3	• Shows limited connection to the ideas raised by the title and stimulus • Shows limited awareness of purpose or appropriate voice

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
	• Shows limited control of language and structure
1–2	• Shows little or no apparent connection to ideas raised by the title and stimulus • Shows little awareness of the purpose(s) of their text • Uses language that is not always clear
0	• Shows no knowledge of the task and/or no attempt to engage with the task

Section C Mark Allocation

Section C Exam Rubric

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
9–10	• Demonstrates a perceptive understanding of contention, the development of argument(s) as constructed in the text and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates sophisticated insight into the ways in which written and spoken language and visuals complement the argument(s) and are used to persuade the intended audience • Uses sophisticated and precise language
8	• Demonstrates a thoughtful understanding of contention, the development of argument(s) as constructed in the text and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates sound insight into the ways in which the written and spoken language and visuals work together to build the argument(s) and persuade the intended audience • Uses language confidently
7	• Demonstrates detailed understanding of contention, argument(s) presented in the text and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates insight into the ways in which the written and spoken language and visuals in the text are used to persuade the intended audience • Uses fluent expression
6	• Demonstrates a clear understanding of contention, the argument(s) presented in the text and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates some awareness of the ways in which the written and spoken language and visuals in the text are used to persuade the intended audience • Uses competent expression
5	• Demonstrates adequate understanding of contention, the argument(s) presented and the point of view expressed • Demonstrates basic awareness of the ways in which the written and spoken language and visuals in the text are used to persuade the intended audience • Uses language adequately
4	• Demonstrates a basic understanding of the contention, the argument(s) and point of view expressed • Describes the ways in which written and spoken language and visuals are used to persuade an audience • Uses basic language

Mark(s)	Expected Qualities
3	• Shows a limited knowledge of the argument(s) or point of view • Shows a limited knowledge of the ways in which written and spoken language and visuals are used • Attempts basic language
1–2	• Shows little understanding of the material • Shows only minimal knowledge of the task • Uses language that is not always clear
0	• Shows no understanding of the requirements of the task

How the Marker Reads Your Essay

Examiners do not read your essay the way a friendly teacher does – they read it in passes, testing it against the criteria. Knowing the passes lets you write for them.

The Six Passes

First, the scope audit: the topic is broken into its explicit and implicit parts, including modifying words ("unrelenting cruelty", not just "cruelty") and both halves of a double-barrelled prompt. A dimension you never address keeps you out of the 8–10 range. Second, the summary filter: every sentence is silently sorted into retelling, explaining, or analysing how the author constructs meaning – and if retelling dominates, the essay cannot reach the upper band no matter how fluent it is. Third, the topic-sentence thread: conceptual topic sentences that build a progressive argument separate 9–10 essays from 7–8 essays that give three parallel examples of one idea. Fourth, the authorial hand: markers look for sentences whose subject is the author ("Jackson constructs…", "Weir juxtaposes…") – writing about characters as though they are real people is a mid-band signature. Fifth, evidence gravity: quotes that stand alone as their own sentences read mid-band; short quotes woven into your own grammar, drawn from across the whole text, read upper-band. Sixth, the gap analysis: the difference between your mark and the next band is always something specific and nameable – which is why good feedback tells you what was missing, not just what was there.

What the Bands Feel Like

A 5 is relevant but basic: simple structure, simple vocabulary, evidence that supports plot points. A 7 is clear and detailed, uses evidence effectively, but stays at the level of what the text shows rather than how and why it was built that way. A 9 or 10 is sophisticated and perceptive: it reframes the topic conceptually, treats the text as a construction, uses precise metalanguage correctly, and integrates evidence so smoothly the quotation marks could be removed without breaking the sentence.

Section-Specific Traps

In Section A, a contention that simply agrees or disagrees without a bigger conceptual claim caps the essay in the middle band, and ignoring the text's social and historical values keeps the top band out of reach. In Section B, a competent story that never engages the Framework's ideas sits mid-band, as do clichéd premises and unearned endings – while adapted echoes of your mentor texts signal studied craft. In Section C, "the readers" is a mid-band audience; the upper band names who the writer targets and what they are being positioned to think, feel and do. Naming a technique without explaining its function for that specific audience is label-picking, and it caps the analysis no matter how many techniques you spot. Track the argument's arc and tonal shifts; treat any visual as part of the argument, not a separate exhibit.

Part

Exam Checklists

General Checklist for Section A Response

Textual Understanding and Interpretation

- Have I demonstrated a clear and accurate understanding of the text?
- Have I explored the ideas, concerns, and values present in the text?
- Have I considered the structure and language used in the text to convey meaning?
- Have I shown awareness of the complexities or subtleties in the text's ideas?

Response to the Topic

- Have I clearly addressed the essay topic throughout my response?
- Have I interpreted the implications of the topic (not just the literal meaning)?
- Have I developed a relevant and thoughtful argument or discussion?
- Have I used an appropriate strategy to explore the topic (e.g., thematic, character-based, structural)?

Use of Evidence

- Have I supported my ideas with specific and relevant evidence from the text?
- Have I explained how my evidence supports my argument?
- Have I used quotations effectively and accurately?

Organisation and Coherence

- Is my essay well-structured, with a clear introduction, body, and conclusion?
- Are my ideas logically sequenced and connected?
- Have I written clear topic sentences and developed each paragraph?

Language Use

- Is my language accurate, appropriate, and mostly free of errors?
- Have I used precise and expressive vocabulary to convey meaning?
- Is my writing fluent and confident in tone?

General Checklist for Section B Response

Engagement with Ideas and Stimulus

- Have I considered the ideas raised by the title and stimulus in a thoughtful and meaningful way?
- Have I connected these ideas to a clear and relevant Framework of Ideas?
- Have I explored the implications or complexities of the ideas, rather than treating them superficially?

Purpose and Voice

- Have I clearly established the purpose(s) of my text?
- Have I maintained an appropriate and consistent voice throughout the piece?
- Is the form of the piece suited to the intended audience and purpose (e.g., speech, monologue, letter)?

Control of Language

- Have I used language that is clear, expressive, and appropriate for the form?
- Have I used a rich and precise vocabulary to strengthen my writing?
- Have I varied sentence structure and language features to create impact and cohesion?

Control of Text Structure

- Is my writing well-organised and easy to follow?
- Have I structured the text purposefully, with a clear beginning, middle, and end?
- Have I used paragraphs and transitions effectively to guide the reader?

General Checklist for Section C Response

Understanding of Argument and Contention

- Have I accurately identified the contention of the text?
- Have I understood how the argument(s) are structured and developed across the text?
- Have I recognised the overall point of view being expressed by the author/speaker?

Analysis of Persuasive Language and Visuals

- Have I analysed how language features (written or spoken) are used to persuade the intended audience?
- Have I explained how visuals (if any) support or enhance the written or spoken argument?
- Have I discussed how these elements work together to construct the overall persuasive strategy?

Expression and Language Use

- Have I used language that is clear, precise, and appropriate to an analytical task?
- Have I written fluently and used analytical vocabulary confidently?
- Have I maintained a consistent and formal tone suitable for academic analysis?

Part

2024 Assessment Report

General Exam Advice

What Worked

- Students clearly understood the structure and expectations of the exam.
- Many responses demonstrated well-developed writing and analytical skills.

What Needs Improvement

- Some students forgot to clearly label their chosen text (Section A) or Framework of Ideas (Section B).
- Some responses misinterpreted the prompt or overlooked key words in the question.

Practical Tips

- Label your work clearly. Always begin with:

  Section A: ‘Text: Macbeth | Prompt: ‘Ambition leads to downfall. Do you agree?’”

  Section B: ‘Title: Resist and Persist | Framework: Protest”
- Build your vocabulary. Familiarise yourself with words like inescapable, perceptions, central concern, implication, etc.
- Select the best-fit prompt. Choose the one that allows you to demonstrate your strongest understanding, not just the one that sounds easiest.

Section A: Analytical Response to a Text

Your task: Write a structured essay in response to one of two prompts for your studied text.

What Worked

- High-scoring responses interpreted the topic with nuance and clarity.
- Students demonstrated a strong understanding of authorial intent.
- Responses were well structured and supported with relevant textual evidence.

What Needs Improvement

- Some students only responded to part of the question (e.g. discussing 'youth" but not 'infatuation with youth").
- Others summarised the plot or characters instead of analysing the text's ideas and values.

Practical Tips

Section A - Effective vs Ineffective Approaches

Effective Approach	Ineffective Approach
Interpreting all keywords in the topic	Ignoring modifiers (e.g. "unrelenting cruelty" vs "cruelty")
Using a clear "what/how/why" structure	Listing unrelated examples
Connecting ideas across paragraphs	Treating each paragraph as a standalone point
Focusing on how the author constructs meaning	Just retelling the storyline

' **Tip:** Write practice introductions where you break down the prompt. Ask:

- What is the main idea or concept?
- Are there two ideas in relationship?
- What are the implications or assumptions?

Section B - Creating a Text (Framework of Ideas)

Your task: Create an original piece of writing that responds to a title and stimulus, grounded in one of the four Frameworks of Ideas.

What Worked

- High-scoring pieces treated the title and stimulus as central, not secondary.
- Strong voice, clear purpose, and tailored language made the writing stand out.
- Responses showed thoughtful exploration of ideas relevant to the Framework.

What Needs Improvement

- Some students ignored or misunderstood the Framework (e.g. writing about sports under the Protest framework).
- Others forced pre-prepared stories to fit the title.
- Lack of planning resulted in unstructured or unfocused pieces.

Practical Strategies

Planning Method

- Framework: Personal Journeys
- Title: Finding My Way
- Stimulus: Butterfly emerging from a cocoon
- Purpose: Reflective
- Audience: Teenagers navigating cultural identity
- Text Type: Memoir

Tips for Strong Writing

- Use recurring imagery or motifs to strengthen cohesion.
- Match tone to purpose: persuasive, reflective, emotive, or narrative.
- End with intention: resolution, reflection, or call to action.

Section C - Analysing Argument

Your task: Analyse how a written and visual text positions its audience.

What Worked

- Identifying the author's contention and target audience.
- Analysing tone, persuasive language, structure, and visuals.
- Exploring how language is used to shape reader response.

What Needs Improvement

- Avoid retelling the article.
- Go beyond spotting techniques; explain their effect and purpose.

Practical Strategies

Section B: Effective Strategies and Examples

Strategy	Example
Identify contention and purpose	'The writer argues that vaping is a growing public health crisis and seeks to alarm parents."
Link language to effect	'By using the phrase 'a ticking time bomb', the writer creates a sense of urgency and panic."
Analyse visuals	'The image of a distressed child reinforces the emotional appeal used in the article's opening."
Use precise metalanguage	Appeal to fear, inclusive language, repetition, expert opinion, etc.

Final Exam Checklist

- Have I practised responding to a range of prompts and titles?
- Do I clearly understand my Frameworks of Ideas?
- Can I write for a clear audience and purpose?
- Have I reviewed unfamiliar vocabulary and metalanguage?
- Can I plan and write all three sections under timed conditions?

Final Advice

The 2027 exam will reward students who think deeply, write purposefully, and tailor their writing to the demands of the task. Whether you're analysing a text, creating your own piece, or evaluating argument and language, success lies in showing insight, clarity, and control.

Strong writing does not come from memorisation—it comes from understanding. Prepare thoughtfully, practise deliberately, and revise reflectively.

Part

2025 Assessment Report

General Exam Advice

The 2025 examination produced near-identical averages across all three sections — 5.4, 5.4 and 5.5 out of 10 — with very few students at either extreme. The middle is crowded; the marks that separate a 5 from an 8 come from the specific skills assessors described, not from writing more.

Section	Average /10	What it was
A	5.4	Analytical response to a text
B	5.4	Creating a text (Frameworks of Ideas)
C	5.5	Analysis of argument and language

How assessors marked

- **Holistic, criteria-based, benchmarked.** Every section was assessed against the published criteria and expected qualities (EQs), using benchmark scripts to set standards. The three EQs are interconnected: the quality of your ideas (EQ1) sets the level of challenge for structuring and substantiating them (EQ2), and language (EQ3) is judged by how well it communicates those ideas.
- **Everything is applied in relation to the topic.** Sound ideas, apt quotations or fluent expression that do not serve the set task cannot score highly. This principle recurs through every section of the report.
- **First-draft conditions were respected.** Assessors explicitly acknowledged that exam writing is timed first-draft work; fluency was not equated with perfection.

Administrative habits that mattered

- Shade the box for your chosen text *and* topic in Section A, and for your Framework *and* stimulus in Section B — and write the Section B title at the start of your response.
- Choose the topic that *best* lets you demonstrate your knowledge and skills, not the one you predicted.
- Bring a dictionary. Assessors specifically noted students with no strategy for unfamiliar words in topics — some simply substituted "and" for a term they didn't understand, which derailed their essays.

Section A: Analytical Response to a Text

The 2025 topics were deliberately narrow — specified ideas and values rather than broad prompts — and this shaped how responses needed to be structured, sequenced and evidenced. Students with topic-interpretation strategies handled both familiar and unfamiliar phrasings well.

Topic types

- **Propositional topics** offered a proposition with a command term: *Discuss*, *Do you agree?* or *To what extent do you agree?* You may challenge the proposition where warranted, but never the topic's conceptual focus itself — a topic linking love and destruction requires discussing both, though "inseparable" can be contested.
- **Quotation topics** paired a quotation with a proposition. There was no obligatory way to use the quotation, but how you used it revealed your understanding of what it conveys in context.

The verbs

The verb in a topic carries the author's purpose, and flattening every verb into a generic "presents" was unwise. Assessors also warned that verbs are often nominalised or implied, and new ones appear each year.

Used in 2025	New in 2025
celebrates, challenges, condemns, demonstrates, displays, explores, highlights, mocks, shows, suggests	is (a cry for), depicts, glorifies, warns

Implications: where the top marks lived

There was a direct correlation between recognising a topic's implications and higher scores. Watch for: absolute terms ("there are *no* right choices"), connotation ("*easy to overlook*"), what a proposition is silent about, comparison ("requires *more than* individual effort"), an included quotation, and the verb itself.

What high-scoring responses did

- **Interpreted before writing** — considered what the topic implies, not just what it states.
- **Sequenced strategically** — used opening and closing summary sentences in each paragraph to make ideas and their connections explicit, guiding the reader through the reading of the text.

- **Substantiated with range** — drew on linguistic elements, characters, structure, plot and allusion, and discussed how these interplayed; assessors noted high scorers took "a more philosophic consideration of the ideas, rather than a literal consideration".
- **Resolved the topic** — used the conclusion to actually answer the question, showing the interplay of context, audience and purpose.
- **Used language to communicate.** Sophisticated vocabulary scored only when it carried sophisticated ideas; "poorly applied polysyllabic words" were called out explicitly.

What limited responses

- Discussing a favourite theme adjacent to the topic instead of the topic (e.g. writing about patriarchy when the topic was about truth).
- Addressing only half the topic — in a topic such as "individuals can be both victims and villains", writing about villainy but not victimhood.
- Substituting prepared material for the terms actually on the paper, or having no strategy for unfamiliar words.

Section B: Creating a Text

Nearly half the state wrote on protest, yet all four Frameworks averaged within 0.4 marks of each other — choose the Framework that suits your ideas, not the popular one.

Framework	% of students	Average score /20
Writing about country	10%	11.2
Writing about protest	47%	10.9
Writing about personal journeys	25%	10.9
Writing about play	17%	10.8

The rules of the task

- **The title is fixed.** You cannot change or modify it; assessors ignored any additions. Choosing a title selects its Framework — no mixing and matching titles, Frameworks or stimulus sets. If your shaded box and your title disagreed, assessors followed the title.
- **Write the title at the start** and shade both the Framework and stimulus boxes.
- **Stimulus ideas must come from your selected Framework's** stimulus material, though how you use them is open.
- **Mentor texts don't need referencing**, and there is no preferred form, style, purpose or audience — responses could explain, express, reflect or argue, and could adapt or subvert any prose form.

What lifted responses

- Using the title as the focus while exploring Framework ideas purposefully through a cohesive text.
- Making deliberate structural and linguistic choices that amplify ideas — the annotated high scorers moved economically between place and time, used imagery to imply location, and chose words that carried complex emotion.
- Establishing a voice that connects strategically with the reader — one exemplar built "a thoughtful, confiding reflective voice" from its opening lines.
- Trusting an adult reader to infer meaning, and guiding that inference deliberately.

What limited responses

- Using stimulus literally (a story of children playing a board game with no other connection to the Framework or title).

- Rambling texts with no observable purpose; simplistic or barely-related ideas; relying on plot alone.
- Contorting a pre-prepared piece to fit the exam title, or writing for yourself rather than a reader.
- Sensationalised content, cloying sentiment and clichéd language — assessors said these "were rarely the most powerful option". Remember an unknown adult reads this for assessment.

Section C: Analysis of Argument and Language

The 2025 text was a letter to a community newsletter from a "local resident" proposing that a regional town replace its annual fireworks with an alternative celebration. Students found it highly accessible — which made the discriminators sharper.

Background information is not decoration

The publication details and the author's "local resident" persona had to be used: inferring the regional audience and its values, the author's altruistic credibility, and the unhurried "evolution, not urgency" framing enabled the most focused analyses. Read the background inferentially *before* writing — the analysis flows from it.

The argument structure most students saw

- Establishing a shared value: love of the celebration in its beautiful setting.
- Raising previously unconsidered problems — environment, frightened pets (with a photo), noise-sensitive residents, cost — aligned with community values.
- Rebutting reasons to keep the status quo.
- Presenting the alternative as a "win-win" (with an inspiring second visual).

What separated skill levels

- **Identification is not analysis.** Most students could list arguments and label techniques; far fewer could explain how the *sequencing* of ideas served the purpose, or what a device actually did to the intended audience.
- **Interplay was the discriminator.** The strongest responses explained how argument, written language and visuals worked together — nearly everyone noticed the frightened dog photo, but skill showed in explaining its contribution to the developing argument, not just "appeals to emotion".
- **Strategic selection beat exhaustive coverage.** Discussing every element was impossible in the time and wasn't expected; choosing the elements most central to the persuasion correlated strongly with success.

Language worth recognising

Assessor-noted elements included appeals to parochial pride, social justice and economic responsibility; strategic characterisation ("beloved pets", "little Fido or Fluffy", "cheaper and

smarter"); escalation ("a single wayward spark ... devastating consequences"); reflection-prompting rhetorical questions; inspirational collective language ("Together we have the opportunity ... to lead the way"); and closing the door on alternatives ("a no-brainer").

Priority Checklist for 2027

The habits below fall straight out of the 2025 report — each one addresses something assessors explicitly rewarded or penalised.

Before the exam

- Build a topic-interpretation routine: identify the conceptual focus, the command term, the verb, and at least two implications before planning.
- Rehearse unfamiliar-verb strategy — and pack a dictionary.
- Practise writing to a fixed title in Section B without bending a pre-prepared piece to fit.
- For Section C practice, always start from the background information and write down audience, purpose and author positioning before analysing.

In the exam

- Shade every box: text and topic (Section A); Framework and stimulus (Section B) — and write the Section B title first.
- Section A: open and close each paragraph with sentences that link your ideas to the topic; use the conclusion to resolve the question.
- Section B: keep the title in view as you write; make every structural and word choice serve your purpose and reader.
- Section C: select the few elements most central to the persuasion and explain their interplay — argument, language and visuals together.
- Everywhere: sophisticated language only where it communicates a sophisticated idea.

Summarised from the VCAA 2025 English examination report. Read alongside the 2024 takeaways and the assessment criteria.

Part

Effectively Studying For Exams

Assess your current study habits

Identifying strengths and weaknesses

Take a few minutes to jot down what's working well in your current study routine. What areas could use some improvement? Consider factors like time management, focus, and understanding of different subjects.

Setting realistic goals

Based on your assessment, you could start by setting 2-3 specific, achievable goals for improving your study habits. Make these goals SMART: Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound. Write them down and place them somewhere visible as a daily reminder.

Create a personalised study schedule

Now that you know where you stand, it's time to map out a path to exam success. Think of your study schedule as a roadmap to help you navigate your way through VCE studies.

Time management tips

List all your subjects and the topics you need to cover for each. Assess how much time you have until your exams. Consider prioritising subjects based on difficulty and your current performance. Using a study schedule template Remember: Be realistic with your schedule. If you're not a morning person, a sunrise study session may not suit you. Try to work with your natural rhythms, and not against them.

Find a study schedule template that works for you – digital or physical, whichever works best.

Block out fixed commitments like school, extracurriculars, and family time. Allocate study blocks for each subject, ensuring a mix of subjects each day. Don't forget to schedule breaks and 'me time' to avoid feelings of burnout.

Organise your study materials

A cluttered space can contribute to a cluttered mind. Here are some strategies to effectively organise your study materials.

Gathering resources

Collect all your textbooks, notes, and past papers for each subject. Organise digital resources into clearly labelled folders on your computer. Consider creating a ‘study toolkit’ with essentials like highlighters, sticky notes, and index cards.

Creating a study-friendly environment

Find a quiet, well-lit space where you can focus without distractions. Ensure you have a comfortable chair and desk at the right height. Keep your study area clean and organised – a tidy space can do wonders for your concentration.

Implement active recall and spaced repetition

Below are some tried and true study techniques you might like to explore.

The power of self-testing

After studying a topic, close your books and try to recall as much as you can. Create flashcards for key concepts and test yourself regularly. Explain concepts out loud as if you're teaching someone else.

Spacing out your study sessions

Avoid cramming by spreading out your study sessions over time. Review material at increasing intervals: e.g. 1 day later, 3 days later, 1 week later, etc.

Utilise practice exams and past papers

Another way to effectively prepare for exams is by practising past exams. Here are some techniques you might find helpful.

Simulating exam conditions

Find past papers or practice exams for your subjects. Set up a quiet space and time yourself as you would in a real exam. Avoid using your notes or textbooks during these practice sessions.

Analysing your performance

Mark your practice exams using the relevant marking schemes, if available. Identify areas where you lost marks and focus on improving these in your study sessions. Keep a log of common mistakes to avoid repeating them in the real exam.

Develop a healthy study-life balance

It's important to look after yourself and practice self-care during this time. Find what works best for you, or try our ideas below.

Incorporating breaks and relaxation

Use techniques like the Pomodoro method: 25 minutes of focused study followed by a 5-minute break. Schedule longer breaks for activities you enjoy – maybe a quick game of basketball or a chat with friends. Practice mindfulness or meditation to help manage stress and improve focus.

Maintaining physical and mental well-being

Aim for 7-9 hours of sleep per night – your brain consolidates memories and learning during sleep. Incorporate regular exercise to improve your mood and reduce stress. Eat a balanced diet with brain-boosting foods like blueberries, nuts, and fatty fish.

Collaborate with study groups

Two heads are better than one, and a study group can be a powerhouse of knowledge, inspiration and motivation.

The benefits of peer learning

Explaining concepts to others can help solidify your own understanding. Gain new perspectives and insights from your peers. Stay motivated and accountable with group study sessions.

Organising effective study sessions

Set clear objectives for each study session. Use tools like shared Google Docs or virtual whiteboards for collaborative note-taking.

Seek help when needed

Remember, asking for help isn't a sign of weakness.

Utilising teacher support

Don't hesitate to approach your teachers with specific questions. Attend any extra help sessions offered by your school or community. Ask for feedback on your work.

Exploring additional resources

Explore online tutorials or video explanations for challenging topics. Consider getting a tutor for subjects where you're really struggling. Join online forums or study groups for your specific subjects.

Fine-tune your exam day strategy

When your exams are approaching – make sure you're feeling prepared.

Pre-exam preparation

Get a good night's sleep before the exam. Eat a nutritious breakfast to fuel your brain. Arrive at the exam venue early to avoid last-minute stress.

During the exam tactics

Read through the entire paper before starting to answer questions. Manage your time wisely – allocate minutes to each section based on mark values. If you get stuck on a question, move on and come back to it later.

Week-by-Week Revision Program

Twelve weeks of structured revision mapping this site's chapters and tools to a plan. Count back twelve weeks from the exam and start; if you have fewer weeks left, begin at the matching week number and compress the early stages. Adjust around your SACs — the order matters more than the calendar.

Weeks 12–11 · Rebuild the foundations

- **Read:** your text's Background and Context and Values chapters (Picnic at Hanging Rock / The Lottery and Other Stories), then What is Needed in an Essay.
- **Do:** re-watch the film / re-read the play once, casually. Skim the scene summaries or quote tables alongside.
- **Tool:** 10 minutes of Quote Flashcards daily — start building recall now, when it's cheap.

Weeks 10–9 · Master the evidence

- **Read:** the Thematic and Character Quote Banks for your text, and the Symbols chapters.
- **Do:** build a one-page theme map: each major theme, three quotes, one symbol, one technique. The Glossary supplies the technique names.
- **Tool:** flashcards daily; add the Technique Quiz twice a week.

Weeks 8–7 · Learn the craft of the essay

- **Read:** Interrogating the Topic, then plan paragraphs with the Th.E.S.A.M.L. scaffold in the Essay Outline Builder.
- **Study:** one annotated exemplar per week (SB / RE) — click through every highlight, one colour category at a time.
- **Tool:** Essay Outline Builder — plan two essays per week without writing them. Micro-Drills for topic sentences.

Weeks 6–5 · Write, mark, rewrite

- **Do:** one full timed Section A essay per week (Practice Topics & Timer, 60 minutes). Swap with a friend and mark each other against the criteria.
- **Read:** the 2024 and 2025 assessor takeaways — especially the topic-verb guidance.
- **Fix:** run a paragraph through the Vocabulary Upgrader after each essay.

Weeks 4–3 · Sections B and C

- **Read:** Creating Texts with its three scored sample pieces, and Analysing Argument including the vocabulary bank.
- **Do:** one timed Section B piece and one timed Section C analysis per week, and mark both against the criteria. Use the practice stimuli and practice articles.

Weeks 2 · Full dress rehearsals

- **Do:** at least one complete three-hour exam under conditions — the Exam Generator makes a fresh paper, or use a practice exam. Fifteen minutes reading time, no phone, all three sections.
- **Mark:** every section against the criteria; note which section costs you most and give it the spare hours this week.

Week 1 · Final week

- **Read:** the Exam Checklists, the Priority Checklist for 2027, and Exam Format one last time.
- **Do:** light passes of the quote banks and flashcards; one plan a day with the Outline Builder — no more full essays after mid-week. Sleep is revision.

Pair this program with the advice in the rest of Effectively Studying For Exams — spaced repetition, study-life balance, and exam-day strategy.